Collins COBUILD English Grammar, 4th edition (2017)

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0.1 About COBUILD

When the 1st COBUILD dictionary was published in 1987, it revolutionized dictionaries for learners.

It was the 1st of the new generation of language reference materials that were based on actual evidence of how English was used, rather than lexicographer intuition.

Collins and the University of Birmingham, led by the linguist John Sinclair, developed an electronic corpus in 1980s, called the Collins Birmingham University International Language Database (COBUILD).

This corpus, which for several years was known as the Bank of English©, became the largest collection of English data in the world.

COBUILD dictionary editors use the corpus to analyze the way that people really use the language.

The Collins Corpus now contains 4.5 billion words taken from websites, newspapers, magazines and books published around the world, and from spoken material from radio, TV and everyday conversations.

New data is added to the corpus every month, to help COBUILD editors identify new words, grammatical structures, and meanings from the moment they are 1st used.

All COBUILD language reference books are based on the information their editors find the Collins Corpus.

Because the corpus is so large, their editors can look at lots of examples of how people really use the language.

The data tells them how the language is used; the function of different structures; which words are used together; and how often these words and structures are used.

All of the examples in COBUILD language materials are examples of real English, taken from the corpus.

The examples have been carefully chosen to demonstrate typical grammatical patterns, typically vocabulary and typical contexts.

COBUILD English Grammar is no exception: Collins editors and researchers have been able to use this wealthy of information to establish a unique and full description of English grammar, and to track the development of certain grammatical structures over time.

The corpus lies at the heart of COBUILD, and you can be confident that COBUILD will show you what you need to know to be able to communicate easily and accurately in English.

To learn more about COBUILD and the Collins Corpus, go to www.collinselt.com and click on 'COBUILD Reference'.

0.2 Introduction

This grammar is suitable for anyone who is interested in the English language and how it works in everyday current contexts.

It has been written mainly for advanced-level students and their teachers, but any serious learner will find it a valuable reference tool.

The information in this book is taken from a long and careful study of present-day English involving the analysis of the Collins Corpus - a corpus of many millions of words of speech and writing.

0.2.1 A functional approach

Most people who study and use a language are interested in how they can *do things* with the language - how they can make meanings, get attention, influence people, and learn about the world.

They are interested in the grammatical structure of the language as a way of getting things done.

A grammar that puts together the patterns of the language and the things you can do with them is called a *functional grammar*.

This is a functional grammar; that is to say, it is based on the important relation between structure and function.

Each chapter is built around a major function of language, e.g. *describing people and things*, and *reporting what someone said*.

Each of these functions is regularly expressed in English by particular structures.

E.g., describing people and things is usually expressed by adjectives, and reporting what people say or think typically involves a reporting verb e.g. *say*, followed by a clause beginning with *that* or a clause with quotation marks (' ') around it.

This grammar follows up each major statement (often called a *rule* in other grammars) with a detailed description of the uses surrounding it - including any exceptions.

The scope of the original function may then be extended.

E.g., the basic, central function of reporting verbs (Chap. 7) is to state what someone has said.

Example 0.2.1. *He said he would be back soon.*

It can be easily be extended to include what someone has written.

Example 0.2.2. *His mother wrote that he had finally arrived home.*

Then it can be widened to include thoughts and feelings; these do not need to be expressed in words, but the reporting structure is very convenient.

Example 0.2.3. *The boys thought he was dead.*

From this we can see the reporting clause as a more general way of introducing another clause.

Examples

All the examples in this book are taken from the Collins Corpus.

As ever, the corpus lies at the heart of each grammar point described, helping compilers to make confident and accurate decisions about different structures and usage.

Examples themselves remain close to the corpus, with minor changes made so that they are more accessible to the learner.

They are carefully chosen so as to illustrate typical patterns and collocations in real-life situations.

0.2.2 Groups of words that behave in the same way

As well as providing a wealth of illustrative examples, this book gives further information about the grammar of a large number of specific words.

The actual words and phrases that are regularly used in each structure are given in a series of lists.

In this way, the learner can get a good idea of how large or small a grammatical class is, and how many words a certain rule applies to.

Wherever there is good reason to do so, the words and phrases are grouped together in a list in a meaningful arrangement.

So, e.g., at [1.21], separate groups are set in a single list, including animals, fish, words ending in *-craft*, and foreign words ending in *-s*.

These all share the same feature, i.e. that they can be either singular or plural nouns without any change in form - *moose, salmon, aircraft, corps*.

From a purely grammatical point of view, they could all go in a single alphabetical list; however from a teaching and learning point of view, it is helpful to have them further classified according to their meaning.

0.2.3 'Be creative'

Certain areas of English grammar are very flexible and *productive*.

Some are well known, e.g. the fact that almost any noun in English can modify another noun.

E.g., the noun *steam* can be used in, among others, the following combinations: *steam bath, steam room, steam engine, steam iron, steam power*, and *steam train*.

With this in mind, several 'Be creative' features are included to encourage learners to use their imagination, and to be more confident about expressing themselves.

In such cases, rather than giving a definite rule, the authors prefer to give guidance so that the user can make individual choices with no serious risk of error.

By describing the language in this way, give plenty of scope for creativity and innovation.

0.2.4 Accessibility

When using a grammar, it can be difficult to find the information that you want.

This is often the biggest single problem for users of grammars, and a good reason why grammars are often unpopular with learners.

This grammar makes a special effort to support the user.

The authors have aimed to use the most up-to-date and commonly used grammatical terminology throughout.

Technical terms have been used only where there is no obvious alternative.

A glossary of terms is provided and they are also all listed in the index.

There is a contents list at the beginning of the book, and there is an individual contents list at the beginning of each chapter.

Using these of the index, the user will be able to find the section or paragraph where a function is associated with a structure.

Throughout the book there are paragraph headings that show the topic of almost every paragraph, and there are frequent additional headings for each section of a chapter.

At the top of each page, there is another heading to guide the user.

0.2.5 New developments in language

The continued development of the corpus enables us to keep us with the ever-changing nature of language.

At COBUILD, the authorscontinually track and research the development of grammatical features, e.g.:

(i) the use of the progressive with so-called stative verbs (e.g. *I'm loving every minute of it*)

(ii) the use of *much* in affirmative unmodified statements (e.g. *There was much debate*)

(iii) the spread of generic pronouns (e.g. *You get some people who are very difficult*)

(iv) the use of *like* in reporting structures (e.g. *And I was like, 'wow!'*)

(v) the use of all-purpose question tags in some varieties of spoken informal English (e.g. *innit*)

The results are often fascinating and surprising, and enable us to ensure that each new edition of the Grammar gives you a clear portrayal of real English as it is written and spoken today.

0.2.6 The grammar of business & academic English

An extension of our functional approach has been to focus on 2 main contexts in which English is used as a lingua franca throughout the world - business and academic English.

As a result, 2 supplementary sections identify the principal areas of grammar that learners need to master if they wish to communicate effectively in business and academic contexts.

The section on the grammar of business English looks at typical structures used in such contexts as sharing information, negotiating, and giving presentations.

The academic English section covers such areas as explaining results, reviewing research, and reporting findings.

Extensive cross-referencing allows the user to refer back to the main text, where structures are discussed in greater detail.

The authors hope that you will enjoy learning about English grammar from a functional perspective - from exploring the wealth of real-world examples of current language, to understanding how certain structures work in business and academic contexts.

The authors hope, too, that as a result, you will gain the confidence to use English creatively and effectively in a wide range of everyday situations.

0.2.7 Getting the most out of COBUILD English Grammar

Would you like to discover more about the wealth of information COBUILD English Grammar has to offer, and explore the subject of grammar further?

If so, go to www.collinselt.com/cobuildenglishgrammar, where you will find a range of blogposts, written by experts in the field, that encourage focused thinking and discussion with your peers on a variety of topics, e.g.:

- questioning traditionally accepted grammar 'rules'
- establishing the difference between nonstandard usage and errors
- thinking about why some people avoid using the word 'tense' to talk about perfect and progressive forms.

To help you examine each topic in turn in greater detail, each blogpost has a link to a corresponding worksheet.

0.3 How to use this Grammar

The COBUILD English Grammar is designed to be used both for quick reference and for in-depth study.

0.3.1 Organization of the main text

The main text of the Grammar is divided into 10 chapters.

The 1st 2 chapters deal with the noun phrase, Chaps. 3–5 with the verb phrase.

Chap. 6 deals with adverbs and prepositions, Chap. 7 with reporting, Chap. 8 with joining words, phrases and clauses, and Chaps. 9–10 with continuous text.

Each chapter consists of a series of main topics and each topic is divided into sections.

Paragraphs in the chapter are numbered, so that Chap. 1 runs from **1.1** to **1.251**, Chap. 2 from **2.1** to **2.302** and so on.

This numbering system makes it easy for the user to refer to different but related points.

There are cross-references throughout the text, either pointing to the main place where a topic is dealt with or to another paragraph where more information is given.

Most paragraphs also have a heading, saying in a few words what it deals with, especially which grammatical structure is being explained.

Some paragraph headings do not show specifically what the paragraph deals with, but indicate information of a different kind.

These paragraphs have the headings 'Be careful,' 'Be Creative', and 'Usage Note'.

[!] 'Be Careful' highlights points where people often have problems with a particular grammatical feature of English, e.g. because it is a feature where English is different from many other languages.

[⋆] 'Be Creative' indicates that the rule that has been mentioned can be applied in English to a very large number of words.

E.g., it is nearly always possible to make the *-ing* participle of a verb into an adjective that is used in front of a noun.

By taking note of these features, you can use the rules that have been presented in a creative and original way, giving you greater freedom to express yourself in English.

'Be Creative' features are explained in greater detail in the Introduction.

[i] 'Usage Note' gives information about the use of individual words or small groups of words.

This information is important but cannot be generalized into a grammatical rule.

The Usage Notes help you to understand points that are important for the understanding of particular words, rather than points that relate to large numbers of words.

The U.S. flag symbol highlights paragraphs containing information about typical American English usage.

The speech bubble symbol identifies paragraphs describing structures that are most commonly found in spoken English.

Most of the grammatical explanations are followed by examples showing how the structure is used.

These examples are all taken from the Collins Corpus, and show how the structures are used naturally in speech or writing.

The examples therefore give important information about typical use of a structure, the words it is frequently used with, and the contexts in which it is likely to occur.

Throughout the book, grammatical explanations are followed by lists of the words that typically illustrate that grammatical point.

E.g., in Chap. 3, the point is made that many verbs can be either transitive or intransitive with the same meaning.

This is followed by a list of verbs that are frequently used in this way.

The lists go beyond the actual examples of use that are given, to other words that behave in similar ways.

They show whether the point being made can be applied to a small number or a large number of words.

If the group is small, all members of it are given.

If the group is large, then the most frequently used words are given.

These lists can be used to help you increase your vocabulary and to check that you are using newly learned English words correctly.

0.3.2 Additional contents

In addition to the main text, various other sections are included to help you to get the most out of this Grammar.

These additional sections are described below.

0.3.2.1 Glossary of grammatical terms

The Glossary explains the meaning of grammatical terms.

It covers the terms that are used in this grammar, and also includes terms that are used in other grammars, with a cross-reference to the term used in this book, where appropriate.

E.g., this grammar talks about the *present progressive*, whereas some other grammars call it the *present continuous*.

Both of these terms are mentioned in the Glossary, with the explanation being given at *present progressive*.

0.3.2.2 Reference section

This section at the back of the book provides an easy-to-use reference guide that shows how the following groups of words are formed:

- plurals of nouns
- the comparative and superlative of adjectives
- '-ly' adverbs formed from adjectives

- the comparative and superlative of adverbs
- tenses
- other verb forms
- passives
- principal parts of irregular verbs

The Reference section also includes other topics.

E.g., it starts with a pronunciation guide, to remind you of the sounds of English.

There are also lists of numbers, and an explanation of how numbers are expressed aloud.

0.3.2.3 The grammar of business & academic English

These sections provide key guidance in the principal areas of grammar that learners need to master for effective communication in business and academic contexts.

0.3.2.4 Index

The Index is a comprehensive list of everything dealt with in the Grammar.

It covers:

- the grammatical and functional topics dealt with in the Grammar;
- individual words which are used as examples of a particular grammatical point;
- grammatical terms, both those used in this book and those commonly used in other books.

0.4 Glossary of grammatical terms

1. **abstract noun**: a noun used to describe a quality, idea, or experience rather than something physical or concrete; e.g., *joy, size, language.*

   Cf. **concrete noun**.

2. **active**: used for describing verb phrases e.g. *gives*, and *has made*, where the subject is the person or thing doing the action or responsible for the action.

   Cf. **passive**.

3. **adjectival clause**: another name for **relative clause**.

4. **adjective**: a word used to tell yu more about a thing, e.g. its appearance, color, size, or other qualities; e.g., ... *a pretty blue dress.*

5. **adverb**: a word that gives more information about when, how, where, or in what circumstances something happens; e.g. *quickly, now.*

   There are several different kinds of adverb; adverbs of degree, manner, place, time, duration, and frequency.

   There are also **focusing adverbs**.

6. **adverbial**: a word or combination of words added to a clause to give more information about time, place, or manner.

   See also **sentence adverbial** and **sentence connector**.

7. **adverb of degree**: an adverb indicating the amount or extent of a feeling or quality; e.g. *extremely.*

8. **adverb/adverbial of duration**: an adverb or adverbial indicating how long something lasts; e.g. *briefly, for a long time.*

9. **adverb/adverbial of frequency**: an adverb or adverbial indicating how often something happens; e.g. *often, once a week.*

10. **adverb of manner**: an adverb indicating the way in which something happens or is done; e.g. *carefully.*

11. **adverb of place**: an adverb that gives more information about position or direction; e.g. *Move closer.*

12. **adverb particle**: an adverb used as part of a phrasal verb; e.g. *hide out, sit up, turn round*.

13. **affirmative**: not containing a negative word.

    Also called **positive**.

14. **agent**: another name for **performer**.

15. **agreement**: the relationship between a subject and its verb, or between a number or determiner and its noun; e.g. *I look/she looks... 1 bell/3 bells*.

    Also called **concord**.

16. **apostrophe s**: an ending ('s) added to a noun to mark possession; e.g. ... *Harriet's daughter... the professor's husband... the Managing Director's secretary*.

17. **article**: see **definite article**, **indefinite article**.

18. **aspect**: the use of verb forms to show whether an action is continuing, repeated, or finished.

19. **attributive**: used for describing the position of adjectives when they are used in front of a noun.

    Cf. **predicative**.

20. **auxiliary verb**: 1 of the verbs *be, have*, and *do* when they are used with a main verb to make verb forms, negatives, questions, and so on.

    Also called **auxiliary**.

    Modals are also auxiliary verbs.

21. **bare infinitive**: another name for **infinitive without to**.

22. **base form**: the form of a verb that has no letters added to the end and is not a past form; e.g. *walk, go, have, be*.

    The base form is the form you look up in a dictionary.

23. **broad negative**: 1 of a small group of adverbs including *barely* and *seldom* which are used to make a statement almost negative; e.g. *I barely knew her*.

24. **cardinal number**: a number used for counting; e.g. *one, seven, nineteen*.

25. **classifying adjective**: an adjective used to identity something as being of particular type; e.g. *Indian, wooden, mental*.

    They do not have comparatives or superlatives.

    Cf. **qualitative adjective**.

26. **clause**: a group of words containing a verb.

    See also **main clause** and **subordinate clause**.

27. **clause of manner**: a subordinate clause that describes the way in which something is done, usually introduced with *as* or *like*; e.g. *She talks like her mother used to*.

28. **collective noun**: a noun that refers to a group of people or things; e.g. *committee, team*.

29. **color adjective**: an adjective referring to a color; e.g. *red, blue, scarlet*.

30. **common noun**: a noun used to refer to a person, thing, or substance; e.g. *sailor, computer, glass*.

    Cf. **proper noun**.

31. **comparative**: an adjective or adverb with *-er* on the end or *more* in front of it; e.g. *friendlier, more important, more carefully*.

32. **complement**: a noun phrase or adjective that comes after a linking verb e.g. *be*, and gives more information about the subject or object of the clause; e.g. *She is a teacher, She is tired, They made her chairperson*.

33. **complex sentence**: a sentence consisting of 2 or more main clauses linked by a subordinating conjunction; e.g. *We went inside when it started to rain*.

34. **compound**: a combination of 2 or more words functioning as a unit.

    E.g., *self-centered* and *free-style* are compound adjectives, *bus stop* and *state of affairs* are compounds nouns, and *dry-clean* and *roller-skate* are compound verbs.

35. **compound sentence**: a sentence consisting of 2 or more main clauses linked by a coordinating conjunction; e.g. *They picked her up and took her into the house.*

36. **concessive clause**: a subordinate clause, usually introduced by *although* or *while*, that contrasts with a main clause; e.g. *Although I like her, I find her hard to talk to.*

37. **concord**: another name for **agreement**.

38. **concrete noun**: a noun that refers to something we can touch or see; e.g. *table, dress, flower.*

    Cf. **abstract noun**.

39. **conditional clause**: a subordinate clause usually starting with *if.*

    The event described in the main clause depends on the condition described in the subordinate clause; e.g. *If it rains, we'll go to the cinema.*

    They would be rich if they had taken my advice.

40. **conjunction**: a word linking together 2 clauses, phrases, or words.

    There are 2 types of conjunction - **coordinating conjunctions**, which link parts of a sentence of the same grammatical type (*and, but, or*), and **subordinating conjunctions**, which begin subordinate clauses (*although, when*).

41. **continuous**: another name for **progressive**.

42. **contraction**: a shortened form in which an auxiliary verb and *not*, or a subject and an auxiliary verb, are joined together and functions as 1 word; e.g. *aren't, she's.*

43. **coordinate clause**: a clause that is connected to another clause with a coordinating conjunction e.g. *and or but*; e.g. *He fell and broke his leg.*

44. **coordinating conjunction**: a word e.g. *and, but*, or *or* which joins together 2 clauses, phrases, or words of the same grammatical type.

45. **copula**: a name sometimes used to refer to the verb *be.*

    In this grammar, the term **linking verb** is used.

46. **countable noun**: a noun that can be singular or plural; e.g. *dog/dogs, lemon/lemons, foot/feet.*

    Also called **count noun**.

47. **declarative**: a clause in the declarative form has the subject followed by the verb.

    Most statements are made in the declarative form.

    Also called **indicative**.

48. **defining non-finite clause**: a participle clause that is placed after a noun phrase to identify the person or thing you are talking about; e.g. *The girl wearing the red hat.*

49. **defining relative clause**: a relative clause that identifies the person or thing that is being talked about; e.g. *I wrote down everything that she said.*

50. **definite article**: the determiner '*the*'.

51. **delexical verb**: a verb that has very little meaning in itself and is used with an object that carries the main meaning of the structure.

    Give, have, and *take* are commonly used as delexical verbs; e.g. *She gave a small cry.*

    I've had a bath.

52. **demonstrative**: 1 of the words *this, that, these*, and *those* used in front of a noun; e.g. ... *this woman... that tree.*

    They are also used as pronouns; e.g. *That looks nice... This is fun.*

53. **dependent clause**: another name for **subordinate clause**.

54. **definite determiner**: 1 of a groups of determiners including *the, that* and *your* which you use when the person you are speaking to understands which person or thing you are talking about; e.g. *the old man, my ideas.*

55. **determiner**: 1 of a group of words including *the, a, some*, and *my* which are used at the beginning of a noun phrase.

56. **direct object**: a noun phrase referring to a person or thing affected by an action, in a sentence with an active verb; e.g. *She wrote her name... I shut the windows.*

57. **direct speech**: speech reported in the words actually spoken by someone, without any changes in tense, person, and so on.

58. **ditransitive verb**: a verb e.g. *give, take*, or *sell* which can have both an indirect and a direct object; e.g. *She gave me a kiss.*

59. **dynamic verb**: a verb e.g. *run, give* or *slice* which describes an action.

    Cf. **stative verb**.

60. ***-ed* adjective**: an adjective that ends in *-ed*, and usually has the same form as the *-ed* participle of a verb, or is formed by adding *-ed* to a noun; e.g. *a worried look... skilled workers.*

    Adjectives that do not end in *-ed* but have the same forms as irregular *-ed* participles are also called *-ed* adjectives; e.g. a *broken* bone.

61. ***-ed* particle**: a verb form e.g. *walked* or *played*, which is used to make perfect forms and passives, or in some cases an adjective.

    Irregular participles e.g. *given* and *broken* are also called *-ed* participles because they behave like regular *-ed* participles.

    Also called **past participle**.

62. **ellipsis**: when you leave out words because they are obvious from the context.

63. **emphasizing adjective**: an adjective e.g. *complete, utter* or *total* which stresses how strongly you feel about something; e.g. *I feel a complete fool.*

64. **ergative verb**: a verb that can be either transitive or intransitive in the same meaning.

    To use the verb intransitively, you use the object of the transitive verb as the subject of the intransitive verb; e.g. *He had boiled a kettle... The kettle had boiled.*

65. **exclamation**: a word or sentence spoken suddenly and loudly in order to express surprise, anger, and so on; e.g. *Oh gosh!*

66. **finite**: a finite verb is inflected according to person or tense rather than being an infinitive or a participle.

67. **first person**: see **person**.

68. **focusing adverb**: a sentence adverb that indicates the most relevant thing involved; e.g. *only, mainly, especially.*

69. **future**: the use of *will* or *shall* with the base form of the verb to refer to future events; e.g. *She will come tomorrow.*

70. **future progressive**: the use of *will be* or *shall be* and an *-ing* participle to refer to future events; e.g. *She will be going soon.*

    Also called **future continuous**.

71. **future perfect**: the use of *will have* or *shall have* and an *-ed* participle to refer to future events; e.g. *I shall have finished tomorrow.*

72. **future perfect progressive**: the use of *will* or *shall* with *have been* and an *-ing* participle to refer to future events; e.g. *I will have been walking for 3 hours by then.*

    Also called **future perfect continuous**.

73. **gender**: a grammatical term referring to the difference between masculine and feminine words e.g. *he* and *she.*

74. **generic pronoun**: 1 of a group of pronouns including *you* and *they* which are used to refer to people in general.

75. **gerund**: another name for ***-ing* noun**.

76. **gradable**: a gradable adjective can be used with a word e.g. *very* to say that the person or thing referred to has more or less of a quantity; e.g. *very boring, less helpful.*

77. **idiom**: a group of 2 or more words with a meaning that cannot be understood by taking the meaning of each individual word; e.g. *to kick the bucket, to run wild.*

78. ***if*-clause**: a **conditional clause**; or a clause used to report a *yes/no*-question.

79. **imperative**: a clause in the imperative has the base form of the verb without a subject, e.g. *Come here... Take 2 tablets every 4 hours... Enjoy yourself.*

80. **impersonal**: ***it*** is an impersonal subject when it is used to introduce a fact, or when it is used in a split sentence; e.g. *It's raining... It was you who asked.*

81. **indefinite article**: the determiners *a* and *an*.

82. **indefinite determiner**: 1 of a group of determiners including *a, many* and *several* which you use to refer to someone or something of a particular type, without saying which person or thing you mean; e.g. *an old man, several suggestions.*

83. **indefinite place adverb**: 1 of a group of adverbs including *anywhere* and *somewhere* which are used to indicate position or location in a general or vague way.

84. **indefinite pronoun**: 1 of a group of pronouns including *someone* and *anything* which are used to refer to a person or thing in a generaly way.

85. **indicative**: another name for **declarative**.

86. **indirect object**: a 2nd object used with a transitive verb to indicate who or what benefits from an action, or gets something as a result of it; e.g. *She gave me a rose.*

87. **indirect question**: a way of asking a question that makes it sound more polite; e.g. *Can you tell me where the bank is?* instead of *Where is the bank?*

88. **indirect speech**: another name for **reported speech**.

89. **infinitive**: the base form of a verb.

    It is often used with *to* in front of it; e.g. *(to) take, (to) see, (to) bring.*

90. **infinitive without to**: the infinitive form without *to* in front of it, used with modals and certain other verbs; e.g. *You must go... Let me think.*

91. **inflection**: the variation in the form of a word to show differences in tense, number, case, and degree.

92. ***-ing* adjective**: an adjective that has the same form as the *-ing* participle of a verb; e.g. *... a smiling face... a winning streak.*

93. ***-ing* participle**: a verb form ending in *-ing* that is used to make verb forms, and as an adjective.

    Also called the **present participle**.

94. ***-ing* noun**: a noun that has the same form as the *-ing* participle of a verb; e.g. *Swimming is good for you.*

95. **interjection**: another name for **exclamation**.

96. **interrogative adverb**: 1 of the adverbs *how, when, where*, and *why* when they are used to ask questions.

97. **interrogative**: a clause in the interrogative form has part or all of the verb phrase in front of the subject.

    Most questions are asked in the interrogative form.

98. **interrogative pronoun**: 1 of the pronouns *who, whose, whom, what*, and *which* when they are used to ask questions.

99. **intransitive verb**: a verb that is used to talk about an action or event that only involves the subject and so does not have an object; e.g. *She arrived... I was yawning.*

100. **inversion**: changing the word order in a sentence, especially changing the order of the subject and the verb.

101. **irregular**: not following the normal rules for inflection.

     An irregular verb has a past form and/or *-ed* participle that is formed in a different way from the regular ending.

102. **lexical verb**: another name for **main verb**.

103. **linking verb**: a verb that links the subject and complement of a clause; e.g. *be, become, seem, appear.*

     Also sometimes called **copula**.

104. **main clause**: a clause that is not dependent on, or is not part of, another clause.

105. **main verb**: any verb that is not an auxiliary verb.

     Also called **lexical verb**.

106. **mass noun**: (in this grammar) a noun that is usually an uncountable noun, but that can be used as a countable noun when it refers to quantities or types of something; e.g. *... 2 sugars... cough medicines.*

107. **measurement noun**: a noun that refers to a unit of size, volume, weight, speed, temperature, etc.: e.g. *mile, liter, degree.*

108. **modal**: an auxiliary verb that is used with a main verb to indicate a particular attitude, e.g. possibility, obligation, prediction, or deduction; e.g. *can, could, may, might.*

     Also called *modal auxiliary* or *modal verb.*

109. **modifier**: a word or group of words that come in front of a noun; e.g. *... a beautiful sunny day... a psychology conference.*

110. **negative**: used for describing a sentence that uses a word like *not, never*, or *no one* to indicate the absence or opposite of something, or to say that something is not the case; e.g. *I don't know you... I'll never forget.*

     The opposite is **affirmative**.

111. **negative word**: a word e.g. *never* and *not* which expresses a negative meaning.

112. **nominal relative clause**: a subordinate clause that functions as a noun and often begins with *what* or *whatever*; e.g. *What he said was true.*

113. **nominal *that*-clause**: a subordinate clause that functions as a noun and begins with *that*; e.g. *He showed that it was true.*

114. **non-defining relative clause**: a relative clause that gives more information about someone or something, but that is not needed to identify them; e.g. *That's Mary, who was at university with me.*

     Cf. **defining relative clause**.

115. **non-finite**: the non-finite forms of a verb are the infinitive and participle forms; e.g. *to take, taking, taken.*

116. **noun**: a word that refers to people, things, and abstract ideas e.g. feelings and qualities; e.g. *woman, Harry, guilt.*

117. **noun phrase**: a group of words that acts as the subject, complement, or object of a clause, or as the object of a preposition.

118. **noun modifier**: a noun used in front of another noun, as if it were an adjective; e.g. *... a car door... a steel works.*

119. **number**: the way in which differences between singular and plural are shown; e.g. *flower/flowers, that/those.*

     See also **cardinal number** and **ordinal number**.

120. **object**: a noun phrase that refers to a person or thing, other than the subject, which is involved in or affected by the action of a verb.

     See also **direct object** and **indirect object**.

     Prepositions are also followed by objects.

121. **object complement**: a word that is used to describe the object of a clause and that occurs with verbs e.g. *make* and *find*; e.g. *It made me tired... I found her asleep.*

122. **ordinal number**: a number that is used to indicate where something comes in an order or sequence; e.g. *1st, 5th, 10th, 100th.*

123. **participle**: a verb form used for making different tenses.

     See ***-ed* participle** and ***-ing* participle** for more details.

124. **partitive**: a word that gives information about the amount of a particular thing; e.g. *pint, loaf, portion.*

125. **passive**: verb forms e.g. *was given, were taken, had been made*, where the subject is the person or thing that is affected by the action.

    Cf. **active**.

126. **past form**: the form of a verb, often ending in *-ed*, that is used for the past simple.

127. **past participle**: another name for ***-ed* participle**.

128. **past perfect**: the use of *had* with an *-ed* participle to refer to past events; e.g. *She had finished.*

129. **past perfect progressive**: the use of *had been* with an *-ing* participle to refer to past events; e.g. *He had been waiting for hours.*

    Also called **past perfect continuous**.

130. **past progressive**: the use of *was* or *were* with an *-ing* participle, usually to refer to past events; e.g. *They were worrying about it yesterday.*

    Also called **past continuous**.

131. **past simple**: the use of the past form of a verb to refer to past events; e.g. *They waited... It fell over.*

132. **past tense**: a tense used to describe actions or events that took place in the past.

    See **tense** for more details.

133. **perfect form**: a verb form with *have* and an *-ed* participle; e.g. *I have met him... We had won.*

134. **performative verb**: a verb that states explicitly what action the speaker is performing when he or she uses it; e.g. *apologize, resign, christen.*

135. **performer**: the person or thing that is responsible for the action expressed by the verb; e.g. *Mark phoned... Our dinner was eaten by the dog.*

136. **person**: a term used to refer to the 3 classes of people who are involved in something that is said.

    They are the 1st person (the person speaking or writing), the 2nd person (the person being addressed), and the 3rd person (the person or things that are being talked about).

137. **personal pronoun**: 1 of a group of pronouns including *I, you*, and *me* which are used to refer back to the people or things you are talking about.

138. **phrasal verb**: a combination of a verb and an adverb and/or a preposition, which have a single meaning; e.g. *back down, hand over, look after, look forward to.*

139. **phrase**: a set of words that is smaller than a clause, and that is based around a particular word class: e.g., a verb phrase is based around a main verb, and can also contain auxiliary verbs.

    See also **noun phrase, verb phrase** and **prepositional phrase**.

    Phrase is also sometimes used to refer to any group of words.

140. **plural**: the form used to refer to more than 1 person or thing; e.g. *dogs, women.*

141. **plural noun**: a noun that is only used in the plural form; e.g. *trousers, scissors, vermin.*

142. **possessive**: a structure used to show possession; e.g. *your, Jerry's, mine.*

143. **possessive determiner**: a determiner e.g. *my, your*, and *their.*

    Also called **possessive adjective**.

144. **possessive pronoun**: 1 of the words *mine, yours, hers, his, ours*, and *theirs.*

145. **postdeterminer**: a small group of adjectives used after a determiner and in front of other adjectives; e.g. *certain, remaining.*

146. **predeterminer**: a word that comes in front of a determiner; e.g. *all the boys... double the trouble... such a mess.*

147. **predicative**: used for describing the position of adjectives when they are used after a linking verb e.g. 'be'.

    Cf. **attributive**.

148. **preposition**: a word e.g. *by, with* or *from*, which is usually followed by a noun phrase or an *-ing* form.

149. **prepositional phrase**: a structure consisting of a preposition and its object; e.g. *on the table, by the sea.*

150. **present participle**: another name for ***-ing* participle**.

151. **present progressive**: the use of the present simple of 'be' with an *-ing* participle to refer to present events; e.g. *Things are improving.*

    Also called **present continuous**.

152. **present perfect**: the use of the present simple of *have* with an *-ed* participle to refer to past events that exist in the present; e.g. *She has loved him for 10 years.*

153. **present perfect progressive**: the use of *have been* and *has been* with an *-ing* participle to refer to past events that exist in the present; e.g. *We have been sitting here for hours.*

    Also called **present perfect continuous**.

154. **present simple**: the use of the base form or the *s* form of a verb, usually to refer to present events; e.g. *I like bananas... My sister hates them.*

155. **present tense**: a tense used to describe events taking place in the present, or situations that exist in the present.

156. **progressive**: a verb form that contains a form of the verb 'be' and an *-ing* participle; e.g. *She was laughing... They had been playing badminton.*

    Also called **continuous**.

157. **pronoun**: a word used instead of a noun, when you do not want to name someone or something directly; e.g. *it, you, none.*

158. **proper noun**: a noun that refers to a particular person, place, or institution; e.g. *Nigel, Edinburgh, Christmas.*

    Cf. **common noun**.

159. **purpose clause**: a subordinate clause, usually introduced by *in order to*, or *so that*;

    e.g. *I came here in order to ask you out to dinner.*

160. **qualifier**: any word, phrase, or clause that comes after a noun phrase, and gives extra information to expand its meaning; e.g. ... *a book with a blue cover* ... *the shop on the corner.*

161. **qualitative adjective**: an adjective that is used to indicate a quality, and is gradable; e.g. *funny, intelligent, small.*

    Cf. **classifying adjective**.

162. **quantity expression**: a phrase ending in *of* that allows you to refer to a quantity of something without being precise about the exact amount; e.g. *some of, a lot of, a little bit of.*

163. **question**: a structure that typically has the verb in front of the subject and that is used to ask someone about something; e.g. *Have you have any money?*

    Also called **interrogative**.

164. **question tag**: a structure or word that is used at the end of a statement in order to form a question.

165. **reason clause**: a subordinate clause, usually introduced by *because, since*, or *as*; e.g. *Since you're here, we'll start.*

166. **reciprocal pronoun**: the pronouns *each other* and *one another*, used to show that 2 or more people do or feel the same thing; e.g. *They loved each other.*

167. **reciprocal verb**: a verb that describes an action that involves people affecting each other in the same way with the same action; e.g. *They met in the street... He met her yesterday.*

168. **reflexive pronoun**: a pronoun ending in *-self*, e.g. *myself* or *themselves*, which is used as the object of a verb when the person affected by an action is the same as the person doing it.

169. **reflexive verb**: a verb that is typically used with a reflexive pronoun; e.g. *enjoy yourself; pride yourself on.*

170. **reflexive clause**: a subordinate clause that gives more information about someone or something mentioned in the main clause.

    See also **defining relative clause** and **non-defining relative clause**.

171. **relative pronoun**: a *wh*-word e.g. *who* or *which*, used to introduce a relative clause; e.g. *... the girl who was carrying the bag.*

172. **reported clause**: the part of a reporting structure that describes what someone has said; e.g. *She said that I couldn't see her.*

173. **reported question**: a question that is reported using a reporting structure rather than the exact words used by the speaker.

174. **reported speech**: speech that is reported using a reporting structure rather than the exact words used by the speaker.

    Also called **indirect speech**.

175. **reporting clause**: a clause that contains a reporting verb, which is used to introduce what someone has said; e.g. *They asked if I could come.*

176. **reporting verb**: a verb that describes what people say or think; e.g. *suggest, say, wonder.*

177. **reporting structure**: a structure that reports what someone has said by using a reported clause rather than repeating their exact words; e.g. *She told me she'd be late.*

178. **result clause**: a subordinate clause introduced by *so that* which gives the result of something; e.g. *The house was severely damaged, so that it is now uninhabitable.*

179. **rhetorical question**: a question that you use in order to make a comment rather than to obtain information; e.g. *Oh, isn't it silly?*

180. **second person**: see **person**.

181. **semi-modal**: the verbs *dare, need*, and *used to* which behave rather like modals.

182. **sentence**: a group of words that express a statement, question, or command.

    A sentence usually has a verb and a subject, and may consist of 1 clause, or 2 or more clauses.

    A sentence in writing has a capital letter at the beginning and a full-stop, question mark, or exclamation mark at the end.

183. **sentence adverbial**: an adverbial that applies to the whole clause, rather than to part of it; e.g. *We possibly have to wait and see.*

    See also **sentence connector**.

184. **sentence connector**: a sentence adverbial used to introduce a comment or reinforce what is said; e.g. *moreover, besides.*

185. ***s* form**: the base form of a verb with *s* on the end, used in the present simple.

186. **simple sentence**: a sentence that contains only 1 clause.

187. **singular**: the form used to refer to or talk about 1 person or thing; e.g. *dog, woman.*

    Cf. **plural**.

188. **singular noun**: a noun typically used in the singular form; e.g. *sun, business.*

189. **split infinitive**: the placing of a word between *to* and the base form of a verb; e.g. *... to boldly go where no man has gone before.*

190. **split sentence**: a sentence in which emphasis is given to either the subject or the object by using a structure beginning with *it, what*, or *all*; e.g. *It's a hammer we need... What we need is a hammer.*

191. **stative verb**: a verb that describes a state ; e.g. *be, live, know.*

    Cf. **dynamic verb**.

192. **subject**: a noun phrase that usually comes before a verb, and agrees with the verb in person and number.

     In active sentences, the subject usually refers to the person or thing who dose the action expressed by the verb; e.g. *We were going shopping.*

193. **subjunctive**: a verb form that is used in some languages to express attitudes e.g. wishing, hoping, and doubting.

     The subjunctive is not very common in English, and is used mainly in conditional clauses e.g. *If I were you...*

194. **submodifying adverb**: an adverb that is used in front of an adjective or another adverb in order to strengthen or weaken its meaning; e.g. *... very interesting... quite quickly.*

195. **subordinate clause**: a clause that begins with a subordinating conjunction e.g. *because* or *while* and which must be used with a main clause.

196. **subordinating conjunction**: a conjunction that begins a subordinate clause.

197. **substitution**: the special use of pronouns and other words to replace part or all of a clause; e.g. *'Are you going to the party?' – 'I hope so'.*

198. **superlative**: an adjective or adverb with *-est* on the end or *most* in front of it; e.g. *thinnest, quickest, most wisely.*

199. **tense**: the verb form that shows whether you are referring to the past or the present.

200. ***that*-clause**: a clause starting with '*that*' which is used mainly when reporting what someone has said; e.g. *She said that she'd wash up for me.*

     That can be omitted when the clause is used after a reporting verb.

201. **third person**: see **person**.

202. **time adverbial**: an adverbial that gives more information about when something happens; e.g. *I saw her yesterday.*

203. **time clause**: a subordinate clause that indicates the time of an event; e.g. *I'll phone you when I get back.*

204. **title**: a word used before a person's name to show their position or status; e.g. *Mrs, Lord, Queen.*

205. ***to*-infinitive**: the base form of a verb preceded by *to*; e.g. *to go, to have, to jump.*

206. **transitive verb**: a verb used to talk about an action or event that involves more than 1 person or thing, and so is followed by an object; e.g. *She's wasting her money.*

207. **uncountable noun**: a noun that refers to a general kind of thing rather than to an individual item, and so has only 1 form; e.g. *money, furniture, intelligence.*

     Also called **uncount noun**.

208. **verb**: a word used with a subject to say what someone or something does, or what happens to them; e.g. *sing, spill, die.*

209. **verb phrase**: a main verb, or a main verb preceded by 1 or more auxiliary verbs, which combines with a subject to say what someone or something does, or what happens to them; e.g. *I'll show them... She's been sick.*

210. **vocative**: a word used when speaking to someone, just as if it were their name; e.g. *darling, madam.*

211. ***wh*-clause**: a clause starting with a *wh*-word.

212. ***whether*-clause**: a clause used to report a *yes/no*-question; e.g. *I asked her whether she'd seen him.*

213. ***wh*-question**: a question that expects an answer giving a particular person, place, thing, amount, and so on, rather than just *yes* or *no*.

214. ***wh*-word**: 1 of a group of words starting with *wh-*, e.g. *what, when* or *who*, which are used in *wh*-questions.

     How is also called a *wh*-word because it behaves like the other *wh*-words.

215. ***yes/no*-question**: a question that can be answered simply with either *yes* or *no*; e.g. *Would you like some more tea?*

Chapter 1

Referring to people & things: nouns, pronouns, & determiners

1.1 Introduction to the noun phrase

1.1 At its simplest, language is used to talk about people and things.

People do this by using words in a variety of ways, e.g. to make statements, to ask questions, and to give orders.

The words chosen are arranged into groups, either around a noun or around a verb.

They are called **noun phrases** and **verb phrases**.

Noun phrases tell us which people or things are being talked about.

Verb phrases tell us what is being said about them, e.g. what they are doing.

Chaps. 1–2 of this grammar deal with noun phrases.

For information about verb phrases, see Chap. 3.

1.2 A noun phrase can be the **subject** or **object** of a verb, it can follow a **linking verb**, or it can be the object of a **preposition**.

Example 1.1.1. *Babies cry when they are hungry.*
I couldn't feel anger against him.
They were teachers.
Let us work together in peace.

1.3 You use a noun phrase to talk about someone or something by naming them.

You do this by using a general name, called a **noun** or **common noun**, or by using a specific name, called a **proper noun**.

Proper nouns are mainly used for people, places, and events.

Example 1.1.2. *Mary likes strawberries.*
I went to Drexel University and then I went to Pittsburgh to work for a psychiatrist.
We flew to Genera with British Airways.

See paragraphs **1.52–1.58** for more information about **proper nouns**.

1.4 If you use a common noun, you are saying that the person or thing you are talking about can be put in a set with others that are similar in some way.

If you just want to say that the person or thing is in that set, you use an **indefinite determiner** with the common noun.

Example 1.1.3. *I met a girl who was a student there.*
Have you got any comment to make about that?
There are some diseases that are clearly inherited.

If you want to show which member of a set you are talking about, you use a **definite determiner** with a common noun.

Example 1.1.4. *I put my arm round her shoulders.*
... the destruction of their city.
She came in to see me this morning.

See paragraphs **1.162–1.251** for more information about **determiners**, and paragraphs **1.13–1.92** for more information about **nouns**.

1.5 You may decide not to name the person or thing and to use a **pronoun** rather than a proper noun or common noun.

You usually do this because the person or thing has already been named, so you refer to them by using a **personal pronoun** or a **demonstrative pronoun**.

Example 1.1.5. *Max will believe us, won't he?*
'Could I speak to Sue, please?' - 'I'm sorry, she doesn't work here now.'
Some people have servants to cook for them.
This led to widespread criticism.

See paragraphs **1.95–1.106** for more information about **personal pronouns**, and paragraphs **1.124–1.127** for more information about **demonstrative pronouns**.

1.6 You may decide not to name the person or thing at all, e.g. because you do not want to, you think it is not important, you do not know, or you want to be vague or mysterious while telling a story.

In such cases you use an **indefinite pronoun**, which does not refer to any particular person or thing.

Example 1.1.6. *I had to say something.*
In this country nobody trusts anyone.
A moment later, his heart seemed to stop as he sensed the sudden movement of someone behind him.

See paragraphs **1.128–1.141** for more information about **indefinite pronouns**.

1.7 If you want to give more information about the person or thing you are talking about, rather than just giving their general or specific name, you can use a **modifier** e.g. an **adjective**, or you can add extra information in the form of a phrase or a clause, for example.

1.8 Most **adjectives** are used as modifiers.

Nouns are also often used as modifiers.

Example 1.1.7. *... a big city.*
... blue ink.
He opened the car door.
... the oil industry.

See paragraphs **2.2–2.168** for more information about **adjectives**, and paragraphs **2.169–2.174** for more information about **noun modifiers**.

1.9 You can add a prepositional phrase, a relative clause, a relative clause, an adverb of place of time, or a *to*-infinitive after the noun.

Example 1.1.8. *... a girl in a dark grey dress.*
... the man who employed me.
... the room upstairs.
... the desire to kill.

Adjectives and participles are also sometimes used after the noun, usually in combination with other words.

Example 1.1.9. *... the Minister responsible for national security.*
... the 3 cards lying on the table.

See paragraphs **2.272–2.302** for more details about information that is added after the noun.

1.10 In particular, prepositional phrases beginning with *of* are very common, because they can express many different kinds of relationship between the 2 noun phrases.

Example 1.1.10. *... strong feelings of jealousy.*
... a picture of a house.
... the rebuilding of the old hospital.
... the daughter of the village cobbler.
... problems of varying complexity.
... the arrival of the police.

For more information about the use of *of* in the noun phrase see paragraphs **2.277–2.283**.

1.11 If you want to refer separately to more than 1 person or thing, or you want to describe them in more than 1 way, you link noun phrases using the **conjunctions** *and, or*, or *but*.

Sometimes you use a common instead of *and*, or just put 1 word next to another.

Example 1.1.11. ... *a table and chair.*
... *his obligations with regard to Amanda, Robert and Matthew.*
... *some fruit or cheese afterwards.*
... *her long black skirt.*

See paragraphs **8.171–8.201** for more information about the use of conjunctions to link noun phrases and words within noun phrases.

1.12 If you want to say how many things you are talking about, or how much of something here is, you use **numbers** and **quantity expressions**.

Example 1.1.12. *Last year I worked 7 days a week 14 hours a day.*
She drinks lots of coffee.

Numbers are dealt with in paragraphs **2.208–2.239**, and **quantity expressions** are dealt with in **2.175–2.193**.

1.2 Identifying people & things: nouns

1.13 A noun is used to identity a person or thing.

In this chapter 6 main types of noun are described.

They are classified according to whether they have a plural form, whether they need a determiner in front of them, and whether they occur with a singular verb or a plural verb when they are the subject of the verb.

The 6 types are:

classification: **example**: **comments**: **paragraph**

1. **countable nouns**: a bird, birds: have plural, need determiner: **1.15–1.22**
2. **uncountable nouns**: happiness equipment: no plural, usually no determiner: **1.23–1.33**
3. **singular nouns**: the moon, a day: no plural, need determiner: **1.34–1.40**
4. **plural nouns**: clothes scissors: no singular: **1.41–1.46**
5. **collective nouns**: the public, the staff: either singular or plural verb: **1.47–1.51**
6. **proper nouns**: Mary, London, The United Nations: start with capital letter: **1.52–1.58**

Many nouns have a number of different meanings, and so can be, e.g., a countable noun for 1 meaning, an uncountable noun for another, and a singular noun for another.

There are few other groups of nouns with special features.

These are dealt with in paragraphs **1.59–1.92**.

1.14 Most nouns do not begin with a capital letter, unless they are used to start a sentence.

However, the following types of noun are always spelled with a capital letter:

- **proper nouns** or names

  Example 1.2.1. ... *my sister Elizabeth.*
  I love reading Shakespeare.
  I'll be in the office on Monday.
  I think he's gone to London.

  For more information on proper nouns, see paragraphs **1.52–1.58**.

  Proper nouns that are time expressions are dealt with a Chap. 4, and those that are place names in Chap. 6.

- nouns that identify people of a particular nationality, or languages

  Example 1.2.2. *Can you think of some typical problems experienced by Germans learning English?*

- nouns that are the name of a particular product

  Example 1.2.3. *He drives a Porsche.*
  Put a bit of Sellotape across it.

1.2.1 Things that can be counted: countable nouns

1.15 Many nouns have 2 forms, the **singular** form, which is used to refer to 1 person or thing, and the **plural** form, which is used to refer to more than 1 person or thing.

These nouns refer to people or things that can be counted.

You can put numbers in front of them.

Example 1.2.4. ... *book*... *books*.
... *day*... *days*.
... *3 brothers*.
... *10 minutes*.

These nouns make up the largest group of nouns in English.

They are called **countable nouns**.

1.16 When you use the singular form of a countable noun as the subject of a verb, you use a singular verb.

When you use the plural form of a countable noun as the subject, you use a plural verb.

Example 1.2.5. *A dog likes to eat far more meat than a human being.*
Bigger dogs cost more.

1.17 Countable nouns have a determiner in front of them when they are used in the singular.

Example 1.2.6. *He got into the car and started the motor.*
They left the house to go for a walk after lunch.

When you use the plural form of a countable noun to talk about something in general, you do not use a determiner.

Example 1.2.7. *They all live in big houses.*
Most classrooms have computers.

However, if you are specifying a particular instance of something, you need to use a determiner.

Example 1.2.8. *The houses in our street are all identical.*
Our computers can give you all the relevant details.

1.18 Here is a list of some common countable nouns:

Example 1.2.9. *accident, account, actor, address, adult, animal, answer, apartment, article, artist, baby, bag, ball, bank, battle, beach, bed, bell, bill, bird, boat, book, bottle, box, boy, bridge, brother, bus, bush, camp, captain, car, card, case, castle, cat, chair, chapter, chest, child, cigarette, city, class, club, coat, college, computer, corner, country, crowd, cup, daughter, day, desk, doctor, dog, door, dream, dress, driver, ear, edge, effect, egg, election, engine, eye, face, factory, farm, father, field, film, finger, foot, friend, game, garden, gate, girl, group, gun, hall, hand, handle, hat, head, heart, hill, horse, hospital, hotel, hour, house, husband, idea, island, issue, job, journey, judge, key, king, kitchen, lady, lake, library, line, list, machine, magazine, man, meal, meeting, member, message, method, minute, mistake, model, month, motor, mouth, nation, neck, newspaper, office, page, park, party, path, picture, plan, plane, plant, problem, product, programme, project, ring, river, road, room, scheme, school, ship, shirt, shock, shop, sister, smile, son, spot, star, station, store, stream, street, student, table, task, teacher, tent, thought, tour, town, valley, village, walk, wall, week, window, woman, yard, year*

Note that many of these nouns have some meanings in which they are uncountable nouns, but they are countable nouns in their commonest meanings.

1.19 For most countable nouns the plural form has *-s* at the end, which distinguishes it from the singular form.

Example 1.2.10. ... *bed*... *beds*.
... *car*... *cars*.

Some countable nouns have other differences between the singular and plural forms.

Example 1.2.11. ... *bus*... *buses*.
... *lady*... *ladies*.
... *calf*... *calves*.
... *man*... *men*.
... *mouse*... *mice*.

For full information about the plural forms of countable nouns, see the Reference section.

1.20 Some countable nouns have the same form for both singular and plural.

Example 1.2.12. *... a sheep.*
... 9 sheep.

Many of these nouns refer to animals or fish; others are more varied in meaning:

Example 1.2.13. *bison, deer, elk, greenfly, grouse, moose, reindeer, sheep*
cod, fish, goldfish, halibut, mullet, salmon, shellfish, trout, whitebait
aircraft, hovercraft, spacecraft
crossroads, dice, fruit, gallows, grapefruit, insignia, mews, offspring, series, species
bourgeois, chassis, corps, patois, précis, rendezvous

1.21 The names of many animals and birds have 2 forms, one singular and one plural.
However, when you are referring to them in the context of hunting or when you are saying that there are large numbers of them, it is quite common to use the form without *-s*, even though you are referring to several animals or birds.

Example 1.2.14. *We went up north to hunt deer.*

Note that the plural form of the verb is used when several animals or birds are the subject of the sentence, even if you use the form without *-s*.

Example 1.2.15. *Zebra are a more difficult prey.*

Similarly, when you are referring to a large number of trees or plants growing together, you can use the singular form of their name.
When you are referring to a small number or to individual trees or plants, you usually use the form with *-s*.

Example 1.2.16. *Zebra are a more difficult prey.*

Similarly, when you are referring to a large number of trees or plants growing together, you can use the singular form of their name.
When you are referring to a small number or to individual trees or plants, you usually use the form with *-s*.

Example 1.2.17. *... the rows of willow and cypress which lined the creek.*
... the poplars and willows along the Peshawar Road.

1.22 [**Be creative**] Although some names of animals, birds, trees, and plants are commonly used in the singular form with plural meaning, in fact all such names can be used in this way.

1.2.2 Things not usually counted: uncountable nouns

1.23 Some nouns refer to general things e.g. qualities, substances, processes, and topics rather than to individual items or events.
These nouns have only 1 form, are not used with numbers, and are not usually used with the determiners *the, a*, or *an*.

Example 1.2.18. *... a boy or girl with intelligence.*
Make sure everyone has enough food and drink.
... new techniques in industry and agriculture.
I talked with people about religion, death, marriage, money, and happiness.

These nouns are called **uncountable nouns**.
1.24 When you use an uncountable noun as the subject of a verb, you use a singular form of the verb.

Example 1.2.19. *Love makes you do strange things.*
They believed that poverty was a threat to world peace.
Electricity is potentially dangerous.

1.25 Here is a list of some common uncountable nouns:

Example 1.2.20. *absence, access, age, agriculture, anger, atmosphere, beauty, behavior, cancer, capacity, childhood, china, comfort, concern, confidence, courage, death, democracy, depression, design, duty, earth, education, electricity, energy, environment, equipment, evil, existence, experience, failure, faith, fashion, fear, finance, fire, flesh, food, freedom, fun, ground, growth, happiness, health, help, history, ice, independence, industry, insurance, intelligence, joy, justice, labor, loneliness, love, luck, magic, marriage, mercy, music, nature, paper, patience, peace, philosophy, pleasure, policy, poverty, power, pride, protection, purity, rain, reality, refief, religion, respect, rice, safety, salt, sand, security, silence, sleep, strength, snow, spite, status, stuff, teaching, technology, time, trade, training, transport, travel, trust, truth, violence, waste, water, wealth, weather, welfare, wind, work, worth, youth*

1.26 [!] There are some words that are uncountable nouns in English, but that refer to things that are considered countable in other languages.

Here is a list of the most common uncountable nouns of this type:

Example 1.2.21. *advice, baggage, furniture, hair, homework, information, knowledge, luggage, machinery, money, news, progress, research, spaghetti, traffic*

1.27 Although uncountable nouns refer to things that cannot be counted and are not used with numbers, you often want to talk about an amount of something that is expressed by an uncountable noun.

Sometimes, you can do this by putting an **indefinite determiner** e.g. *all, enough, little*, or *some* in front of the noun.

Example 1.2.22. *Do you have enough money?*
There's some chocolate cake over there.

For more information on indefinite determiners that can be used with uncountable nouns, see paragraph **1.225**.

You can also put a **quantity expression** in front of the noun.

E.g., when you refer to water you can say *drops of water, a cup of water, 4 gallons of water*, and so on.

The use of quantity expressions with uncountable nouns is explained in paragraphs **2.194**–**2.207**.

1.28 When you are sure that your reader or hearer will understand that a quantity of something is being referred to, you do not need to use a quantity expression.

E.g., in a restaurant you can ask for *3 cups of coffee*, but you can also ask for *3 coffees* because the person you are talking to will know that you mean *3 cups of coffee*.

In this way, the uncountable noun *coffee* has become countable.

Nouns used in this way are called **mass nouns**.

1.29 Mass nouns are often used to refer to quantities of a particular kind of food or drink.

Example 1.2.23. *We spent 2 hours talking over coffee and biscuits in her study.*
We stopped for a coffee at a small café.

1.30 Similarly, some uncountable nouns can be mass nouns when they refer to types of something,

E.g., *cheese* is usually an uncountable noun but you can talk about *a large range of cheeses*.

Example 1.2.24. *... plentiful cheap beer.*
... profits from low-alcohol beers.
We were not allowed to buy wine or spirits at lunch time.
We shell a wide variety of wines and liqueurs.

Mass nouns referring to different types of a substance are mainly used in technical contexts.

E.g. *steel* is nearly always an uncountable noun, but in contexts where it is important to distinguish between different kinds of steel it can be a mass noun.

Example 1.2.25. *... imports of European steel.*
... the use of small amounts of nitrogen in making certain steels.

1.31 The following is a list of frequency used mass nouns:

Example 1.2.26. *adhesive, beer, brandy, bread, cake, cheese, claret, cloth, coal, coffee, cognac, coke, cotton, curry, deodorant, detergent, disinfectant, dye, fabric, fertilizer, fuel, fur, fin, glue, ink, insecticide, iron, jam, jelly, juice, lager, liqueur, lotion, material, meat, medicine, metal, milk, oil, ointment, ore, paint, perfume, pesticide, plastic, poison, preservative, ribbon, salad, sauce, sherry, soap, soil, soup, steel, sugar, tea, vodka, whisky, wine, wood, wool, yarn, yoghurt*

1.32 There are also some other nouns that can be uncountable nouns when they refer to a thing in general, and countable nouns when they refer to a particular instance of it.

Some nouns are commonly both uncountable nouns and countable nouns.

E.g., *victory* refers to the idea of winning in general but *a victory* refers to a particular occasion when someone wins.

Example 1.2.27. *He worked long and hard and finally led his team to victory.*
... his victory in the Australian Grand Prix.
Many parents were alarmed to find themselves in open conflict with the church.
Hundreds of people have died in ethnic conflicts.

Some uncountable nouns are rarely or never countable nouns; i.e., they do not occur in a plural form, or with a number.

Example 1.2.28. *... a collection of fine furniture.*
We found Alan weeping with relief and joy.
He saved money by refusing to have a telephone.

1.33 Some nouns that end in *-s* and look as if they are plural are in fact uncountable nouns.
This means that when they are the subject of a verb, the verb is in the singular.
These nouns refer mainly to subjects to study, activities, games, and diseases.

Example 1.2.29. *Physics is fun.*
Politics plays a large part in village life.
Economics is the oldest of the social sciences.
Darts is a very competitive sport.
Measles is in most cases a relatively harmless disease.

Here are 3 lists of uncountable nouns ending in *-s*.
These nouns refer to subjects of study and activities:

Example 1.2.30. *acoustics, aerobics, aerodynamics, aeronautics, athletics, classics, economics, electronics, genetics, gymnastics, linguistics, logistics, mathematics, mechanics, obstetrics, physics, politics, statistics, thermodynamics*

Note that some of these nouns are occasionally used as plural nouns, especially when you are talking about a particular person's work or activities.

Example 1.2.31. *His politics are clearly right-wing.*

These nouns refer to games:

Example 1.2.32. *billiards, bowls, cards, darts, draughts, skittles, tiddlywinks*

These nouns refer to diseases:

Example 1.2.33. *diabetes, measles, mumps, rabies, rickets, shingles*

1.2.3 When there is only 1 of something: singular nouns

1.34 There are certain things in the world that are unique.
There are other things that you almost always want to talk about one at a time.
This means that there are some nouns, or more often some meanings of nouns, for which only a singular form is used.
When a noun is used with such a meaning, it is called a **singular noun**.
Singular nouns are always used with a determiner, because they behave like the singular form of a countable noun.
1.35 When you use a singular noun as the subject of a verb, you use a singular form of the verb.

Example 1.2.34. *The sun was shining.*
The atmosphere is very relaxed.

1.36 Some singular nouns refer to 1 specific thing and therefore are used with the.
Some of these nouns, in fact, refer to something of which there is only one in the world.

Example 1.2.35. *There were huge cracks in the ground.*
The moon had not yet reached my window.
Burning tanks threw great spirals of smoke into the air.
He's always thinking about the the past and worrying about the future.

1.37 Other singular nouns can be used to refer to 1 thing only when it is obvious from the context what you are referring to.
E.g., if you are in Leeds and say *I work at the university*, you will almost certainly mean Leeds University.
However, in the following examples it is not clear exactly who or what the singular noun refers to, because there is not enough context.

Example 1.2.36. *In many countries the market is small numerically.*
Their company looks good only because the competition looks bad.
You've all missed the point.

Unless it is made clear which goods or products are being talked about, it is not possible for the reader or listener to be sure which group of potential buyers *the market* refers to.

Similarly it is not possible to know exactly which company or group of companies *the competition* refers to.

In the last example, the speaker is presumably going to state what he or she thinks *the point* is.

1.38 There are some activities that you do not usually do more than once at a time.

The nouns that refer to them are usually the object of a verb, and are used with the determiner *a*.

In this structure the verb has very little meaning and the noun carries most of the meaning of the whole structure.

For more information about these verb + object idioms, see paragraphs **3.32**–**3.45**.

Example 1.2.37. *I went and had a wash.*
Bruno gave it a try.

Some singular nouns are used so regularly with a particular verb that they have become fixed phrases and are idiomatic.

Example 1.2.38. *I'd like very much for you to have a voice in the decision.*
Isn't it time we made a move?

1.39 There are 2 special kinds of structure in which a singular noun is used.

A singular noun is sometimes used with the determiner *a* after a linking verb.

See paragraphs **3.126**–**3.181** for more information about **linking verbs**.

Example 1.2.39. *Decision-making is an art.*
The quickest way was by using the car.
It was a risk but he decided it had to be taken.
They were beginning to find Griffiths' visits rather a strain.

A singular noun is sometimes used with the determiner *the*, followed by a prepositional phrase beginning with *of*.

Example 1.2.40. *Comedy is the art of making people laugh.*
Old machines will be replaced by newer ones to reduce the risk of breakdown.
He collapsed under the strain of a heavy workload.

This group includes nouns used metaphorically; see paragraph **1.64** for more details.

Some singular nouns are always used to refer to 1 particular quality or thing, but are rarely used alone; i.e., they need to be specified in some way by the use of supporting material.

They can be used with a number of different determiners.

Example 1.2.41. *There was a note of satisfaction in his voice.*
Bessie covered the last 50 yards at a tremendous pace.
Simon allowed his pace to slacken.
She was simply incapable of behaving in a rational and considered manner.
... their manner of rearing their young.

Nouns that are rarely used alone without supporting material are discussed in detail in paragraphs **1.59**–**1.65**.

[i] Usage note.

1.40 Some nouns are used in the singular with a particular meaning only in an idiomatic phrase.

They have the appearance of singular nouns, but they are not used as freely as singular nouns.

Example 1.2.42. *What happens down there is none of my business.*
It's a pity I can't get to him.

1.2.4 Referring to more than 1 thing: plural nouns

1.41 There are some things that are considered to be plural rather than singular, so some nouns have only a plural form.

E.g., you buy *goods*, but not *a good*.

These nouns are called **plural nouns**.

Other nouns have only a plural form when they are used with a particular meaning.

E.g., an official meeting between American and Russian leaders is usually referred to as *talks* rather than as *a talk*.

In these meanings, these nouns are also called **plural nouns**.

Example 1.2.43. *Union leaders met the company for wage talks on Oct 9.*
It is inadvisable to sell goods on a sale or return basis.
Take care of your clothes.
The weather conditions were the same.
All proceeds are going to charity.
Employees can have meals on the premises.

Note that some plural nouns do not end in *-s*: e.g. *clergy, police, poultry*, and *vermin*.

1.42 When you use a plural noun as the subject of a verb, you use plural form of the verb.

Example 1.2.44. *Expenses for attending meetings are sometimes claimed.*
The foundations were shaking.
Refreshments were on sale in the café.
Attempts were made where resources were available.

1.43 You do not usually use numbers in front of plural nouns.

You can, however, use some **indefinite determiners** e.g. *some* or *many*.

For more information about the indefinite determiners that can be used with plural nouns, see the section beginning at paragraph **1.223**.

Some plural nouns usually have a definite determiner in front of them, because they are specific; some never have a determiner at all, because they are very general; and some are rarely used alone without extra information in the form of a phrase or a clause, e.g., because they need supporting material.

The lists in the following 2 paragraphs contain some common plural nouns that are frequently used in 1 of these ways.

Many of them have other meanings in which they are countable nouns.

1.44 Some plural nouns are most commonly used with *the*.

Example 1.2.45. *Things are much worse when the rains come.*
The authorities are concerned that the cocaine may be part of an international drug racket.
The coach tour of Gran Canaria was a wonderfully relaxing way to see the sights.

Here is a list of plural nouns that are most commonly used with *the*:

Example 1.2.46. *authorities, foundations, fruits, heavens, mains, odds, pictures, races, rains, sights, waters, wilds*

Some plural nouns are most commonly used with a possessive determiner e.g. *my* or *his*:

Example 1.2.47. *It offended her feelings.*
My travels up the Dalmation coast began in Dubrovnik.
This only added to his troubles.

Here is a list of plural nouns that are most commonly used with a possessive determiner:

Example 1.2.48. *activities, attentions, feelings, likes, movements, reactions, terms, travels, troubles, wants*

Some plural nouns are most commonly used without a determiner.

Example 1.2.49. *There were 1 or 2 cases where people returned goods.*
There is only 1 applicant, which simplifies matters.
They treated us like vermin.

Here is a list of plural nouns that are most commonly used without a determiner:

Example 1.2.50. *airs, appearances, events, expenses, figures, goods, matters, refreshments, riches, solids, talks, vermin*

Some plural nouns can be used both with or without determiners.

Example 1.2.51. *The house was raided by police.*
We call the police.
A luxury hotel was to be used as headquarters.
The city has been his headquarters for 5 years.
We didn't want it to dampen spirits which were required to remain positive.
The last few miles really lifted our spirits.

Here is a list of plural nouns that can be used with or without a determiner:

Example 1.2.52. *arms, basics, brains, clergy, costs, directions, essentials, greens, grounds, handcuffs, headquarters, interests, looks, means, morals, papers, particulars, people, police, poultry, premises, proceeds, rates, resources, specifics, spirits, supplies, talks, thanks, tracks, troops, values*

1.45 Some plural nouns are rarely used alone without a modifier, or some other form of extra information, because they need supporting material.

Example 1.2.53. *He doesn't tolerate bad manners.*
Our country's coastal defences need improving.
... the hidden pressures of direct government funding.

Here is a list of plural nouns that are rarely used alone without a modifier or some other extra information:

Example 1.2.54. *affairs, conditions, defences, demands, details, effects, forces, hopes, lines, manners, materials, matters, pressures, proportions, quarters, relations, remains, sands, services, thoughts, wastes, ways, words, works, writings*

1.46 2 special groups of nouns are usually plural: nouns referring to clothes and some other things that people wear, and nouns referring to tools and some other things that people use.
This is because some clothes and tools, e.g. *trousers* and *scissors*, are made up of 2 similar parts.

Example 1.2.55. *She wore brown trousers and a green sweater.*
He took off his glasses.
... using the pliers from the toolbox.

When you want to refer to these items in general, or to an unspecified number of them, you use the plural form with no determiner.

Example 1.2.56. *Never poke scissors into a light bulb socket.*
The man was watching the train through binoculars.

Here is a list of some plural nouns that refer to clothes and other things that people wear:

Example 1.2.57. *braces, briefs, cords, dungarees, glasses, jeans, jodhpurs, knickers, leggings, overalls, panties, pants, pyjamas, shorts, slacks, specs, spectacles, sunglasses, tights, trousers, trunks, underpants*

Here is a list of plural nouns that refer to tools and other things that people use:

Example 1.2.58. *binoculars, clippers, compasses, dividers, nutcrackers, pincers, pliers, scales, scissors, secateurs, shears, tongs, tweezers*

When you want to refer to a single piece of clothing or a single tool, you use *some* or *a pair of* in front of the noun.
You refer to more than 1 item by using a number or a quantity expression with *pairs of*.

Example 1.2.59. *I got some scissors out of the kitchen drawer.*
I went out to buy a pair of scissors.
He was wearing a pair of old grey trousers.
Liza has 3 pairs of jeans.

You can also use *a pair of* when you are talking about things e.g. gloves, shoes, and socks that typically occur in twos.

Example 1.2.60. *... a pair of new gloves.*

A possessive determiner e.g. *my* can be used instead of *a*.

Example 1.2.61. *... his favorite pair of shoes.*

When you use *a pair of* with a noun in the plural form, the verb is singular if it is in the same clause.
If the verb is in a following relative clause, it is usually plural.

Example 1.2.62. *It is likely that a new pair of shoes brings more happiness to a child than a new car brings to a grown-up.*
I always wear a pair of long pants underneath, or a pair of pyjamas is just as good.
He put on a pair of brown shoes, which were waiting there for him.
He wore a pair of earphones, which were plugged into a radio.

You use a plural pronoun after *a pair of*.

Example 1.2.63. *She went to the wardrobe, chose a pair of shoes, put them on and leaned back in the chair.*
He brought out a pair of dark glasses and handed them to Walker.

1.2.5 Referring to groups: collective nouns

1.47 Some nouns in English refer to a group of people or things.

These nouns are called **collective nouns**.

They have only 1 form, but many collective nouns have other meanings in which they are countable nouns with 2 forms.

1.48 When you use a collective noun, you can use either a singular verb or a plural verb after it.

You choose a singular verb if you think of the group as a single unit, and a plural verb if you think of the group as a number of individuals.

Example 1.2.64. *Our little group is complete again.*
A 2nd group are those parents who feel that we were too harsh.
Our family isn't poor any more.
My family are all perfectly normal.
The enemy was moving slowly to the east.
The enemy were visibly cracking.
His arguments were confined to books which the public was unlikely to read.
The public were deceived by the newspapers.

[AE] In American English, it is more usual to use a singular verb unless the sentence contains an element that clearly refers to more than 1 person or thing.

The names of many organizations are collective nouns, and can be used with a singular or a plural verb.

Example 1.2.65. *The BBC is sending him to Tuscany for the summer.*
The BBC are planning to use the new satellite next month.
England was leading 18-0 at half-time.
England are seeking alternatives for their B team.

[AE] American English uses a singular verb for these.

Example 1.2.66. *GE reports its 2nd-quarter financial results on Jul 16.*
New England is going to sign him to a long-term contract.

If you want to refer back to a collective noun, you choose a singular pronoun or determiner if the previous verb is singular, and a plural pronoun or determiner if the previous verb is plural.

Example 1.2.67. *The government has said it would wish to do this only if there was no alternative.*
The government have made up their minds that they're going to win.

[i] Usage note.

1.49 Note that the words *bacteria, data*, and *media* are now often used as collective nouns, that is with either a singular or a plural verb and no change in form.

Some careful speakers think they should only be used with a plural verb because they have the rare singular forms *bacterium, datum*, and *medium* and are therefore countable nouns.

Example 1.2.68. *Medieval Arabic data show that the length of the day has been increasing more slowly than expected.*
Our latest data shows more firms are hoping to expand in the near future.

1.50 [!] Although you can use a plural verb after a collective noun, these nouns do not behave like the plural forms of countable nouns.

E.g., you cannot use numbers in front of them.

You cannot say *3 enemy were killed.*

You have to say *3 of the enemy were killed.*

1.51 Here is a list of common collective nouns:

Example 1.2.69. *aristocracy, army, audience, bacteria, brood, cast, committee, community, company, council, crew, data, enemy, family, flock, gang, government, group, herd, jury, media, navy, nobility, opposition, panel, press, proletariat, public, staff, team*

Some collective nouns are also **partitives** (nouns that are used to talk about a quantity of something).

E.g., you talk about *a flock of sheep* and *a herd of cattle.*

See paragraph **2.198** for more information about these.

1.2.6 Referring to people & things by name: proper nouns

1.52 When you talk about a particular person, you can use their name.
Names are usually called **proper nouns**.
People's names are spelled with a capital letter, and do not have a determiner in front of them.

Example 1.2.70. *... Michael Hall... Jenny... Smith.*

Ways of using people's names when you are speaking to them directly are explained in paragraph **9.95–9.99**.

1.53 Sometimes a person's name is used to refer to something they create.
You can refer to a painting, sculpture, or book by a particular person by using the person's name like a countable noun.
You still spell it with a capital letter.

Example 1.2.71. *In those days you could buy a Picasso for £300.*
I was looking at their Monets and Matisses.
I'm reading an an Agatha Christie at the moment.

You can refer to music composed or performed by a particular person by using the person's name like an uncountable noun.

Example 1.2.72. *I remembered it when we were listening to the Mozart.*
... instead of playing Chopin and Stravinsky all the time.

1.54 Nouns that refer to relationships between the people in a family, e.g. *mother, dad, aunt*, and *grandpa*, can also be used like names to address people or refer to them.
They are then spelled with a capital letter.

Example 1.2.73. *I'm sure Mum will be pleased.*

1.55 Words that show someone's social status or job are called **titles**.
They are spelled with a capital letter.
You use a title in front of a person's name, usually their surname or their full name, when you are talking about them in a fairly formal way or are showing respect to them.

Example 1.2.74. *... Doctor Barker... Lord Curzon... Captain Jack Langtry... Mrs Ford.*

Here is a list of the most common titles that are used before names:

Example 1.2.75. *Admiral, Archbishop, Baron, Baroness, Bishop, Brother, Captain, Cardinal, Colonel, Congressman, Constable, Corporal, Dame, Doctor, Emperor, Father, General, Governor, Imam, Inspector, Justice, King, Lady, Lieutenant, Lord, Major, Miss, Mr, Mrs, Ms, Nurse, Police Constable, Pope, President, Prince, Princess, Private, Professor, Queen, Rabbi, Representative, Saint, Senator, Sergeant, Sir, Sister*

A few titles, e.g. *King, Queen, Prince, Princess, Sir*, and *Lady*, can be followed just by the person's 1st name.

Example 1.2.76. *... Queen Elizabeth.*
... Prince Charles' eldest son.
Sir Michael has made it very clear indeed.

Ways of using titles when you are speaking to people directly are explained in paragraphs **9.97–9.98**.

1.56 Determiners, other modifiers, and phrases with *of* are sometimes used with titles, and the person's name is omitted.

Example 1.2.77. *... Her Majesty the Queen and the Duke of Edinburgh.*
... the Archbishop of Canterbury.
... the President of the United States.
... the Bishop of Birmingham.

1.57 Most words that are titles can also be countable nouns, usually without a capital letter.

Example 1.2.78. *... lawyers, scholars, poets, presidents and so on.*
... a foreign prince.
Maybe he'll be a Prime Minister 1 day.

1.58 The names of organizations, institutions, ships, magazines, books, plays, paintings, and other unique things are also proper nouns and are spelled with capital letters.

Example 1.2.79. ... *British Broadcasting Corporation*
... *Birmingham University.*

They are sometimes used with *the* or another determiner.

Example 1.2.80. ... *the United Nations* ... *the Labor Party*... *the University of Birmingham*... *the Queen Mary*... *the Guardian*... *the Wall Street Journal*... *the British Broadcasting Corporation.*

The determiner is not spelled with a capital letter, except in the names of books, plays, and paintings.

Example 1.2.81. ... *The Grapes of Wrath.*
... *A Midsummer Night's Dream.*

Some time expressions are proper nouns, and are dealt with in Chap. 4.

1.2.7 Nouns that are rarely used alone

1.59 There are some nouns that are rarely used alone.

They need extra material e.g. an adjective or a following phrase, because the meaning of the noun would not be clear without it.

Some of these nouns have many meanings; others have very little meaning on their own.

E.g., you cannot usually refer to someone as *the head* without saying which organization they are head of.

Similarly, you cannot say that there was *a note* in someone's voice without describing it as, e.g., *a triumphant note* or *a note of triumph.*

These nouns are used on their own only if it is obvious from the context what is meant.

E.g., if you have just mentioned a mountain and you say *the top*, it is clear that you mean the top of that mountain.

1.60 A **modifier** is an adjective or a noun that is added to a noun in order to give more information about it.

Example 1.2.82. ... *her wide experience of political affairs.*
I detected an apologetic note in the agent's voice.
He did not have British citizenship.
Check the water level.

For more information on modifiers, see Chap. 2.

1.61 Extra information after the noun is usually in the form of a phrase beginning with *of.*

Example 1.2.83. ... *at the top of the hill.*
There he saw for himself the extent of the danger.
Ever since the rise of industrialism, education has concentrated on producing workers.
... *a high level of interest.*

For more information, see paragraphs **2.272**–**2.302**.

1.62 Some nouns are always used with a modifier.

E.g., you would not say that someone is *an eater* because all people eat, but you may want to say that he or she is *a meat eater* or *a messy eater.*

Similarly, if you use *range*, you have to refer to a particular *price range* or *age range.*

If you use *wear* to mean *clothing*, you have to say what sort of clothing, e.g. *sports wear* or *evening wear.*

Example 1.2.84. *Time was a slow eater.*
... *the other end of the age range.*
The company has plans to expand its casual wear.

1.63 Some nouns are almost always used with a possessive, that is a **possessive determiner**, **'s**, or a prepositional phrase beginning with *of*, because you have to show who or what the thing you are talking about relates to or belongs to.

Example 1.2.85. *The company has grown rapidly since its formation 10 years ago.*
Advance warning of the approach of enemies was of the greatest importance.
... *the portrait of a man in his prime.*

1.64 Nouns that are being used metaphorically (= when 1 thing is used to describe another thing) often have a modifier or some other form of extra information, often in the form of a phrase beginning with *of*, to show what is really being referred to.

Example 1.2.86. ... *the maze of politics.*
He has been prepared to sacrifice this company on the altar of his own political ambitions.
He has worked out a scheme for an economic lifeline by purchasing land.
Lloyd's of London is the heart of the world's insurance industry.
... those on the lower rungs of the professional ladder.

1.65 Many nouns have some meanings that need a modifier or some other form of extra information, and other meanings that do not.

Here is a list of these nouns:

Example 1.2.87. *affair, approach, area, back, band, base, bottom, boundary, branch, case, center, circumstances, citizenship, class, condition, crisis, culture, depth, development, discovery, eater, edge, edition, element, end, enterprise, epidemic, experience, extent, feeling, field, formation, fringe, ground, growth, head, height, impression, inception, kind, length, level, limit, line, matter, movement, nature, note, period, point, position, power, prime, range, rate, regime, relic, repertoire, rise, role, scale, side, sort, stage, status, structure, stuff, style, system, texture, theory, thought, time, tone, top, transfer, type, version, view, wave, way, wear, wing, world*

1.2.8 Adjectives used as nouns: *the poor, the impossible*

1.66 When you want to talk about groups of people who share the same characteristic or equality, you can use *the* + adjective.

E.g., instead of saying *poor people*, you can say *the poor*.

Example 1.2.88. ... *the help that's given to the blind.*
No effort is made to cater for the needs of the elderly.
... the task of rescuing the injured.
... men and women who would join the sad ranks of the unemployed.
Working with the young is stimulating and full of surprises.
... providing care for the sick, the aged, the workless and the poor.

Note that you never add *-s* to the adjective, even though it always refers to more than 1 person.

1.67 [⋆] Although some adjectives are commonly used in this way, in fact it is possible to use almost any adjective in this way.

1.68 When the adjective being used as a noun is the subject of a verb, you use a plural form of the verb.

Example 1.2.89. *The rich have benefited much more than the poor.*

1.69 If you want to talk about a more specific group of people, you put a **submodifying adverb** (= an adverb that you put in front of an adjective to give more information about it) or another adjective in front of the headword.

For more information about submodifying adverbs, see paragraphs **2.140–2.168**.

Example 1.2.90. *In this anecdote, Ray shows his affection for the very old and the very young.*
... the highly educated.
... the urban poor.

If you mention 2 groups, you sometimes omit *the*.

Example 1.2.91. ... *a study that compared the diets of rich and poor in several nations.*
... to help break down the barriers between young and old.

With a few words e.g. *unemployed* and *dead*, you can say how many people you are referring to by putting a number in front of them.

Example 1.2.92. *We estimate there are about 300 dead.*

1.70 When you want to refer to the quality of something rather than to the thing itself, you can use the appropriate adjective with *the*.

Example 1.2.93. *Don't you think that you're wanting the impossible?*
He is still exploring the limits of the possible.
... a mix of the traditional and the modern.

1.71 All color adjectives can also be used as nouns.

Example 1.2.94. *... patches of blue.*
... brilliant paintings in reds and greens and blues.

Clothing of a particular color can be referred to simply by using the color adjective.

Example 1.2.95. *The men wore grey.*
... the fat lady in black.

[i] Usage note.
1.72 Nationality adjectives that end in *-ch, -sh, -se*, or *-ss* can be used in a similar way, unless there is a separate noun for the people.
E.g., French people are referred to as *the French* but Polish people are referred to as *Poles* or *the Poles*.

Example 1.2.96. *For many years the Japanese have dominated the market for Chinese porcelain.*
Britons are the biggest consumers of chocolate after the Swiss and the Irish.

1.2.9 Nouns referring to males or females

1.73 English nouns are not masculine, feminine, or neuter in the way that nouns in some other languages are.
E.g., most names of jobs, e.g. *teacher, doctor*, and *writer*, are used for both men and women.
But some nouns refer only to males and others only to females.
E.g., some nouns indicating people's family relationships, e.g. *father, brother*, and *son*, and some nouns indicating people's jobs, e.g. *waiter* and *policeman*, are used only to refer to males.
In the same way *mother, sister, daughter, waitress, actress*, and *sportswoman* are used only to refer to females.
1.74 Words that refer to women often end in *-ess*, e.g. *actress, waitress*, and *hostress*.
Another ending is *-woman*, as in *policewoman* and *sportswoman*.

Example 1.2.97. *... his wife Susannah, a former air stewardess.*
A policewoman dragged me out of the crowd.
Steph Burton was named sportswoman of the year.

1.75 Words ending in *-man* are either used to refer only to men or to both men and women.
E.g., a *postman* is a man, but a *spokesman* can be a man or a woman.
Some people now use words ending in *-person*, e.g. *chairperson* and *spokesperson*, instead of words ending in *-man*, in order to avoid appearing to refer specifically to a man.
[i] Usage note.
1.76 Most names of animals are used to refer to both male and female animals, e.g. *cat, elephant, horse, monkey*, and *sheep*.
In some cases there are different words that refer specifically to male animals or female animals, e.g. a male horse is a *stallion* and a female horse is a *mare*.
In other cases the general name for the animal is also the specific word for males or females: *dog* also refers more specifically to male dogs, *duck* also refers more specifically to female ducks.
Many of these specific words are rarely used, or used mainly by people who have a special interest in animals, e.g. farmers or vets.
Here is a list of some common specific words for male and female animals:

Example 1.2.98. *stallion, mare*
bull, cow
cock, hen
dog, bitch
drake, duck
fox, vixen
gander, goose
lion, lioness
ram, ewe
buck, hind, stag, doe
tiger, tigress
boar, sow

1.2.10 Referring to activities & processes: *-ing* nouns

1.77 When you want to talk about an action, activity, or process in a general way, you can use a noun that has the same form as the *-ing* participle of a verb.

These nouns are called different things in different grammars: gerunds, verbal nouns, or *-ing* forms.

In this grammar they are referred to as ***-ing* nouns**.

It is sometimes difficult to distinguish and ***-ing* noun** from an ***-ing* participle**, and it is usually not necessary to do so.

However, there are times when it is clearly a noun, e.g. when it is the subject of a verb, the object of a verb, or the object of a preposition.

Example 1.2.99. *Swimming is a great sport.*
The emphasis was on teaching rather than learning.
The closing of so many mills left thousands unemployed.
Some people have never done any public speaking.

The spelling of *-ing* nouns is explained in the Reference section.

The use of *-ing* adjectives is explained in paragraphs **2.63**–**2.76**.

1.78 Because *-ing* nouns refer to activities in a general way, they are usually **uncountable nouns**; i.e., they have only 1 form, cannot be used with numbers, and do not usually have a determiner in front of them.

For more information on uncountable nouns, see paragraphs **1.23**–**1.33**.

1.79 You often use an *-ing* noun because it is the only noun form available for certain verbs, e.g. *eat, hear, go, come*, and *bless*.

Other verbs have related nouns that are not *-ing* nouns: e.g. *see* and *sight*; *arrive* and *arrival*, *depart* and *departure*.

Example 1.2.100. *Eating is an important part of a cruise holiday.*
. . . loss of hearing in 1 ear.
Only 6% of children receive any further training when they leave school.

1.80 If you want to describe the action expressed by the noun, you use 1 or more adjectives or nouns in front of it.

Example 1.2.101. *He served a jail sentence for reckless driving.*
The police need better training in dealing with the mentally ill.
He called for a national campaign against under-age drinking.

1.81 A few *-ing* nouns, mostly words for sporting or leisure activities, and much more common than their related verbs.

In some cases there is no verb, although it is always possible to invent one.

E.g., you are more likely to say *We want caravanning around France* than *We caravanned around France.*

Here is a list of the commonest of these nouns:

Example 1.2.102. *angling, boating, bowling, canoeing, caravanning, electioneering, hang-gliding, mountaineering, paragliding, shoplifting, shopping, sightseeing, skateboarding, snorkeling, snowboarding, surfing, weightlifting, window-shopping, windsurfing, yachting*

Although these words are not always associated with a verb, most of them can be used as *-ing* participles.

Example 1.2.103. *I spent the afternoon window-shopping with Grandma.*

1.82 Some *-ing* nouns that are related to verbs are **countable nouns**.

They generally refer to the result of an action or process, or to an individual instance of it.

Sometimes their meaning is not closely related to that of the verb.

Here is a list of the commonest of these nouns:

Example 1.2.104. *beginning, being, building, drawing, feeling, finding, hearing, meaning, meeting, offering, painting, saying, setting, showing, sitting, suffering, turning, warning*

For more information on countable nouns, see paragraphs **1.15**–**1.22**.

1.2.11 Compound nouns: *car park, mother-in-law, breakdown*

1.83 A single noun is often not enough to refer clearly to a person or thing.

When this is the case, a **compound noun** can be used.

A compound noun is a fixed expression that is made from more than 1 word, and that behaves as a noun.

Example 1.2.105. *Some people write out a new address book every January.*
How would one actually choose a small personal computer?
Where did you hide the can opener?
... a private swimming pool.

Once it is clear what you are referring to, it is sometimes possible to use just the 2nd word of a 2-word compound noun. E.g., after mentioning *a swimming pool*, you can just refer to *the pool*.
Most compound nouns consist of 2 words, but some consist of 3 or more words.

Example 1.2.106. *... a vase of lily of the valley.*

1.84 Some compound nouns are written with hyphens instead of spaces between the words.

Example 1.2.107. *I'm looking forward to a lie-in tomorrow.*
He's very good at problem-solving.
Judy's brother-in-law lived with his family.

Some compound nouns, especially very frequent ones, are written as 1 word.

Example 1.2.108. *... patterned wallpaper.*
They copied questions from the blackboard.

In some cases, you can choose whether to write a compound noun with or without a hyphen, or with or without a space. E.g., both *air-conditioner* and *air conditioner* are possible, and both *postbox* and *post box* are possible.
A few compound nouns that consist of more than 2 words are written partly with hyphens and partly with spaces, e.g. *back-seat driver* and *bring-and-buy sale*.

Example 1.2.109. *... children from 1-parent families.*
... a Parent-Teacher Association.

1.85 Compound nouns may be countable, uncountable, singular, or plural.
Here is a list of some common countable compound nouns:

Example 1.2.110. *address book, air conditioner, air raid, alarm clock, assembly line, baby-sitter, back-seat driver, bank account, bird of prey, book token, blood donor, bride-to-be, bring-and-buy sale, brother-in-law, burglar alarm, bus stop, can opener, car park, compact disc, contact lens, credit card, dining room, drawing pin, driving license, estate agent, fairytale, father-in-law, film star, fire engine, fork-lift truck, frying pan, guided missile, health center, heart attack, high school, human being, letter box, lily of the valley, mother-in-law, musical instrument, nervous breakdown, news bulletin, old hand, 1-parent family, package holiday, Parent-Teacher, Association, parking meter, pen-friend, personal computer, polar bear, police station, post office, rolling pin, sister-in-law, sleeping bag, swimming pool, T-shirt, tea bag, telephone number, traveler's cheque, washing machine, X-ray, youth hostel, zebra crossing.*

1.86 Here is a list of some common uncountable compound nouns:

Example 1.2.111. *air conditioning, air-traffic control, barbed wire, birth control, blood pressure, bubble bath, capital punishment, central heating, chewing gum, common sense, cotton wool, data processing, do-it-yourself, dry-cleaning, family planning, fancy dress, fast food, 1st aid, food poisoning, further education, general knowledge, hay fever, heart failure, higher education, hire purchase, income tax, junk food, law and order, lost property, mail order, mineral water, nail varnish, natural history, old age, pocket money, remote control, science fiction, show business, show jumping, sign language, social security, social work, soda water, stainless steel, table tennis, talcum powder, toilet paper, tracing paper, unemployment benefit, value added tax, washing powder, washing-up liquid, water-skiing, writing paper*

1.87 Here is a list of some common singular compound nouns:

Example 1.2.112. *age of consent, arms race, brain drain, continental divide, cost of living, death penalty, diplomatic corps, dress circle, fire brigade, general public, generation gap, greenhouse effect, hard core, human race, labor force, labor market, long jump, mother tongue, open air, private sector, public sector, rank and file, solar system, sound barrier, space age, welfare state, women's movement*

1.88 Here is a list of some common plural compound nouns:

Example 1.2.113. *armed forces, baked beans, civil rights, current affairs, French fries, grass roots, high heels, human rights, industrial relations, inverted commas, licensing laws, luxury goods, modern languages, natural resources, race relations, road works, social services, social studies, swimming trunks, vocal cords, winter sports, yellow pages*

1.89 Most compound nouns consist of 2 nouns, or an adjective and a noun.

Example 1.2.114. *I listened with anticipation to the radio news bulletin.*
. . . a big dining room.
Old age is a time for reflection and slowing down.

however, some compound nouns are related to **phrasal verbs**.
These are sometimes written with a hyphen, and sometimes as 1 word.
They are rarely written as separate words.

Example 1.2.115. *The President was directly involved in the Watergate cover-up.*
I think there's been a mix-up.
. . . a breakdown of diplomatic relations.
The singer is making a comeback.

Here is a list of frequent nouns based on phrasal verbs.
They are shown in this list in the form in which they are most frequently written, either with a hyphen or as 1 word.

Example 1.2.116. *backup, bailout, blackout, breakaway, breakdown, break-in, breakout, break-up, build-up, buyout, check-in, checkout, check-up, comeback, cover-up, crackdown, cutbacks, drawback, feedback, follow-up, giveaway, handout, kick-off, lead-up, lookout, make-up, meltdown, mix-up, passer-by, run-in, runner-up, run-off, run-up, sell-out, setback, set-up, show-off, slowdown, takeaway, take-off, turnover, warm-up*

For more information about phrasal verbs, see paragraphs **3.83–3.116**.
[i] Usage note.
1.90 In some cases, the meaning of a compound noun is not obvious from the words it consists of.
E.g., someone's *mother tongue* is not the tongue of their mother but the language they learn as a child, and an *old hand* is not a hand that is old but a person who is experienced at doing a particular job.
[Bubble] In other cases, the compound noun consists of words that do not occur on their own, e.g. *hanky-panky, hodge-podge*, and *argy-bargy.*
These nouns are usually used in informal conversation rather than formal writing.

Example 1.2.117. *Most of what he said was a load of hocus-pocus.*
She is usually involved in some sort of jiggery-pokery.

1.91 The plural forms of compound nouns vary according to the type of words that they consist of.
If the final word of a compound noun is a countable noun, the plural form of the countable noun is used when the compound noun is plural.

Example 1.2.118. *Air raids were taking place every night.*
. . . health centers, banks, post offices, and police stations.
Loud voices could be heard through letter boxes.
. . . the refusal of dockers to use fork-lift trucks.

For full information about the plural forms of countable nouns, see the Reference section.
Compound nouns that are directly related to phrasal verbs usually have a plural form ending in *-s*.

Example 1.2.119. *Nobody seems disturbed about cover-ups when they are essential to the conduct of a war.*
Naturally, I think people who drive smarter, faster cars than mine are show-offs.

A few compound nouns are less directly related to phrasal verbs, and consist of a countable noun and an adverb.
In these cases, the plural form of the countable noun is used before the adverb when the compound noun is plural.
E.g., the plural of *runner-up* is *runners-up*, and the plural of *summing-up* is *summings-up*.

Example 1.2.120. *Passers-by helped the victim, who was unconscious.*

Compound nouns that consist of 2 nouns linked by the prepositions *of* or *in*, or a noun followed by *to-be*, have a plural form in which the 1st noun in the compound is plural.

Example 1.2.121. *I like birds of prey and hawks particularly.*
She was treated with contempt by her sisters-in-law.
Most mothers-to-be in their 40s opt for this test.

Some compound nouns have been borrowed from other languages, mainly French and Latin, and therefore do not have normal English plural forms.

Example 1.2.122. *Agents provocateurs were sent to cause trouble.*
The nouveaux riches of younger states are building palatial mansions for themselves.

1.92 Compound nouns are fixed expressions.
However, nouns can always be used in front of other nouns in order to refer to something in a more specific way.
For the use of nouns as **modifiers**, see paragraphs **2.169–2.174**.

1.3 Talking about people & things without naming them: pronouns

1.93 When you use language, both in speech and writing, you constantly refer to things you have already mentioned or are about to mention.
You can do this by repeating the noun phrase, but unless there is a special reason to do so, you are more likely to use a **pronoun** instead.
Pronouns make statements less repetitive.

Example 1.3.1. *John took the book and opened it.*
Deborah recognized the knife as hers.
Shilton was pleased with himself.
This is a very busy place.

However, if you have mentioned 2 or more different things, you usually have to repeat the noun phrase to make it clear which thing you are now talking about.

Example 1.3.2. *Leaflets and scraps of papers were scattered all over the floor.*
I started to pick up the leaflets.
I could see a lorry and a car.
The lorry stopped.

For other ways of talking about things that have already been mentioned, see paragraphs **10.2–10.39**.
1.94 There are several different types of pronoun:

- **personal pronouns**. See paragraphs **1.95–1.106**.
- **possessive pronouns.** See paragraphs **1.107–1.110**.
- **reflexive pronouns.** See paragraphs **1.111–1.118**.
- **generic pronouns.** See paragraphs **1.119–1.123**.
- **demonstrative pronouns.** See paragraphs **1.124–1.127**.
- **indefinite pronouns.** See paragraphs **1.128–1.141**.
- **reciprocal pronouns.** See paragraphs **1.142–1.145**.
- **relative pronouns.** See paragraphs **1.146–1.150**.
- **interrogative pronouns.** See paragraphs **1.151–1.153**.

There are a few other words that can be used as pronouns.
For more information about these, see paragraphs **1.154–1.161**.

1.3.1 Talking about people & things: personal pronouns

1.95 You use **personal pronouns** to refer to yourself, the people you are talking to, or the people or things you are talking about.
There are 2 sets of personal pronouns: subject pronouns and object pronouns.
1.96 Subject pronouns refer to the subject of a clause.
Here is a table of subject pronouns:

	singular	**plural**
1st person	I	we
2nd person	you	you
3rd person	he, she, it	they

1.97 You refer to yourself by using the pronoun *I*.
I is always written with a capital letter.

Example 1.3.3. *I don't know what to do.*
I think I made the wrong decision.
May I ask why Stephen's here?

1.98 You refer to the person or people you are talking to as *you*.
Note that the same word is used for the singular and the plural.

Example 1.3.4. *You may have to wait a bit.*
Would you come and have a drink?
How did you get on?

You is also used to refer to people in general, rather than to the person you are talking or writing to.
For more information on this, see paragraph **1.120**.
If you want to make it clear that you are addressing more than 1 person, you can create a plural form by using *you* followed by a determiner, a number or a noun.
Forms like this can also be used in object position.

Example 1.3.5. *My granddad wants you both to come round next Saturday.*
As you all know, this is a challenge.

Here is a list of the most common plural forms of *you*.

Example 1.3.6. *you all, you guys, you lot, you 2, you 3, you both*

You guys and *you lot* are more frequent in informal English.
You lot is not commonly used in American English.

Example 1.3.7. *I love working with you guys.*
You guys are great!
So you lot will have to look after yourselves.

Note that people often use *you lot* when they are being very direct with a group of people, as in the last example above.
[AE] Some varieties and dialects of English have developed particular forms of plural *you*.
In American English, particularly Southern American English, *y'all* is sometimes used, especially in speech.

Example 1.3.8. *What did y'all eat for breakfast?*
I want to thank y'all.

In some dialects of British and American English, *yous* and *youse* are used as plural forms:

Example 1.3.9. *I know what some of yous might be thinking.*

Another plural form is *you people*.
However, this can sound rude, and should only be used if you want to show that you are angry or annoyed with the people you are talking to.

Example 1.3.10. *'Why can't you people leave me alone?' he says.*
'I can't work with you people,' Zoe said.

Some plural forms of *you* - *you guys, you lot, you 2, you 3* and *y'all* - can be used as **vocatives**.
For more information on vocatives, see paragraphs **9.95–9.99**.
You all and *you both* cannot be used as vocatives.

Example 1.3.11. *'Listen, you guys,' she said. 'I'll tell you everything you want.'*
Come on, you 2. Let's go home.
Bye, y'all!

For more information on *you* as an **object pronoun**, see paragraphs **1.104–1.106**.
1.99 You refer to a man or a boy as *he*, and to a woman or a girl as *she*.

Example 1.3.12. *My father is 78, and he's very healthy and independent.*
Billy Knight was a boxer, wasn't he?
Mary came in. She was a good-looking woman.
'Is Sue there?' - 'I'm sorry, she doesn't work here now.'

1.100 You use *it* to refer to anything that is not male or female; e.g., an object, a place, an organization, or something abstract.

Example 1.3.13. *Have you seen Toy Story? It's a good film for kids.*
'Have you been to London?' - 'Yes, it was very crowded.'
How much would the company be worth if it were sold?
It is not an idea that has much public support.

It is often used to refer to an animal when its gender is not known or not considered to be important.
Some people also refer to babies in this way.

Example 1.3.14. *They punched the crocodile until it let go of her.*
If the shark is still around it will not escape.
How Winifred loved the baby! And how Stephanie hated it!

You also use *it* in general statements, e.g. to refer to a situation, the time, the date, or the weather.

Example 1.3.15. *It is very quiet here.*
It is half past 3.
It is Jan 19th.
It is rainy and cold.

For more information on the use of *it* in general statements, see paragraphs **9.31–9.45**.
Note that *it* is also an **object pronoun**.
For more information on this, see paragraphs **1.104–1.106**.
[i] Usage note.
1.101 Although *it* is used as a pronoun to refer to something that is not male or female, *she* is sometimes used to refer to ships, cars, and countries.
Some people do not like this usage.

Example 1.3.16. *When the repairs had been done she was a fine and beautiful ship.*

1.102 You use *we* to refer to a group of people that includes yourself.
The group can be:

- you can the person or people you are talking to

  Example 1.3.17. *Where shall we meet, Sally?*

- you and the person or people you are talking to and 1 or more others not there at the time

  Example 1.3.18. *We aren't exactly gossips, you and I and Watson.*

- you and 1 or more other people, but not including the person or people you are talking to

  Example 1.3.19. *I do the washing; he does the cooking; we share the washing-up.*

- any group that you feel yourself to be part of, e.g. a school, your local community, or even mankind as a whole.

  For more information on this, see paragraph **1.122**.

1.103 You use *they* to refer to a group of things, or to a group of people not including yourself or the person or people you are talking to.

Example 1.3.20. *All the girls think he's great, don't they?*
Newspapers reach me on the day after they are published.
Winters here vary as they do elsewhere.

They is also used to refer to people in general.
For more information on this, see paragraph **1.123**.
1.104 Object pronouns refer to the same sets of people or things as the corresponding subject pronouns.
Here is a table of object pronouns:

	singular	**plural**
1st person	me	us
2nd person	you	you
3rd person	him, her, it	them

1.105 Object pronouns are used as the object of a clause.

Example 1.3.21. *The nurse washed me with cold water.*
He likes you; he said so.
The man went up to the cat and started stroking it.

They can be the indirect object of a clause.

Example 1.3.22. *Send us card so we'll know where you are.*
A man gave him a car.
You have to offer them some kind of incentive.

They can also be the object of a preposition.

Example 1.3.23. *She must have felt intimidated by me.*
Madeleine, I want to talk to you immediately.
We were all sitting in a café with him.

1.106 Object pronouns can also be used after **linking verbs**.
E.g., you can say *It was me, It's her.*
However, in formal or written English, people sometimes use a subject pronoun after a linking verb.
E.g., *It was I, It is she.*
For more information on linking verbs, see paragraphs **3.126–3.181**.

1.3.2 Talking about possession: possessive pronouns

1.107 When you are talking about people or things, you often want to say how they are connected with each other.
There are several different ways in which you can do this, but you usually do it by using a **possessive pronoun** to show that something belongs to someone or is associated with them.
Here is a table showing possessive pronouns:

	singular	**plural**
1st person	mine	ours
2nd person	yours	yours
3rd person	his, hers	theirs

Note that *its* cannot be used as a possessive pronoun.
1.108 You use possessive pronouns when you are talking about the same type of thing that has just been mentioned but want to show that it belongs to someone else.
E.g., in the sentence *Jane showed them her passport, then Richard showed them his*, *his* refers to a passport and shows that it belongs to Richard.
Possessive pronouns are often used to contrast 2 things of the same type that belong to or are associated with different people.
E.g., *Sarah's house is much bigger than ours.*

Example 1.3.24. *Her parents were in Malaya, and so were mine.*
He smiled at her and laid his hand on hers.
Is that coffee yours or mine?
My marks were higher than his.
Fred put his profits in the bank, while Julia spent hers on a car.
That's the difference between his ideas and ours.
It was his fault, not theirs.

1.109 Possessive pronouns are used with *of* to add information to a noun phrase.
This structure suggests that you are talking about 1 of a group of things.
E.g., if you say *a friend of mine* you are talking about 1 of a number of friends whereas if you say *my friend* you are talking about 1 friend in particular.

Example 1.3.25. *He was an old friend of mine.*
A student of yours has just been to see me.
David Lodge? I've just read a novel of his.
It was hinted to him by some friends of hers.
The room was not a favorite of theirs.

1.110 For other ways of showing that something belongs to someone or is connected with them, see paragraphs **1.211–1.221**.

1.3.3 Referring back to the subject: reflexive pronouns

1.111 When you want to show that the object or the indirect object of a verb is the same person or thing as the subject of the verb, you use a **reflexive pronoun**.

Some verbs are very frequently used with reflexive pronouns.

For information about these, see paragraphs **3.26–3.31**.

Here is a table of reflexive pronouns:

	singular	**plural**
1st person	myself	ourselves
2nd person	yourself	yourselves
3rd person	himself, herself, itself	themselves

1.112 [!] Unlike personal pronouns and possessive pronouns, there are 2 forms of the reflexive pronoun used for the 2nd person.

You use *yourself* when you are talking to 1 person.

You use *yourselves* when you are talking to more than 1 person, or referring to a group that includes the person you are talking to.

1.113 You use a reflexive pronoun to make it clear that the object of a verb is the same person or thing as the subject of the verb, or to emphasize this.

E.g., *John killed himself* means that John did the killing, and he was also the person who was killed.

Example 1.3.26. *He forced himself to remain absolutely still.*
She stretched herself out on the sofa.
I'm sure history repeats itself.
We all shook hands and introduced ourselves.
The boys formed themselves into a line.
Here is the question you have to ask yourselves.

You also use reflexive pronouns to show or emphasize that the indirect object of a verb is the same person or thing as the subject of the verb.

E.g., in the sentence *Ann poured herself a drink*, Ann did the pouring and she was also the person who the drink was for.

Example 1.3.27. *Here's the money, you can go and buy yourself a watch.*

1.114 [!] Reflexive pronouns are not usually used with actions that people normally do to themselves, e.g. washing, dressing, or shaving.

So you do not usually say *He shaves himself every morning.*

You can, however, sometimes use reflexive pronouns with these actions for emphasis, or to talk about a surprising event, e.g. a child doing something that they were not previously able to do.

1.115 If the subject of a clause and the object of a preposition refer to the same person, and the clause does not have a direct object, you use a reflexive pronoun after the preposition.

Example 1.3.28. *I was thoroughly ashamed of myself.*
Barbara stared at herself in the mirror.
We think of ourselves as members of the local community.
They can't cook for themselves.

However, if the clause does have a direct object, you usually use a personal pronoun after the preposition.

Example 1.3.29. *I will take it home with me.*
They put the book between them on the kitchen table.
I shivered and drew the rug around me.
Mrs Bixby went out, slamming the door behind her.

Note that if the clause has a direct object and it is not obvious that the subject of the clause and the object of the preposition refer to the same person, you use a reflexive pronoun.

E.g., *The Managing Director gave the biggest pay rise to himself.*

1.116 Especially in speech, people sometimes use reflexive pronouns rather than personal pronouns as the object of a preposition, in order to emphasize them.

Example 1.3.30. *... people like myself who are politically active.*
... the following conversation between myself and a 15-year-old girl.
The circle spread to include himself and Ferdinand.
People like yourself still find new things to say about Shakespeare.
There is always someone worse off than yourself.
With the exception of a few Algerians and ourselves, everyone spoke Spanish.

1.117 You can use reflexive pronouns in addition to nouns to personal pronouns.
You usually do this in order to make it clear or to emphasize who or what you are referring to.

Example 1.3.31. *I myself sometimes say things I don't mean.*
Sally herself came back.

You also use a reflexive pronoun to compare or contrast 1 person or thing with another.

Example 1.3.32. *His friend looked as miserable as he felt himself.*
It is not Des Moines I miss, but Iowa itself.

The reflexive pronoun follows the noun or pronoun that it relates to.

Example 1.3.33. *It is hot in London; but I myself can work better when it's hot.*
The town itself was so small that it didn't have a priest.
The lane ran right up to the wood itself.

It can also be placed at the end of the clause.

Example 1.3.34. *I am not a particularly punctual person myself.*
You'll probably understand better when you are a grandparent yourself.
It is rare for Governments to take the initiative themselves.

1.118 You use a reflexive pronoun to emphasize that someone did something without any help or interference from anyone else.
In this use, the reflexive pronoun is normally placed at the end of the clause.

Example 1.3.35. *She had printed the card herself.*
I'll take it down to the police station myself.
Did you make these yourself?

1.3.4 People in general: generic pronouns

1.119 When you want to talk about people in general, you can use a **generic pronoun**.
Here is a list of pronouns that can be used as generic pronouns:

Subject	you	one	we	they
Object	you	one	us	them
Possessive	yours	-	ours	theirs
Reflexive	yourself	oneself	ourselves	themselves

1.120 *You* is sometimes used to make statements about people in general, or about a person in a situation that you are imaging.
You is used in this way in both subject and object position.
The possessive form *yours* and the reflexive form *yourself* can also be used as generic pronouns.

Example 1.3.36. *To be a good doctor you need to have good communication skills.*
Champagne can give you a headache.
Once you've bought a physical book, you own it: you can lend it to people, donate it, and, well, it's yours.
When you live alone you have to force yourself to go out more.

In informal English, you can use *you get* or *you have* to make a general statement about something that exists in the world.

Example 1.3.37. *You get some old people who are very difficult.*
Anytime you have over 8 inches of snow, driving becomes problematic.

1.121 In formal writing, *one* is sometimes used instead of *you*.
Once can be used in subject or object position.
The reflexive form *oneself* is also used, but there is no possessive pronoun form of *one*.

Example 1.3.38. *Going round Italy, one is struck by the number of opera houses there are.*
This scene makes one realize how deeply this community has been afflicted.
If one puts oneself up for public office, then it is inappropriate that one should behave badly.

1.122 You can refer to a general group that includes yourself as *we* or, in object position, *us*.
This group can be all of mankind, or it can be smaller group e.g. a nation or a community.
The possessive form *ours* and the reflexive form *ourselves* can also be used in this way.

Example 1.3.39. *We all need money.*
This survey gives us insight into our attitudes and behavior as a nation.
No other language has ever advanced as far, as fast, as ours.
We need a change of government; just riding ourselves of the prime minister isn't enough.

1.123 You can use *they* to refer to people in general.

Example 1.3.40. *Isn't that what they call love?*

They can also refer to a group of people whose identity does not need to be stated.
E.g., in the sentence *They've given John another pay rise* it is clear that *they* refers to John's employers.

Example 1.3.41. *'Don't worry', I said to Mother, 'they are moving you from this ward soon.'*

You can also use *they* in subject position, or *them* in object position, to refer to an individual when you do not know, or do not want to specify, whether the individual is male or female.
The possessive form *theirs* and the reflexive form *themselves* can also be used in this way.
This use is very common after:

- the **indefinite pronouns** *anyone, anybody, someone* and *somebody*.

  These are explained in paragraphs **1.128–1.141**.

- singular nouns e.g. *person, parent* and *teacher*, which do not specify whether the person is male or female

  - If anyone wants to be a childminder, they must attend a course.
    If I think someone is having problems, I will spend hours talking to them.
    A person's body fat determines how long they can withstand cold water.

Note that the plural form of the verb is always used after *they*, even when it refers to only 1 person.
You can also use *they, them, theirs* and *themselves* to refer to:

- the **indefinite pronouns** *everyone, everybody, no one* and *nobody*.

  These are explained in paragraphs **1.128–1.141**.

- noun phrases with the determiners *each, every* and *any*.

In these cases, although the pronouns or noun phrases are grammatically singular, they refer to groups of people.

Example 1.3.42. *I never avoid my obligations and I expect everyone else to meet theirs.*
Each parent was sent an individual letter informing them of the situation.
We want every player to push themselves to get into the team.

Another way is to use *he or she* instead of *they, him or her* instead of *them, himself or herself* instead of *themselves* and *his or hers* instead of *theirs*.
This is often used in formal or written English.

Example 1.3.43. *Would a young person be able to get a job in Europe? That would depend on which country he or she wanted to go to.*
The student should feel that the essay belongs to him or her.

Some people use *he* and *him* in general statements or after indefinite pronouns, but many people object to this use because it suggests that person being referred to is male.

1.3.5 Referring to a particular person or thing: *this, that, these* and *those*

1.125 When *this, that, these*, and *those* are used as pronouns, they are used as the subject or the object of a clause, or the object of a preposition.

Demonstrative pronouns are rarely used as the indirect object of a clause, because the indirect object is usually a person, and demonstrative pronouns normally refer to things.

1.125 *This* and *that* are usually used as pronouns only when they refer to things.

You use them instead of a singular countable noun or an uncountable noun.

This refers to something that is close to you in place or time, and *that* refers to something that is more distant in place or time.

Example 1.3.44. *This is a list of the rules.*
This is the most important part of the job.
The biggest problem was the accent. That was difficult for me.
That looks interesting.

1.126 *This* and *that* are used as pronouns to refer to a person when you are identifying someone or asking who they are.

Example 1.3.45. *Who's this?*
He stopped and looked at a photograph that stood on the dressing table. Is this your wife?
Was that Patrick on the phone?

When you are introducing people, you can say *This is Mary* or *This is Mr and Mrs Baker*.

Note that you use *this* even when you are introducing more than 1 person.

1.127 *These* and *those* can be used as pronouns instead of a plural countable noun.

They are most often used to refer to things, although they can be used to refer to people.

These refers to a number of people and things that are close to you in place or time, and *those* refers to a number of people and things that are more distant in place or time.

Example 1.3.46. *'I brought you these.' Adam held out a bag of grapes.*
Vitamin tablets usually contain vitamins A, C, and D. These are available from any child health clinic.
These are no ordinary students.
It may be impossible for them to pay essential bills, e.g. those for heating.
Those are easy questions to answer.
There are a lot of people who are seeking employment, and a great number of those are married women.

This, that, these, and *those* can also be **definite determiners**.

For more information, see paragraphs **1.184–1.193**.
See also *Referring back* and *Referring forward* in Chap. 10.

1.3.6 Referring to people & things in a non-specific way: *someone, anyone, everyone*, etc.

1.128 When you want to refer to people or things but you do not know exactly who or what they are, or their identity is not important, you can use an **indefinite pronoun** e.g. *someone, anyone*, or *everyone*.

An indefinite pronoun shows only whether you are talking about people or about things, rather than referring to a specific person or thing.

Example 1.3.47. *I was there for over an hour before anybody came.*
Jack was waiting for something.

Here is a list of indefinite pronouns:

Example 1.3.48. *I was there for over an hour before anybody came.*
Jack was waiting for something.

Here is a list of indefinite pronouns:

Example 1.3.49. *anybody, anyone, anything, everybody, everyone, everything, nobody, no one, nothing, somebody, someone, something*

[**AE**] Note that all indefinite pronouns are written as 1 word except *no one*.

It is always 2 words in American English, but in British English it can also be spelled with a hyphen: *no-one*.

1.129 You always use singular verbs with indefinite pronouns.

Example 1.3.50. *Is anyone here?*
Everybody recognizes the importance of education.
Everything was ready.
Nothing is certain in this world.

1.130 You use the indefinite pronouns ending in *-thing* to talk about objects, ideas, situations, or activities.

Example 1.3.51. *Can I do anything?*
Jane said nothing for a moment.

1.131 You use the indefinite pronouns ending in *-one* and *-body* to refer to people.

Example 1.3.52. *It had to be someone like Dan.*
Why does everybody believe in the law of gravity?

Note that indefinite pronouns ending in *-body* are more frequent in informal English.
1.132 Although you use singular verbs with indefinite pronouns, if you want to refer back to an indefinite pronoun, you use the plural pronouns *they, them*, or *themselves*, or the possessive determiner *their*.

Example 1.3.53. *Ask anyone. They'll tell you.*
There's no way of telling somebody why they've failed.
No one liked being young then as they do now.
Everybody's enjoying themselves.
Everyone put their pens down.

See paragraph **1.123** for more information about *they* used to refer to 1 person.
[i] Usage note.
1.133 In more formal English, some people prefer to use *he, him, his*, or *himself* to refer back to an indefinite pronoun, but many people dislike this use because it suggests that the person being referred to is male.

Example 1.3.54. *If someone consistently eats a lot of fatty foods, it is not surprising if he ends up with clogged arteries.*
Everybody has his dream.

For other ways of using pronouns when you do not want to specify whether the person you are talking about is male or female, see paragraph **1.123**.
1.134 You add *'s* (apostrophe *s*) to indefinite pronoun to refer to things that belong to or are associated with people.

Example 1.3.55. *She was given a room in someone's studio.*
That was nobody's business.
I would defend anyone's rights.
Everything has been arranged to everybody's satisfaction.

1.135 [!] You do not usually add *'s* to indefinite pronouns referring to things.
So, e.g., you would be more likely to say *the value of something* than *something's value.*
1.136 When you want to give more information about the person or thing referred to by an indefinite pronoun, you can use a phrase or a clause after it.

Example 1.3.56. *Anyone over the age of 18 can apply.*
He would prefer to have somebody who had a background in the humanities.

1.137 You can also use adjectives to add information.
Note that adjectives are placed after the indefinite pronoun rather than in front of it, and that you do not use a determiner.
You do not say *an important someone*, you say *someone important.*

Example 1.3.57. *What was needed was someone practical.*
They are doing everything possible to take care of you.
There is nothing wrong with being popular.

1.138 If you have already mentioned a person or thing, and you want to refer to a different person or thing, or an additional one, you use *else* after an indefinite pronoun.

Example 1.3.58. *Somebody else will have to go out there.*
She couldn't think of anything else.
Everyone knows what everyone else is doing.
He got that job because nobody else wanted it.

Note that if you want to show association or possession with an indefinite pronoun and *else*, you add the *'s* to *else*.

Example 1.3.59. *Problems always became someone else's fault.*
No one has control over anyone else's career.

1.139 Just like nouns, indefinite pronouns are the subject, object, or indirect object of clauses.
They can also be used as the objects of prepositions.
The indefinite pronouns beginning with *some-* and *every-* are most often used in affirmative clauses.

Example 1.3.60. *Everything went according to plan.*
I remember somebody putting a pillow under my head.
'Now you'll see something,' he said.
I gave everyone a generous helping.
I want to introduce you to someone who is helping me.
Is everything all right?

They are sometimes used as the subject of a negative clause.

Example 1.3.61. *He could tell that something wasn't right.*

Note that the indefinite pronouns beginning with *some-* cannot be used as the object of a negative clause, unless they are followed by a phrase or a clause.

Example 1.3.62. *He wasn't someone I admired as a writer.*

1.140 Indefinite pronouns beginning with *any-* can be used as the object or indirect object of a question or a negative clause.

Example 1.3.63. *Don't worry - I won't tell anyone.*
You still haven't told me anything.
Take a good look and tell me if you see anything different.
I haven't given anyone their presents yet.

They are often used as the subject of both negative and affirmative questions.
Note that they are not used as the subject of a negative statement.
You do not say, e.g., *Anybody can't come in.*

Example 1.3.64. *Does anybody agree with me?*
Won't anyone help me?
If anything unusual happens, could you call me on this number?

Note that when you are making an affirmative statement, *anyone* and *anybody* are used to refer to people in general and not to only 1 person.

Example 1.3.65. *Anybody who wants to can come in and buy a car from me.*

1.141 Indefinite pronouns beginning with *no-* are always used with the affirmative form of a verb, and they make the clause negative.
For more information on **negative statements**, see paragraphs **5.49–5.93**.

Example 1.3.66. *Nobody said a word.*
There was nothing you could do, nothing at all.
She was to see no one, to speak to nobody, not even her own children.

Note that they are sometimes used in questions.
When this is the case, the answer to the question is usually expected to be *no*.

Example 1.3.67. *'Is there nothing I can do?' - 'Not a thing'.*
'Is there nobody else?' - 'Not that I know of'.

1.3.7 Showing that people do the same thing: *each other* & *one another*

1.142 *Each other* and *one another* are called **reciprocal pronouns**.

They are used to say that people do the same thing, feel the same way, or have the same relationship.

E.g., if your brother hates your sister and your sister hates your brother, you can say *My brother and sister hate each other* or *They hate one another*.

Reciprocal pronouns are not used as the subject of a clause.

You can use them as the object or indirect object of a verb.

Example 1.3.68. *We help each other a lot.*
You and I understand each other.
We support one another through good times and bad.
They sent each other gifts from time to time.

You also use them as the object of a preposition.

Example 1.3.69. *Terry and Mark were jealous of each other.*
The 2 lights were moving towards one another.
They didn't dare to look at one another.

Some verbs are very commonly used with reciprocal pronouns.

For more information about these, see paragraphs **3.68**–**3.72**.

1.143 Note that there is very little difference between *each other* and *one another*.

They are both used to talk about 2 or more people or things, although some people prefer the use of *each other* when there are only 2 people or things, and *one another* when there are more than 2.

1.144 In formal written English, you can also use *each* as the subject of a clause and *the other* as the object of a clause or preposition.

So, a more formal way of saying *They looked at each other* is *Each looked at the other*.

Note that *each* is always followed by a singular verb.

Example 1.3.70. *Each accuses the other of lying.*
Each is unwilling to learn from the experience of the others.

Each is also a determiner.

For more information about this, see paragraph **1.243**.

1.145 You add *'s* (apostrophe *s*) to *each other, one another*, and *the other* to form possessives.

Example 1.3.71. *I hope that you all enjoy each other's company.*
Apes spend a great deal of time grooming one another's fur.
The males fight fiercely, each trying to seize the other's long neck in its beak.

1.3.8 Joining clauses together: relative pronouns

1.146 When a sentence consists of a main clause followed by a **relative clause** introduced by *who, whom, which*, or *that*, these words are called **relative pronouns**.

Relative pronouns do 2 things at the same time.

Like other pronouns, they refer to someone or something that has already been mentioned.

At the same time they join clauses together.

For more information about relative clauses, see paragraphs **8.83**–**8.116**.

1.147 *Who* and *whom* always refer to people.

Who can be the subject of a relative clause.

Example 1.3.72. *... mathematicians who are concerned with very difficult problems.*

In the past, *whom* was normally used as the object of a relative clause.

Nowadays, *who* is more often used, although some careful speakers of English think that this is more correct to use *whom*.

Example 1.3.73. *... a man who I met recently.*
He's the man who I saw last night.
... 2 girls whom I met in Edinburgh.

Who is sometimes used as the object of a preposition when the object is separated from the preposition.

Some careful speakers think that it is more correct to use *whom*.

Example 1.3.74. *That's the man who I gave it to.*
... those whom we cannot talk to.

Whom is almost always used when the object comes immediately after the preposition.

Example 1.3.75. *... Lord Scarman, a man for whom I have immense respect.*

1.148 *Which* always refers to things.
It can be used as the subject or object of a relative clause, or as the object of a preposition.
Which is often used in British English to introduce relative clauses that refer to things.

Example 1.3.76. *... a region which was threatened by growing poverty.*
... 2 horses which he owned.
... the house in which I was born.

Note that which cannot be used as the indirect object of a clause.
1.149 *That* refers to either people or things.
It is used as the subject or the object of a relative clause or the object of a preposition.
That is generally preferred in American English to introduce relative clauses that refer to things or to combinations of people and things.

Example 1.3.77. *... the games that politicians play.*
He's the boy that sang the solo last night.
It was the 1st bed that she had ever slept in.

That cannot be used as the indirect object of a clause.
1.150 *Whose* shows who or what something belongs to or is connected with.
Note that it cannot be used by itself, but must come in front of a noun.

Example 1.3.78. *... the thousands whose lives have been damaged.*
There was a chap there whose name I've forgotten.
... predictions whose accuracy will have to be determined.
... sharks, whose brains are minute.

Note that *whose* is not restricted to people.

1.3.9 Asking questions: interrogative pronouns

1.151 1 way of asking questions i by using an **interrogative pronoun**.
The interrogative pronouns are *who, whose, whom, what*, and *which*.
They are used as the subject or object of a clause, or as the object of a preposition.
Whose and *which* are also determiners.
Other words, e.g. *where, when, why*, and *how*, are also used to ask questions.
Interrogative pronouns are not used as the indirect object of a clause.

Example 1.3.79. *Who was at the door?*
'There's a cat outside.' - 'Whose is it?'
Whom do you support?
Which is best, gas or electric?

For more information about structures in which interrogative pronouns are used, see paragraphs **5.10–5.36**.
1.152 Interrogative pronouns refer to the information you are asking for.
Who, whose, and *whom* are used when you think that the answer to the question will be a person.

Example 1.3.80. *'He lost his wife.' - 'Who? Terry?'*
He looked at the cat. Whose is it? Have you ever seen it before?
'To whom, if I may ask, are you engaged to be married?' - 'To Danial Orton.'

Which and *what* are used when you think that the answer to the question will be something other than a person.

Example 1.3.81. *Is there really a difference? Which do you prefer?*
'What did he want?' - 'Maurice's address.'

1.153 Interrogative pronouns are also used to introduce reported questions.

Example 1.3.82. *I asked her who she had been talking to.*
He wondered what Daintry would do now.

For more information about **reported questions**, see paragraphs **7.32–7.38**.

1.3.10 Other pronouns

1.154 Many other words can be pronouns, provided that it is clear what is being talked about, because it is then unnecessary to repeat the noun.

E.g., most **indefinite determiners** can also be pronouns.

For more information about indefinite determiners, see paragraphs **1.223–1.250**.

Here is a list of indefinite determiners that are also pronouns:

Example 1.3.83. *all, another, any, both, each, either, enough, few, fewer, less, little, many, more, most, much, neither, several, some*

Like all noun phrases, they can be used as the subject, direct object, or indirect object of a clause, or the object of a preposition.

Example 1.3.84. *Both were offered jobs immediately.*
Children? I don't think she has any.
I saw 1 girl whispering to another.

1.155 Although *a, an, every*, and *no* are indefinite determiners, they cannot stand alone as pronouns.

To refer back to a noun phrase that includes the determiner *a* or *an*, you can use the pronoun *one*.

Similarly, you use *each* to refer back to a noun phrase that includes *every*, and *none* to refer back to a noun phrase that includes *no*.

Note that *another* and *others* are pronouns, but *other* cannot be a pronoun.

1.156 *All, both*, and *each* can be used in addition to nouns or personal pronouns for emphasis, in a similar way to use of **reflexive pronouns** described in paragraphs **1.116–1.118**.

Example 1.3.85. *The brothers all agreed that something more was needed.*
He loved them both.
Ford and Duncan each had their chances.

They come after an auxiliary verb, a model, or *be*.

Example 1.3.86. *They were both still working at their universities.*
The letters have all been signed.
The older children can all do the same things together.

Each can also come at the end of the clause.

Example 1.3.87. *3 others were fined £200 each.*

1.157 **Numbers** can also be pronouns.

E.g., the answer to the question *How many children do you have?* is usually *3* rather than *3 children*.

Example 1.3.88. *'How many people are there?' - '45.'*
Of the other women, 2 are dancers.
They bought 8 companies and sold of 5.

For more information on numbers, see paragraphs **2.213–2.231**.

1.158 The number *one* is a special case.

Like other numbers, it is sometimes used to refer to 1 of a group of things.

One is also used to refer back to a noun phrase with the determiner *a*.

Example 1.3.89. *Could I have a bigger one, please?*

It can also be used for emphasis after another determiner.

Example 1.3.90. *There are systems of communication right through the animal world; each one is distinctive.*

One can be used as a **personal pronoun**.

This use is explained in paragraph **1.121**.

1.159 Note that *the one* and *the ones* can be used to refer to a noun alone, rather than to the whole of the noun phrase.

They are nearly always used with a modifier e.g. an adjective, or some form of information after the noun, e.g. a prepositional phrase.

Example 1.3.91. *'Which poem?' - 'The one they were talking about yesterday.'*
There are 3 bedrooms. Mine is the one at the back.
He gave the best seats to the ones who arrived 1st.

1.160 You use *the other, the others, others*, or *another* to refer to different members of a group of things or people.

Example 1.3.92. *Some writers are greater than others.*
1 runner was way ahead of all the others.

1.161 If you want to say something about a member of a group of people or things you can use *one*.
You can then refer to the rest of the group as *the others*.

Example 1.3.93. *The bells are carefully installed so that disconnecting one will have no effect on the others.*
They had 3 little daughters, one a baby, the others twins of 12.

You use *the one* and *the other* to refer to each of a pair of things.

Example 1.3.94. *The same factors push wages and prices up together, the one reinforcing the other.*

If you do not wish to specify exactly which of a group you are talking about, you refer to *one or other* of them.

Example 1.3.95. *It may be that one or other of them had fears for their health.*

1.4 Definite & indefinite determiners

1.162 In English, there are 2 main ways in which you can use a **noun phrase**.
You can use it to refer to someone or something, knowing that the person you are speaking to understands which person or thing you are talking about.

Example 1.4.1. *The man began to run towards the boy.*
Young people don't like these operas.
Thank you very much for your comments.
. . . a visit to the Houses of Parliament.

Alternatively, you can use a noun phrase to refer to someone or something of a particular type, without saying which person or thing you mean.

Example 1.4.2. *There was a man in the lift.*
I wish I'd bought an umbrella.
Any doctor would say she didn't know what she was doing.

In order to distinguish between these 2 ways of using a noun phrase, you use a special class of words called **determiners**.
There are 2 types of determiner, **definite determiners** and **indefinite determiners**.
You put them at the beginning of a noun phrase.

1.4.1 Using the definite determiner *the*

1.163 *The* is the most common definite determiner; it is sometimes called the **definite article**.
This, that, these, and *those* are often called **demonstratives** or **demonstrative adjectives**.
For more information on these, see paragraphs **1.184–1.193**.
My, your, his, her, its, our and *their* are **possessive determiners**.
They are also sometimes called **possessive adjectives** or just **possessives**.
For more information about these, see paragraphs **1.194–1.210**.
Here is the list of definite determiners:

Example 1.4.3. *the*
this, that, these, those
my, your, his, her, its, our, their

Note that in English you cannot use more than 1 definite determiner before a noun.
1.164 Because *the* is the most common definite determiner, you can put *the* in front of any common noun.

Example 1.4.4. *She dropped the can into the grass.*
The girls were not in the house.

In these examples, the use of *the can* means that a can has already been mentioned; *the grass* is definite because it has already been stated that *she* is outside, and the presence of grass may also have been stated or is presumed; *the girls*, like *the can*, must have been mentioned before; and *the house* means the one where the girls were staying at the time.
1.165 *The* always has the same spelling, but it has 3 different pronunciations:

- /ðə/ when the following word begins with a consonant sound

  Example 1.4.5. *... the dictionary... the 1st act... the big box*

- /ði/ when the following word begins with a vowel sound

  Example 1.4.6. *... the exhibition... the effect... the impression*

- /ðiː/ when it is emphasized

  Example 1.4.7. *You don't mean the Ernest Hemingway?*

See paragraph **1.181** for more information about emphatic uses of *the*.

1.166 You can use a noun phrase consisting just of *the* and a noun when you know that the person you are talking or writing to will understand which person, thing, or group you are referring to.

Example 1.4.8. *The expedition sailed out into the Pacific.*
... the most obnoxious boy in the school.
He stopped the car in front of the bakery.

1.167 Some nouns are used with *the* because they refer to only 1 person, thing, or group.

Some of these are specific names or **proper nouns**, e.g. titles e.g. *the Pope*, unique things e.g. *the Eiffel Tower*, and place names e.g. *the Atlantic*.

Example 1.4.9. *... a concert attended by the Queen.*
We went on camel rides to the Pyramids.

See paragraphs **1.52–1.58** for more information about proper nouns.

Some are **singular nouns**, that is they refer to something of which there is only 1 in the world, e.g. *the ground*, or *the moon*.

Example 1.4.10. *The sun began to turn red.*
In Apr and May the wind blows steadily.

See paragraphs **1.34–1.40** for more information about singular nouns.

1.168 Other nouns are used to talk about just 1 person, thing, or group in a particular place or organization, so that if you are talking about that place or organization or talking to someone in it, you can use just *the* and the noun.

E.g., if there is only 1 station in a town, the people who live in the town will talk about *the station*.

Similarly, people living in Britain talk to each other about *the economy*, meaning *the British economy*, and people working for the same organization might talk about *the boss, the union*, or *the canteen* without needing to specify the organization.

Example 1.4.11. *The church has been broken into.*
There's a wind coming off the river.
We had to get rid of the director.
The mayor is a 48-year-old former laborer.
What is the President doing about all this?

1.169 Normally, if you want to talk generally about all people or things of a particular type, you use the plural form of a noun without a determiner.

However, there are some countable nouns that are used in the singular with *the* to refer to something more general.

E.g., you can use *the theater* or *the stage* to talk about all entertainment performed in theaters.

Similarly, *the screen* refers to films in general, and *the law* refers to the system of laws in a country.

Example 1.4.12. *For him, the stage was just a way of earning a living.*
He was as handsome in real life as he was on the screen.
They do not hesitate to break the law.

Some nouns that normally refer to an individual thing or person can be used in the singular with *the* to refer generally to a system or service in a particular place.

E.g., you can use *the bus* to talk about a bus service and *the phone* to talk about a telephone system.

Example 1.4.13. *How long does it take on the train?*
We rang for the ambulance.

Nouns referring to musical instruments can be used in the singular with *the* when you are talking about someone playing, or being able to play, a particular kind of instrument.

Example 1.4.14. *You play the oboe, I see, said Simon.*
I was playing the piano when he phoned.

1.170 When you want to talk generally about groups of people who share the same characteristic or quality, you often choose an adjective preceded by *the*.

Example 1.4.15. *This project is all about giving employment to the unemployed.*

See paragraphs **.166–1.72** for more information about using adjectives as nouns.
1.171 Nouns referring to plants and animals can be used in the singular with *the* when you are making a statement about every member of a species.
E.g., if you say *The swift has long, narrow wings*, you mean that all swifts have long, narrow wings.

Example 1.4.16. *The primrose can grow abundantly on chalk banks.*
Australia is the home of the kangaroo.

Similarly, a noun referring to a part of the human body can be used with *the* to refer to that part of anyone's body.

Example 1.4.17. *These arteries supply the heart with blood.*
... the arteries supplying the kidneys.

The is sometimes used with other nouns in the singular to make a statement about all the members of a group.

Example 1.4.18. *The article focuses on how to protect the therapist rather than on how to cure the patient.*

These uses are fairly formal.
They are not common in ordinary speech.
Usually, if you want to make a statement about all the things of a particular kind, you use the plural form of a noun without a determiner.
See paragraph **1.227** for more information about this.
[i] Usage note.
1.172 Many common time expressions consist of just *the* and a noun.

Example 1.4.19. *We wasted a lot of money in the past.*
The train leaves Cardiff at 4 in the afternoon.
... the changes which are taking place at the moment.

See Chap. 4 for more information about time expressions.
1.173 In each of the paragraphs above showing uses of *the* and a noun, it is possible to understand who or what is being referred to because the noun phrase is commonly accepted as referring to 1 particular person, thing, or group.
However, you can use *the* with any noun, if it is obvious who or what you are referring to from what has already been said or written.
The usual way of referring back to a noun is to use a pronoun, but if the 2nd reference does not come immediately after the 1st one, or if it is not immediately obvious which noun is being referred to, you should use *the*, and the noun again.
E.g., if you have already mentioned that you were in a train, and then continued to tell a story, you can say afterwards *The train suddenly stopped.*
1.174 You can also use *the* and a noun when you are referring to someone or something closely connected with something you have just mentioned.
E.g., you do not usually say *We tried to get into the room, but the door of the room was locked.*
You say *We tried to get into the room, but the door was locked*, because it is obvious which door you are referring to.

Example 1.4.20. *She stopped and lit a match. The wind almost blew out the flame.*

1.175 Although there are many situations where you use just *the* and a noun, there are other occasions when you need to add something else to the noun in order to make it clear which person, thing, or group you are referring to.
1.176 Sometimes you can show who or what you are referring to by putting an **adjective** between *the* and the noun.

Example 1.4.21. *This is the main bedroom.*
Somebody ought to have done it long ago, remarked the fat man.

Sometimes you need to use more than 1 adjective.

Example 1.4.22. *After the crossroads look out for the large white building.*

For more information about adjectives, see paragraphs **2.2–2.168**.

1.177 When you use an adjective between *the* and a noun, you do not always do it in order to make clear who or what is being referred to.

E.g., you might want to add further information about someone or something that you have already mentioned.

So, if you 1st refer to someone as *a woman* in a sentence e.g. *A woman came into the room*, you might later want to refer to her as *the unfortunate woman* or *the smiling woman*.

This is a very common use in written English, especially in stories, but it is not often used in conversation.

Example 1.4.23. *The astonished waiter was now watching from the other end of the room.*
The poor woman had witnessed terrible violence.
The loss of pressure caused the speeding car to go into a skid.

1.178 Another way of showing who or what you are referring to is buy adding extra information after *the* and a noun, e.g. a prepositional phrase, a relative clause, a *to*-infinitive, an adverb of place or time, or a phrase introduced by a participle.

So you might refer to particular people at a party by using noun phrases e.g. *the girl in the yellow dress, the woman who spilled her drink*, or *the man smoking a cigar*.

Example 1.4.24. *The cars in the driveways were all Ferraris and Porsches.*
The book that I recommend now costs over 20 pounds.
The thing to aim for is an office of your own.
Who made the bed in the room upstairs?
It depends on the person being interviewed.

For more information about this type of extra information that is added to a noun, see paragraphs **2.272–2.302**.

1.179 You do not normally use *the* with **uncountable nouns** because they refer to something in a general way.

However, *the* is necessary if the uncountable noun is followed by extra information e.g. clause or a phrase that relates it to a particular person, thing, or group.

E.g., you cannot say *I am interested in education of young children*,

You have to say *I am interested in the education of young children.*

Example 1.4.25. *Babies need the comfort of their mother's arms.*
Even the honesty of Inspector Butler was in doubt.
I've no idea about the geography of Scotland.

For more information about uncountable nouns, see paragraphs **1.23–1.33**.

1.180 *The* is also used with **superlative adjectives**.

Example 1.4.26. *I'm not the best cook in the world.*
They went to the most expensive restaurant in town.

See paragraphs **2.112–2.122** for more information about superlative adjectives.

1.181 *The* is often used in front of a noun to indicate that someone or something is the best of its kind.

Example 1.4.27. *New Zealand is now the place to visit.*

You can also use *the* in front of a person's name to show that you are referring to the most famous person with that name.

Example 1.4.28. *You actually met the George Harrison?*

When you use *the* in either of these ways, you emphasize it and pronounce it /ðiː/.

1.182 *The* can be used in front of some **indefinite determiners**, usually to give an indication of amount or quantity.

These indefinite determiners are:

Example 1.4.29. *few, little, many, other*

Example 1.4.30. *... pleasures known only to the few.*
... a coup under the leadership of the select few.
He was 1 of the few who knew where to find me.
We have done the little that is in our power.

For more information about indefinite determiners, see paragraphs **1.223–1.250**.

1.183 *The* is used with *one* and *ones*.

Example 1.4.31. *I'm going to have the green one.*
The shop was different from the ones I remembered.
. . . a pair of those old glasses, the ones with those funny square lenses.

The is also used with other **numbers**.

Example 1.4.32. *It is a mistake to confuse the 2.*
Why is she so different from the other 2?

See paragraphs **2.208–2.239** for more information about numbers.

1.4.2 Definite determiners: using *this, that, these*, and *those*

1.184 You use the **definite determiners** *this, that, these*, and *those* to talk about people or things in a definite way.
You use *this* and *these* to talk about people and things that are close to you in place or time.
When you talk about people or things that are more distant in place or time, you use *that* and *those*.
You put *this* and *that* in front of singular nouns, uncountable nouns, and the singular pronoun one.
You put *these* and *those* in front of plural nouns and the plural pronoun *ones*.
This, that, these, and *those* are often called **demonstratives** or **demonstrative adjectives**.
1.185 *This* and *these* are used to talk about people or things that are very obvious in the situation that you are in.
E.g., if you are inside a house, you can refer to it as *this house*.
If you are holding some keys in your hand, you can refer to them as *these keys*.
If you are at a party, you can refer to it as *this party*.

Example 1.4.33. *I have lived in this house my entire life.*
I am going to walk up these steps towards you.
I'll come as soon as these men have finished their work.
I like this university.
Good evening. In this programme we are going to look at the way in which British music has developed in recent years.

When it is clear who or what you are referring to, you can use *this* and *these* as **pronouns**.
This use is explained in paragraphs **1.124–1.127**.
1.186 *This* and *these* are also used in many expressions that refer to current periods of time, e.g. *this month, this week*, and *these days*.
This use is explained in Chap. 4.
1.187 You use *that* and *those* when you are talking about things or people that you can see but that are not close to you.

Example 1.4.34. *How much is it for that big box?*
Can I have one of those brochures?
Can you move those books off there?

1.188 When it is clear who or what you are talking about, you can use *that* and *those* as **pronouns**.
This use is explained in paragraphs **1.124–1.127**.

Example 1.4.35. *Could you just hold that?*
Please don't take those.

[i] Usage note.
1.189 You can show that you are referring to the same person or thing you have just mentioned by using *this, that, these*, or *those* in front of a noun.
E.g., if you have just mentioned a girl, you can refer to her as *this girl* or *that girl* the 2nd time you mention here.
Normally, you use a **pronoun** to refer to someone or something you have just mentioned, but sometimes you cannot do this because it might not be clear who or what the pronoun refers to.

Example 1.4.36. *Students and staff suggest books for the library, and normally we're quite happy to get those books.*
Their house is in a valley. The people in that valley speak about the people in the next valley as foreigners.
They had a lot of diamonds, and they asked her if she could possibly get these diamonds to Britain.

The use of *this, that, those*, etc. to refer again to something that has already been mentioned is fully explained in paragraphs **10.7–10.10**.
1.190 In informal English, you can also use *that* and *those* in front of a noun to talk about people or things that are already known to the person you are speaking or writing to.

Example 1.4.37. *That idiot Antonio has gone and locked our cabin door.*
Have they found those missing children yet?
Do you remember that funny little apartment?

1.191 You can use *that* in front of a noun when you are talking about something that has just happened.

Example 1.4.38. *I knew that meeting would be difficult.*

That is used as a **pronoun** to talk about something that has just happened.
This use is explained in paragraphs **1.124–1.127**.
1.192 In more formal English, *those* can be used instead of *the* in front of a plural noun when the plural noun is followed by a **relative clause**.
In this use, the relative clause specifies exactly which group of people or things are being referred to.

Example 1.4.39. *... those workers who are employed in large enterprises.*
The parents are not afraid to be firm about those matters that seem important to them.

1.193 In informal spoken English, people sometimes use *this* and *these* in front of nouns even when they are mentioning someone or something for the 1st time.

Example 1.4.40. *And then this woman came up to me and she said, I believe you have a goddaughter called Celia Ravenscroft.*
At school we had to wear these awful white cotton hats.

1.4.3 Possessive determiners: *my, your, their*, etc.

1.194 You often want to show that a thing belongs to someone or that it is connected in some way with someone.
1 way of doing this is to use a word like *my, your*, and *their*, which tells you who something belongs to.
These words are called **possessive determiners**.

Example 1.4.41. *Are your children bilingual?*
I remember his name now.
They would be welcome to use our library.
I'd been waiting a long time to park my car.

1.195 There are 7 possessive determiners in English, and each one is associated with a particular personal pronoun:

	singular	**plural**
1st person	my	our
2nd person	your	your
3rd person	his, her, its	their

Personal pronouns are explained in paragraphs **1.95–1.106**.
1.196 [!] You do not spell the possessive *its* with an apostrophe.
It's is short for *it is*.
1.197 Possessive determiners, like other determiners, come after any words like *all* or *some of* (called **predeterminers**), and before any numbers or adjectives.

Example 1.4.42. *... all his letters.*
... their next message.
... my little finger.
... our 2 lifeboats.

See paragraph **1.251** for more information about predeterminers.
1.200 [!] When you want to draw attention to the fact that something belongs or relates to a particular person or thing, you can use the word *own* after the possessive determiner.

Example 1.4.43. *I helped him to some more water but left my own glass untouched.*
Residents are allowed to bring their own furniture with them if they wish to do so.
Make your own decisions.
I heard it with my own ears.
She felt in charge of her own affairs.

If you use a number or adjective in this structure, you put the number or adjective after *own*.

Example 1.4.44. *... their own 3 children.*
The players provided their own white shorts.

1.201 Possessive determiners do not always show that what follows them is actually possessed (or owned) by someone.
Sometimes they just show that what follows is connected or associated with someone in some way.

Example 1.4.45. *They then turned their attention to other things.*
... the vitality of our music and our culture.
In summer, hay fever interfaced with all her activities.
It's his brother who has the workshop.

1.202 You can use a possessive determiner in front of a noun that refers to an action, in order to show who or what is doing the action.

Example 1.4.46. *... not long after our arrival.*
... his criticism of the Government.
... their fight for survival.
I'm waiting for your explanation.
Most of their claims were worthy.

In the last example, *their claims* refers to the claims that they have made.
1.203 You can also use a possessive determiner to say who or what is affected by an action.

Example 1.4.47. *My appointment as the 1st woman chairman symbolizes change.*
... the redistribution of wealth, rather than its creation.
They expressed their horror at her dismissal.

In the last example, *her dismissal* refers to the fact that she was dismissed by someone or by a company.
In the 1st of the following examples, *his supporters* means the people who support him.

Example 1.4.48. *... Birch and his supporters.*
She returned the ring to its owner.

[i] Usage note.
1.204 Sometimes in English the determiner *the* is used where there is an obvious possessive meaning.
In these cases the possession is already made clear by a preceding noun or pronoun.
The following paragraphs explain the situations in which you use *the* rather than a possessive determiner.
1.205 When you refer to a specific part of somebody's body, you normally use a possessive determiner.

Example 1.4.49. *She has something on her feet and a bag in her hand.*
Nancy suddenly took my arm.
The children wore nothing on their feet.
She thanked him shyly and patted his arm.
I opened the cupboard and they fell on my head.
He shook his head.

However, when you are describing an action that someone does a part of someone else's body, you often use the definite article (*the*), especially when the body part is the object of a preposition and when the object of the verb is a pronoun.
E.g., if you say *She hit me on the head, head* is the object of the preposition *on* and *me* is the object of the verb *hit*.

Example 1.4.50. *I patted him on the head*.
He took her by the arm and began drawing her away.

You use the definite article because the *owner* of the body part has already been identified, and you do not need to repeat this information.
Similarly, if the object of the verb is a **reflexive pronoun** e.g. *myself, yourself*, and so on, you use the definite article.
This is because the reflexive pronoun already refers to you or to the person who is doing the action, so you do not need to repeat this information by using a possessive determiner.

Example 1.4.51. *I accidentally hit myself on the head with the brush handle.*
We can pat ourselves on the back for bringing up our children.

Uses of reflexive pronouns are explained in paragraphs **1.111–1.118**.

1.206 If you want to describe something that you do to yourself or that someone else does to themselves, you normally use a possessive determiner.

Example 1.4.52. *She was brushing her hair.*
'I'm going to brush my teeth,' he said.
She gritted her teeth and carried on.
He walked into the kitchen and shook his head.

1.207 [!] You usually use possessive determiners when you refer to people or animals.
You do not usually use them to refer to things that are not alive.
It is, e.g., more usual to say *the door* or *the door of the room* than *its door*.

1.208 Possessive determiners are sometimes used to talk about things that belong to or are associated with people in general, in a similar way to generic pronouns.
For more information on **generic pronouns**, see paragraphs **1.119–1.123**.
Your can be used when you are talking about something that belongs to or is associated with people in general, or with a person in a situation that you are imagining.

Example 1.4.53. *Can eating a low-fat diet weaken your hair?*
Going to the gym is good for your general health.
Part of the process involves discussing your decision with a career counselor.

In more formal English, *one's* is sometimes used instead of *your*.

Example 1.4.54. *A satisfying job can bring structure and meaning to one's life.*

Our can be used to talk about all of mankind or society.

Example 1.4.55. *Being a child is not easy in our society.*

Their can be used to refer to a person when you do not know, or do not want to specify, whether that person is male or female.

Example 1.4.56. *The most important asset a person has is their ability to work.*
Each winner received a plaque with their award title.

1.209 There are other ways of showing that something is owned by or connected with someone or something else.
E.g., you can use *'s* (apostrophe *s*) or a prepositional phrase beginning with *of*.

Example 1.4.57. *Mary's daughter is called Elizabeth.*
Very often the person appointed has no knowledge of that company's end product.
... the house of a rich banker in Paris.
In the opinion of the team, what would they consider to be absolutely necessary?

1.210 Possessive determiners are also sometimes used in titles e.g. *Your Majesty* and *His Excellency*.
This use is explained in paragraph **1.56**.

1.4.4 The possessive form: apostrophe *s* (*'s*)

1.211 You usually show that something belongs to or is associated with a specific, named person by adding *'s* to the name of the person, and by placing this possessive form in front of the thing that belongs to them, or is associated with them.
E.g., if John owns a motorbike, you can refer to it is 'John's motorbike'.

Example 1.4.58. *Sylvia put her hand on John's arm.*
... the main features of Mr Brown's economic policy.

When you use a noun rather than a name to refer to the person, the noun phrase containing the possessive form also contains a determiner in the usual way.

Example 1.4.59. *... his grandmother's house.*
Your mother's best handbag.

Note that the determiner applies to the possessive form and not to the noun that is being modified by the possessive.

1.212 The spelling and pronunciation patterns used to form possessives change according to the spelling and pronunciation of the name or noun.

These are explained in the Reference section.

1.213 Note that in addition ot being the possessive form, the pattern *'s* can also be added to words as a contraction of *is* or *has*.

This is explained in the Reference section.

1.214 Apostrophe *s* (*'s*) is most often added to a noun referring to a person or an animal.

Example 1.4.60. *I wore a pair of my sister's boots.*
Philip watched his friend's reaction.
Billy patted the dog's head.

It can also be used to show that something belongs to or is associated with a group of people or an institution.

Example 1.4.61. *She runs the foreign exchange desk for the banks corporate clients.*
They also prepare the university's budget.
... the paper's political editor, Mr Fred Emery.
There was a raid on the Democratic Party's headquarters.
What is your government's policy?

1.215 Apostrophe *s* (*'s*) is sometimes added to a noun referring to an object when specifying a part of it or a quality or feature that it has.

Example 1.4.62. *I like the car's design.*
You can predict a computer's behavior because it follows rules.

Apostrophe *s* (*'s*) is used after nouns and names referring to places to specify something in that place.

Example 1.4.63. *He is the administrative head of the country's biggest city.*
The city's population is in decline.
... Britain's most famous company.

1.216 If you want to emphasize that something belongs or relates to a particular person and nobody else, you use *own*.

Own can be used after the possessive form of a name or noun, as well as after a possessive determiner.

Example 1.4.64. *Prof. Wilson's own answer may be unacceptable.*
We must depend on David's own assessment.

If you are specifying a number of things, you put the number after *own*.

Example 1.4.65. *... the Doctor's own 2 rooms.*

1.217 When you are talking about 2 things of the same type that belong to different people you can use the possessive form of a name or noun like a possessive pronoun so that you can avoid repeating the thing itself.

In the 1st example below, *her brother's* is used instead of *her brother's appearance*.

Example 1.4.66. *Her appearance is very different to her brother's.*
My room is next to Karen's.
It is your responsibility rather than your parents'.

The possessive form can also be used on its own to refer to someone's home or place of work.

Example 1.4.67. *He's round at David's.*
She stopped off at the butcher's for a piece of steak.
She hasn't been back to the doctor's since.

Possessive pronouns are explained in paragraphs **1.107–1.110**.

1.218 The possessive form can be used in a prepositional phrase beginning with *of* after a noun phrase.

You use this structure when you are talking about 1 of a number of things that belong to someone or are associated with them, rather than about something unique.

Example 1.4.68. *Julia, a friend of Jenny's, was there too.*
That word has a favorite of of your father's.

[i] Usage note.

1.219 Possessive forms can also be used to refer to things of a particular type that are usually associated with someone.

Example 1.4.69. *... a woman dressed in a man's raincoat.*
... a policeman's uniform.
... women's magazines.
... the men's lavatory.

1.220 The possessive form can sometimes be used with nouns that refer to an action in order to show who or what is performing the action.

Example 1.4.70. *... the banking service's rapid growth.*
... Madeleine's arrival at Fairwater House School.

Note that phrases beginning with *of* are used more commonly to do this, and that they are more formal than this use of possessive forms.

The use of prepositional phrases beginning with *of* to show who or what is performing an action is explained in paragraph **2.282**.

1.221 Sometimes you can add apostrophe *s* (*'s*) to a noun referring to the thing affected by the performer of an action and put it in front of the noun referring to that performer.

E.g., you can talk about *the scheme's supporters.*

Example 1.4.71. *... Christ's followers.*
... the car's owner.

Sometimes an apostrophe *s* (*'s*) structure can be used to refer to the thing affected by an action.

Example 1.4.72. *... Capello's appointment as England manager.*

Note again that *of* structures are more commonly used to do this.

1.222 It is also possible to show possession by using either a prepositional phrase beginning with *of*, or a structure with a noun modifier in it.

Prepositional phrases beginning with *of* are explained in paragraphs **2.277–2.283**.

Noun modifiers are explained in paragraphs **2.169–2.174**.

1.4.5 Indefinite determiners: *all, some, many*, etc.

1.223 **Indefinite determiners** are used in noun phrases when you are talking about people or things in a general way, without identifying them.

Here is a list of indefinite determiners:

Example 1.4.73. *a, all, an, another, any, both, each, either, enough, every, few, little, many, more, most, much, neither, no, other, several, some*

A, and *an* are the most common indefinite determiners; they are sometimes called the **definite article**.

For more information about *a* and *an*, see paragraphs **1.228–1.235**.

For more information about the other indefinite determiners, see paragraphs **1.236–1.250**.

1.224 *A* and *an* are used with singular countable nouns, and show that you are talking about just 1 person or thing.

Another is used with singular countable nouns and *other* with plural countable nouns, but only after 1 or more of the same type of person or thing has been mentioned.

Any can be used with singular and plural countable nouns to talk about 1 or more people or things.

You use *enough, few, many, more, most, several*, and *some* with plural countable nouns to show that you are talking about a number of people or things.

Each of these determiners indicates a different set or group within the total number.

For more information about their meanings, see the section beginning at paragraph **1.236**.

All, both, each, either, and *every* show that you are talking about the total number of people or things involved.

Both and *either* specify that only 2 people or things are involved.

Both is used with a plural noun, and *either* with a singular noun.

All, each, and *every* usually show that there are more than 2.

All is used with a plural noun, and *each* and *every* with a singular noun.

No and *neither* refer to the total number of things involved in negative statements.

No is used with singular or plural nouns, and *neither* only with singular nouns.

No and *neither* are covered in the section on **negative words** in Chap. 5.

For more information about **countable nouns**, see paragraphs **1.15–1.22**.

1.225 For uncountable nouns, *any, enough, little, more, most, much*, and *some* are used to talk about a quantity of something.

No and *all* indicate the total quantity of it.

For more information about **uncountable nouns**, see paragraphs **1.23–1.33**.

1.226 [!] *A, an, another, both, each, either, every, few, many, neither*, and *several* are not usually used with uncountable nouns.

1.227 When you are referring to things or people in an indefinite way, you can sometimes use a noun without a determiner.

Example 1.4.74. *... raising money from industry, government, and trusts.*
Permission should be asked before visitors are invited.

Uncountable nouns are usually used without a determiner.

Example 1.4.75. *Health and education are matters that most voters feel strongly about.*
Wealth, like power, tends to corrupt.

Plural nouns are used without a determiner when you are referring to all the people or things of a particular kind.

Example 1.4.76. *Dogs need a regular balanced diet, not just meat.*
Are there any jobs that men can do that women can't?

Plural nouns can also be used without a determiner to talk about an unspecified number of things.

Example 1.4.77. *Teachers should read stories to children.*
Cats and dogs get fleas.

For more information about plural nouns, see paragraphs **1.41–1.46**.

1.4.6 *A & an*

1.228 *A* and *an* are the most common **indefinite determiners**.

They are used for talking about a person or thing when it is not clear or not important which one is intended.

You put *a* or *an* in front of the singular form of a **countable noun**.

Example 1.4.78. *He's bought the children a puppy.*
He was eating an apple.
An old lady was calling to him.

1.229 You use *a* when the following word begins with a consonant sound.

Example 1.4.79. *... a piece... a good teacher... a language class.*

This includes some words that begin with a vowel in their written form, because the 1st sound is a *y* sound, /j/.

Example 1.4.80. *... a university... a European language.*

You use *an* when the following word begins with a vowel sound.

Example 1.4.81. *... an example... an art exhibition... an early train.*

This includes some words that begin with the letter *h* in their written form, because the *h* is not pronounced.

Example 1.4.82. *... an honest politician... quarter of an hour.*

A is usually pronounced /ə/.

An is usually pronounced /ən/.

1.230 People often say that you use *a* or *an* when you are mentioning something for the 1st time, but this is not a very helpful rule because there are so many situations where you use *the* for the 1st mention of something.

See, e.g., paragraphs **1.166**, **1.167–1.168**.

You usually use *a* or *an* when it is not clear or not important which specific person or thing is being referred to.

Example 1.4.83. *She picked up a book.*
After weeks of looking, we eventually bought a house.
A colleague and I got some money to do research on rats.

1.231 Sometimes, *a* or *an* is simply followed by a noun.

Example 1.4.84. *I got a postcard from Susan.*
The FBI is conducting an investigation.

But if you want to add extra information, you can add an adjective, or a following clause or phrase.

Example 1.4.85. *I met a Swedish girl on the train from Copenhagen.*
I've been reading an interesting article in The Economist.
We had to write a story about our parents' childhood.
I chose a picture that reminded me of my own country.

1.232 You can alos use *a* or *an* after a **linking verb**.

Example 1.4.86. *She is a model and an artist.*
His father was an alcoholic.
Noise was considered a nuisance.
His brother was a sensitive child.

For more informative about linking verbs, see Chap. 3.

1.233 Sometimes, *a* or *an* are used with an uncountable noun, especially one that relates to human emotions or mental activity.

This only happens when the uncountable noun is limited by an adjective, or a phrase or clause giving more information.

Example 1.4.87. *A general education is perhaps more important than an exact knowledge of some particular theory.*
She had an eagerness for life.

1.234 You can use *a* or *an* with a noun when you are using 1 individual person or thing to make a general statement about all people or things of that type.

E.g., if you say *A gun must be kept in a safe place*, you are talking about an individual gun in order to make a general statement about all guns.

Example 1.4.88. *A computer can only do what you program it to do.*
A dog likes to eat far more meat than a human being.
An unmarried mother was looked down on.

This is not the usual way of referring to groups.

Normally, if you want to make a statement about all the people or things of a particular kind, you use the plural form of a noun without a determiner.

See paragraph **1.227** for more information about this.

1.235 *A* and *an* sometimes used with **singular nouns** e.g. *sun, moon*, and *sky* that refer to just 1 thing.

You normally use *the* with these nouns, but you use *a* or *an* when you are drawing attention to some special feature by adding a modifier or a following phrase or clause to the noun.

This use is particularly common in literature.

Example 1.4.89. *We drove under a gloomy sky.*
A weak sun shines on the promenade.

For more information on singular nouns, see paragraphs **1.34–1.40**.

1.4.7 Other indefinite determiners

1.236 *Some* is usually used to show that there is a quantity of something or a number of things or people, without being precise.

It is used with uncountable nouns and plural countable nouns.

Some is usually used in affirmative statements.

Example 1.4.90. *There is some evidence that the system works.*
There's some chocolate cake over there.
I had some good ideas.

Some can be used in questions, when you expect the answer to be *yes*.

Example 1.4.91. *Could you give me some examples?*
Would you like some coffee?

Some is also used to mean quite a large amount or number.
E.g., in *I did not meet her again for some years, some* means almost the same as *several* or *many.*

Example 1.4.92. *You will be unable to restart the car for some time.*
It tool some years for Dan to realize the truth.

1.237 You can also use *some* in front of numbers, in slightly more literary English, to show that you are not being totally accurate.

Example 1.4.93. *I was some 15 miles by sea from the nearest village.*
. . . an animal weighing some 5 tons.

1.238 When you want to emphasize that you do not know the identity of a person or thing, or you think their identity is not important, you can use *some* with a singular countable noun, instead of *a* or an.

Example 1.4.94. *Most staff members will spend a few weeks in some developing country.*
Supposing you had some eccentric who came and offended you a thousand pounds.

1.239 *Any* is used before plural nouns and uncountable nouns when you are referring to a quantity of something that may or may not exist.

Example 1.4.95. *The patients know their rights like any other consumers.*
Check online if you're in any doubt.
You can stop at any time you like.

Any is also used in questions asking whether something exists or not.
It is also used in negative statements to say that something does not exist.

Example 1.4.96. *Do you have any advice on that?*
Do you have any vacancies for bar staff?
It hasn't made any difference.
Nobody in her house knows any English.
I range up to see if there were any tickets left.

Questions and negative statements are explained further in Chap. 5.
Note that you can use *any* with singular countable nouns to talk about someone or something of a particular type, when you do not want to mention a specific person or thing.

Example 1.4.97. *Any big tin container will do.*
Cars can be rented at almost any US airport.

Any can also be used as a **pronoun**.
See paragraphs **1.93–1.161** for more information about pronouns.
It is also used in ***if*-clauses**.
For more information about these, see Chap. 8.
1.240 *Another* is used with singular countable nouns to talk about an additional person or thing of the same type as you have already mentioned.

Example 1.4.98. *Could I have another cup of coffee?*
He opened another shop last month.

It can also be used before numbers to talk about more than 1 additional thing.

Example 1.4.99. *Margaret staying with us for another 10 days.*
5 officials were sacked and another 4 arrested.

Other is used with plural nouns, or occasionally with uncountable nouns.

Example 1.4.100. *Other people must have thought like this.*
They are either asleep or entirely absorbed in play or other activity.

1.241 *Enough* is used to say that there is as much of something as is needed, or as many things as are needed.
You can therefore use *enough* in front of uncountable nouns or plural nouns.

Example 1.4.101. *There's enough space for the children to run around.*
They weren't getting enough customers.

Many indicates that there is a large number of things, without being very precise.
You use *many* with a plural countable noun.

Example 1.4.102. *He spoke many different languages.*

When you want to emphasize that there is only a small number of things of a particular kind, you use *few* with a plural countable noun.

Example 1.4.103. *There are few drugs that act quickly enough to be effective.*
There were few doctors available.

Few is quite formal.
In less formal English, you can use *not many* with the same meaning.

Example 1.4.104. *There aren't many gardeners like him.*

Most indicates nearly all of a group or amount.
You use *most* with an uncountable noun or a plural countable noun.

Example 1.4.105. *Most people recover but the disease can be fatal.*
Most farmers are still using the old methods.

Several usually indicates an imprecise number that is not very large, but is more than 2.
You use *several* with a plural countable noun.

Example 1.4.106. *Several projects had to be postponed.*
I had seen her several times before.
There were several reasons for this.

1.242 *All* includes every person or thing of a particular kind.
You use *all* with an uncountable noun or a plural countable noun.

Example 1.4.107. *They believe that all prisoners should be treated the same.*

Both is used to say something about 2 people or things of the same kind.
You use *both* with a plural countable noun.
The 2 people or things have usually been mentioned or are obvious from the context.
Both is sometimes used to emphasize that 2 people or things are involved, rather than just 1.

Example 1.4.108. *There were excellent performances from both actresses.*
Denis held his cocoa in both hands.

Either is also used to talk about 2 things, but usually indicates that only 1 of the 2 is involved.
You use *either* with a singular countable noun.
When it is part of the subject of a clause, the verb is in the singular.

Example 1.4.109. *No argument could move either old gentleman from this decision.*
If either parent has the disease, there is a much higher chance that the child will develop it.

Note that *either* can mean both of 2 things, especially when it is used with *end* and *side*.

Example 1.4.110. *They stood on either side of the bed.*

1.243 You use *each* and *every* when you are talking about all the members of a group of people or things.
You use *each* when you are thinking about the members as individuals, and *every* when you are making a general statement about all of them.
Each and *every* are followed by a singular countable noun.

Example 1.4.111. *Each seat was covered with a white lace cover.*
They would rush out to meet each visitor.
This new wealthy can be seen in every village.
Every child would have milk every day.
Each applicant has 5 choices.
I agree with every word Peter says.

You can modify *every* but not *each*.

You can say things e.g. *Almost every chair is broken* or *Not every chair is broken* but you cannot say *Almost each chair is broken* or *Not each chair is broken*.

This is because *each* is slightly more precise and definite than *every*.

Note that *each* can be used when talking about 2 people or things, but *every* is only used for numbers larger than 2.

1.244 If you want to emphasize that there is only a small amount of something, you use *little*.

You use *much* to emphasize a large amount.

Little and *much* are used with uncountable nouns.

Little is used only in affirmative statements.

It is not used in questions or negatives.

Example 1.4.112. *There was little applause.*
We've made little process.
We have very little information.

Little is quite formal.

In less formal contexts, *not much* is more common.

E.g., instead of saying *We've made little progress*, you can say *We haven't made much progress.*

Much is usually used in questions and negatives.

Example 1.4.113. *Do you watch much television?*
He did not speak much English.

Very much is used only in negative statements.

E.g., *I don't have very much sugar* means *I have only a small quantity of sugar.*

Example 1.4.114. *I haven't given very much attention to this problem.*

Much is used in affirmative statements when it is modified by an adverb e.g. *too, so* or *as.*

Example 1.4.115. *It would take too much time.*
Provide as much information as you can about the property.

In more formal English, *much* can be used in affirmative statements without an adverb.

This usage is most common with abstract nouns, particularly those relating to discussion, debate and research.

Example 1.4.116. *The subject of company annual accounts is generating much debate among accountants and analysts.*
The team's findings have caused much excitement among medical experts.
After much speculation, intelligence agencies now believe that he survived.

Usually, though, *much* is not used in affirmative statements.

Instead, people generally use *a lot of* and, in less formal texts, *lots of.*

E.g., people would not usually say *I have much work to do;* instead, they would say *I have a lot of work to do.*

For more information on *a lot of*, see **2.176**.

1.245 Some other words can be indefinite determiners, e.g. *certain, numerous*, and *various.*

You use *certain, numerous* and *various* with a plural countable noun.

Certain is used to refer to some members of a group, without specifying which ones.

Example 1.4.117. *We have certain ideas about what topics are suitable.*

Numerous, like *many*, indicates a large number in an imprecise way.

Example 1.4.118. *I have received numerous requests for information.*

Various is used to emphasize that you are referring to several different things or people.

Example 1.4.119. *We looked at schools in various European countries.*

1.246 There are 3 comparatives that are determiners.

More is used in front of plural and uncountable nouns, usually with *than*, to refer to a quantity or amount of something that is greater than another quantity or amount.

Example 1.4.120. *He does more hours than I do.*
His visit might do more harm than good.

But *more* is also often used to refer to an additional quantity of something rather than in comparisons.

Example 1.4.121. *More teachers need to be recruited.*
We need more information.

Less is used to refer to an amount of something that is smaller than another amount.
Fewer is used to refer to a group of things that is smaller than another group.
Less is usually used before uncountable nouns and *fewer* before plural nouns, but in informal English *less* is also used before plural nouns.

Example 1.4.122. *The poor have less access to education.*
. . . machinery which uses less energy.
As a result, he found less time than he would have hoped for his hobbies.
There are fewer trees here.

For more information about **comparison**, see paragraphs **2.103–2.139**.
1.247 Some other expressions also behave like indefinite determiners: *a few, a little, a good many, a great many.*
These have a slightly different meaning from the single word determiners *few, little*, and *many.*
If you are mentioning a small number of things, but without any emphasis, you can use *a few* with plural countable nouns.

Example 1.4.123. *They went to San Diego for a few days.*
A few years ago we set up a factory.
I usually do a few jobs for him in the house.

Similarly, if you are just mentioning a small amount of something without any emphasis, you can use *a little* with uncountable nouns.

Example 1.4.124. *He spread a little honey on a slice of bread.*
I have to spend a little time in Oxford.
Charles is having a little trouble.

However, *a good many* and *a great many* are more emphatic forms of *many.*

Example 1.4.125. *I haven't seen her for a good many years.*
He wrote a great many novels.

1.248 Some indefinite determiners can be modified by *very, too*, and *far*, or sometimes by another indefinite determiner.
You can modify *more* with numbers or with other indefinite determiners.

Example 1.4.126. *Downstairs there are 4 more rooms.*
There had been no more accidents.
You will never have to do any more work.

You can use too many or *too much* to say that a quantity is more than is wanted or needed, and *too few* or *too little* if it is not enough.

Example 1.4.127. *There were too many competitors.*
They gave too much power to the Treasury.
There's too little literature involved.

You can use *very* before *few, little, many*, and *much.*
You can also say *a very little* or *a very great many.*

Example 1.4.128. *Very many women have made their mark on industry.*
Very few cars had reversing lights.
I had very little money left.

1.249 You use *one* as a determiner when you have been talking or writing about a group of people or things and you want to say something about a particular member of the group.
One is used instead of *a* or *an* and is slightly more emphatic.

Example 1.4.129. *We had 1 case that dragged on for a couple of years.*
They criticize me all the time, wrote 1 woman.
I know 1 household where that happened, actually.

The use of *one* as a **number** is explained in paragraphs **2.214–2.215**.

1.250 Many determiners are also **pronouns**; i.e., they can be used without a following noun.
For more information about these, see paragraphs **1.154–1.161**.

1.251 Normally, a determiner is the 1st word in a noun phrase.
However, there is a class of words called **predeterminers** which can come in front of a determiner.
Here is a list of predeterminers:

Example 1.4.130. *all, both, double, half, many, quarter, twice*
quite, rather, such, what

The 1st group are used to talk about amounts or quantities.
All can also be used to refer to every part of something.
When used with this meaning it is used with an uncountable noun.

Example 1.4.131. *<u>All</u> the boys started to giggle.*
He will give you <u>all</u> the information.
<u>All</u> these people knew each other.
I shall miss <u>all</u> my friends.
I invited <u>both</u> the boys.
<u>Both</u> these parties shared 1 basic belief.
She paid <u>double</u> the sum they asked for.
I'm getting <u>twice</u> the pay I used to get.

In the 2nd group, *quite* and *rather* can be used either to emphasize or to reduce the effect of what is being said.
In speech, the meaning is made clear by your tone of voice.
In writing, it is sometimes difficult to know which meaning is intended without reading more of the text.

Example 1.4.132. *It takes <u>quite</u> a long time to get a divorce.*
It was <u>quite</u> a shock.
Seaford is <u>rather</u> a pleasant town.
It was <u>rather</u> a disaster.

Such and *what* are used for emphasis.

Example 1.4.133. *He has <u>such</u> a beautiful voice.*
<u>What</u> a mess!

Chapter 2

Giving information about people & things: adjectives, numbers, & other modifiers

2.1 Introduction

2.1 In the previous chapter the use of nouns, pronouns, and determiners to name and identify people and things was explained.

This chapter explains ways of giving more information about the people and the things that have already been named or identified.

1 way of giving more information within a noun phrase about people or things is by the use of an **adjective**, e.g. *small, political*, or *blue*.

Adjectives can be used as modifiers of a noun or after linking verbs.

They are explained in paragraphs **2.2**–**2.168**.

Sometimes, **nouns**, rather than adjectives, are used to modify the noun.

This is explained in paragraphs **2.169**–**2.174**.

There are other groups of words that are used before a noun phrase to give more information about people and things.

They are linked to the noun phrase by *of*.

These include certain **indefinite determiners** e.g. *many of* and *some of* (explained in paragraphs **2.176**–**2.193**), and other expressions that are used for describing a part or amount of something, e.g. *a piece of* and *a bottle of* (explained in paragraphs **2.194**–**2.207**).

Numbers and **fractions** are also used to indicate the amount of people or things you are talking about.

Numbers are explained in paragraph **2.208**–**2.239** and fractions are explained in paragraphs **2.250**–**2.249**.

The other way of giving more information within a noun phrase about people or things is by using a **qualifier**, i.e., giving extra information in the form of a phrase or a clause after the noun to expand its meaning.

This is explained in paragraphs **2.272**–**2.302**.

2.2 Describing people & things: adjectives

2.2 When you want to give more information about something than you can give by using a noun alone, you can use an **adjective** to identify it or describe it in more detail.

Example 2.2.1. *... a new idea.*
... new ideas.
... new creative ideas.
Ideas are important.
... to suggest that new ideas are useful.

2.3 The most important things to notice about an adjective in English are

- what structure it is in (e.g. before a noun or after a linking verb)
- what type of adjective it is (e.g. describing a quality or placing the noun in a particular class).

2.4 [!] The form of an adjective does not change: you use the same form for singular and plural and for subject and object.

Example 2.2.2. *We were looking for a good place to camp.*
The next good place was 45 miles further on.
Good places to fish were hard to find.
We found hardly any good places.

2.5 Adjectives are nearly always used in connection with a noun or pronoun to give information about the person, thing, or group that is being referred to.

When this information is not the main purpose of a statement, adjectives are placed in front of a noun, as in *hot coffee*.

The use of adjectives in a noun phrase is explained in paragraph **2.19**.

2.6 Sometimes, however, the main purpose of a statement is to give the information expressed by an adjective.

When this happens, adjectives are placed after a **linking verb** e.g. *be* or *become*, as in *I am cold* and *He became ill*.

The use of adjectives after a linking verb is explained in paragraphs **3.122**–**3.137**.

2.7 There is a large group of adjectives that identify qualities that someone or somethings has.

This group includes words e.g. *happy* and *intelligent*.

These are called **qualitative adjectives**.

Qualitative adjectives are explained in paragraphs **2.22**–**2.25**.

2.8 There is another large group of adjectives that identify someone or something as a member of a class.

This group includes words e.g. *financial* and *intellectual*.

These are called **classifying adjectives**.

Classifying adjectives are explained in paragraphs **2.26**–**2.28**.

Some adjectives are both qualitative and classifying.

These are explained in paragraph **2.29**.

2.9 There is a small group of adjectives that identify the color of something.

This group includes words like *blue* and *green*.

They are called **color adjectives**.

Color adjectives are explained in paragraphs **2.30**–**2.35**.

2.10 Another small group of adjectives are used to emphasize your feelings about the person or thing you are talking about.

These adjectives are called **emphasizing adjectives**, and they include adjectives e.g. *complete, absolute*, and *utter*.

Emphasizing adjectives are explained in paragraphs **2.36**–**2.39**.

2.11 There is a small group of adjectives that are used in a very similar way to **determiners** (see paragraphs **1.162**–**1.251**) to make the reference more precise.

These are called **postdeterminers** because their place in a noun phrase is immediately after the determiner, if there is one, and before any other adjectives.

Postdeterminers are explained in paragraph **2.40**.

2.12 Most adjectives can be used either before the noun or after a linking verb.

However, there are some that can be used only in 1 position or the other.

This is explained in paragraphs **2.41**–**2.53**.

2.13 There are a few adjectives that can be used immediately after the noun.

They are explained in paragraphs **2.58**–**2.62**.

2.14 When 2 or more adjectives are used in a structure, they usually occur in a particular order.

This is explained in paragraphs **2.54**–**2.57**.

2.15 There are a large number of English adjectives ending in *-ing*, many of which are related to the ***-ing* participle** of a verb.

In this grammar they are called ***-ing* adjectives**.

There are also a large number of English adjectives ending in *-ed*, many of which are related to the ***-ed* participle** of a verb.

In this grammar they are called ***-ed* adjectives**.

-ing adjectives are explained in paragraphs **2.63**–**2.76**.

-ed adjectives are explained in paragraphs **2.77**–**2.93**.

2.16 **Compound adjectives** are made up of 2 or more words, usually written with hyphens between them.

Compound adjectives are explained in paragraphs **2.94**–**2.102**.

2.17 When you want to compare the amount of a quality that 2 or more people or things have, you can use **comparative** and **superlative** adjectives.

There are also some other ways of comparing things.

Comparatives are explained in paragraphs **2.103**–**2.111**, and superlatives are explained in paragraphs **2.113**–**2.122**.

Other ways of comparing things are explained in paragraphs **2.123**–**2.139**.

2.18 You can also talk about the amount of a quality that something or someone has by using an adverb like *totally* or *mildly* with an adjective.

This is explained in paragraphs **2.141**–**2.168**.

2.2.1 Adjective structures

2.19 Adjectives are used in 2 main structures.

1 of them involves adjectives coming before the noun phrase.

If you say *Julia was carrying an old suitcase*, you main purpose is to say that Julia was carrying a suitcase.

The adjective *old* gives more information about what kind of suitcase it was.

Example 2.2.3. *He was wearing a white t-shirt.*
... a technical term.
... a pretty little star-shaped flower bed.

Most adjectives can be used in this way.

2.20 The other main structure involves adjectives being used after **linking verbs** e.g. *be* and *become*.

Putting an adjective after a linking verb has the effect of focusing attention on the adjective.

If you say *The suitcase she was carrying was old*, your main purpose is to describe the suitcase, so the focus on the adjective *old*.

Example 2.2.4. *The roads are busy.*
The house was quiet.
He became angry.
I feel cold.
Nobody seemed amused.

The use of adjectives after linking verbs is explained in paragraphs **3.132–3.137**.

Most adjective can be used in this way.

2.21 In the following examples, the 1st example in each pair shows an adjective being used before the noun, while the 2nd example shows it being used with a linking verb.

Example 2.2.5. *There was no clear evidence.*
'That's very clear,' I said.
It has been a pleasant evening.
It's not a big stream, but it's very pleasant.
She bought a loaf of white bread.
The walls were white.

2.2.2 Identifying qualities: *a sad story, a pretty girl*

2.22 There are 2 main types of adjective, **qualitative** and **classifying**.

Adjectives that describe a quality that someone or something has, e.g. *sad, pretty, small, happy, healthy, wealthy*, and *wise*, are called **qualitative adjectives**.

Example 2.2.6. *... a sad story.*
... a pretty girl.
... a small child.
... a happy mother with a healthy baby.
... a wealthy bankers.
I think it would be wise to give up.

2.23 Adjectives that describe qualities are **gradable**, which means that the person or thing referred to can have more or less of the quality mentioned.

2.24 The usual way in which you show the amount of a quality that something or someone has is by using adverbs like *very* and *rather* in front of qualitative adjectives.

This is explained in paragraphs **2.140–2.156**.

2.25 The other way in which you can talk about the amount of a quality that something or someone has is by using a **comparative**, e.g. *bigger* and *more interesting*, or a **superlative**, e.g. *the biggest* and *the most interesting*.

Comparatives and superlatives are explained in paragraphs **2.103–2.122**.

Here is a list of qualitative adjectives:

Example 2.2.7. *active, angry, anxious, appropriate, attractive, bad, beautiful, big, brief, bright, broad, busy, calm, careful, cheap, clean, clear, close, cold, comfortable, common, complex, cool, curious, dangerous, dark, dear, deep, determined, different, difficult, dirty, dry, easy, effective, efficient, expensive, fair, familiar, famous, fast, fat, fine, firm, flat, frank, free, fresh, friendly, frightened, funny, good, great, happy, hard, heavy, high, hot, important, interesting, kind, large, late, light,*

likely, long, loose, loud, lovely, low, lucky, narrow, nervous, new, nice, obvious, odd, old, pale, patient, plain, pleasant, poor, popular, powerful, pretty, proud, quick, quiet, rare, reasonable, rich, rough, sad, safe, sensible, serious, sharp, shocked, short, sick, significant, silly, simple, slow, small, soft, special, steady, strange, strong, stupid, successful, suitable, sure, surprised, sweet, tall, terrible, thick, thin, tight, tiny, tired, typical, understanding, useful, violent, warm, weak, wet, wide, wild, worried, young

2.2.3 Identifying type: *financial help, abdominal pains*

2.26 The other main type of adjective consists of adjectives that you use to identify the type or *class* that something belongs to.

E.g., if you say *financial help*, you are using the adjective *financial* to describe what type of help you are talking about (i.e., to *classify* help).

Adjectives that are used in this way are called **classifying adjectives**.

Example 2.2.8. ... *financial help.*
... *abdominal pains.*
... *a medieval manuscript.*
... *my daily shower.*
... *an equal partnership.*
... *a sufficient amount of milk.*

Note that **noun modifiers** (see paragraphs **2.169–2.174**) are used in a similar way to classifying adjectives.

E.g., *financial matters* and *money matters* are similar in both structure and meaning.

Here is a list of classifying adjectives:

Example 2.2.9. *absolute, active, actual, agricultural, alternative, annual, apparent, available, basic, central, chemical, civil, commercial, communist, conservative, cultural, daily, democratic, direct, domestic, double, due, east, eastern, economic, educational, electric, empty, external, female, financial, foreign, free, full, general, golden, historical, human, ideal, independent, industrial, inevitable, intellectual, internal, international, legal, local, magic, male, medical, mental, military, modern, moral, national, natural, negative, north, northern, nuclear, official, open, original, personal, physical, political, positive, possible, potential, private, professional, proper, psychological, public, raw, ready, real, religious, revolutionary, right, royal, rural, scientific, separate, sexual, single, social, solid, south, southern, standard, straight, sufficient, theoretical, traditional, urban, west, western, wooden, wrong*

2.27 Adjectives e.g. *British, American*, and *Australian*, that indicate nationality or origin, are also classifying adjectives.

They start with a capital letter because they are related to names of countries.

Example 2.2.10. ... *American citizens.*

Some classifying adjectives are formed from people's names, e.g. *Victorian* and *Shakespearean.*

They also start with a capital letter.

Example 2.2.11. ... *Victorian houses.*

2.28 Because they put something in a class, classifying adjectives are not **gradable** in the way that qualitative adjectives are.

E.g., if you do not have to pay for something, you cannot say that it is *very free*, or *rather free.*

Things are either in a particular class or not in it.

Therefore, classifying adjectives do not have comparatives and superlatives and are not normally used with adverbs like *very* and *rather.*

However, when you want to show that you feel strongly about what you are saying, you can use an *intensifying* adverb e.g. *absolutely* with a classifying adjective.

This is explained in paragraphs **2.147–2.148**.

2.29 Some adjectives can be either **qualitative** or **classifying** depending on the meaning.

E.g., in *an emotional person, emotional* is a qualitative adjective meaning *feeling or expressing strong emotions*; it has a comparative and superlative and it can be used with words like *very* and *rather.*

Thus, a person can be *very emotional, rather emotional*, or *more emotional* than someone else.

However, in *the emotional needs of children, emotional* is a classifying adjective meaning *relation to a person's emotions*, and so it cannot be used with words like *very* or *rather*, and it does not have a comparative and superlative.

Here is a list of adjectives that are often used both as qualitative adjectives and as classifying adjectives:

Example 2.2.12. *academic, conscious, dry, educational, effective, emotional, extreme, late, modern, moral, objective, ordinary, regular, religious, revolutionary, rural, scientific, secret, similar, social*

2.2.4 Identifying colors: color adjectives

2.30 When you want to say what color something is, you use a **color adjective**.

Example 2.2.13. *... her blue eyes.*
... a red ribbon.

Here is a list of the main color adjectives:

Example 2.2.14. *black, blue, brown, cream, green, grey, orange, pink, purple, red, scarlet, violet, white, yellow*

2.31 If you want to specify color more precisely, you use a word e.g. *light, pale, dark, deep*, or *bright*, in front of a color adjective.

Example 2.2.15. *... light brown hair.*
... a pale green suit.
... a dark blue dress.
... deep red dye.

These combinations sometimes have hyphens.

Example 2.2.16. *... a light-blue suit.*
... the plant's tiny pale-pink flowers.

Note that these words cannot be used with the colors *black* or *white*, because you cannot have different shades of black and white.

If you want to talk about a color that does not have a definite name you can:

- use a color adjective with *-ish* added to the end

  Example 2.2.17. *... greenish glass.*
  ... yellowish hair.

- combine 2 color adjectives, often with *-ish* or *-y* on the end of the 1st one.

  Example 2.2.18. *... greenish-white flowers.*

2.33 [⋆] You can mix colors in these ways to produce whatever new color you are trying to describe.
2.34 Color adjectives e.g. *blue* and *green* occasionally have comparatives and superlatives ending in *-er* and *-est*.

Example 2.2.19. *His face was redder than usual.*
... the bluest sky I have ever seen.

Comparatives and **superlatives** are explained in paragraphs **2.103**–**2.122**.
2.35 Colors can also be nouns, and the main colors can also be plural nouns.

Example 2.2.20. *The snow shadows had turned to a deep blue.*
They blended in so well with the khaki and reds of the landscape.
... brilliantly colored in reds, yellows, blacks, and purples.

2.2.5 Showing strong feelings: *complete, absolute*, etc.

2.36 You can emphasize your feelings about something that you mention by putting an adjective e.g. *complete, absolute*, or *utter* in front of a noun.

Example 2.2.21. *He made me feel like a complete idiot.*
Some of it was absolute rubbish.
... utter despair.
... pure bliss.

You generally use an adjective of this kind only when the noun shows your opinion about something.
Because they are used to show strong feelings, these adjectives are called **emphasizing adjectives**.
Here is a list of emphasizing adjectives:

Example 2.2.22. *absolute, complete, entire, outright, perfect, positive, pure, real, total, true, utter*

2.37 A small group of adjectives ending in *-ing* are used in very informal spoken English for emphasis, usually to show disapproval or contempt.

Example 2.2.23. *Everybody in the whole stinking town was loaded with money.*
Shut that blinking door!

Here is a list of adjectives used informally for emphasis:

Example 2.2.24. *blinking, blithering, blooming, blundering, crashing, flaming, freezing, piddling, raving, scalding, stinking, thumping, thundering, whopping*

2.38 [!] Many of these adjectives are usually used with 1 particular noun or adjective after them: *blithering idiot, blundering idiot, crashing bore, raving lunatic, thundering nuisance, freezing cold, scalding hot, piddling little..., thumping great..., whopping great....*

Example 2.2.25. *He's driving that car like a raving lunatic!*
I've got a stinking cold.
... a piddling little car.

2.39 The word *very* is sometimes used to emphasize a noun, in expressions like *the very top* and *the very end*.

Example 2.2.26. *... at the very end of the shop.*
... the very bottom of the hill.
These molecules were formed at the very beginning of history.

2.2.6 Making the reference more precise: postdeterminers

2.40 There is a small group of adjectives that are used in a very similar way to **determiners** (see paragraphs **1.162–1.251**) to make the reference more precise.

These are called **postdeterminers**, because their place in a noun phrase is immediately after the determiner, if there is one, and before any other adjectives.

Example 2.2.27. *... the following brief description.*
... certain basic human qualities.
... improvements in the last few years.
... further technological advance.
He wore his usual old white coat...
... the only sensible thing to do.

You often need to make it clear precisely what you are referring to.
E.g., if you say *Turn left at the tall building* someone might ask which tall building you mean.
If you say *Turn left at the next tall building*, there can be no doubt which one you mean.
The postdeterminer *next* picks it out precisely.
Here is a list of adjectives that are postdeterminers:

Example 2.2.28. *additional, certain, chief, entire, existing, 1st, following, further, last, main, next, only, opposite, other, particular, past, present, previous, principal, remaining, same, special, specific, usual*

Some of these adjectives are also ordinary classifying adjectives.

Example 2.2.29. *He had children from a previous marriage.*
There are 2 main reasons for this.

Here is a list of postdeterminers that are also classifying adjectives:

Example 2.2.30. *additional, chief, existing, further, main, other, particular, past, previous, principal, remaining, specific*

Adjective that are used to show the position of something are also used for precise reference.

Example 2.2.31. *... the middle button of her black leather coat.*
... the top 100 German companies.

Here is a list of adjectives sometimes used to talk about the position of something as well as for precise reference:

Example 2.2.32. *left, right, upper, lower, top, bottom, middle, end, front, back*

Postdeterminers can also be used with numbers.
This is explained in paragraph **2.219**.

2.2.7 Special classes of adjectives

2.41 Most adjectives can be used both before the noun and after a linking verb, but there are some that are only used in 1 position or the other.

There are a few adjectives that are always or almost always used in front of a noun and are never or rarely used after a linking verb.

These adjectives are called **attributive adjectives**.

Examples are *atomic* and *outdoor*.

You can talk about *an atomic explosion*, but you do not say *The explosion was atomic*.

You can talk about *outdoor pursuits*, but you do not say *Their pursuits are outdoor*.

2.42 A few **qualitative adjectives** (see paragraphs **2.22–2.25**) are only used in front of a noun.

Here is a list of qualitative adjectives always used in this way:

Example 2.2.33. *adoring, belated, chequered, choked, commanding, fateful, flagrant, fleeing, knotty, paltry, punishing, ramshackle, scant, searing, thankless, unenviable*

Most adjectives that are only used in front of a noun are **classifying adjectives** (see paragraphs **2.26–2.28**).

Here is a list of classifying adjectives used attributively:

Example 2.2.34. *atomic, bridal, cardiac, countless, cubic, digital, east, eastern, eventual, existing, federal, forensic, indoor, institutional, introductory, investigate, judicial, lone, maximum, nationwide, neighboring, north, northern, occasional, orchestral, outdoor, phonetic, preconceived, remedial, reproductive, smokeless, south, southern, subterranean, supplementary, underlying, west, western, woolen*

2.43 There are no **color adjectives** (see paragraphs **2.30–2.35**) that are restricted to this position.

Emphasizing adjectives (see paragraphs **2.36–2.39**) are usually used in front of a noun.

2.44 Some adjectives are normally used only after a linking verb and not in front of a noun.

These adjectives are called **predicative adjectives**.

E.g., you can say *She felt glad*, but you do not normally talk about *a glad woman*.

Here is a list of adjectives usually used in this way:

Example 2.2.35. *afraid, alive, alone, apart, asleep, awake, aware, content, due, glad, ill, likely, ready, safe, sorry, sure, unable, unlikely, well*

Note that they do not have to be followed by a prepositional phrase.

2.45 Some adjectives are usually followed by a prepositional phrase because their meaning would otherwise be unclear or incomplete.

E.g., you cannot simply say that someone is *accustomed*.

You have to say that they are *accustomed to* something.

The following usage note explains which prepositions you use after a particular adjective.

[i] Usage note.

2.46 There are a few adjectives that are followed by the preposition *to* when they are used after a linking verb.

Example 2.2.36. *She's allergic to cats.*

Older people are particularly susceptible to heart problems.

Here is a list of adjectives that are usually or always used after a linking verb and are followed by *to*:

Example 2.2.37. *accustomed, adjacent, allergic, attributable, attuned, averse, close, conducive, devoted, impervious, injurious, integral, prone, proportional, proportionate, reconciled, related, resigned, resistant, similar, subject, subservient, susceptible, unaccustomed*

2.47 There are a few adjectives that are followed by the preposition *of* when they are used after a linking verb.

Example 2.2.38. *He was aware of the danger that faced him.*

They seemed capable of winning their 1st game of the season.

He was devoid of any talent whatsoever.

His mind seemed to have become incapable of any thought.

Here is a list of adjectives that are usually or always used after a linking verb and are followed by *of*:

Example 2.2.39. *aware, bereft, capable, characteristic, desirous, devoid, fond, full, heedless, illustrative, incapable, indicative, mindful, reminiscent, representative*

2.48 There are a few adjectives that are followed by the preposition *with* when they are used after a linking verb.

Example 2.2.40. *His surprise became tinged with disbelief.*
The plastic has to be compatible with the body tissues that make contact with it.
This way of life is fraught with danger.

Here is a list of adjectives that are usually or always used after a linking verb and are followed by *with*:

Example 2.2.41. *compatible, consonant, conversant, filled, fraught, riddled, tinged*

2.49 Some adjectives are followed by other prepositions when they are used after a linking verb.

Example 2.2.42. *These ideas are rooted in self-deception.*
Didn't you say the raid was contingent on the weather?
Darwin concluded that people were descended from apes.

Here is a list of adjectives that are usually or always used after a linking verb and are followed by the preposition indicated:

Example 2.2.43. *contingent on, descended from, inherent in, lacking in, rooted in, steeped in, swathed in, unhampered by*

In some cases, there is a choice between 2 prepositions.

Example 2.2.44. *Many of their courses are connected with industry.*
Such names were arbitrarily given and were not connected to any particular event.

Here is a list of adjectives that are usually or always used after a linking verb and that are followed by the prepositions shown:

Example 2.2.45. *answerable for/to, burdened by/with, connected to/with, dependent on/upon, immune from/to, inclined to/towards, incumbent on/upon, insensible of/to, intent on/upon, parallel to/with, reliant on/upon, stricken by/with*

2.50 *Different* is most commonly followed by *from*.
It is also sometimes followed by *to* in British English or *than* in American English.

Example 2.2.46 (AE)**.** *Students today are different from the students 10 years ago.*

2.51 To complete the meaning of some adjectives that are used predicatively, you need to follow with a clause beginning with a ***to*-infinitive**.
E.g., you cannot just say *He is unable.*
You have to add a clause beginning with *to*-infinitive e.g. *to do*: *He is unable to do it.*
***To*-infinitive clauses** are explained in the Reference section.

Example 2.2.47. *They were unable to help her.*
I am willing to try.
She is bound to notice there's something wrong.
I'm inclined to agree with the minister.

Here is a list of adjectives that are always or nearly always followed by a *to*-infinitive clause:

Example 2.2.48. *able, bound, destined, doomed, due, fated, fit, inclined, liable, likely, loath, prepared, unable, unwilling, willing*

2.52 You can also use a clause beginning with *to*-infinitive after many other adjectives to give more information about something.

Example 2.2.49. *I was afraid to go home.*
I was happy to see them again.
He was powerless to prevent it.
I was almost ashamed to tell her.
The path was easy to follow.

Note that the subject of the main clause is also the subject of the *to*-infinitive clause.
2.53 When adjectives that refer to someone's beliefs or feelings are used after a linking verb, they are often followed by a ***that*-clause** (see paragraphs **8.119**–**8.121**).
The subject of the *that*-clause is not always the same as the subject of the main clause, so you need to specify it.

Example 2.2.50. *She was sure that he meant it.*
He was frightened that something terrible might be said.
I'm aware that I reached a rather large audience through the book.

note that the word *that* is not always used in a *that*-clause.

Example 2.2.51. *They were sure she had been born in the city.*

Here is a list of common adjectives often followed by a *that*-clause:

Example 2.2.52. *afraid, angry, anxious, aware, certain, confident, frightened, glad, happy, pleased, proud, sad, sorry, sure, surprised, unaware, upset, worried*

Note that all of these adjectives except *angry, aware, unaware, upset*, and *worried* can also be followed by a *to*-infinitive.

Example 2.2.53. *I was afraid that she might not be able bear the strain.*
Don't be afraid to ask questions.
She was surprised that I knew about it.
The twins were very surprised to see Ralph.

2.2.8 Position of adjectives in noun phrases

2.54 When you use more than 1 adjective in a noun phrase, the usual order for the adjective is: qualitative adjectives, followed by color adjectives, followed by classifying adjectives.

Example 2.2.54. *... a little white wooden house.*
... pretty black lacy dresses.
... a large circular pool of water.
... a beautiful pink suit.
... rapid technological advance.
... a nice red apple.
... the black triangular fin.

This order is nearly always followed in English.
Occasionally however, when you want to focus on a particular characteristic of the person or thing you are describing, you can vary this order, especially when 1 of the adjectives refers to color or size.

Example 2.2.55. *... a square black hole.*

Note that you sometimes put a common or *and* between adjectives.
This is explained in paragraphs **8.180–8.186** and paragraph **8.201**.

Example 2.2.56. *... the long, low caravan.*
It was a long and tedious business.

2.55 **Comparatives** (see paragraphs **2.103–2.111**) and **superlatives** (see paragraphs **2.112–2.122**) normally come in front of all other adjectives in a noun phrase.

Example 2.2.57. *... better parental control.*
... the highest monthly figures on record.

2.56 When a noun phrase contains both an adjective and a noun modifier (see paragraphs **2.169–2.174**) the adjective is placed in front of the noun modifier.

Example 2.2.58. *... the booming European car industry.*
... the world's biggest and most prestigious book fair.

2.57 When you use 2 adjectives after a linking verb, you use a conjunction, usually *and*, to link them.
If you use more than 2 adjectives, you usually put a conjunction e.g. *and* between the last 2 adjectives and commas between the others.
This is fully explained in paragraphs **8.180–8.186** and paragraph **8.201**.

Example 2.2.59. *The room was large and square.*
We felt hot, tired, and thirsty.

Note that you put the adjectives in the order that you think is the most important.

2.58 There are a few adjectives that are usually or always used after a noun.

Here is a list showing the different groups of adjectives used after a noun:

Example 2.2.60. *designate, elect, galore, incarnate, manqué*
broad, deep, high, long, old, tall, thick, wide
concerned, involved, present, proper, responsible
affected, available, required, suggested

[i] Usage note.

2.59 The adjectives *designate, elect, galore, incarnate*, and *manqué* are only used immediately after a noun.

Example 2.2.61. *She was now president elect.*
There are empty houses galore.

2.60 The adjectives *broad, deep, high, long, old, tall, thick*, and *wide* are used immediately after measurement nouns when giving the size, duration, or age of a thing or person.

This use is fully explained in paragraph **2.253**.

Example 2.2.62. *... 6 feet tall.*
... 3 meters wide.
... 25 years old.

2.61 The adjectives *concerned, involved, present, responsible*, and *proper* have different meanings depending on whether you put them in front of a noun or immediately after one.

E.g., *the concerned mother* describes a mother who is anxious, but *the mother concerned* simply refers to a mother who has just been mentioned.

Example 2.2.63. *... the approval of interested and concerned parents.*
The idea needs to come from the individuals concerned.
All this became a very involved process.
He knew all of the people involved.
... the present international situation.
Of the 18 people present, I know only one.
... parents trying to act in a responsible manner.
... the person responsible for his death.
... a proper training in how to teach.
... the 1st round proper of the FA Cup.

2.62 The adjectives *affected, available, required*, and *suggested* can be used in front of a noun or after a noun without any change in meaning.

Example 2.2.64. *Newspaper were the only available source of information.*
... the number of teachers available.
... the required changes.
You're way below the standard required.
... the cost of the suggested improvements.
The proposals suggested are derived from successful experiments.
Aside from the affected child, the doctor checks every other member of the household.
... the proportion of the population affected.

2.2.9 Special forms: *-ing* adjectives

2.63 There are many adjectives ending in *-ing*.

Most of them are related in form to the ***-ing* participles** of verbs.

In this grammar they are called ***-ing* adjectives**.

Example 2.2.65. *He was an amiable, amusing fellow.*
He had been up all night attending a dying man.

The ***-ing* form** is explained in the Reference section.

2.64 1 group of *-ing* adjectives describe the effect that something has on your feelings and ideas, or on the feelings and ideas of people in general.

Example 2.2.66. *... an alarming increase in burglaries.*
A surprising number of men do not marry.
... a charming house on the outskirts of the town.
... a warm welcoming smile.

2.65 These adjectives are normally **qualitative adjectives**.
This means that they can be used with a **submodifying adverb** (a word like *very* or *rather*), and have comparatives and superlatives.

Example 2.2.67. *... a very convincing example.*
There is nothing very surprising in this.
... a very exciting idea.
... a really pleasing evening at the theater.
When Bernard moans he's much more convincing.
... 1 of the most boring books I've ever read.

2.66 They can be used in front of a noun or after a linking verb.

Example 2.2.68. *They can still show amazing loyalty to their parents.*
It's amazing what they can do.
... the most terrifying tale ever written.
The present situation is terrifying.

2.67 These *-ing* adjectives have a related transitive verb that you use to describe the way someone is affected by something.
E.g., if you speak of *an alarming increase*, you mean that the increase alarms you.
If you speak of *a surprising number*, you meant that the number surprises you.
Here is a list of *-ing* adjectives that describe an effect and that have a similar meaning to the usual meaning of the related verb:

Example 2.2.69. *alarming, amazing, amusing, annoying, appalling, astonishing, astounding, bewildering, boring, challenging, charming, compelling, confusing, convincing, demeaning, depressing, devastating, disappointing, disgusting, distracting, distressing, disturbing, embarrassing, enchanting, encouraging, entertaining, exciting, frightening, harassing, humiliating, infuriating, inspiring, interesting, intimidating, intriguing, menacing, misleading, mocking, overwhelming, pleasing, refreshing, relaxing, rewarding, satisfying, shocking, sickening, starling, surprising, tempting, terrifying, threatening, thrilling, tiring, welcoming, worrying*

Transitive verbs are explained in paragraphs **3.14**–**3.25**.
2.68 The other main group of *-ing* adjectives are used to describe a process or state that continues over a period of time.

Example 2.2.70. *... her growing band of supporters.*
Oil and gas drillers are doing a booming business.
... a life of increasing labor and decreasing leisure.

2.69 These adjectives are **classifying adjectives**, so they are not used with words like *very* and *rather*.
However, adjectives used to identify a process are often modified by adverbs that describe the speed with which the process happens.

Example 2.2.71. *... a fast diminishing degree of personal freedom.*
... rapidly rising productivity.

2.70 These *-ing* adjectives have related intransitive verbs.
Here is a list of *-ing* adjectives that describe a continuing process or state and that have a similar meaning to the usual meaning of the related verb:

Example 2.2.72. *ageing, ailing, bleeding, booming, bursting, decreasing, diminishing, dwindling, dying, existing, increasing, living, prevailing, recurring, reigning, remaining, resounding, rising, ruling*

Intransitive verbs are explained in paragraphs **3.8**–**3.13**.
2.71 These *-ing* adjectives are only used in front of a noun, so when *-ing* forms of intransitive verbs appear after the verb *be* they are actually part of a progressive form.
2.72 [⋆] In English, you can make most verbs into adjectives by adding *-ing* to the verb and putting it in front of the noun, to say that someone or something is doing.

Example 2.2.73. *... a walking figure.*
... FIFA, world football's ruling body.
... bands performing in front of screaming crowds.
... 2 years of falling employment.
... a tremendous noise of smashing glass.

2.73 Most of the *-ing* adjectives talked about so far are related to verbs.
Sometimes however, *-ing* adjectives are not related to verbs at all.
E.g., there is no verb *to neighbor*.

Example 2.2.74. *Whole families came from neighboring villages.*

Here is a list of *-ing* adjectives that are not related to verbs:

Example 2.2.75. *appetizing, balding, cunning, enterprising, excruciating, impending, neighboring, scathing, unwitting*

2.74 Sometimes, an *-ing* adjectives is related to an uncommon use of a verb, or appears to be related to a verb but is not related exactly to any current use.
E.g., the verb *haunt* is most commonly used in connection with ghosts, but the adjective *haunting* is more often used to talk about such things as songs and memories.
A *haunting tune* is a tune you cannot forget.
Here is a list of qualitative *-ing* adjectives that are not related to a common transitive use of a verb:

Example 2.2.76. *becoming, bracing, cutting, dashing, disarming, engaging, fetching, halting, haunting, moving, penetrating, piercing, pressing, promising, rambling, ravishing, retiring, revolting, searching, taxing, trying*

Here is a list of classifying *-ing* adjectives that are not related to a common intransitive use of a verb:

Example 2.2.77. *acting, driving, floating, gathering, going, leading, missing, running*

2.75 Some adjectives are derived from a verb and a prefix.
E.g., *outgoing* is derived from the verb *go* and the prefix *out-*.
There is no verb *to outgo*.

Example 2.2.78. *Wouldn't that cause a delay in outgoing mail?*

here is a list of *-ing* adjectives derived from a verb and a prefix:

Example 2.2.79. *forthcoming, incoming, oncoming, ongoing, outgoing, outstanding, overarching, overbearing, uplifting, upstanding*

2.76 A small group of *-ing* adjectives are used in informal spoken English for emphasis, usually to express disapproval.
This use is explained in paragraphs **2.41**–**2.42**.
Some **compound adjectives** (see paragraphs **2.94**–**2.102**) end in *-ing*.

2.2.10 Special forms: *-ed* adjectives

2.77 A large number of English adjectives end in *-ed*.
Many of them have the same form as the ***-ed* participle** of a verb.
Others are formed by adding *-ed* to a noun.
Others are not closely related to any other words.

Example 2.2.80. *... a disappointed man.*
... a bearded man.
... sophisticated electronic devices.

2.78 Adjectives with the same form as irregular ***-ed* participles** (see the Reference section) that do not end in *-ed* are also included here as *-ed* adjectives.

Example 2.2.81. *Was it a broken bone, a torn ligament, or what?*

The *-ed* participles of some **phrasal verbs** (see paragraphs **3.83**–**3.116**) can also be used as adjectives.
When they are used in front of a noun, the 2 parts of the phrasal verb are usually written with a hyphen between them.

Example 2.2.82. *... the built-up urban mass of the city.*

2.79 Most *-ed* adjectives are related to a transitive verb and have a passive meaning.
They show that something has happened or is happening to the thing being described.
E.g., *a frightened person* is a person who has been frightened by something.
A known criminal is a criminal who is known by the police.

Example 2.2.83. *We have a long list of satisfied customers.*
We cannot refuse to teach children the required subjects.

2.80 *-ed* adjectives that refer to a person's mental or emotional reaction to something are generally qualitative.

Example 2.2.84. *He was a worried old man.*
... a bored old woman.
... an interested student.

These adjectives can be modified by words e.g. *very* and *extremely*, just like other qualitative adjectives (see paragraphs **2.140–2.156**).
2.81 Like other adjectives used for talking about feelings, these adjectives are often used to describe the expression, voice, or manner or the person affected, instead of referring directly to that person.

Example 2.2.85. *... her big blue frightened eyes.*
She could hear his agitated voice.
Barry gave him a worried look.

2.82 Here is a list of qualitative *-ed* adjectives that have a similar meaning to the most common meaning of the related verb:

Example 2.2.86. *agitated, alarmed, amused, appalled, astonished, bored, confused, contented, delighted, depressed, deprived, disappointed, disgusted, disillusioned, distressed, embarrassed, excited, frightened, inhibited, interested, pleased, preoccupied, puzzled, satisfied, shocked, surprised, tired, troubled, worried*

Here is a list of qualitative *-ed* adjectives that do not have a similar meaning to the usual meaning of the related verb:

Example 2.2.87. *animated, attached, concerned, determined, disposed, disturbed, guarded, hurt, inclined, mixed, strained*

2.83 Many other *-ed* adjectives are used for classifying, and so cannot be used with words like *very* and *rather*.
E.g., *a furnished apartment* is 1 type of apartment, contrasting with *an apartment without furniture*.

Example 2.2.88. *... a furnished apartment.*
... a painted wooden bowl.
... the closed bedroom door.

Most adjectives that refer to physical distinctions are classifying adjectives.
2.84 Here is a list of classifying *-ed* adjectives that have a similar meaning to the most common meaning of the related verb:

Example 2.2.89. *abandoned, armed, blocked, boiled, broken, canned, classified, closed, concentrated, condemned, cooked, divided, drawn, dried, established, fixed, furnished, haunted, hidden, improved, infected, integrated, known, licensed, loaded, paid, painted, processed, reduced, required, torn, trained, united, wasted*

Here is list of *-ed* classifying adjectives that have a different meaning from the most common meaning of the related verb:

Example 2.2.90. *advanced, marked, noted, pointed, spotted, veiled*

2.85 Classifying *-ed* adjectives cannot normally be modified with words like *quite* and *very*.
However, an **adverb of manner**, (see paragraphs **6.36–6.44**) or an **adverb of degree**, (see paragraphs **6.45–6.52**) is often used before an *-ed* adjective.
E.g., *a pleasantly furnished room* is a room that has been furnished with pleasant furniture.

Example 2.2.91. *... pleasantly furnished rooms.*
... a well-known novelist.

2.86 Some *-ed* adjectives are not often used on their own, and an adverb is necessary to complete the sense.
You do not usually talk about *dressed people*, but you can say that they are *well dressed* or *smartly dressed* e.g.
The *-ed* adjectives in the following examples nearly always have an adverb in front of them.

Example 2.2.92. *... a cautiously worded statement.*
... impeccably dressed men.
It was a richly deserved honor.
... superbly cut clothes.
... the existence of a highly developed national press.
... a well organized campaign.
... a tall, powerfully built man.
She gazed down at his perfectly formed little face.

Note that combinations like this are sometimes hyphenated, making them **compound adjectives**.

Example 2.2.93. *... a well-equipped army.*

2.87 A few *-ed* adjectives are related to the *-ed* participle of intransitive verbs and have an active meaning, not a passive meaning.
E.g., *a fallen tree* is a tree that has fallen.

Example 2.2.94. *... a capsized ship.*
She is the daughter of a retired army officer.
... an escaped prisoner.

Here is a list of *-ed* adjectives with an active meaning:

Example 2.2.95. *accumulated, dated, escaped, faded, fallen, retired, swollen, wilted*

2.88 Most *-ed* adjectives can be used both in front of a noun and after a linking verb.

Example 2.2.96. *The worried authorities decided to play safe.*
My husband was worried.

A small number of *-ed* adjectives are normally only used after a linking verb.
Often, they are followed by a preposition, a *to*-infinitive, or a *that*-clause.

Example 2.2.97. *I was thrilled by the exhibition.*
The Brazilians are pleased with the results.
... food destined for areas of south Sudan.
He was always prepared to account for his actions.

Here is a list of *-ed* adjectives often used after a linking verb, with or without a phrase or clause after them:

Example 2.2.98. *convinced, delighted, interested, intimidated, intrigued, involved, pleased, prepared, scared, thrilled, tired, touched*

Here is a list of *-ed* adjectives normally used after a linking verb with a phrase or clause after them:

Example 2.2.99. *agreed, destined, dressed, finished, lost, prepared, shut, stuck*

2.89 [⋆] The *-ed* participle of almost any transitive verb can be used as an adjective, though some are more commonly used than others.

Example 2.2.100. *... she said, with a forced smile.*
There was 1 paid tutor and 3 volunteer tutors.
The recovered animals will be released.
... the final corrected version.

2.90 ⋆ Some *-ed* adjectives are formed from nouns.
E.g., if a living thing has wings, you can describe it as *winged*.
Inf someone has skills, you can describe them as *skilled*.

Example 2.2.101. *... winged angels.*
... a skilled engineer.
She was dressed in black and carried a black beaded purse.
... armored cars.
... the education of gifted children.

2.91 Here is a list of *-ed* adjectives formed from nouns:

Example 2.2.102. *armored, barbed, beaded, bearded, detailed, flowered, freckled, gifted, gloved, hooded, mannered, pointed, principled, salaried, skilled, spotted, striped, turbaned, walled, winged*

-ed adjectives formed from nouns are commonly used as the 2nd part of **compound adjectives** (see paragraph **2.94–2.102**) e..g *grey-haired* and *open-minded*.

2.92 There are also some *-ed* adjectives in regular use that are not related to verbs or nouns in the ways described above. E.g., there are no words *parch* or *belove*.

There is a noun *concert*, but the adjective *concerted* does not mean *having a concert*.

Example 2.2.103. *He climbed up the dry parched grass to the terrace steps.*
. . . a complex and antiquated system of taxation.
. . . attempts to mount a concerted campaign.
. . . the purchase of expensive sophisticated equipment.

2.93 Here is a list of *-ed* adjectives that are not related to verbs or nouns:

Example 2.2.104. *antiquated, ashamed, assorted, beloved, bloated, concerted, crazed, deceased, doomed, indebted, parched, rugged, sophisticated, tinned*

2.2.11 Compound adjectives

2.94 **Compound adjectives** are made up of 2 or more words, usually written with hyphens between them. They may be qualitative, classifying, or color adjectives.

Example 2.2.105. *I was in a light-hearted mood.*
She was dressed in a bottle-green party dress.
. . . the built-up urban mass of the city.
. . . an air-conditioned restaurant.
. . . a good-looking girl.
. . . 1-way traffic.
. . . a part-time job.

2.95 These are the most common and least restricted patterns for forming compound adjectives:

- adjective or number plus noun plus *-ed*, e.g. *grey-haired* and *1-sided*
- adjective or adverb plus *-ed* participle, e.g. *low-paid* and *well-behaved*
- adjective, adverb, or noun plus *-ing* participle, e.g. *good-looking, long-lasting* and *man-eating*.

Note that compound adjectives describe simple concepts: a *good-looking* person looks good, and a *man-eating* beast eats humans.

More complex descriptions in English need to be given using a following phrase or clause.

2.96 These are less common and more restricted patterns for forming compound adjectives:

- noun plus *-ed* participle, e.g. *tongue-tied* and *wind-swept*
- noun plus adjective, e.g. *accident-prone, trouble-free*
- adjective plus noun, e.g. *deep-sea, present day*
- *-ed* participle plus adverb, e.g. *run-down, cast-off*
- number plus singular countable noun, e.g. *5-page, 4-door*

Note that compound adjectives formed according to the last of these patterns are always used in front of a noun.

2.97 Here is a list of compound qualitative adjectives:

Example 2.2.106. *able-bodied, absent-minded, accident-prone, big-headed, clear-cut, close-fitting, cold-blooded, easy-going, far-fetched, far-reaching, good-looking, good-tempered, hard-up, hard-wearing, ill-advised, kind-hearted, labor saving, laid-back, light-hearted, long-lasting, long-standing, long-suffering, low-cut, low-paid, low-slung, mind-blowing, mouth-watering, muddle-headed, narrow-minded, nice-looking, off-color, off-hand, off-putting, old-fashioned, 1-sided, open-minded, run-down, 2nd-class, 2nd-rate, shop-soiled, short-handed, short-lived, short-sighted, short-tempered, slow-witted, smooth-talking, soft-hearted, starry-eyed, strong-minded, stuck-up, sun-tanned, swollen-headed, tender-hearted, thick-skinned, tongue-tied, top-heavy, trouble-free, 2-edged, 2-faced, warm-hearted, well-balanced, well-behaved, well-dressed, well-known, well-off, wind-blown, wordly-wise, wrong-headed*

2.98 Here is a list of compound classifying adjectives:

Example 2.2.107. *air-conditioned, all-out, all-powerful, audio-visual, blue-blooded, bow-legged, brand-new, breast-fed, broken-down, broken-hearted, built-up, bullet-proof, burnt-out, cast-off, clean-shaven, cross-Channel, cross-country, cut-price, deep-sea, deep-seated, double-barreled, double-breasted, drip-dry, drive-in, duty-bound, duty-free, empty-handed, face-saving, far-flung, 1st-class, free-range, free-standing, freeze-dried, front-page, full-blown, full-face, full-grown, full-length, full-scale, gilt-edged, grey-haired, half-price, half-yearly, hand-picked, high-heeled, home-made, ice-cold, interest-free, knee-deep, last-minute, late-night, lead-free, left-handed, lift-size, long-distance, long-lost, long-range, loose-leaf, made-up, man-eating, mass-produced, middle-aged, never-ending, north-east, north-west, nuclear-free, odds-on, off-guard, off-peak, 1-way, open-ended, open-mouthed, panic-stricken, part-time, present-day, purpose-built, ready-made, record-breaking, red-brick, remote-controlled, right-angled, right-handed, 2nd-class, 2nd-hand, see-through, silver-plated, single-handed, so-called, so-so, south-east, south-west, strong-arm, tax-free, tone-deaf, top-secret, unheard-of, wide-awake, world-famous, worn-out, year-long*

2.99 Here is a list of compound color adjectives:

Example 2.2.108. *blood-red, blue-black, bottle-green, dove-grey, electric-blue, flesh-colored, ice-blue, iron-grey, jet-black, lime-green, navy-blue, nut-brown, off-white, pea-green, pearl-grey, royal-blue, shocking-pink, sky-blue, snow-white*

2.100 A few compound adjectives are made up of more than 2 words.

Compounds of 3 or more words are often written with hyphens when they are used in front of nouns, and without hyphens when they are used after a linking verb.

Example 2.2.109. *... the day-to-day chores of life.*
... a down-to-earth approach.
... a free-and-easy relationship.
... life-and-death decisions.
... a trip to an out-of-the-way resort.
Their act is out of date.

2.101 Some compound adjectives seem rather odd because they contain words that are never used as single words on their own, e.g. *namby-pamby, higgledy-piggledy*, and *topsy-turvy.*

Words like these are usually informal.

Example 2.2.110. *... all that artsy-craftsy spiritualism.*
... his la-di-da family.

2.102 Some compound adjectives are borrowed from foreign languages, especially from French and Latin.

Example 2.2.111. *... the arguments once used to defend laissez-faire economics.*
... their present per capita fuel consumption.
In the commercial theater, almost every production is ad hoc.

Here is a list of compound adjectives borrowed from other languages:

Example 2.2.112. *à la mode, a posteriori, a priori, ad hoc, ad lib, au fait, avant-garde, bona fide, compos mentis, cordon bleu, de facto, de jure, de luxe, de rigueur, de trop, ex gratia, hors de combat, infra dig, laissez-faire, non compas mentis, per capita, prima facie, pro rata, sub judice*

2.3 Comparing things: comparatives

2.103 You can describe something by saying that it has more of a quality than something else.

You do this by using **comparative adjectives**.

Only qualitative adjectives usually have comparatives, but a few color adjectives also have them.

Comparatives normally consist of the usual form of the adjective with either *-er* added to the end, as in *harder* and *smaller*, or *more* placed in front, as in *more interesting* and *more flexible.*

Note that *good* and *bad* have the irregular comparative forms *better* and *worse.*

The patterns for forming regular and irregular comparatives are explained in the Reference section.

2.104 Comparatives can be used as **modifiers** in front of a noun.

Example 2.3.1. *The family moved to a smaller home.*
He dreams of a better, more exciting life.
A harder mattress often helps with black injuries.

Note that comparatives can also be used as modifiers in front of *one*.

Example 2.3.2. *An understanding of this reality provokes a better one.*

2.105 Comparatives can also be used after a **linking verb**.

Example 2.3.3. *The ball soaked up water and became heavier.*
His breath became quieter.
We need to be more flexible.

The use of adjectives after linking verbs is explained in paragraphs **3.132–3.137**.

2.106 Comparatives are often followed by *than* when you want to specify what the other thing involved in the comparison is.

You say exactly what you are comparing by using 1 of a number of structures after *than*.
These structures can be

Example 2.3.4. *noun phrases*

Example 2.3.5. *Charlie was more honest than his predecessor.*
. . . an area bigger than Mexico.

Note that when than is followed by a pronoun on its own, the pronoun must be an object pronouns e.g. me, him, or her.

Example 2.3.6. *My brother is younger than me.*
Lamin was shorter than her.

phrases that start with a preposition

Example 2.3.7. *The changes will be even more striking in the case of teaching than in medicine.*
The odds of surviving childhood in New York City are worse than in some 3rd World countries.

clauses

Example 2.3.8. *I would have done a better job than he did.*
I was a better writer than he was.
He's taller than I am.

Note that when a comparative is not followed by a *than* phrase, the other thing in the comparison should be obvious.
E.g., if someone says *Could I have a bigger one, please?* they are likely to be holding the item that they think is too small.

Example 2.3.9. *A mattress would be better.*

2.107 If you choose a phrase or clause beginning with *than* when you are using a comparative in front of a noun, you usually put the phrase or clause after the whole noun phrase, not directly after the comparative.

Example 2.3.10. *The world is a more dangerous place than it was.*
Willy owned a larger collection of books than anyone else I have ever met.

A comparative can also come immediately after a noun, but only when it is followed by *than* and a noun phrase.

Example 2.3.11. *We've got a rat bigger than a cat living in our roof.*
. . . packs of cards larger than he was used to.

2.108 *More* is sometimes used in front of a whole noun phrase to show that something has more of the qualities of 1 thing than another, or is 1 thing rather than being another.

Example 2.3.12. *Music is more a way of life than an interest.*
This is more a war movie than a western.

Note that *more than* is used before adjectives for emphasis.

Example 2.3.13. *Their life may be horribly full, but they are more than satisfied.*
You would be more than welcome.

2.109 Comparative adjectives are sometimes used as noun-type words in fairly formal English.
In such phrases, you put *the* in front of it, and follow it with *of* and a noun phrase that refers to the 2 things being compared.

Example 2.3.14. ... *the shorter of the 2 lines.*
Dorothea was the more beautiful of the 2.
There are 2 windmills, the larger of which stands a hundred feet high.

If it is clear what you are talking about, you can omit *of* and the following noun phrase.

Example 2.3.15. *Notice to quit must cover the rental period or 4 weeks, whichever is the longer.*

2.110 The form that is used to say that something does not have as much of a quality as something else is *less* followed by an adjective.

Example 2.3.16. *The answer had been less truthful than his own.*

You can also use *less* and an adjective to say that something does not have as much of a quality as it had before.

Example 2.3.17. *As the days went by, Sita became less anxious.*

Note that less than is used before adjectives to express a negative idea.

Example 2.3.18. *It would have been less than fair.*

2.111 You show that 1 amount of a quality or thing is linked to another amount by using 2 contrasted comparatives preceded by *the*.

Example 2.3.19. *The smaller it is, the cheaper it is to post.*
The more militant we became, the less confident she became.
The larger the organization, the less scope there is for decision.

2.4 Comparing things: superlatives

2.112 Another way of describing something is to say that it has more of a quality than anything else of its kind.
You do this by using a **superlative adjective**.
Only qualitative adjectives usually have superlatives, but a few color adjectives also have them.
Superlatives normally consist of either *-est* added to the end of an adjective and *the* placed in front of it, as in *the hardest* and *the smallest*, or of *the most* placed in front of the adjective, as in *the most interesting* and *the most flexible*.
Note that *good* and *bad* have the irregular superlative forms *the best* and *the worst*.
The patterns for forming regular and irregular superlatives of adjectives are explained in the Reference section.
Note that superlative adjectives are nearly always preceded by *the*, because you are talking about something definite.
Occasionally, when superlatives are used after a linking verb, *the* is omitted (see paragraph **2.117**).
2.113 [!] Adjectives with *most* in front of them are not always superlatives.
Most can also mean *very*.

Example 2.4.1. *This book was most interesting.*
My grandfather was a most extraordinary man.

Words like *very* and *rather* are called **submodifying adverbs**.
These are explained in paragraphs **2.140–2.156**.
2.114 Superlatives can be used as **modifiers** in front of a noun.

Example 2.4.2. *He was the cleverest man I ever knew.*
It was the most exciting summer of their lives.
She came out of the thickest part of the crowd.
Now we come to the most important thing.
... *the oldest rock paintings in North America.*
... *the most eminent scientists in Britain.*

Note that superlatives are also used as modifiers in front of *one*.

Example 2.4.3. *No one ever used the smallest one.*

2.115 Superlatives are also used after a **linking verb**.

Example 2.4.4. *He was the youngest.*
The sergeant was the tallest.

The use of adjectives after linking verbs is explained in paragraphs **3.132–3.137**.

2.116 You can use a superlative on its own if it is clear what is being compared.

E.g., if you say *Paul was the tallest*, you are referring to a group of people that has already been identified.

If you need to refer to the point of the comparison, you use a phrase or clause that consists of

- phrases that start with a preposition, usually *in* or *of*

  Example 2.4.5. *Henry was the biggest of them.*

  The 3rd requirement is the most important of all.

  These cakes are probably the best in the world.

- a relative clause

  Example 2.4.6. *It's the best I'm likely to get.*

  The waiting room was the worst I had seen.

Note that if the superlative is placed in front of a noun, the relative clause comes after the noun.

Example 2.4.7. *That's the most convincing answer that you've given me.*

2.117 [i] You usually put *the* in front of the superlative, but you can occasionally omit it, especially in informal speech or writing.

Example 2.4.8. *Wool and cotton blankets are generally cheapest.*
It can be used by whoever is closest.

However, you cannot omit *the* when the superlative is followed by *of* or another structure showing what group of things you are comparing.

So, e.g., you can say *Amanda was the youngest of our group* or *Amanda was the youngest* or *Amanda was youngest*, but you cannot say *Amanda was youngest of our group.*

You can sometimes use the possessive form of a noun or a possessive determiner instead of *the* in front of a superlative.

Often the possessive form of a noun is used instead of a phrase beginning with a preposition.

E.g., you can say *Britain's oldest man* instead of *the oldest man in Britain.*

Example 2.4.9. ... *the world's most popular cheese.*
... *my newest assistant.*

The possessive form of nouns is explained in paragraphs **1.211-1.222**, and possessive determiners are explained in paragraphs **1.194–1.210**.

2.118 A superlative is sometimes accompanied by another adjective ending in *-able* or *-ible*.

This 2nd adjective can be placed either between the superlative and the noun or after the noun.

Example 2.4.10. ... *the narrowest imaginable range of interests.*
... *the most beautiful scenery imaginable.*
... *the longest possible gap.*
I say that in the nicest way possible.

2.119 Superlative adjectives are sometimes used like nouns in fairly formal English.

When you use a superlative adjective in this way, you put *the* in front of it, and follow it with *of* and a noun or pronoun that refers to the things being compared.

When superlative adjectives are used in this way they can refer to 1 thing or to more than one.

Example 2.4.11. *They are often too poor to buy or rent even the cheapest of houses.*
He made several important discoveries. The most interesting of these came from an examination of an old manuscript.

If it is clear what you are talking about, you can omit *of* and the following noun phrase.

Example 2.4.12. *There are 3 types of ant-eater. The smallest lives entirely in trees.*

2.120 [i] In informal speech, people often use a superlative rather than a comparative when they are talking about 2 things.

E.g., someone might say *The train is quickest* rather than *The train is quicker* when comparing a train service with a bus service.

However, some people think that it is better to use superlatives only when comparing more than 2 things.

2.121 **Ordinal numbers** are used with superlatives to show that something has more of a quality than nearly all other things of their kind.

E.g., if you say that a mountain is *the 2nd highest mountain*, you mean that it is higher than any other mountain except the highest one.

Example 2.4.13. *Cancer is the 2nd biggest cause of death in Britain.*
... the 2nd most important man in her life, her hairdresser.
It is Japan's 3rd largest city.

Ordinal numbers are explained in paragraphs **2.232–2.239**.

2.122 When you want to show that something has less of a quality than anything else, you use *the least* followed by an adjective.

Example 2.4.14. *This is the least popular branch of medicine.*

Similarly, when you are talking about a group of things that have less of a quality than other things of their kind, you use *the least*.

Example 2.4.15. *... the least savage men in the country.*

2.5 Other ways of comparing things: saying that things are similar

2.123 Another way of describing things is by saying that something is similar in some way to something else.

2.124 If you want to say that a thing or person has as much of a quality as something or someone else, you can use a structure based on the word *as* in front of a qualitative adjective.

Usually this adjective is followed by a phrase or clause that also begins with *as*.

This can be

- a phrase beginning with the preposition *as*

  Example 2.5.1. *You're just as bad as your sister.*
  ... huge ponds as big as tennis courts.
  Talking were as high as ever.

- a clause introduced by *as*

  Example 2.5.2. *Conversation was not as slow as I feared it would be.*
  The village gardens aren't as good as they used to be.

2.125 When this comparative structure is followed by a phrase consisting of *as* and a pronoun on its own, the pronoun must be an object pronoun e.g. *me, him*, or *her*.

Example 2.5.3. *Jane was not as clever as him.*

However, when the comparative structure is followed by a clause consisting of *as* and a pronoun that is the subject of a clause, then that pronoun must be a subject pronoun e.g. *I, he* or *she*.

Example 2.5.4. *They aren't as clever as they appear to be.*

2.126 If it is clear what you are comparing something to someone to, you can omit the phrase or clause.

Example 2.5.5. *Frozen peas are just as good.*

2.127 You can also use the *as... as...* structure to say that something has much more or less of a quality than something else.

You do this by putting an expression e.g. *twice, 3 times, 10 times*, or *half* in front of the 1st *as*.

E.g., if 1 building is 10 meters high and another building is 20 meters high, you can say that the 2nd building is *twice as high as* the 1st building or that the 1st building is *half as high as* the 2nd one.

Example 2.5.6. *The grass was twice as tall as in the rest of the field.*
Water is 800 times as dense as air.

This structure is often used in the same way to refer to qualities that cannot be measured.

E.g., if you want to say that something is much more useful than something else, you can say that the 1st thing is *a hundred times as useful as* the 2nd one.

Example 2.5.7. *Without this help, rearing our children would be 10 times as hard as it is.*

2.128 [i] When the *as... as...* structure is preceded by *not*, it has the same meaning as *less... than*.
E.g., *I am not as tall as George* means the same as *I am less tall than George*.
Some people use *not so... as...* instead of *not as... as...*

Example 2.5.8. *The film is not as good as the book.*
The younger otter is not so handsome as the old.

2.129 Words like *just, quite, nearly* and *almost* can be used in front of this comparative structure, modifying the comparison with their usual meanings.

Example 2.5.9. *Sunburn can be just as severe as a heat burn.*

The use of these words in comparison is explained in paragraphs **2.157–2.168**.
2.130 When you are using the *as... as...* structure you sometimes put a noun after the adjective and before the following phrase or clause.
This noun must begin with *a* or *an*.
E.g., instead of saying *This knife is as good as that one*, you can say *This is as good a knife as that one.*

Example 2.5.10. *I'm as good a cook as she is.*
This was not as bad a result as they expected.

Sometimes, instead of using *not* before this structure, you use *not such* followed by *a* or *an*, an adjective, a noun, and *as*.

Example 2.5.11. *Water is not such a good conductor as metal.*

2.131 Instead of using this as... as... structure you can use expressions e.g. *the height of* and *the size of* to show that something is as big as something else, or bigger or smaller.

Example 2.5.12. *The tumor was the size of a golf ball.*
It is roughly the length of a man's arm.

2.132 If something has similar qualities or features to something else, instead of using the *as... as...* comparative structures you can say that the 1st thing is *like* the 2nd one.
You do this by using phrases beginning with *like* after **linking verbs**/

Example 2.5.13. *He looked like an actor.*
That sounds like an exaggeration.
The whole thing is like a bad dream.

Here is a list of the linking verbs used with *like*:

Example 2.5.14. *be, feel, look, seem, smell, sound, taste*

When you want to say that 1 thing resembles another, you can use a phrase beginning with *like* after these linking verbs.

Example 2.5.15. *It was like a dream.*
Sometimes I feel like a prisoner here.
He looked like a nice man.
The houses seemed like mansions.
You smell like a tramp!
It sounded like a fine idea.

2.133 *Like* has the comparative *more like* and *less like*, and the superlative *most like* and *least like*.

Example 2.5.16. *It made her seem less like a child.*
Of all his children, she was the one most like me.

2.134 [i] You can use words like *exactly* and *just* in front of *like*.

Example 2.5.17. *He looks just like a baby.*
She looked like a queen, just exactly like a queen.

This is explained in paragraph **2.165**.
2.135 If you want to say that 1 thing is exactly like something else, you can say that it is *the same as* the other thing.

Example 2.5.18. *The rich are the same as the rest of us.*

The same as can be followed by a noun phrase, a pronoun, or a clause.

Example 2.5.19. *24 Spring Terrace was the same as all its neighbors.*
Her coloring was the same as mine.
The furnishings are not exactly the same as they were when we lived there.

If 2 or more things are exactly like each other, you can say that they are *the same*.

Example 2.5.20. *Come and look! They're exactly the same.*
They both taste the same.

You use *the same* when you are comparing people or things with other people or things that you have just mentioned.

Example 2.5.21. *It looks like a calculator and weights about the same.*
The message was the same.
The end result is the same.

Note that you use *the opposite* and *the reverse* in a similar way.

Example 2.5.22. *The kind of religious thoughts I had were just the opposite.*
Some people think that a healthy diet is expensive, but in fact the reverse is true.

2.136 [i] You can use words like *nearly* and *exactly* in front of *the same as* and *the same*.

Example 2.5.23. *They are virtually the same as other single cells.*
You 2 look exactly the same.

Here is a list of words used in the same way with *the same as* and *the same*:

Example 2.5.24. *almost, exactly, just, more or less, much, nearly, virtually*

These words are explained in paragraphs **2.140–2.168**.
2.137 You can put a noun e.g. *size, length*, or *color* after *the same*.
E.g., if you want to say that 1 street is as long as another one, you can say that the 1st street is *the same length* as the 2nd one, or that the 2 streets are *the same length*.

Example 2.5.25. *Its brain was about the same size as that of a gorilla.*
They were almost the same height.

2.138 The adjectives *alike, comparable, equivalent, identical*, and *similar* are also used to say that 2 or more things are like each other.
You can put the preposition *to* after all of them except *alike* in order to mention the 2nd of the things being compared.

Example 2.5.26. *They all looked alike.*
The houses were all identical.
Flemish is similar to Afrikaans.

2.139 When you want to suggest that you are comparing different amounts of a quality, you can use words like *comparatively, relatively*, and *equally*.

Example 2.5.27. *Psychology's a comparatively new subject.*
The costs remained relatively low.
Her technique was less dramatic than Ann's, but equally effective.
He was extra polite to his superiors.

2.6 Talking about different amounts of a quality

2.140 When you want to say something more about the quality that an adjective describes, you can use a **submodifying adverb** e.g. *very* or *rather* with it.
You do this in order to indicate the amount of the quality, or to intensify it.
2.141 Because qualitative adjectives are **gradable**, allowing you to say how much or how little of the quality is relevant, you are more likely to use **submodifying adverbs** (words like *extremely* or *slightly*) with them than with other types of adjective.

Example 2.6.1. *... an extremely narrow road.*
... a highly successful company.
... in a slightly different way.
I was extraordinarily happy.
... helping them in a strongly supportive way.
... a very pretty girl.
She seems very pleasant.
... a rather clumsy person.
His hair was rather long.

2.142 You can use words like *very* and *extremely* with some classifying adjectives (see paragraphs **2.146–2.148**) and with color adjectives (see paragraph **2.35**).

Note that most *-ed* adjectives can be modified by words e.g. *very* and *extremely*, just like other qualitative adjectives.

Example 2.6.2. *... a very frightened little girl.*
... an extremely disappointed young man.

2.143 You can use many submodifying adverbs like *very* or *extremely* with qualitative adjectives in order to intensify their meaning.

Example 2.6.3. *... extremely high temperatures.*
Geoffrey was a deeply religious man.
France is heavily dependent on foreign trade.

Here is a list of words used to intensify the meaning of adjectives:

Example 2.6.4. *amazingly, awfully, bitterly, critically, dangerously, deeply, delightfully, disturbingly, dreadfully, eminently, especially, exceedingly, extraordinarily, extremely, fantastically, greatly, heavily, highly, hopelessly, horribly, hugely, impossibly, incredibly, infinitely, notably, particularly, radically, really, remarkably, seriously, strikingly, supremely, surprisingly, suspiciously, terribly, unbelievably, very, violently, vitally, wildly, wonderfully*

Note that *very* can be used in front of superlative adjectives when you want to be very emphatic.
This is explained in paragraphs **2.167–2.168**.

2.144 Many of these submodifying adverbs not only intensify the meaning of the adjective but also allow you to express your opinion about what you are saying.

E.g., if you say that something is *surprisingly large*, you are expressing surprise at how large it is as well as intensifying the meaning of *large*.

Example 2.6.5. *He has amazingly long eyelashes.*
... a delightfully refreshing taste.
... a shockingly brutal scene.
... a horribly uncomfortable chair.
... incredibly boring documents.

However, you use a few of these submodifying adverbs with no other purpose than to intensify the meaning of the adjective.

Example 2.6.6. *They're awfully brave.*
The other girls were dreadfully dull companions.

Here is a list of words only used to intensify adjectives:

Example 2.6.7. *awfully, dreadfully, especially, extremely, greatly, highly, really, so, terribly, very*

Note that *awfully, dreadfully*, and *terribly* are used in informal language and *highly* is used in very formal language.
Note also that *so* is normally only used after a linking verb.

Example 2.6.8. *I am so sorry.*

2.145 Some submodifying adverbs are used to reduce the effect of qualitative adjectives.

Example 2.6.9. *The story was mildly amusing.*
It's fairly common feeling.
... moderately rich people.
... his rather large stomach.
My last question is somewhat personal.

Here is a list of words used to reduce the effect of an adjective:

Example 2.6.10. *faintly, fairly, mildly, moderately, pretty, quite, rather, reasonably, slightly, somewhat*

Note also that *quite* is normally only used with adjectives that are used after a linking verb.

Example 2.6.11. *She was quite tall.*

2.146 Some modifying adverbs are used to talk about the extent of the quality that you are describing.
Here is a list of words used to talk about the extent of a quality:

Example 2.6.12. *almost, exclusively, fully, largely, mainly, mostly, nearly, partly, predominantly, primarily, roughly absolutely, altogether, completely, entirely, perfectly, purely, quite, simply, totally, utterly*

2.147 The 1st group in the list above are used almost always just to talk about the extent of a quality.
They are most commonly used with classifying adjectives.

Example 2.6.13. *It was an almost automatic reflex.*
. . . a shop with an exclusively female clientele.
. . . the largely rural south east.
The wolf is now nearly extinct.
The reasons for this were partly economic and practical, and partly political and social.

Almost and *nearly* are also used with qualitative adjectives.

Example 2.6.14. *The club was almost empty.*
It was nearly dark.

Note that *roughly* can be used when you want to say that something is nearly or approximately like something else.

Example 2.6.15. *West Germany, Japan and Sweden are at roughly similar levels of economic development.*

Note also that *half* is sometimes used in this way.
E.g., you can describe someone as *half American* if just 1 of their parents was American.
2.148 The 2nd group in the list above are used not only to talk about the extent of a quality but also to emphasize the adjective.
They are used with classifying adjectives as well as qualitative adjectives.

Example 2.6.16. *You're absolutely right.*
This policy has been completely unsuccessful.
Everyone appeared to be completely unaware of the fact.
The discussion was purely theoretical.
It really is quite astonishing.
. . . a totally new situation.
We lived totally separate lives.
. . . utterly trivial matters.

Note that *absolutely* is frequently used with qualitative adjectives that express enthusiasm or lack of enthusiasm.
When you use *absolutely* in this way you are emphasizing how strongly you feel about what you are saying.

Example 2.6.17. *. . . an absolutely absurd idea.*
I think it's absolutely wonderful.
The enquiry is absolutely crucial.

Here is a list of qualitative adjectives often emphasized by *absolutely*:

Example 2.6.18. *absurd, awful, brilliant, certain, crucial, enormous, essential, excellent, furious, hilarious, huge, impossible, massive, perfect, ridiculous, splendid, terrible, vital, wonderful*

Note also that *completely* and *utterly* can also be used in this way.

Example 2.6.19. *It is completely impossible to imagine such a world.*
He began to feel utterly miserable.

2.149 You can use submodifying adverbs e.g. *adequately, sufficiently*, and *acceptably* when you want to say that someone or something has enough of the quality you are describing.

Example 2.6.20. *The roof is adequately insulated.*
We found a bank of snow sufficiently deep to dig a cave.

2.150 [i] You can also show that you think something is sufficient by using *enough*.
Enough always comes after the adjective, and never before it.

Example 2.6.21. *I was not a good enough rider.*
It seemed that Henry had not been careful enough.

Enough can be followed by the preposition *for* to indicate a person involved, or by a *to*-infinitive to indicate a related action.

Example 2.6.22. *A girl from the factory wasn't good enough for him.*
If you find that the white wine is not cold enough for you, ask for some ice to be put in it.
The children are old enough to travel to school on their own.
None of the fruit was ripe enough to eat.

Note that when *enough* is used after an adjective, you can use *just* in front of the adjective to show that someone or something has enough of the quality described by the adjective, but no more than that.

Example 2.6.23. *Some of these creatures are just large enough to see with the naked eye.*

2.151 *Enough* is also a determiner (see paragraphs **1.223–1.247**).

Example 2.6.24. *He hasn't had enough exercise.*

When *enough* is a determiner, it can have a word like *just* or *almost* in front of it.

Example 2.6.25. *There was just enough space for a bed.*
I have almost enough tokens for 1 book.

2.152 If you want to show that you think something you are describing is insufficient, you can use submodifying adverbs e.g. *inadequately, insufficiently*, and *unacceptably*.

Example 2.6.26. *... people growing up in insufficiently supportive families.*
Their publications were inadequately researched.

2.153 If you want to say that you think someone or something has too much of a quality, you normally use *too* in front of a qualitative adjective that is used after a linking verb.

Example 2.6.27. *My feet are too big.*
It was too hot.
Dad thought I was too idealistic.

You can emphasize *too* by putting *far* in front of it.
In informal English you can also use *way*.

Example 2.6.28. *The journey was far too long.*
It was far too hot to work in the garden.
The price was way too high.

Too can be followed by the preposition *for* to indicate a person involved or by a *to*-infinitive to indicate a related action.

Example 2.6.29. *The shoes were too big for him.*
He was too old for that sort of thing.
She was too weak to lift me.
He was too proud to apologize.

Note that you do not usually use *too* with an adjective in front of a noun, although you do use *too* in front of the determiners *many, much*, and *few*.

Example 2.6.30. *There is too much chance of error.*
Too few people nowadays are interested in literature.
You ask too many questions, Sam.

2.154 [!] *Too* cannot be used instead of *very*.

Rather than saying *I am too happy to meet you*, you must say *I am very happy to meet you*.

2.155 Other words that indicate too much of a quality are *excessively, overly*, and the prefix *over-*.

These can be used, like *too*, with adjectives that come after a linking verb, but they can also be used with adjectives in front of a noun.

Example 2.6.31. *... excessively high accident rates.*
... an intellectual but over-cautious man.
They were overly eager.

2.156 [⋆] As well as adverbs of degree like *excessively* and *insufficiently*, you can use some other types of adverb in front of adjectives to modify their meaning.

Example 2.6.32. *... the once elegant palace.*
... a permanently muddy road.
... internationally famous golfers.
... naturally blonde hair.
... coolly elegant furniture.
... purposely expensive gadgets.

Adverbs are explained in Chap. 6.

2.7 Saying things are different

2.157 When you are using comparative adjectives, you may want to say that something has much more or much less of a quantity than something else.

You do this by adding words like *much* or *a little*.

Example 2.7.1. *It is a much better school than yours.*
These creatures are much less mobile.
These are far worse dangers.
Some children are a lot more difficult than others.

You also use these words to say that something has much more or much less of a quality than it had before.

Example 2.7.2. *He had become much more nature.*
That's much less important than it was.

2.158 Some modifying words and phrases are only used when comparative adjectives are being used after linking verbs.

Example 2.7.3. *You look a lot better.*
It would be a good deal easier if you came to my place.
The journey back was a great deal more unpleasant than the outward one had been.

Here is a list of modifying words and phrases used in front of comparative adjectives after a linking verb:

Example 2.7.4. *a good deal, a great deal, a lot, heaps, lots*

Note that *lots* and *heaps* are only used in informal spoken English.

2.159 However, other submodifying adverbs can be used with comparative adjectives that are being used either in front of a noun or after a linking verb.

Example 2.7.5. *They are faced with a much harder problem than the rest of us.*
The risk from smoking is much greater if you have a weak heart.
Computers can be applied to a far wider range of tasks.
The delay was far longer than they claimed.

Here is a list of submodifying adverbs used with adjectives that are used both in front of a noun and after a linking verb:

Example 2.7.6. *considerably, far, infinitely, much, vastly, very much*

2.160 [i] If you want to say that something has more of a quality than something else that already has a lot of it, you use *even* or *still* before a comparative adjective, or *still* after it.

Example 2.7.7. *She's even lazier than me!*
She was even more possessive than Rosamund.
I had a still more recent report.
The text is actually worse still/

Similarly, you use *even* or *still* to say that something has less of a quality than something else that has little of this quality.

Example 2.7.8. *This did not happen before the war, and is now even less likely.*

You also use *even* or *still* when comparing the amount of a quality that something has at 1 time with the amount that it has at another.

Example 2.7.9. *The flight was even faster coming back.*
They will become richer still.

In formal or literary English, *yet* is sometimes used in the same way as *still*.

Example 2.7.10. *He would have been yet more alarmed had she withdrawn.*
The planes grow mightier yet.

2.161 You can show that something has an increasing or decreasing amount of a quality by repeating comparative adjectives. E.g., you can say that something is getting *bigger and bigger, more and more difficult*, or *less and less common*.

Example 2.7.11. *He's getting taller and taller.*
... defences that were proving more and more effective.

Increasingly can be used instead of *more and more* and *decreasingly* instead of *less and less*.

Example 2.7.12. *I was becoming increasingly depressed.*
It was the 1st of a number of increasingly frank talks.

2.162 If you want to say that something has a little more or a little less of a quality than something else, you use *rather, slightly, a bit, a little bit*, or *a little* with comparative adjectives.

Example 2.7.13. *It's a rather more complicated story than that.*
She's only a little bit taller than her sister.

You also use these forms to say that something has a little more or a little less of a quality than it had before.

Example 2.7.14. *We must be rather more visible to people in the community.*
... the little things that made life slightly less intolerable.

2.163 If you want to say emphatically that something has no more of a quality than something else or than it had before, you can use *no* in front of comparative adjectives.

Example 2.7.15. *Some species of dinosaur were no bigger than a chicken.*

Any is used for emphasis in front of comparatives in negative clauses, questions, and conditional clauses.
E.g., *He wasn't any taller than Jane* means the same as *He was no taller than Jane.*

Example 2.7.16. *I was 10 and didn't look any older.*
If it will make you any happier, I'll shave off my beard.
Is that any clearer?

Note that you only use *no* and *any* like this when comparatives are being used after a linking verb.
You cannot use *no* and *any* with comparatives when they are being used in front of a noun phrase.
E.g., you cannot say *It was a no better meal* or *Is that an any faster train?*

2.164 When you use the comparative structure *as... as...* (see paragraphs **2.124–2.130**), submodifying words e.g. *just, quite, nearly*, and *almost* can be used in front of it, modifying the comparison with their usual meanings.

Example 2.7.17. *Mary was just as pale as he was.*
There is nothing quite as lonely as illness.
... a huge bird which was nearly as big as a man.
The land seemed almost as dark as the water.

Nearly is also used when the *as... as...* structure is preceded by *not* with the meaning *less... than*.
You put it after the *not*.
E.g., *I am not nearly as tall as George* means the same as *I am much less tall than George*.

Example 2.7.18. *This is not nearly as complicated as it sounds.*

2.165 When you use *like* to describe someone or something by comparing them with someone or something else (see paragraphs **2.132–2.134**), you can use a submodifying adverb in front of it.

Example 2.7.19. *... animals that looked a little like donkeys.*
It's a plane exactly like his.

Here is a list of modifying words and phrases used with *like*:

Example 2.7.20. *a bit, a little, exactly, just, quite, rather, somewhat, very*

2.166 When you use *the same as* and *the same* to describe someone or something by saying they are identical to someone or something else, you can use a number of submodifying adverbs in front of them, including *just, exactly, much, nearly, virtually*, and *more or less*.

Example 2.7.21. *I'm just the same as everyone else.*
The situation was much the same in Germany.
The moral code would seem to be more or less the same throughout the world.

2.167 When you are using superlative adjectives, you may wish to say that something has much more or much less of a quality than anything else of its kind.
The submodifying adverbs *much, quite, easily, by far*, and *very* can be used with the superlative adjectives.
Much, quite, and *easily* are placed in front of *the* and the superlative.

Example 2.7.22. *Music may have been much the most respectable of his tastes.*
... the most frightening time of my life, and quite the most dishonest.
This is easily the best film of the year.

By far can be placed either in front of *the* and the superlative or after the superlative.

Example 2.7.23. *They are by far the most dangerous creatures on the island.*
The Union was the largest by far.

2.168 *Very* is only used with superlatives formed by adding *-est* or with irregular superlatives e.g. *1st* or *last*.

Example 2.7.24. *... in the very smallest countries.*
... 1 of the very finest breeds of dogs.
... on the very 1st day of the war.
He had come at the very last moment.
That very next afternoon he was working in his room.
He spent weeks in that very same basement.

2.8 Modifying using nouns: noun modifiers

2.169 Nouns can be used as modifiers in front of other nouns when you want to give more specific information about someone or something.
Sometimes, when nouns are used like this they become fixed expressions called **compound nouns** (see paragraphs **1.83–1.92**).
When the nouns used in front of other nouns are not in fixed expressions, they are called **noun modifiers**.

Example 2.8.1. *... the car door.*
... tennis lessons.
... a football player.
... cat food.
... the music industry.
... a surprise announcement.

2.170 You normally use the singular form of a **countable noun** (see paragraphs **1.15**–**1.22**) as a noun modifier, even when you are referring to more than 1 thing.

E.g., you refer to a shop that sells books as *a book shop*, not *a books shop*, even though it sells a large number of books, not just 1.

Many **plural nouns** lose their *-s* endings when used in front of other nouns.

Example 2.8.2. ... *my trouser pocket.*
... *pyjama trousers.*
... *paratroop attacks.*

Here is a list of common plural nouns that lose their *-s* and *-es* endings when they are used as modifiers:

Example 2.8.3. *knickers, paratroops, pyjamas, scissors, spectacles, troops, trousers*

However, some plural nouns keep the same form when used in front of other nouns.

Example 2.8.4. ... *arms control.*
... *clothes pegs.*

Here is a list of common plural nouns that remain the same when they are used as modifiers:

Example 2.8.5. *arms, binoculars, clothes, glasses, jeans, sunglasses*

Plural nouns are explained in paragraphs **1.41**–**1.46**.

2.171 If you want to be even more specific, you can use more than 1 noun modifier.

E.g., a *car insurance certificate* is a certificate that shows that a car has been insured, and a *state pension scheme* is a scheme that is run by the state and concerns workers' pensions.

Example 2.8.6. ... *a Careers Information Officer.*
... *car body repair kits.*
... *a family dinner party.*
... *a school medical officer.*

2.172 If you want to give more information about a noun that has a noun modifier in front of it, you can put **adjectives** in front of the noun modifier.

Example 2.8.7. ... *a long car journey.*
... *a new scarlet silk handkerchief.*
... *complex business deals.*
... *this beautiful morning sunlight.*
... *the French film industry.*

When an adjective comes in front of 2 nouns, it is usually obvious whether it is modifying the 2 nouns combined or only the noun modifier.

E.g., in *an electric can opener*, the adjective *electric* is modifying the combination *can opener*, whereas in *electric shock treatment, electric* is modifying the noun *shock* and then both the adjective and the noun modifier are modifying the noun *treatment*.

Adjectives are explained in paragraphs **2.2**–**2.102**.

2.173 **Proper nouns** can also be used as noun modifiers.

E.g., if you want to show that something is connected with a place, organization, or institution, you put the name of the place, organization, or institution in front of all other noun modifiers.

You also put them in front of classifying adjectives.

Example 2.8.8. ... *Brighton Technical College.*
... *the Cambridge House Literacy Scheme.*

Proper nouns are explained in paragraphs **1.52**–**1.58**.

2.174 [⋆] The use of noun modifiers in English is very common indeed.

In fact, when the context makes it clear what you mean, you can use almost any noun to modify any other noun.

You can use noun modifiers to talk about a wide range of relationships between the 2 nouns.

E.g., you can say what something is made of, as in *cotton socks*.

You can also say what is made in a particular place, as in *a glass factory*.

You can say what someone does, as in *a football player*, or you can say where something is, as in *my bedroom curtains*.

You can say when something happens, as in *the morning mist* and *he wartime activities*.

You can also describe the nature or size of something, as in *a surprise attack* and *a pocket chess-set*.

2.9 Talking about quantities & amounts

2.175 This section deals with ways of talking about quantities and amounts of things.

You often refer to quantities by using a number, but sometimes in everyday situations you can do this by using a word or a phrase e.g. *several* or *a lot* and link it with *of* to the following noun.

Quantity expressions like these are explained in paragraphs **2.176–2.193**.

When phrases e.g. *a bottle* are used like this, they are called **partitives**.

Partitives are explained in paragraphs **2.194–2.207**.

When you want to be very precise about the quality or amount of something, you can use **numbers** (see paragraphs **2.208–2.239**) or **fractions** (see paragraphs **2.240–2.249**).

Numbers, fractions, and quantity expressions are also used in expressions of measurement to indicate the size, weight, length, and so on, of something.

Ways of talking about **measurements** are explained in paragraphs **2.250–2.257**.

Approximate measurements are explained in paragraphs **2.264–2.271**.

Numbers are also used to say how old someone or something is.

This is explained in paragraphs **2.258–2.263**.

2.9.1 Talking about amounts of things: *a lot of ideas, plenty of shops*

2.176 When you want to talk about a quantity of things or an amount of something, you can use the pronoun form of some indefinite determiners (e.g. *all* or *both*) followed by *of* and a noun phrase.

Example 2.9.1. *I am sure both of you agree with me.*
Most of the population have fled.
All of her children live abroad.

2.177 Here is the list of indefinite determiners that can be used in this way.

Of is given after each as a reminder.

Example 2.9.2. *all of, another of, any of, both of, each of, either of, enough of, (a) few of, fewer of, less of, (a) little of, lots of, many of, more of, most of, much of, neither of, none of, 1 of, several of, some of*

You can also use a phrase e.g. *a lot of* or *a number of* to talk about quantity in the same way.

Example 2.9.3. *... a house with lots of windows.*
I make a lot of mistakes.
In Tunis there are a number of art galleries.
I never found the rest of my relatives.

2.178 Here is a list of phrases that can be used to talk about quantity.

Example 2.9.4. *an amount of, a bit of, a little bit of, a couple of, a good deal of, a great deal of, a lot of, a good many of, a great many of, a number of, plenty of, a quantity of*
a majority of, the majority of, a minority of
part of, the remainder of, the rest of, the whole of
*gobs of (*American*), heaps of, loads of, masses of, tons of*

Note that the words in the last group in this list are used in informal speech only.

2.179 Some of these quantity expressions are linked by *of* only to noun phrases that begin with a definite determiner e.g. *the, these*, or *my*.

A pronoun e.g. *us, them*, or *these* can also be used after *of*.

Example 2.9.5. *Nearly all of the increase has been caused by inflation.*
Part of the farm lay close to the river bank.
Only a few of them were armed.

Here is a list of quantity expressions with *of* that are usually or always followed by noun phrases beginning with definite determiners:

Example 2.9.6. *all of, another of, any of, both of, certain of, each of, either of, enough of, few of, fewer of, less of, little of, many of, more of, most of, much of, neither of, none of, 1 of, part of, several of, some of, various of*
a few of, a little of, a good many of, a great many of
the remainder of, the rest of, the whole of

2.180 Some of these quantity expressions can also be used with place names.

Example 2.9.7. *Much of America will be shocked by what happened.*
... involving most of Africa and a lot of South America.

Here is a list of quantity expressions used with place names:

Example 2.9.8. *all of, less of, more of, most of, much of, none of, part of, some of*
a bit of, a little bit of, a good deal of, a great deal of, a lot of
the rest of, the whole of

2.181 When you use a quantity expression as the subject of a verb, the verb is singular or plural depending on whether the quantity expression refers to 1 thing or to more than 1 thing.

Example 2.9.9. *Some of the information has already been analyzed.*
Some of my best friends are policemen.

2.182 Many quantity expressions can only be used in front of plural noun phrases.

Example 2.9.10. *I am sure both of you agree with me.*
Start by looking through their papers for either of the 2 documents mentioned below.
Few of these organizations survive for long.
Several of his best books are about space flight.
I would like to ask you a couple of questions.
The report contained large numbers of inaccuracies.

Here is a list of quantity expressions that are only used with plural noun phrases:

Example 2.9.11. *another of, both of, certain of, each of, either of, few of, fewer of, many of, neither of, numbers of, 1 of, several of, various of*
a couple of, a few of, a good many of, a great many of, a number of

For more information about *each of* see paragraphs **2.186–2.187**, about *fewer of* see paragraph **2.189**, and about *a number of* see paragraphs **2.191–2.192**.
Note that *neither of* is used in a similar way to *either of* when you are talking about 2 things in negative clauses.
This is explained in paragraphs **5.81**.

2.183 A few quantity expressions are only used with uncountable nouns and singular noun phrases.

Example 2.9.12. *Much of the day was taken up with classes.*
This is a bit of a change.
There was a good deal of smoke.
If you use rich milk, pour off a little of the cream.
I spent the whole of last year working there.

Here is a list of quantity expressions only used with uncountable nouns and singular noun phrases:

Example 2.9.13. *less of, little of, much of, part of*
a bit of, a little bit of, a good deal of, a great deal of, a little of
the whole of

For more information about *less of* see paragraph **2.189**.

2.184 A very few quantity expressions are used only with plural noun phrases and uncountable nouns.

Example 2.9.14. *... the seizure of vast quantities of illegal weapons.*
Very large quantities of aid were needed.
They had loads of things to say about each other.
We had loads of room.
... plenty of the men.
Make sure you give plenty of notice.

Here is a list of quantity expressions that are only used with plural noun phrases and uncountable nouns:

Example 2.9.15. *plenty of, quantities of*
*gobs of (*American*), heaps of, loads of, masses of, tons of*

Note that when the 2nd group in this list are used with an uncountable noun as the subject of a verb, the verb is singular, even though the quantity expression looks plural.

Example 2.9.16. *Masses and masses of food was left over.*

2.185 Some quantity expressions can be used with plural nouns, with singular nouns, or with uncountable nouns.

Example 2.9.17. *... some of the most distinguished men of our time.*
We did some of the journey by night.
Some of the gossip was surprisingly accurate.

Here is a list of quantity expressions that are used with plural nouns, singular nouns, or uncountable nouns:

Example 2.9.18. *all of, any of, enough of, lots of, more of, most of, none of, some of*
an amount of, a lot of, a quantity of
the remainder of, the rest of

Note that *an amount of* is nearly always used with an adjective e.g. *small*: *a small amount of.*
This is explained in paragraph **2.191**.
Note also that when *lots of* is used with an uncountable noun as the subject of a verb, the verb is singular, even though the quantity expression looks plural.

Example 2.9.19. *He thought that lots of lovely money was the source of happiness.*

Any of is explained more fully in paragraphs **2.188**.
2.186 [i] When you want to refer to each member of a particular group, you can use *each of* and a plural noun phrase.

Example 2.9.20. *Each of the drawings is slightly different.*
We feel quite differently about each of our children.
Work out how much you can afford to pay each of them.

Note that *each one* and *every one* can be used before *of* instead of *each*, for emphasis.

Example 2.9.21. *This view of poverty influences each one of us.*
Every one of them is given a financial target.

2.187 [!] When the quantity expression *each of* is used with a plural noun phrase, the verb after the noun phrase is always singular.
2.188 [i] *Any of* can refer to 1 or several people or things, or to part of something.
Note that if it is the subject of a verb, when it refers to several things, the verb is plural, and when it refers to a part of something, the verb is singular.

Example 2.9.22. *She has those coats. She might have been wearing any of them.*
Hardly any of these find their way into consumer products.
Has any of this been helpful?
It was more expensive than any of the other magazines we were normally able to afford.

2.189 There are 3 comparative quantity expressions that can be used before noun phrases.
Less of is usually used with singular nouns and uncountable nouns, *fewer of* is usually used with plural nouns, and *more of* is used with all 3 types of noun.

Example 2.9.23. *I enjoy cooking far more now, because I do less of it.*
Fewer of these children will become bored.
He was far more of an existentialist.

Note that *more of* is sometimes used in front of a noun phrase to intensify it.

Example 2.9.24. *He could hardy have felt more of a fool than he did at that moment.*
She was more of a flirt than ever.
America is much more of a classless society.

Note also hat *less of* is sometimes used instead of *fewer of*, but many people think that this is not correct.
2.190 When the context makes it clear, or when you think that the person you are talking to will understand what you mean, you can sometimes reduce the structure to the quantity word only.
E.g., if you are talking about applications for a job and there were 20 candidates, you can say *Some were very good* rather than *Some of them were very good.*

Example 2.9.25. *A few crossed over the bridge.*
Some parts can be separated from the whole.
I have 4 bins. I keep one in the kitchen and the rest in the dustbin area.
Most of the books had been packed into an enormous trunk and the remainder piled on top of it.

2.191 [i] You can add adjectives to *a number of* and *a quantity of* to say how large or small an amount or number of things is.

Example 2.9.26. *The city attracts a large number of tourists.*
We had a limited number of people to choose from.
The novel provides an enormous quantity of information.
... a tiny quantity of acid.

An amount of is always used with adjectives, and is usually used with uncountable nouns.

Example 2.9.27. *Pour a small amount of the sauce over the kitchen.*
He has a large amount of responsibility.
It only involves a small amount of time.
There has to be a certain amount of hard work.

The plural forms of *quantity, number*, and *amount* are used, especially when referring to separate amounts.

Example 2.9.28. *... groups that employ large numbers of low-paid workers.*
Enormous amounts of money are spent on advertising.

2.192 When a quantity expression contains an adjective, you can put *very* in front of the adjective.

Example 2.9.29. *... a very great deal of work.*
... a very large amount of money.

2.193 Some quantity expressions can be modified using *quite*.

Example 2.9.30. *I've wasted quite enough of my life here.*
Quite a few of the employees are beginning to realize the truth.
Most of them have had quite a lot of experience.
... quite a large amount of industry.

Here is a list of quantity expressions that can be modified by *quite*:

Example 2.9.31. *enough, a few, a lot of, a large amount of, a small amount of, a number of, a large number of*

2.9.2 Talking about particular amounts of things: *a piece of paper, a drop of water*

2.194 When you want to talk about a particularly quantity of something, you can use a **partitive** structure that consists of a particular partitive (e.g. *piece*) linked by *of* to another noun.
Partitives are always countable nouns.

Example 2.9.32. *Who owns this bit of land?*
... portions of mashed potato.

If the partitive is singular, then the verb used with it is usually singular.
If it is plural, the verb is also plural.

Example 2.9.33. *A piece of paper is lifeless.*
2 pieces of metal were being rubbed together.

Note that all partitives consist of 2 or more words, because *of* is needed in every case.
Of is printed in the lists below as a reminder.
2.195 When the noun after the partitive is an uncountable noun, you use countable noun e.g. *bit, drop, lump*, or *piece* as the partitive.

Example 2.9.34. *Here's a bit of paper.*
... a drop of blood.
Drops of sweat dripped from his forehead.
... a tiny piece of material.
... a pinch of salt.
... specks of dust.

These partitives can be used without *of* when it is obvious what you are talking about.

Example 2.9.35. *He sat down in the kitchen before a plate of cold ham, but he had only eaten 1 piece when the phone rang.*

2.196 Here is a list of partitives used with uncountable nouns:

Example 2.9.36. *amount of, bit of, blob of, chunk of, dash of, drop of, grain of, heap of, knob of, lump of, mass of, morsel of, mountain of, piece of, pile of, pinch of, pool of, portion of, scrap of, sheet of, shred of, slice of, speck of, spot of, touch of, trace of*

Some of these partitives are also used with plural nouns referring to things that together form a mass.

Example 2.9.37. *... a huge heap of stones.*
... a pile of newspapers.

Here is a list of partitives used with both uncountable and plural nouns:

Example 2.9.38. *amount of, clump of, heap of, mass of, mountain of, pile of, portion of*

2.197 [⋆] Many nouns that refer to the shape of an amount of something can also be partitives with uncountable or plural nouns.

Example 2.9.39. *... a ball of wool.*
... columns of smoke.
... a ring of excited faces.

Here is a list of partitives used for talking about the shape of an amount of something:

Example 2.9.40. *ball of, column of, ring of, shaft of, square of, stick of, strip of, thread of, tuft of, wall of*

Many nouns that refer to both shape and movement can also be used as partitives.

Example 2.9.41. *It blew a jet of water into the air.*
... a constant stream of children passing through the door.

Here is a list of partitives used for talking about both shape and movement:

Example 2.9.42. *dribble of, gush of, gust of, jet of, shower of, spurt of, stream of, torrent of*

[⋆] You can use any noun to describe shape in this way.
E.g., you can talk about *a triangle of snooker balls.*
2.198 There are many nouns that refer to groups that can be used as partitives.
They are linked by *of* to plural nouns that indicate what the group consists of.

Example 2.9.43. *It was evaluated by an independent team of inspectors.*
A group of journalists gathered at the airport to watch us take off.
... a bunch of flowers.

Here is a list of partitives referring to groups:

Example 2.9.44. *audience of, bunch of, clump of, company of, family of, flock of, gang of, group of, herd of, team of, troupe of*

[⋆] You can use any noun referring to a group of people or things in this way.
E.g., you can talk about *an army of volunteers.*
2.199 Nouns referring to measurements are often used in partitive structures to talk about an amount of something that is a particular length, area, volume, or weight.
Uncountable nouns are used after *of* in structures referring to length, and both uncountable and plural nouns are used in structures referring to weight.

Example 2.9.45. *... 10 yards of velvet.*
Thousands of square miles of land have been contaminated.
I drink a pint of milk a day.
... 3 pounds of strawberries.
... 10 ounces of cheese.

Nouns referring to measurements are explained in paragraphs **2.250–2.257**.

2.200 You use partitives when you want to talk about the contents of a container as well as to the container itself.
E.g., you can refer to a carton filled with milk as *a carton of milk*.

Example 2.9.46. *I went to buy a bag of chips.*
The waiter appeared with a bottle of red wine.
. . . a packet of cigarettes.
. . . a pot of honey.
. . . tubes of glue.

You can also use partitives to refer to the contents only.

Example 2.9.47. *They drank another bottle of champagne.*
She ate a whole box of chocolates.

Here is a list of partitives referring to containers:

Example 2.9.48. *bag of, barrel of, basin of, basket of, bottle of, bowl of, box of, bucket of, can of, carton of, case of, cask of, crate of, cup of, glass of, jar of, jug of, mug of, pack of, packet of, plate of, pot of, sack of, spoon of, tablespoon of, tank of, teaspoon of, tin of, tub of, tube of, tumbler of*

2.201 You can add *-ful* to these partitives referring to containers.

Example 2.9.49. *He brought me a bagful of sweets.*
Pour a bucketful of cold water on the ash.
. . . a cupful of boiled water.
. . . a tankful of petrol.

Here is a list of partitives referring to containers that are very commonly used with *-ful*:

Example 2.9.50. *bag, basket, box, bucket, cup, plate, spoon, tablespoon, tank, teaspoon*

When people want to make a noun ending in *-ful* plural, they usually add an *-s* to the end of the word, as in *bucketfuls*. However some people put the *-s* in front of *-ful*, as in *bucketsful*.

Example 2.9.51. *She ladled 3 spoonfuls of sugar into my tea.*
They were collecting basketfuls of apples.
. . . 2 teaspoonfuls of powder.
. . . 2 teaspoonsful of milk.

2.202 [⋆] You can also add *-ful* to other partitives.

Example 2.9.52. *Eleanor was holding an armful of red roses.*
I went outside to throw a handful of bread to the birds.
He took another mouthful of whisky.
. . . a houseful of children.

2.203 [i] You sometimes use a mass noun instead of a partitive structure.
E.g., *2 teas* means the same as *2 cups of tea*, and *2 sugars* means *2 spoonfuls of sugar*.

Example 2.9.53. *We drank a couple of beers.*
I asked for 2 coffees with milk.

Mass nouns are explained in paragraphs **1.28–1.31**.

2.204 You use a partitive when you want to talk about a part or a fraction of a particular thing.

Example 2.9.54. *I spent a large part of my life in broadcasting.*
The system is breaking down in many parts of Africa.
A large portion of the university budget goes into the Community Services area.
. . . a mass movement involving all segments of society.

Here is a list of partitives referring to a part of something:

Example 2.9.55. *part of, portion of, section of, segment of*

2.205 You use a partitive with an uncountable noun referring to things of a certain type when you want to refer to 1 particular thing of that type.

Example 2.9.56. *... an article of clothing.*
I bought a few bits of furniture.
Any item of information can be accessed.

Here is a list of partitives referring to 1 thing of a particular type:

Example 2.9.57. *article of, bit of, item of, piece of*

Here is a list of uncountable nouns referring to things of a certain type that are often used with the partitives listed above:

Example 2.9.58. *advice, apparatus, baggage, clothing, equipment, furniture, homework, information, knowledge, luggage, machinery, news, research*

2.206 Some plural nouns refer to things that are normally thought to consist of 2 parts, e.g. trousers or scissors.
Some others refer to things that are made in twos, e.g. shoes or shocks.
When you want to talk about 1 of these 2-part items, or 2-item sets, you use the partitive *pair* linked to these plural nouns by *of*.

Example 2.9.59. *... a pair of jeans.*
... a pair of tights.
... a dozen pairs of sunglasses.
I brought a pair of tennis shoes.
I smashed 3 pairs of skis.

These **plural nouns** are explained in paragraphs **1.41–1.46**.
2.207 [⋆] Whenever you want to

(i) talk about a limited amount of something,

(ii) indicate the area that something occupies, or

(iii) specify a particular feature that something has,

you can use a noun that indicates the amount or the nature of the thing (e.g. *bottle*), linked by *of* to a noun that indicates what the thing is (e.g. *water*).
E.g., if you say *a forest of pines*, you are talking about a large area of trees.
Similarly, you can talk about *a border of roses*.
This structure can be extended very widely, so that you can talk about *a city of dreaming spires*, e.g.

2.10 Referring to an exact number of things: numbers

2.208 When you want to refer to an exact number of things, you use numbers e.g. *two, thirty*, and *777*, which are called **cardinal numbers**, or sometimes **cardinals**.

Example 2.10.1. *I'm going to ask you 30 questions.*
... 260 copies of the record.

The cardinal numbers are listed in the Reference section and their use is explained in paragraphs **2.213–2.231**.
2.209 When you want to identify or describe something by showing where it comes in a series or sequence, you use an **ordinal number**, or an **ordinal**, e.g. *1st, 2nd, 14th*, or *27th*.

Example 2.10.2. *She received a video camera for her 14th birthday.*
I repeated my story for the 3rd time that day.

The ordinal numbers are listed in the Reference section and their use is explained in paragraphs **2.232–2.239**.
2.210 When you want to show how large a part of something is compared to the whole of it, you use a **fraction** e.g. *a 3rd* or *3-quarters*.

Example 2.10.3. *A 3rd of the American forces were involved.*
The bottle was about 3-quarters full when he started.

Fractions are explained in paragraphs **2.240–2.249**.
2.211 When you want to talk about a size, distance, area, volume, weight, speed, or temperature, you can do so by using a number or quantity expression in front of a **measurement noun** e.g. *feet* and *miles*.

Example 2.10.4. *He was about 6 feet tall.*
It's 4 miles to the city center from here.

Measurements nouns are explained in paragraphs **2.250–2.257**.

If you do not know the exact number, size, or quantity of something, you can give an approximate amount of measurement using 1 of a group of special words and expressions.

These are explained in paragraphs **2.263–2.271**.

2.212 When you want to say how old someone or something is, you have a choice of ways in which to do it.

These are explained in paragraphs **2.258–2.263**.

2.10.1 Talking about the number of things: cardinal numbers

2.213 If you want to talk about some or all of the things in a group, you can show how many things you are talking about by using a **cardinal number**.

The cardinal numbers are listed in the Reference section.

Example 2.10.5. *By Christmas, we had 10 cows.*

When you use a determiner and a number in front of a noun, you put the determiner in front of the number.

Example 2.10.6. *... the 3 young men.*
... my 2 daughters.
Watch the eyes of any 2 people engrossed in conversation.
All 3 candidates are coming to Blackpool later this week.

When you put a number and an adjective in front of a noun, you usually put the number in front of the adjective.

Example 2.10.7. *... 2 small children.*
... 1500 local residents.
... 3 beautiful young girls.

2.214 *One* is used as a number in front of a noun to emphasize that there is only 1 thing, to show that you are being precise, or to contrast 1 thing with another.

One is followed by a singular noun.

Example 2.10.8. *That is the 1 big reservation I've got.*
He balanced himself on 1 foot.
There was only 1 gate into the palace.
This treaty was signed 1 year after the Suez Crisis.
It was negative in 1 respect but positive in another.

One is also used, like other numbers, as a quantity expression.

Example 2.10.9. *1 of my students sold me her ticket.*
... 1 of the few great novels of the century.
It's 1 of the best films I've ever seen.

One also has special uses a determiner and a pronoun.

These are explained in paragraph **1.249** and paragraphs **1.158–1.161**.

2.215 When a large number begins with the figure *1*, the *1* can be said or written as *a* or *one*.

One is more formal.

Example 2.10.10. *... a million dollars.*
... a hundred and fifty miles.
Over one million pounds has been raised.

2.216 The number 0 is not used in ordinary English to say that the number of things you are talking about is zero.

Instead the negative determiner *no* or the negative pronoun *none* is used, or *any* is used with a negative.

These are explained in paragraphs **5.51** and **5.71–5.73**.

2.217 When you use any number except *one* in front of a noun, you use a plural noun.

Example 2.10.11. *There were 10 people there, all men.*
... 100 years.
... 101 things.

2.218 When you use a number and a plural noun to talk about 2 or more things, you usually use a plural verb.
You use a singular verb with *one*.

Example 2.10.12. *7 guerrillas were wounded.*
There is 1 clue.

However, when you are talking about an amount of money or time, or a distance, speed, or weight, you usually use a number, a plural noun, and a singular verb.

Example 2.10.13. *300 pounds is a lot of money.*
10 years is a long time.
26 miles is a long way to run.
90 miles an hour is much too fast.
90 pounds is all she weighs.

Ways of measuring things are explained in paragraphs **2.250–2.257**.
2.219 You can use cardinal numbers with both **ordinals** (see paragraphs **2.232–2.239**) and **postdeterminers** (see paragraph **2.40**).
When you use a cardinal number with a determiner followed by an ordinal number of a postdeterminer, the cardinal number usually comes after the determiner and the ordinal or postdeterminer.

Example 2.10.14. *The 1st 2 years have been very successful.*
... throughout the 1st 4 months of this year.
... the last 2 volumes of the encyclopedia.
... in the previous 3 years of his reign.

Note that some postdeterminers can be used like ordinary **classifying adjectives** (see paragraph **2.40**).
When they are used like this, the cardinal number comes before them.

Example 2.10.15. *He has written 2 previous novels.*
... 2 further examples.

2.220 When either the context makes it clear, or you think that your listener already knows something, you can use the cardinal number without a noun.

Example 2.10.16. *These 2 are quite different.*

When cardinal numbers are used like this, you can put ordinal numbers, postdeterminers, or superlatives adjectives in between the determiner and the cardinal number.

Example 2.10.17. *I want to tell you about the programmes. The 1st 4 are devoted to universities.*
The other 6 are masterpieces.
The best 30 have the potential to be successful journalists.

2.221 When you use *dozen, hundred, thousand, million*, or *billion* to indicate exact numbers, you put *a* or another number in front of them.

Example 2.10.18. *... a hundred dollars.*
... 610 miles.
... a thousand billion pounds.
... 2 dozen diapers.

2.222 [!] When you use *dozen, hundred, thousand, million*, or *billion* they remain singular even when the number in front of them is greater than 1.
2.223 [!] You can use *dozen, hundred, thousand, million*, or *billion* without *of* in a less precise way by putting *several, a few*, and *a couple of* in front of them.

Example 2.10.19. *... several hundred people.*
A few thousand cars have gone.
... life a couple of hundred years ago.

2.224 When you want to emphasize how large a number is without stating it precisely, you can use *dozens, hundreds, thousands, millions*, and *billions* in the same way as cardinals followed by *of*.

Example 2.10.20. *That's going to take hundreds of years.*
... hundreds of dollars.
We traveled thousands of miles across Europe.
... languages spoken by millions of people.
We have dozens of friends in the community.

You can put *many* in front of these plural forms.

Example 2.10.21. *I have traveled many hundreds of miles with them.*

2.225 [i] People often use the plural forms when they are exaggerating.

Example 2.10.22. *I was meeting thousands of people.*
Do you have to fill in hundreds of forms before you go?

You can also emphasize or exaggerate a large number of using these words in phrases beginning with *by*.

Example 2.10.23. *... a book which sells by the million.*
... people who give injections by the dozen.
Videos of the royal wedding sold by the hundred thousand.

2.226 Cardinal numbers are used to label or identify things.

Example 2.10.24. *Room 777 of the Stanley Hotel.*
Number 11 Downing Street.

2.227 You can also use cardinal numbers as quantity expressions linked by *of* to a noun phrase referring to a group.
You do this when you want to emphasize that you are talking about a part or all of a group.

Example 2.10.25. *I saw 4 of these programmes.*
3 of the questions today have been about democracy.
I use plastic kitchen bins. I have 4 of them.
All 8 of my great-grandparents lived in the city.
All 4 of us wanted to get away from the Earl's Court area.
The clerk looked at the 6 of them and said, All of you?
I find it less worrying than the 2 of you are suggesting.

Quantity expressions are explained in paragraphs **2.176**–**2.193**.
2.228 Cardinal numbers are used to quantify something without the *of* and the noun phrase, when it is clear what you are referring to.

Example 2.10.26. *... a group of painters, 9 or 10 in all.*
Of the other wives, 2 are dancers and 1 is a singer.
... the taller student of the 2.
... breakfast for 2.

2.229 Cardinal numbers are also used after subject pronouns.

Example 2.10.27. *In the fall we 2 are going to England.*
You 4, come with me.

2.230 Cardinal numbers can be used as part of a **compound adjective** (see paragraphs **2.94**–**2.102**).
The cardinal number is used in front of a noun to form a compound adjective that is usually hyphenated

Example 2.10.28. *He took out a 5-dollar bill.*
I wrote a 5-page summary of the situation.

Note that the noun remains singular even when the number is 2 or more, and that compound adjectives that are formed like this cannot be used after a linking verb.
E.g., you cannot say *My essay is five-hundred-word.*
Instead you would probably say *My essay is 500 words long.*
2.231 Cardinal numbers are sometimes used with general time words e.g. *month* and *week*.
You do this when you want to describe something by saying how long it lasts.
If the thing is referred to with an uncountable noun, you use the **possessive form** (see paragraphs **1.211**–**1.222**) of the general time word.

Example 2.10.29. *She's already had at least 9 months' experience.*
On Friday she had been given 2 weeks' notice.

Sometimes the apostrophe is omitted.

Example 2.10.30. *They wanted 3 weeks holiday and 3 weeks pay.*

The determiner *a* is usually used when you are talking about a single period of time, although *one* can be used instead when you want to be more formal.

Example 2.10.31. *She's on a year's leave from Hunter College.*
He was only given 1 week's notice.

Cardinal numbers are also used with general time words as modifiers of adjectives.

Example 2.10.32. *She was 4 months pregnant.*
The rains are 2 months late.
His rent was 3 weeks overdue.

2.10.2 Referring to things in a sequence: ordinal numbers

2.232 If you want to identify or describe something by saying where it comes in a series or sequence, you use an **ordinal number**.

Example 2.10.33. *Quietly they took their seats in the 1st 3 rows.*
Flora's flat is on the 4th floor of this 5-storey block.
They stopped at the 1st of the trees.

Note that you can also use *following, last, next, preceding, previous*, and *subsequent* like ordinal numbers to say where something comes in a series or sequence.

Example 2.10.34. *The following morning he checked out of the hotel.*
... the last rungs of the fire-escape.
... at the next general election.
The preceding text has been professionally transcribed.
I mentioned this in a previous programme.
... the subsequent career patterns of those taking degrees.

Following, subsequent, previous, and *preceding* are only used to indicate the position of something in a sequence in time or in a piece of writing.
Next and *last* are used more generally, e.g. to refer to things in rows or lists.
The ordinal numbers are listed in the Reference section.
2.233 Ordinals are often used in front of nouns.
They are not usually used after linking verbs like *be*.
They are usually preceded by a determiner.

Example 2.10.35. *... the 1st day of autumn.*
He took the lift to the 16th floor.
... on her 21st birthday.
... his father's 2nd marriage.

In some idiomatic phrases ordinals are used without determiners.

Example 2.10.36. *The picture seems at 1st glance chaotic.*
I might. On 2nd thoughts, no.
1st children usually get a lot of attention.

2.234 Ordinals can be written in abbreviated form, e.g. in dates or headings or in very informal writing.
You write the last 2 letters of the ordinal after the number expressed in figures.
E.g., *first* can be written as *1st, twenty-second* as *22nd, hundred and thirds* as *103rd*, and *fourteenth* as *14th*.

Example 2.10.37. *... on August 2nd.*
... the 1st Division of the Sovereign's Escort.
... the 11th Cavalry.

2.235 You can specify which group the thing referred to by an ordinal belongs to by using the preposition *of* after the ordinal.

Example 2.10.38. *It is the 3rd of a series of 8 programmes.*
Tony was the 2nd of 4 sons.

When ordinals are used like this, they usually refer to 1 person or thing.
However, when they are used with a *to*-infinitive, or another phrase or clause after them, they can refer to 1 person or thing or to more than 1.
1st is used like this more than the other ordinals.

Example 2.10.39. *I was the 1st to recover.*
They had to be the 1st to go.
The proposals - the 1st for 22 years - amount to a new charter for the mentally ill.
The withdrawals were the 1st that the army agreed to.

2.236 You can use an ordinal to refer to a member of a group that you have already mentioned or to something of the kind already mentioned, and you can omit the noun that identifies the thing.

Example 2.10.40. *In Aug 1932 2 of the group's members were expelled from the party and a 3rd was suspended.*
The 3rd child tries to outdo the 1st and 2nd.
A 2nd pheasant flew up. Then a third and a 4th.

2.237 The adjectives *next* and *last* can be used, like ordinals, by themselves when the context makes the meaning clear.

Example 2.10.41. *You missed 1 meal. The meal is on the table in half an hour.*
Smithy removed the last of the crews.

2.238 The ordinal *1st* is also used as an adverb to show that something is done before other things.
Other ordinals are also sometimes used to show the order in which things are done, especially in informal English.
People also use ordinals as adverbs when they are giving a list of points, reasons, or items.
This is explained fully in paragraph **10.54**.
2.239 The use of ordinals in expressing fractions is explained in paragraphs **2.241**–**2.243**.
The use of ordinals to express dates, as in *the 17th of June*, is explained in paragraph **4.88**.
Ordinal numbers can be used in front of cardinal numbers.
This is explained in paragraphs **2.219**–**2.220**.

2.10.3 Talking about an exact part of something: fractions

2.240 When you want to show how small or large a part of something is compared to the whole of it, you use a **fraction**, e.g. *a 3rd*, followed by *of* and a noun referring to the whole thing.
Fractions can also be written in figures (see paragraph **2.248**).
2.241 When you express a fraction in words, the way you do so depends on whether the fraction is singular or plural.
If it is singular, you write or say an **ordinal number** or the special fraction terms *half* or *quarter*, with either the number *one* or a determiner e.g. *a* in front of them.
The fraction is linked to a noun by *of*.

Example 2.10.42. *This state produces a 3rd of the nation's oil.*
... a quarter of an inch.
You can take a 5th of your money out on demand.
A 10th of our budget goes on fuel.
Forests cover 1 3rd of the country.
... 100th of a degree.
... 1 quarter of the total population.

An adjective can also be placed after the determiner and before the fraction.

Example 2.10.43. *... the 1st half of the 20th century.*
I read the 1st half of the book.
... the southern half of England.
... in the 1st quarter of 2004.

2.242 [i] If you are using *half* in front of a pronoun, you still use *of* after the *half*.

Example 2.10.44. *Nearly half of it comes from the Middle East.*
More than half of them have gone home.
Half of us have lost our jobs.

Note that when the fraction *a half* is used with *of*, you usually write or say it as *half* without a determiner.
A half and *one half* are rarely used.

Example 2.10.45. *They lost half of their pay.*
Half of the people went to private schools.
I had crossed more than half of America.

2.243 If the fraction is plural, you put a **cardinal number** in front of a plural form of the **ordinal number** or special fraction word *quarter*.

Example 2.10.46. *... the poorer 2 3rds of the world.*
The journey is going to take 3 quarters of an hour.
... 4 5ths of the money.
9 10th of them live on the land.
... 3 millionths of a centimeter.

When *half* is used with whole numbers or amounts, it is used with the determiner *a*.

Example 2.10.47. *... 1 and a half acres of land.*
... 4 and a half centuries.

2.244 When you talk about fractions of a single thing, you use a singular form of a verb afterwards.

Example 2.10.48. *Half of our work is to design programmes.*
2 3rds of the planet's surface is covered with water.
2 5ths of the forest was removed.

However, when you talk about fractions of a number of things, you use a plural form of a verb afterwards.

Example 2.10.49. *2 3rds of Chad's exports were cotton.*
A quarter of the students were seen individually.
More than half of these photographs are of her.

2.245 When it is clear to your listener or reader who or what you are referring to, either because of the context or because you and your listener or reader know what is meant, you can use fraction as pronouns without the *of* and noun after them.

Example 2.10.50. *Of the people who work here, half are French and half are English.*
2 3rds were sterilized.
1 6th are disappointed with the service.

2.246 Besides their use as quantity expressions linked by *of* to a noun phrase, fractions can also be used after a whole number or amount plus *and*, with a noun placed after the fraction.
The noun must be plural even if the number is *1*.

Example 2.10.51. *You've got to sit there for 1 and a half hours.*
... 5 and a quarter days.
... more than 4 and a half centuries ago.

If you are using *a* instead of *one*, the *and* and the fraction come after the noun.

Example 2.10.52. *... a mile and a half below the surface.*
... a mile and a quarter of motorway.

2.247 Besides being used with *of* as a quantity expression, *half* is also used as a **predeterminer** (see paragraph **1.251**), directly in front of a determiner.

Example 2.10.53. *I met half the girls at the conference.*
The farmers sold off half their land.
... half a pound of coffee.
... half a bottle of milk.

Note that *half* is always used with *of* before a pronoun (see paragraph **2.242**).

2.248 You can write a fraction in figures, e.g. $\frac{1}{2}$, $\frac{1}{4}$, $\frac{3}{4}$, and $\frac{2}{3}$.

These correspond to *a half, a quarter, 3 quarters* and *2 3rds*, resp.

2.249 Fractions are often given in a special form as a number of 100ths.

This type of fraction is called a **percentage**.

E.g., *3 100ths*, expressed as a percentage, is *3 per cent*.

It can also be written as *3 percent* or *3%*.

A half can be expressed as *50 per cent, 50 percent*, or *50%*.

Example 2.10.54. *90 percent of most food is water.*
About 20 per cent of student accountants are women.
Before 1960 45% of British trade was with the Commonwealth.

You use percentages on their own as noun phrases when it is clear what they refer to.

Example 2.10.55. *90 per cent were self employed.*
... interest at 10% per annum.

2.10.4 Talking about measurements

2.250 You can refer to a size, distance, area, volume, weight, speed, or temperature by using a number of quantity expression in front of a **measurement noun**.

Measurement nouns are countable.

Example 2.10.56. *They grow to 20 feet.*
... blocks of stone weighting up to a hundred tons.
Reduce the temperature by a few degrees.
Average annual temperatures exceed 20° centigrade.

Other ways of expressing distance are explained in paragraphs **6.91–6.92**.

Measurement nouns referring to size, area, volume, and weight are often used in **partitive structures** (see paragraphs **2.194–2.207**) e.g. *a pint of milk* and *a pound of onions*.

They are also used in phrases beginning with *of* (see paragraph **2.283**).

2.251 There are 2 systems of measurement used in Britain - the **imperial system** and the **metric system**.

Each system has its own measurement nouns.

Here is a list of the imperial units of measurement indicating size, distance, area, volume, and weight:

Example 2.10.57. *inch, foot, yard, mile*
acre
pint, quart, gallon
ounce, pound, stone, hundredweight, ton

Note that the plural of *foot* is *feet*, but *foot* can also be used with numbers.

Similarly *stone* is usually used instead of *stones*.

Here is a list of the metric units of measurement indicating size, distance, area, volume, and weight:

Example 2.10.58. *millimeter, centimeter, meter, kilometer*
hectare
milliliter, centiliter, liter
milligram, gram, kilogram, tonne

2.252 Measurement nouns are often used after **linking verbs** e.g. *be, measure* and *weigh*.

Example 2.10.59. *The fish was about 8 feet long.*
It measures approximately 26 inches wide ×25 inches long.
... a square area measuring 900 meters on each side.
It weighs 50 or more kilos.

The use of adjectives after linking verbs is explained in paragraphs **3.132–3.137**.

2.253 When measurement nouns that give the size of something are used after a linking verb, they are often followed by an adjective that makes it clear exactly what the measurement refers to

Example 2.10.60. *He was about 6 feet tall.*
The spears were about 6 foot long.
. . . a room 2 meters wide.
The water was 15 feet deep.
. . . a layer of stone 4 meters thick.

Here is a list of the adjectives that follow measurement nouns indicating size:

Example 2.10.61. *broad, deep, high, long, tall, thick, wide*

Note that you do not say *2 pounds heavy* but *2 pounds in weight* instead.
2.254 Similarly, some measurement nouns can be followed by prepositional phrases beginning with *in*.

Example 2.10.62. *. . . a block of ice 1 cubic foot in size.*
I put on nearly a stone in weight.
They are 30 centimeters in length.
. . . deposits measuring up to a kilometer in thickness.
It was close to 10 feet in height.

Here is a list of phrases beginning with *in* used after measurements:

Example 2.10.63. *in area, in breadth, in depth, in distance, in height, in length, in size, in thickness, in volume, in weight, in width*

2.255 Measurement nouns can also be used as modifiers in front of a noun when you want to describe things in terms of their measurements.

Example 2.10.64. *. . . a 5 foot 9 inch bed.*
. . . 70 foot high mounds of dust.
. . . 12 × 12 inch tiles.
. . . a 5-pound bag of lentils.

Note that the measurement noun is singular.
2.256 [i] If you want to describe fully the size of an object or area, you can give its dimensions; i.e., you give measurements of its length and width, or length, width, and depth.
When you give the dimensions of an object, you separate the figures using *and, by*, or the multiplication sign ×.

Example 2.10.65. *. . . planks of wood about 3 inches thick and 2 feet wide.*
The island measures about 25 miles by 12 miles.
Lake Nyasa is 450 miles long by about 50 miles wide.
The box measures approximately 26 inches wide × 25 inches deep × 16 inches high.

If you are talking about a square object or area, you give the length of each side followed by the word *square*.

Example 2.10.66. *Each family hs only 1 room 8 or 10 feet square.*
The site measures roughly 35 feet square.

Square is used in front of units of length when expressing data.
Cubic is used in front of units of length when expressing volume.

Example 2.10.67. *. . . a farm covering 300 square miles.*
The brain of the 1st ape-men was about the same size as that of gorilla, around 500 cubic centimeters.

You express temperature in degrees, using either degrees centigrade, or degrees Fahrenheit.
Note that in everyday language the metric term *centigrade* is used to indicate temperature, whereas in scientific language the term *Celsius* is used which refers to exactly the same scale of measurement.
2.257 You talk about the speed of something by saying how far it can travel in a particular unit of time.
To do this, you use a noun e.g. *mile* or *kilometer*, followed by *per, a*, or *an*, and a time noun.

Example 2.10.68. *The car would do only 45 miles per hour.*
Wind speeds at the airport were 160 kilometers per hour.
Warships move at about 500 miles per day.

2.10.5 Talking about age

2.258 When you want to say how old someone is, you have a choice of ways in which to do it.
You can be exact or approximate.
Similarly, when you ant to say how old something is, you can use different ways, some exact, and some approximate.

2.259 When you want to talk about a person's exact age, you can do so by using

- *be* followed by a number, and sometimes *years old* after the number.

  Example 2.10.69. *I was 19, and he was 21.*

  I'm only 63.

  She is 25 years old.

  I am 40 years old.

- *of* (or less commonly *aged*) and a number after a noun

  Example 2.10.70. *... a child of 6.*

  ... 2 little boys aged about 9 and 11.

- a compound adjective, usually hyphenated, consisting of a number, followed by a singular noun referring to a period of time, followed by *old*

  Example 2.10.71. *... a twenty-two-year-old student.*

  ... a 5-month-old baby.

  ... a pretty 350-year-old cottage.

  ... a violation of a 6-year-old agreement.

- a compound noun consisting of a number followed by *-year-old*

  Example 2.10.72. *The servant was a pale little 14-year-old who looked hardly more than 10.*

  All the 6-year-olds are taught by 1 teacher.

  ... Melvin Kalkhoven, a tall, thin 35-year-old.

2.260 When you want to talk about a person's age in an approximate way, you can do so by using

- *in*, followed by a possessive determiner, followed by a plural noun referring to a particular range of years e.g. *twenties* and *teens*

  Example 2.10.73. *He was in his sixties.*

  I didn't mature till I was in my forties.

  ... the groups who are now in their thirties.

  ... when I was in my teens.

  Note that you can use *early, mid-, middle*, or *late* to indicate approximately where someone's age comes in a particular range of years.

  Example 2.10.74. *He was then in his late seventies.*

  She was in her mid-twenties.

  Jame is only in her early forties.

- *over* or *under* followed by a number

  Example 2.10.75. *She was well over 50.*

  She was only a little over 40 years old.

  There weren't enough people who were under 25.

  Note that you can also use *above* or *below* followed by *the age of* and a number.

Example 2.10.76. *55 per cent of them were below the age of 21.*

- a compound noun referring to a group of people whose age is more or less than a particular number, which consists of *over* or *under* followed by the plural form of the particular number.

  Example 2.10.77. *The over-sixties do not want to be turned out of their homes.*
  Schooling for under-fives should be expanded.

  [AE] This construction is not common in American English.

2.261 You can put several of the above structures after a noun to talk about the age of a person or thing.

Example 2.10.78. *... a woman in her early 30s.*
... help for elderly ladies over 65.
She had 4 children under the age of 5.

2.262 If you want to say that someone's age is similar to someone else's age, you use structures e.g. *of his age* and *of her parents's age* after a noun.
The *of* is often dropped.

Example 2.10.79. *A lot of girls of Helen's age are interested in clothes.*
It's easy to make friends because you're with people of your own age.
She will have a tough time when she plays with children her own age.

2.263 If you want to say what the age of a thing is, you can use

- *be* followed by a number followed by *years old*

  Example 2.10.80. *It's at least a thousand million years old.*
  The house was about 30 years old.

  Note that you can also use this pattern after a noun.

  Example 2.10.81. *... rocks 200 million years old.*

- a compound adjective indicating the century when something existed or was made, which consists of an ordinal number and *century*

  Example 2.10.82. *... a 6th-century church.*
  ... life in 5th-century Athens.

- a compound adjective, usually hyphenated, consisting of a number, followed by a singular noun referring to a period of time, followed by *old*

  Example 2.10.83. *... a 1,000-year-old temple.*

2.11 Approximate amounts & measurements

2.264 If you do not know the exact number, size, or quantity of something, you can give an approximate amount of measurement using 1 of a group of special words and expressions.
Some of these words and expressions are put in front of a quantity and some are put after it.
Here is a list of some of the words and expressions used to give approximate amounts and measurements:

Example 2.11.1. *about, almost, a maximum of, a minimum of, approximately, around, at least, at most, at the maximum, at the most, less than, maximum, minimum, more than, nearly, no more than, odd, or less, or more, or so, or thereabouts, or under, over, roughly, some, something like, under, upto*

2.265 Some of these expressions indicate that a number is a minimum figure and that the actual figure is or may be larger.
Here is a list of expressions that indicate a minimum number:

Example 2.11.2. *a minimum of, a least, minimum, more than, or more, over, plus*

2.266 [i] You put *a minimum of, more than*, and *over* in front of a number.

Example 2.11.3. *He needed a minimum of 26 Democratic votes.*
... a school with more than 1300 pupils.
The British have been on the island for over a thousand years.

You put *or more* and *plus* after a number or amount, and *minimum* after an amount.

Example 2.11.4. *... a choice of 3 or more possibilities.*
This is the worst disaster I can remember in my 25 years plus as a police officer.
He does an hour's homework per night minimum.

You put *at least* in front of a number or after a number or amount.

Example 2.11.5. *She had at least a dozen brandies.*
I must have slept 12 hours at least!

2.267 Some of these expressions are used to indicate that a number is a maximum figure and that the actual figure is or may be smaller.

Here is a list of expressions that indicate a maximum number:

Example 2.11.6. *almost, a maximum of, at most, at the maximum, at the most, fewer than, less than, maximum, nearly, no more than, or less, or under, under, up to*

2.2608 [i] You put *almost, a maximum of, fewer than, less than, nearly, no more than, under* and *up to* in front of a number.

Fewer than and *less than* mean the same, but *fewer than* is more formal.

Example 2.11.7. *There were fewer than 20 people at the event.*
The puppy's less than 7 weeks old.
The company now supplies almost 100 of the city's restaurants.
These loans must be repaid over a maximum of 3 years.
She had nearly 50 dollars.
We managed to finish the entire job in under 3 months.
Their bodies might be up to a meter wide.

You put *at the maximum, at most, at the most, maximum, or less*, and *or under* after a number.

Example 2.11.8. *Classes are of 8 at the maximum.*
The images take 36 hours maximum.
The area would yield only 200 pounds of rice or less.
... 12 hours a week or under.

2.269 Some of these expressions are used to show that a number is approximate and that the actual figure could be larger or smaller.

Here is a list of the expressions showing that a number is approximate:

Example 2.11.9. *about, approximately, around, odd, or so, or thereabouts, roughly, some, something like*

2.270 [i] You put *about, approximately, around, roughly, some*, and *something like* in front of a number.

Example 2.11.10. *About 85 students were there.*
Every year we have approximately 40 pupils who take mathematics.
It would cost around 35 million pounds.
A loft conversion costs roughly £12,000.
They have to pay America some $683,000 this year.
Harrington has cheated us out of something like 30,000 quid over the past 2 years.

You put *odd* and *or so* after a number or amount, and *or thereabouts* after an amount.

Example 2.11.11. *... a hundred odd acres.*
For half a minute or so, neither of them spoke.
Get the temperature to 30° *or thereabouts.*

2.271 You show a range of numbers using *between* and *and*, or *from* and *to*, or just *to*.

Example 2.11.12. *Most of the farms around here are between 4 and 5 hundred years old.*
My hospital groups contain from 10 to 20 patients.
... peasants owning 2 to 5 acres of land.

Note the use of *anything* before *between* and *from*, to emphasize how great the range is.

Example 2.11.13. *An average rate of anything between 25 and 60% is usual.*
It is a job that takes anything from 2 to 5 weeks.

2.12 Expanding the noun phrase

2.272 This section deals with structures that are used to add further information about the person or thing referred to.
These are called **qualifiers**.
The word that is qualified is usually a noun but can be an indefinite pronoun or *those*.
2.273 The structures that are dealt with in this section are

Example 2.12.1.

prepositional phrases

Example 2.12.2. *... a girl with red hair.*
... the man in the dark glasses.

*The use of prepositional phrases to expand the noun phrase is explained in paragraphs **2.275–2.290**.*

adjectives followed by phrases or clauses

Example 2.12.3. *... machinery capable of clearing rubble off the main roads.*
... the type of comments likely to provoke criticism.
... a concept inconceivable a hundred years earlier.

*The use of adjectives followed by phrases or clauses to expand the noun phrase is explained in paragraphs **2.291–2.292**.*

non-finite clauses

Example 2.12.4. *... a simple device to test lung function.*
... 2 of the problems mentioned above.
He gestured towards the 3 cards lying on the table.

*The use of non-finite clauses to expand the noun phrase is explained in paragraphs **2.293–2.301**.*

noun phrases giving further information about other noun phrases.
*This is explained in paragraph **2.302**.*

2.274 Some other structures are also used.
These are explained fully in other sections.
They include

- single words e.g. *galore* and *concerned*, which are explained in paragraphs **2.58–2.62**.
- relative clauses

  Example 2.12.5. *Shortly after the shooting, the man who had done it was arrested.*
  Where's that cake your mother made?

- place adverbs and time adverbials

  Example 2.12.6. *... down in the dungeon beneath.*
  ... a reflection of life today in England.

  Time adverbials are explained in Chap. 4 and adverbs of place are explained in paragraphs **6.53–6.72**.

2.12.1 Nouns with prepositional phrases

2.275 In general, any prepositional phrase that describes classifies something can be used directly after a noun or pronoun.

Example 2.12.7. *... the main in charge.*
... a film about 4 men on holiday.
She reached into the room behind her.

2.276 In particular, there are several kinds of prepositional phrase that are usually only used in this way.
Of these, prepositional phrases beginning with *of* are the most numerous.
Others include certain uses of *with, in* and *by*.
2.277 Many nouns referring to things and actions can be expanded by using prepositional phrases beginning with *of* after them.
This allows the noun to be expanded with a wide range of meanings.

You can use *of* with nouns referring to feelings e.g. *love* and *fear* to show what the feeling relates to; e.g., *fear of lying* and *love of animals*.

Further meanings are described in the following paragraphs.

2.278 [!] **Personal pronouns** are not usually placed after *of*.

E.g., you cannot say *Joyce was the daughter of him* or *the pages of it*.

Possessive determiners are used instead to show possession.

These are explained in paragraphs **1.194–1.210**.

2.279 Prepositional phrases beginning with *of* can be used to show what something consists of.

Example 2.12.8. *... a letter of confirmation.*
... strong feelings of jealousy.

They can also be used to show what the subject matter of something is.

Example 2.12.9. *... a picture of a house.*
... Gretchen's account of her interview with Nichols.
... the idea of death.

2.280 Prepositional phrases beginning with *of* can be used to say that something belongs to or is associated with someone or something.

Example 2.12.10. *Cental is a trademark of Monotore Ltd.*
No.28 was the town house of Sir Winston Churchill.
James is the son of a Methodist minister.
The acting ability of the pupils is admirable.
... the beauty of the Welsh landscape.
4 boys sat on the floor of the living room.
Ellen aimlessly turned the pages of her magazine.

Note that apostrophe *s* ('s) structures are much more frequently used to say that something belongs to someone or something.

Apostrophe *s* ('s) is explained in paragraphs **1.211–1.222**.

2.281 Prepositional phrases beginning with *of* can be used to say that someone or something has a particular quality.

Example 2.12.11. *... a woman of energy and ambition.*
... problems of varying complexity.
... a flower of monstrous proportions.
A household of this size inevitably has problems.

Of can also be used in front of a number to indicate someone's age.

Example 2.12.12. *... a woman of 22.*
... a child of 6.

Other ways of talking about age are explained in paragraphs **2.258–2.263**.

2.282 Prepositional phrases beginning with *of* can be used with nouns referring to an action to show who or what is performing the action.

Example 2.12.13. *... the arrival of the police.*
... the growth of modern industry.

They are also used to show who or what someone does something to.

E.g., if you are talking about people who support a scheme, you can call them *the supporters of the scheme*.

Example 2.12.14. *... supporters of the hunger strike.*
... critics of the Trade Union Movement.
... the creator of the universe.
... a student of English.
... the cause of the tragedy.

Of structures can also used to indicate the thing affected by an action.

Example 2.12.15. *... the destruction of their city.*
... the dismissal of hundreds of workers.

2.283 Prepositional phrases beginning with *of* and containing measurement are used to show how great an area, speed, distance, or temperature is.

Example 2.12.16. *There were fires burning over a total area of about 600 square miles.*
It can barely maintain a speed of 25 kilometers an hour.
... an average annual temperature of 20°.

Ways of measuring things are explained in paragraphs **2.250–2.257**.

2.284 Prepositional phrases beginning with *with* can be used to say that someone or something has a particular characteristic, feature, or possession.

Example 2.12.17. *... a girl with red hair.*
... a girl with a foreign accent.
... a big car with reclining seats.
... a man with a violent temper.
... the man with the gun.
... those with large families.

They are also used to indicate what something has on or in it.

Example 2.12.18. *... a sheet of paper with writing on it.*
... a round box with some buttons in it.
... a white, plain envelope with her name printed on it.
... fragments of wrapping paper with bits of sticky tape still adhering to them.

2.285 Prepositional phrases beginning with *in* can be used to say what someone is wearing.

Example 2.12.19. *... a grey-haired man in a raincoat.*
... the man in the dark glasses.
... little groups of people in black.

2.286 Prepositional phrases beginning with *by* can be used after a noun referring to an action to say who or what is performing it.

Example 2.12.20. *... his appointment by the King.*
... the compression of air by the piston.

2.287 Some nouns, especially abstract nouns, need to be followed by a prepositional phrase to show what they relate to. There is often little or no choice about which preposition to use after a particular noun.

Example 2.12.21. *He has an allergy to peanuts.*
... his authority over them.
... the solution to our energy problem.
... the bond between mother and child.

2.288 Here is a list of nouns that usually or often have *to* after them:

Example 2.12.22. *access, addiction, adherence, affront, allegiance, allergy, allusion, alternative, answer, antidote, approach, attachment, aversion, contribution, damage, devotion, disloyalty, exception, fidelity, incitement, introduction, preface, prelude, recourse, reference, relevance, reply, resistance, return, sequel, solution, susceptibility, testimony, threat, vulnerability, witness*

Here is a list of nouns that usually or often have *for* after them:

Example 2.12.23. *admiration, appetite, aptitude, bid, craving, credit, cure, demand, desire, disdain, dislike, disregard, disrespect, hunger, love, need, provision, quest, recipe, regard, remedy, respect, responsibility, room, search, substitute, sympathy, synonym, taste, thirst, demand*

Here is a list of nouns that usually or often have *on* after them:

Example 2.12.24. *assault, attack, ban, claim, comment, concentration, constraint, crackdown, curb, dependence, effect, embargo, hold, insistence, reflection, reliance, restriction, stance, tax*

Here is a list of nouns that usually or often have *with* after them:

Example 2.12.25. *affinity, collision, collusion, connection, contrast, correspondence, date, dealings, dissatisfaction, encounter, familiarity, identification, intersection, intimacy, involvement, link, parity, quarrel, relationship, sympathy*

Here is a list of nouns that are usually followed by 1 of 2 prepositions.
The list indicates the choice of prepositions available:

Example 2.12.26. *agreement about/on, argument against/for, battle against/for, case against/for, debate about/on, decision about/on, transition from/to*

Here is a list of other nouns that are usually followed by a preposition.

Example 2.12.27. *complex about, crime against, grudge against, insurance against, reaction against, safeguard against, anger at, bond between, departure from, escape from, excerpt from, freedom from, quotation from, foray into, relapse into, awareness of, authority over, control over*

As you can see from the lists and examples given above, it is often the case that words with a similar meaning are typically followed by the same preposition.
E.g., *appetite, craving, desire, hunger*, and *thirst* are all followed by *for*.
2.289 [i] Some nouns are related to verbs that are always or often followed by a particular preposition.
These nouns are followed by the same preposition as their related verbs, and they are used to indicate the thing that is affected by the action.
E.g., *to* is used after both the verb *refer* and the related noun *reference*.

Example 2.12.28. *We have already referred to this phenomenon.*
... reverent references to the importance of home.
They swim about busily searching for food.
... the search for food.
I want to escape from here.
... an escape from reality.

2.290 Some nouns referring to a feeling or state are related to an adjective that is usually followed by a preposition.
These nouns are followed by the same preposition as their related adjectives.
E.g., *of* is used after the adjective *aware* and the related noun *awareness*.

Example 2.12.29. *She was quite aware of her current situation.*
... the public's increasing awareness of the problems.
He was angry at Sally Gardner for accusing him.
... her anger at the kids.

2.12.2 Nouns with adjectives

2.291 When adjectives are used in clauses after nouns or pronouns to expand their meaning they can be followed by

- prepositional phrases

  Example 2.12.30. *... a warning to people eager for a quick cure.*
  those responsible for the project.

- a *to*-infinitive

  Example 2.12.31. *... remarks likely to cause offence.*
  It has been directed against those least able to retaliate.

- expression of time or place

  Example 2.12.32. *... a concept inconceivable 100 years earlier.*
  For the facilities available here, I must ask for a fee.

Note that you can use adjectives as qualifiers when they are preceded by time or measurement expressions.

Example 2.12.33. *... those still alive.*
... a small hill about 400 feet high.

Note also that a few adjectives, e.g. *present* and *responsible*, can be used on their own after a noun or pronoun.

The use of these adjectives is explained in paragraphs **2.58**–**2.62**.

2.292 There are some other structures, especially those that indicate comparison, degree, or result, that often involve a qualifying structure.

In particular, some words that modify adjectives, e.g. *more, too*, or *so*, often have a qualifying structure to complete their meaning.

Example 2.12.34. *Peter came in, more excited than anyone had seen him before.*
Ralph was too angry to think clearly.
... steel cylinders strong enough to survive a nuclear catastrophe.
... a grand piano as big as 2 coffins.
She was so ill that she couldn't eat.
Technology has made such spectacular advances that it is difficult to keep up.

The use of comparative adjectives plus *than* after noun phrases is explained in paragraphs **2.106**–**2.108**.

Other ways of comparing things are explained in paragraphs **2.123**–**2.139**.

The use of *so... that* and *such... that* is explained in paragraphs **8.58**–**8.63**.

2.12.3 Nouns followed by *to*-infinitive, *-ed* participle, or *-ing* participle: *something to eat, a girl called Patricia, a basket containing eggs*

2.293 The following **non-finite** clauses (= clauses containing a verb that has no tense) can be used to expand the meaning of a noun: *to*-infinitive clauses (see paragraphs **2.294**–**2.299**), *-ed* participle clauses (see paragraph **2.300**), and *-ing* participle clauses (see paragraph **2.301**).

2.294 A *to*-infinitive clause is often placed after nouns in order to show what the thing referred to is intended to do.

Example 2.12.35. *The government of Mexico set up a programme to develop new varieties of wheat.*
They need people to work in the factories.

2.295 You can refer to something or someone that should or can have something done to them by using a clause containing a *to*-infinitive after a noun or indefinite pronoun.

Example 2.12.36. *I make notes in the back of my diary of things to be mended or replaced.*
... When I've had something to eat.

You can also use a clause consisting of a *to*-infinitive followed by a preposition.

Example 2.12.37. *There wasn't even a chair to sit on.*
He had nothing to write with.

2.296 You can also use a *to*-infinitive clause when you want to say that you are talking about, e.g., the 1st, oldest, or only person who did something.

Example 2.12.38. *... the 1st woman to be elected to the council.*

2.297 A clause containing a *to*-infinitive is used after some abstract nouns to show what action they relate to.

Example 2.12.39. *... people who didn't have the opportunity to go to university.*

2.298 [i] Many of these nouns are related to verbs or adjectives that are also often followed by *to*-infinitive clauses.

E.g., a *to*-infinitive clause is used after both the verb *need* and the noun *need*, and after both the adjective *able* and the related noun *ability*.

Example 2.12.40. *I need to borrow 5000 dollars.*
... the need to preserve secrecy about their intentions.
It failed to grow.

2.299 Here is a list of nouns that usually or often have a *to*-infinitive clause after them:

Example 2.12.41. *ability, attempt, bid, chance, compulsion, desire, disinclination, failure, inability, inclination, need, opportunity, readiness, reason, refusal, unwillingness, urge, way, willingness*

2.300 A clause containing an *-ed* participle can be used directly after a noun to show that something has been produced or affected by an action.

Example 2.12.42. *... a girl called Patricia.*
... dresses made of paper.
... 2 of the problems mentioned above.
... a story written by a 9-year-old girl.

2.301 A clause containing an *-ing* participle can be used directly after a noun to show that someone or something is doing something.

Example 2.12.43. *He gestured towards the 3 cards lying on the table.*
... a wicker shopping-basket containing groceries.

2.302 You can give further information about someone or something by using a noun phrase that describes them or identifies them.

If you put this noun phrase after the main noun phrase, a comma is almost always put after the main noun phrase because the 2nd noun phrase is separate from it, not part of it.

Example 2.12.44. *... the bald eagle, the symbol of America.*
... David Beckham, a 1st-class football player.
Her mother, a Canadian, died when she was 6.

If you put this noun phrase before the main noun phrase, you can sometimes choose whether to use a comma to separate the 2 noun phrases or not.

Example 2.12.45. *... Joan's husband, Jim Inglis.*
... my husband George.

Chapter 3

Making a message: types of verb

3.1 When you make a statement, you use a **clause**.

A clause that is used to make a statement contains a **noun phrase**, which refers to the person or thing that you are talking about, and a **verb phrase**, which shows what short of action, process, or state you are talking about.

The noun phrase, which usually comes in front of the verb, is called the **subject** or the verb or the clause.

E.g., in the clause *Ellen laughed, Ellen* is the subject.

The information of noun phrases is explained in **Chaps. 1–2**.

A verb phrase used in a statement has a particular form, and shows agreement with number and person.

The formation of verb phrases is explained in the Reference section.

Quite often in statements the verb phrase is a single word, and it is quite common to talk about the *verb* of a clause.

This chapter deals mainly with the use of the verbs in **active** clauses, where the subject is the performer of an action rather than the person or thing affected by an action.

The use of verbs in **passive** clauses, where the subject is the person or thing affected, is explained in paragraphs **9.8–9.24**.

3.1 Show who is involved

3.2 If an action or event involves only 1 person or thing, you mention only the performer of the action (the subject) and the action (the verb).

Example 3.1.1. *The girl screamed.*
I waited.
An awful thing has happened.

Verbs like this are called **intransitive verbs**.

However, you can then mention another person or thing that is involved using a **prepositional phrase**.

Example 3.1.2. *She walked across the street.*

Intransitive verbs are explained in paragraphs **3.8–3.13**.

3.3 If the action or event involves another person or thing that the action affects, relates to, or produces, you put a noun phrase referring to them after the verb.

This is called the **object** of the verb.

If it is necessary to distinguish it from other objects, it is called the **direct object**.

Example 3.1.3. *He closed the door.*
I hate sport.
Some of the women noticed me.

Verbs like this are called **transitive verbs**.

Transitive verbs are explained in paragraphs **3.14–3.25**.

Reflexive verbs and **delexical verbs** are special kinds of transitive verbs.

They are explained in paragraphs **3.26–3.31** and **3.32–3.45**.

3.4 The majority of verbs in English give you the option of presenting an event either as involving the subject only, or as involving the subject and someone or something else as a direct object.

Example 3.1.4. *She paints by holding the brush in her teeth.*
Yarkov paints vivid portraits of friends and acquaintances.
Gus asked me whether I'd like to have dinner with him. I accepted.
I accepted the invitation.

This means that most verbs can be used with or without an object.
Verbs that can be used like this are explained in paragraphs **3.46–3.54**.
With some verbs, the thing affected by the action can be put as the object of the verb or as the object of a preposition after the verb.
These verbs are explained in paragraphs **3.55–3.58**.
Ergative verbs are a special kind of verb that can be used with or without an object.
They are explained in paragraphs **3.59–3.67**.
3.5 **Reciprocal verbs** refer to actions that involve people affecting each other in the same way with the same action.
There are 2 types of **reciprocal verb**.
1 type is used either with or without an object.

Example 3.1.5. *We met at Hargreaves' place.*
I had met him in Zermatt.

The other type is used without an object, and with or without a prepositional phrase mentioning 1 of the participants.

Example 3.1.6. *We argued over this question for a long time.*
I argued with this man for half an hour.

Reciprocal verbs are explained in paragraphs **3.68–3.72**.
3.6 Some transitive verbs also allow you to mention a person who benefits from an action or receives something as a result.
The verb is then followed by both a direct object and an **indirect object**.

Example 3.1.7. *Hand me my bad.*
His uncle had given him books on India.
She sends you her love.
She passed him his cup.

Verbs that can take an indirect object as well as a direct object are explained in paragraphs **3.73–3.82**.
3.7 Some verbs have 2 or 3 parts.
These are **phrasal verbs** and **compound verbs**.
Phrasal verbs are explained in paragraphs **3.83–3.116**, and compound verbs are explained in paragraphs **3.117–3.125**.

3.1.1 Intransitive verbs: talking about events that involve only the subject

3.8 When you are talking about an action or event that does not have an object, you use an **intransitive verb**.

Example 3.1.8. *Her whole body ached.*
Such people still exist.
My condition deteriorated.

Many intransitive verbs describe physical behavior or making of sounds.

Example 3.1.9. *Bob coughed.*
Vicki wept bitterly.
The gate squeaked.

3.9 Here is a list of verbs that are normally used without an object and that usually or often have no adverb or prepositional phrase after them:

Example 3.1.10. *ache, advance, arise, arrive, bleed, blush, cease, collapse, cough, crackle, cry, decay, depart, deteriorate, die, digress, dine, disappear, disintegrate, doze, droop, economize, elapse, ensue, erupt, evaporate, exist, expire, faint, fall, falter, fidget, flinch, flourish, fluctuate, gleam, growl, happen, hesitate, howl, itch, kneel, laugh, moan, occur, pause, persist, prosper, quiver, recede, relent, rise, roar, scream, shine, shiver, sigh, sleep, slip, smile, snarl, sneeze, snore, snort, sob, sparkle, speak, squeak, squeal, stink, subside, sulk, surrender, swim, throb, tingle, vanish, vary, vibrate, wait, waver, weep, wilt, work, yawn*

A few of these verbs are used with an object in idioms or with very specific objects, but they are intransitive in all their common meanings.

3.10 Many intransitive verbs always or typically have an adverb or prepositional phrase after them.

With some, only a prepositional phrase beginning with a particular preposition is possible.

This use of a preposition allows something affected by the action to be mentioned, as the object of the preposition.

Example 3.1.11. *Everything you see here belongs to me.*
Landlords often resorted to violence.
I sympathized with them.
I'm relying on Bill.
He strives for excellence in all things.

3.11 Here is a list of verbs that always or typically have a particular preposition after them when they are used with a particular meaning:

Example 3.1.12. *rave about*
insure against, plot against, react against
hint at
alternate between, differentiate between, oscillate between
appeal for, atone for, care for, clamor for, hope for, long for, opt for, pay for, qualify for, strive for, yearn for
detract from, emanate from, emerge from, radiate from, shrink from, stem from, suffer from
believe in, consist in, culminate in, dabble in, indulge in, invest in, result in, wallow in
lapse into
complain of, conceive of, consist of, despair of, learn of, smack of, think of, tire of
bet on, feed on, insist on, spy on, trample on
adhere to, allude to, amount to, appeal to, aspire to, assent to, attend to, belong to, bow to, cling to, defer to, dictate to, lead to, listen to, object to, refer to, relate to, resort to, revert to, stoop to
alternate with, associate with, consort with, contend with, flirt with, grapple with, sympathize with, teem with

Here is a list of verbs that can have either of 2 prepositions after them with the same or very similar meaning:

Example 3.1.13. *abound in/with, cater for/to, conform to/with, contribute to/towards, depend on/upon, dote on/upon, embark on/upon, end in/with, engage in/on, enthuse about/over, gravitate to/towards, hunger after/for, improve on/upon, liaise between/with, lust after/for, prevail on/upon, profit by/from, rely on/upon, revolve around/round, spring from/out of*

Note that some intransitive verbs can be used in the passive when they are followed by a preposition.

See paragraph **9.23**.

3.12 Other verbs can be followed by a variety of prepositional phrases, or an adverb, often relating to time or place.

Verbs of movements are usually or often followed by adverbs or phrases relating to direction.

Example 3.1.14. *He went back to his own room.*
I traveled south.

Here is a list of verbs of movement:

Example 3.1.15. *come, crawl, creep, drift, flow, gallop, glide, go, hurtle, plunge, run, soar, spring, stroll, travel, walk*

Look, gaze, glance, and *stare* are also followed by adverbs or phrases relating to direction.

Verbs of position are usually followed by adverbs or phrases relating to position.

Example 3.1.16. *Donald was lying on the bed.*
She lives in Lausanne.
I used to live here.

Here is a list of verbs of position:

Example 3.1.17. *be, belong, hand, lie, live, be located, remain, sit, be situated, stand, stay*

Verbs e.g. *extend* or *stretch* are followed by adverbs or phrases relating to extent.

Example 3.1.18. *... an area stretching from London to Cambridge.*

There are a few verbs that are always followed by other types of adverb or phrase.

Example 3.1.19. *It behaves rather like a squirrel.*
My brother agreed to act as a go-between.
I hoped that the absorption of poison hadn't progressed too far.

Here is a list of verbs that are always followed by other types of adverb or phrase:

Example 3.1.20. *act, behave, campaign, progress*

3.13 There are a few verbs that are usually intransitive but that can be transitive when they are used with 1 particular object.
The object is usually directly related to the verb.
E.g., *smile* is usually used without an object, but you can use it with the noun *smile*.
E.g., *He smiled a patient smile* is a literary alternative to saying *He smiled patiently*.
The focus is on the type of smile rather than on the act of smiling.

Example 3.1.21. *Steve smiled his thin, cruel smile.*
He appears to have lived the life of any other rich gentleman.
Alice laughed a scornful laugh.
I once dreamed a very nice dream about you.

Here is a list of verbs that can only be used with an object when the object is directly related to the verb:

Example 3.1.22. *dance (a dance), die (a death), dream (a dream), laugh (a laugh), live (a life), sigh (a sigh), smile (a smile)*

A more common way of focusing on the noun phrase is to use a **delexical verb** e.g. *give, take*, or *have*, as in *Mary gave him a really lovely smile*.
See paragraphs **3.32–3.45** for more information about the use of delexical verbs.

3.1.2 Transitive verbs: involving someone or something other than the subject

3.14 Many verbs describe events that must, in addition to the subject, involve someone or something else.
Some of these verbs can only be used with a following object.

Example 3.1.23. *The extra profit justifies the investment.*
He had committed a disgraceful action.
They are employing more staff.

This means that they are followed by a direct object.

Example 3.1.24. *She had friends.*
Children seek independence.
The trial raised a number of questions.

3.15 Many verbs that are only used with an object can take a large range of objects.
E.g., there are many things you can *want*: money, a rest, success, and so on.

Example 3.1.25. *She wanted some help.*
I put my hand on the door.
She described her background.
I still support the government.
He had always liked Mr Phillips.
Japan has a population of about a hundred million.

Some transitive verbs have a restricted range of objects, because of their meaning.
E.g., the object of the verb *kill* must be something that is alive.
The object of the verb *waste* must be something you ca use, e.g. time, money, or food.

Example 3.1.26. *They killed huge elephants with tiny poisoned darts.*
Why waste money on them?

3.16 Here is a list of verbs that are transitive:

Example 3.1.27. *achieve, address, admire, affect, afford, avoid, bear, believe, blame, build, buy, calm, carry, catch, claim, commit, complete, concern, consider, control, convince, correct, cover, create, cut, damage, defy, demand, describe, design, desire, destroy, discover, discuss, display, do, dread, enjoy, equal, exchange, expect, experience, express, favor, fear, fill, find, free, get, give, grant, guard, handle, hate, have, hear, heat, hire, hit, include, influence, introduce, issue, justify, keep, kill, know, lack, like, list, love, lower, maintain, make, mean, mention, name, need, own, plant, please, prefer, prevent, process, produce, pronounce, protect, provide, raise, reach, receive, recommend, record, release, remember, remove, rent, report, respect, reveal, risk, see, seek, sell, shock, specify, spot, support, take, tease, test, threaten, trust, upset, use, value, want, waste, wear, welcome*

Note that *do* and *have* are also very often used as **auxiliaries**.
See the Reference section for this us.
Have got and *has got* are often used instead of the present tense of *have* when talking about possession.
The forms of *have* like auxiliaries when used like this before *got*.

Example 3.1.28. *I've got an umbrella.*
She's got a degree.

Measure and *weigh* are sometimes considered to be transitive verbs when used to state measurements and weights.
This use is explained in paragraph **2.252**.
Cost is used to state the cost of something, as in *An adult ticket costs 90p.*
3.17 When you are talking about something that affects a person rather than a thing, it is normal in English to say who that person is.
Therefore, verbs e.g. *anger, thank*, and *warn*, which involve affecting people, usually have a human object.

Example 3.1.29. *I tried to comfort her.*
Her sudden death had surprised everybody.
Blue suits you.
Money did not interest him very much.
Lebel briefed Caron on the events of th afternoon.

3.18 Here is a list of verbs that usually have a human object:

Example 3.1.30. *anger, brief, comfort, contact, frighten, interest, suit, surprise, tease, thank, trouble, warn*

3.19 With some transitive verbs, you have to give additional information about what is going on by using an adverb or prepositional phrase after the object.
Some verbs typically have a prepositional phrase beginning with a particular preposition after their object.

Example 3.1.31. *The judge based his decision on constitutional rights.*
He had subjected me to the pressure of financial ruin.
My parents still view me as a little boy.

Here is a list of verbs that always or usually have a particular preposition after their object:

Example 3.1.32. *regard as, view as*
mistake for, swap for
dissociate from, prevent from
deprive of, remind of, rid of, rob of
accustom to, ascribe to, attribute to, compare to, condemn to, confine to, consign to, dedicate to, entitle to, liken to, owe to, return to, subject to, subordinate to
acquaint with, associate with, confront with, engrave with, pelt with, ply with, trust with

With the following verbs, there is a choice of preposition:

Example 3.1.33. *divide by/into*
incorporate in/into
based on/upon, lavish on/upon
entrust to/with, equate to/with, present to/with, supply to/with

3.20 Other verbs are typically followed by an adverb or prepositional phrase, but not one containing a particular preposition.
The adverb or phrase often relates to place.

Example 3.1.34. *He placed the baby on the woman's lap.*
I positioned my chair outside the room.
He never puts anything away.
He treated his laborers with kindness.

Here is a list of verbs that usually have some kind of adverb or prepositional phrase after their object:

Example 3.1.35. *bring, chuck, convey, cram, direct, drag, escort, fling, hoist, job, jot, jay, lead, place, point, position, prop, put, rip, send, set, shove, smear, stick, store, throw, thrust, tie, treat*

For more on adverbs and phrases that follow verbs, see Chap. 6.

3.21 Note that some verbs of movement and position are transitive, not intransitive; they are followed by nouns referring to places rather than by adverbs or prepositional phrases.
This is because the verbs themselves show that you are talking about movement or position of a particular kind.
E.g., *enter* implies movement *into* a place and *occupy* implies position *in* a place.

Example 3.1.36. *He approached the house nervously.*
It was dark by the time they reached their house.
A small ornamental pool occupied the center of the room.
Everyone had left the room.

Here is a list of transitive verbs of movement:

Example 3.1.37. *approach, enter, leave, near, reach, round*

Here is a list of transitive verbs of position:

Example 3.1.38. *cover, crowd, fill, inhabit, occupy, throng*

Some verbs of movement can be followed either by a noun phrase or by a prepositional phrase.
See paragraph **3.58**.

3.22 [i] Note that even verbs that are almost always followed by an object can occasionally be used without an object.
This is possible in very restricted contexts.
E.g., if you are contrasting 2 actions, it is not necessary to say what else is involved.

Example 3.1.39. *Money markets are the places where people with money buy and sell.*
Some people build while others destroy.
We gave, they took.

If you use a list of different verbs for emphasis, you do not need to name the object.

Example 3.1.40. *They set out to be rude; to defy, threaten, or tease.*

If you repeat a verb in order to contrast it with a similar action, or to emphasize it, the object can be omitted.

Example 3.1.41. *She had ceased to love as she had once loved.*

3.23 Verbs that describe feelings and attitudes are sometimes used without an object, particularly in the ***to*-infinitive** form.
This is because the object is assumed to be people in general.
E.g., *please* usually requires an object, but you can say *He likes to please*, meaning he likes to please people.

Example 3.1.42. *He likes to shock.*
She was anxious to please.
He must be convinced if he is to convince.
I have a tendency to tease.

3.24 There is a large group of verbs, e.g. *say, suggest*, and *think*, which are used to report what people say or think.
They are called **reporting verbs**.
They are followed by a *that*-clause which is called the **reported clause**.

Example 3.1.43. *She said that she would come.*

The reported clause is often thought of as being an object, and so these verbs are usually said to be transitive verbs.

In this book, reporting verbs are explained in Chap. 7.

Reporting verbs e.g. *advise* and *persuade*, which have an object that refers to the person being addressed, are explained in paragraphs **7.75–7.76**.

Some reporting verbs can take as their object a noun e.g. *question* or *story* that refers to something that is said or written.

These verbs are listed in paragraph **7.82**.

Some take an object that refers to an event or fact, and is therefore closely related to a *that*-clause.

These are listed in paragraph **7.83**.

Verbs e.g. *believe* and *know* that can be used as reporting verbs, but that are ordinary transitive verbs when used with another common meaning, are included in the lists of transitive verbs given above.

3.25 Most transitive verbs can be used in the passive.

See paragraphs **9.9–9.21**.

3.1.3 Reflexive verbs: verbs where the object refers back to the subject

3.26 If you want to talk about a situation where the same person is involved as both the subject and the object of an action, you use a **reflexive pronoun** as the object of a clause.

E.g., it is common to blame someone else if something goes wrong, but you say *I blame myself for what happened* if you think that the mistake was your own fault.

Although a few verbs are typically used with reflexive pronouns, you can actually use a reflexive pronoun as the object of any transitive verb, when the meaning allows you to do so.

Example 3.1.44. *I blame myself for not paying attention.*
She freed herself from my embrace.
After the meeting, he introduced himself to me.
Why not buy a book and teach yourself?
Don't deceive yourself.
We must ask ourselves several questions.
Every country has the right to defend itself.

Reflexive pronouns are explained in paragraphs **1.111–1.118**.

3.27 Note that the verbs *busy, content*, and *pride* are true reflexive verbs: they must be used with a reflexive pronoun.

Example 3.1.45. *He had busied himself in the laboratory.*
Many scholars contented themselves with writing textbooks.
He prides himself on his tidiness.

3.28 Another small group of verbs only take an object that refers to a person when the object is a reflexive pronoun.

E.g., you can *express an opinion* and you can *express yourself* (meaning that you can put ideas into words), but you cannot *express a person.*

Example 3.1.46. *Prof. Baxendale expressed himself very forcibly.*
She enjoyed herself enormously.
He applied himself to learning how Parliament worked.

Here is a list of verbs that take a reflexive pronoun as their object when you refer to a person:

Example 3.1.47. *apply, compose, distance, enjoy, excel, exert, express, strain*

3.29 Some verbs that normally do not have objects, because they involve only the performer of the action, can have a reflexive pronoun as their object if you want to emphasize that the subject is doing something that affects himself or herself.

You can therefore say *Bill washed himself* rather than *Bill washed.*

Example 3.1.48. *I always wash 5 times a day.*
Children were encouraged to wash themselves.
I stood in the kitchen while he shaved.
He prefers to shave himself before breakfast.
Ashton had behaved abominably.
He is old enough to behave himself.
Successful companies know how to adapt to change.
You've got to be willing to adapt yourself.

Here is a list of verbs that have sense in which you can use a reflexive pronoun for emphasis:

Example 3.1.49. *acclimatize, adapt, behave, commit, dress, hide, move, readjust, shave, undress, wash*

3.30 [i] Note that reflexive pronouns are not used as much in English as in some other languages when talking about actions that you do to yourself.

As mentioned above, you would usually say *I washed* rather than *I washed myself* in English.

Sometimes a noun with a possessive is used instead.

E.g., you would say *I combed my hair* rather than *I combed myself*.

3.31 Note that reflexive verbs are not used in the passive.

3.1.4 Delexical verbs: verbs with little meaning

3.32 There are some very common verbs that are used with nouns as their object to show simply that someone performs an action, not that someone affects or creates something.

These verbs have very little meaning when they are used in this way.

E.g., *had* in *She had a shower* has very little meaning in itself.

Most of the meaning of the sentence is carried by the noun *shower*.

Example 3.1.50. *We were having a joke.*
Roger gave a grin of sheer delight.
He took a step towards Jack.

3.33 This section focuses on the very common verbs that are used in this transitive structure.

They are called **delexical verbs**.

Here is a list of verbs that are used as delexical verbs.

The 1st 4 are very commonly used in this way.

Example 3.1.51. *give, have, make, take*
do, hold, keep, set

Note that *have got* is not used as a delexical verb.

Structures containing delexical verbs are very common in English.

Although the total number of delexical verbs is small, it includes some of the most common words in the language.

3.34 In many cases, there is a verb that has a similar meaning to the meaning of the delexical verb + noun.

E.g., the verb *look* means almost the same as *have a look*.

When *look* is a verb, as in *I looked round the room*, you are focusing on the action of looking.

When you use *look* as a noun in a delexical structure, you are naming a event, something that is complete.

This structure often seems to be preferred.

Note that the verb corresponding to the delexical structure is often intransitive.

Example 3.1.52. *She made a signal.*
She signaled for a taxi.
A couple were having a drink at a table by the window.
A few students were drinking at the bar.
She gave an amused laugh.
They both laughed.
He gave a vague reply.
They replied to his letter.

There are also some verbs that are transitive.

Example 3.1.53. *Fans tried to get a glimpse of the singer.*
I glimpsed a bright flash of gold on the left.
He gave a little sniff.
She sniffed the air.
Comis took a photograph of her.
They photographed the pigeons in Trafalgar Square.

3.36 The noun that is the object of the delexical verb is often in the singular and is usually preceded by *a* or *an*.

Example 3.1.54. *She made a remark about the weather.*
She gave a cry when I came in.
I might take a stroll.

There are some countable nouns that are almost always used in the singular after a delexical verb.
Here is a list of these nouns:

Example 3.1.55. *cry, feel, grouse, grumble, need, read, smell, taste, try*

Note that these words are more commonly used as verbs in the language as a whole.
3.36 You can also use a delexical verb followed by a plural noun.

Example 3.1.56. *She took little sips of the cold drink.*
He took photographs of Vita in her summer house.
The newspaper made unpleasant remarks about his wife.

3.37 It is also occasionally possible to follow a delexical verb with an uncountable noun.

Example 3.1.57. *We have made progress in both science and art.*
Cal took charge of this side of their education.

3.38 1 difference in meaning between using a structure containing a delexical verb and a verb with a similar meaning is that the delexical structure can give the impression that the event you are describing is brief.
E.g., *She gave a scream* suggests that there was only 1 quick scream, whereas *She creamed* does not suggest that the event was brief.

Example 3.1.58. *Mr. Sutton gave a shout of triumph.*
Zoe gave a sigh of relief.
He gave a laugh.

3.39 Another reason for choosing a delexical structure is that you can add further details about the event by using adjectives in front of the noun, rather than by using adverbs.
It is more natural, e.g., to say *He gave a quick furtive glance round the room* than to say *He glanced quickly and furtively round the room.*

Example 3.1.59. *He gave a long lecture about Roosevelt.*
She had a good cry.
He was forced to make a humiliating apology.
These legends hold a romantic fascination for many Japanese.

3.40 There are some nouns used in delexical structures that do not correspond in form to a verb that has a similar meaning to the delexical structure.
Sometimes there is such a verb, but the form is slightly different.

Example 3.1.60. *Work experience allows students to make more effective career decisions.*
I decided I wouldn't resign after all.
He made the shortest speech I've ever heard.
Iain spoke candidly about the crash.

In other cases, there is no corresponding verb with a similar meaning at all and so there is no other structure that can be used.

Example 3.1.61. *He had been out all day taking pictures of the fighting.*
That is a very foolish attitude to take.
She made a number of relevant points.
Try not to make so much noise.

3.41 In most cases, only 1 delexical verb is used with any particular noun.
The following examples show nouns that are used after *have*.

Example 3.1.62. *They have a desperate need to communicate.*
They had a fundamental belief in their own superiority.
She had a good cry.
Let's not have a quarrel.
We should have a talk.

Here is a list of nouns that are used after *have*:

Example 3.1.63. *argument, belief, chat, cry, dance, disagreement, fall, fight, grouse, grumble, need, quarrel, respect, sleep, talk*

3.42 The following examples show nouns that are used after *take*.

Example 3.1.64. *He takes no interest in his children.*
... kids taking turns to use a playground slide.
He was taking no chances.
She was prepared to take great risks.
Davis took the lead in blaming the pilots.
The Government fought against suggestions that it should take full blame for the affair.

Here is a list of nouns that are used after *take*.
The 1st set of nouns are countable nouns; the 2nd set of nouns are uncountable nouns or always either singular or plural:

Example 3.1.65. *attitude, chance, decision, interest, photo, photograph, picture, risk, turn*
blame, care, charge, consequences, form, lead, offence, office, power, responsibility, shape, time, trouble

3.43 Many nouns can be used after *give*.
Some of these nouns refer to noises that people make, or expressions they make with their face.
Using *give* with 1 of these nouns often suggests that the action is involuntary or that it is not necessarily directed at other people.
E.g., *She gave a scream* suggests that she could not help screaming.

Example 3.1.66. *The young cashier gave a patient sigh.*
Roger gave a grin of sheer delight.
He gave a shrill gasp of shock.
Both of them gave an involuntary little giggle.
He gave a soft chuckle.

Here is a list of nouns that refer to noises people make, or expressions they make with their face:

Example 3.1.67. *chuckle, cry, gasp, giggle, grin, groan, laugh, scowl, scream, shout, shriek, sigh, smile, sniff, snigger, whistle, yell*

Another group of nouns are often preceded by an indirect object (i.e., an object that refers to the person or thing that received the action) because they describe activities that involve someone else, apart from the subject.

Example 3.1.68. *They gave us a wonderfully warm welcome.*
Elaine gave him a hug.
He gave her hand a squeeze.
He gave him a good kick.
She gave him a long kiss.

Here is a list of nouns that can be preceded by an indirect object:

Example 3.1.69. *clue, glance, hint, hug, kick, kiss, look, punch, push, ring, shove, slap, squeeze, welcome*

A 3rd group of nouns refer to actions involving something being said.

Example 3.1.70. *The poetry professor is required to give a lecture every term.*
Lord Young will be giving a 1st-hand account of the economic difficulties the Russians are struggling to overcome.
Senator Brown has given warning that conflict over the plans could lead to a constitutional crisis.

Here is a list of nouns that refer to actions involving something being said:

Example 3.1.71. *account, advice, answer, example, information, interview, lecture, news, reason, report, speech, summary, talk, thought, warning*

3.44 Many nouns can be used after *make*.
The delexical structures using a lot of these nouns are closely related to **reporting structures**, which are explained in Chap. 7.
There is usually a related verb that can be used followed by a reported clause.

Example 3.1.72. *She made a remark about the weather.*
Allen remarked that at times he thought he was back in America.
Now and then she makes a comment on something.
He commented that he was only doing his job.
I haven't made a full confession, sir.
Fox confessed that he had stolen the money.
The cricketers made a public protest against apartheid.
She protested that his comments were sexist.
I made a secret signal to him.
The Bank of England signaled that there would be no change in interest rates.
You made the right decision.
1 candidate resigned, deciding that banking was not for her.

Here is a list of nouns that are used after *make* and have a related reporting verb:

Example 3.1.73. *arrangement, claim, comment, confession, decision, promise, protest, remark, signal, suggestion*

Other nouns used with *make* express actions involving something being said, or describe change, results, effort, and so on.

Example 3.1.74. *I'll make some enquiries for you.*
They agreed to make a few minor changes.
They made an emotional appeal for their daughter's safe return.
He made an attempt to calm down.
He has made a significant contribution to the success of the business.

Here is a list of other nouns that are used after *make*:

Example 3.1.75. *appeal, attempt, change, charge, contribution, effort, enquiry, impression, noise, point, progress, recovery, sound, speech, start, success*

Note that, unlike the other nouns in this list, *progress* is uncountable.

3.45 There are some nouns that can be used after either *have* or *take*.

In general *have* is more common with these nouns in British English and *take* is more common in American English.

There is sometimes a slight difference in emphasis: using *have* puts more emphasis on the experience, and using *take* puts more emphasis on the performer of the action.

1 group of these nouns refer to physical activities.

Example 3.1.76. *I'd rather have a swim.*
Have a drink.
She decided to take a stroll along the beach.
I took a bath, my 2nd that day.

Here is a list of nouns that refer to physical activities:

Example 3.1.77. *bath, break, drink, holiday, jog, paddle, rest, run, shower, stroll, swim, vacation (*American*), walk*

Another group refer to actions that involve using our senses.

Example 3.1.78. *She should let a doctor have a look at you.*
Even Sally had a little sip of wine.
A Harvard scientist was once allowed in to have a peep.
Mark took a bite of meat.

Here is a list of nouns that refer to such actions:

Example 3.1.79. *bite, feel, look, peep, sip, smell, sniff, taste*

3.1.5 Verbs that can be used both with and without an object

3.46 There are several reasons why you can use verbs both with and without an object.

3.47 1 important reason for using verbs both with and without an object is that many verbs have more than 1 common meaning.

E.g., the verb *run* is used without an object when it is used in the sense *to move quickly.*

But *run* has an object when it is used in the sense *to manage* or *operate.*

Example 3.1.80. *She runs in order to keep fit.*
She runs a hotel.
She reflected for a moment and then decided to back out.
The figures reflected the company's attempts to increase its profile.
I can manage perfectly well on my own.
I can no longer manage my life.
She moved rather gracefully.
The whole incident had moved her profoundly.

3.48 Here is a list of verbs that can be used both with and without an object, depending on which meaning you are using:

Example 3.1.81. *add, aim, beat, blow, call, change, cheat, count, draw, dress, drive, escape, exercise, fit, fly, follow, hang, head, hold, hurt, leak, lose, manage, meet, miss, move, pass, play, point, press, propose, reflect, run, shoot, show, sink, spread, stand, stretch, strike, study, tend, touch, turn, win*

3.49 Many verbs in English can be used with or without an object, with the same basic meaning.

The object is not needed when it is obvious what type of thing you are talking about.

E.g., you could say either *She eats food slowly* or *She eats slowly.*

It is obvious in this context that what she eats is food, and so you only mention food if you want to emphasize the fact (which is unlikely), or if you want to say what kind of food she eats.

With verbs like these, you normally use an object only when you want to be specific or when you want to contrast what happened on 1 specific occasion with what happens normally.

E.g., you would say *I've been studying history*, as opposed to *I've been studying*, only if you want or need to mention the subject specifically, or if you normally study something else.

Example 3.1.82. *... a healthy person who eats sensibly.*
Twice a week he eats an apple for lunch.
He raised his own glass and drank.
He drank a good deal of coffee.
He had won, and she had helped.
She could help him to escape.
I cooked for about 8 directors.
She had never cooked dinner for anyone.
I washed and ironed for them.
She ironed my shirt.
Rudolph waved and went into the house.
She smiled and waved her hand.
She sat and typed.
She typed a letter to the paper in question.

You need to give the object when it is different from the one that people would normally associate with the verb.

E.g., *to wave* is usually interpreted as meaning to *wave your hand*, so if something else is being waved, you have to mention it.

Example 3.1.83. *He waved a piece of paper in his left hand.*
Charlie washed Susan's feet.

You also mention the object when you want to say something specific about it.

Example 3.1.84. *He washed his summer clothes and put them away.*
Bond waved a cheerful hand.
I could save quite a lot of money.

3.50 Here is a list of verbs that can be used without an object when it is obvious what sort of thing is involved:

Example 3.1.85. *borrow, change, clean, cook, draw, drink, drive, dust, eat, film, help, iron, learn, lend, marry, paint, park, point, read, ride, save, sing, smoke, spend, steal, study, type, wash, wave, write*

3.51 There is another group of verbs that usually have an object but that can be used without an object with the same meaning.

E.g., if you have already mentioned the place where something happened, you can say *I left*, without naming the place again.

Example 3.1.86. *At least she thanked them and left.*
He turned away an walked quickly up the passage. I locked the door and followed.
I was in the middle of a quiet meal when the tanks attacked.
She did not look round when he entered.
The sentry fired at the doctor and fortunately missed.
Only 200 or 300 men belonged to the Union before the wr, now thousands joined.

3.52 Here is a list of verbs that can be used without an object when the object has already been mentioned:

Example 3.1.87. *accept, aim, answer, approach, ask, attack, begin, bite, blow, board, call, check, choose, consider, direct, dry, enter, explain, fit, follow, forget, gain, guess, improve, join, judge, know, lead, leave, lose, mind, miss, move, notice, observe, offer, order, pass, phone, play, produce, pull, push, remember, ring, rule, search, serve, share, sign, strike, telephone, understand, watch, win*

3.53 If you think that the object may not be obvious from what has been said or if you particularly want to draw attention to it, you mention it.

Example 3.1.88. *All I know is that Michael and I never left the house.*
Miss Lindley followed Rose into the shop.
They were unaware they had attacked a British warship.
A man entered the shop and demanded money.
She threw the 1st dart and missed the board altogether.
I had joined an athletic club in Chicago.

3.54 There are not many verbs that always have an object or never have an object.

The decision about whether or not to mention an object is left to the users.

If they think that the people reading or listening to them will have no difficulty in working out what person or thing is affected by the action, then they can leave out the object.

If they think that this will not be clear, they will use an object in order to prevent misunderstanding.

The main reasons for omitting the object are that it is obvious from the meaning of the verb itself, or that it is obvious from what has already been said.

3.1.6 Verbs that can take an object or a prepositional phrase

3.55 There is a small group of verbs that can be followed by either an object or a prepositional phrase.

The verb *fight* is 1 of these verbs, so that, e.g., you can say *He fought the enemy* or *He fought against the enemy.*

Example 3.1.89. *The Polish Army fought the Germans for nearly 5 weeks.*
He was fighting against history.
The New Zealand rugby team played South Africa's Springboks.
In his youth, Thomas played against Glamorgan.

3.56 There is usually little difference in meaning between using the verb on its own and following it with a preposition.

E.g., there is very little difference in meaning between *brush* and *brush against, gnaw* and *gnaw at*, and *hiss* and *hiss at* in the following examples.

Example 3.1.90. *Her arm brushed my cheek.*
Something brushed against the back of the shelter.
Rabbits often gnaw the woodwork of their cages.
Insects had been gnawing at the wood.
They hissed the Mayor at the ceremony.
Frederica hissed at him.

3.57 Here is a list of verbs that can be use with an object or a prepositional phrase, with little difference in meaning:

Example 3.1.91. *boo (at), brush (against), check (on), distinguish (between), enter (for), fight (against/with), gain (in), gnaw (at), hiss (at), infiltrate (into), jeer (at), juggle (with), mock (at), mourn (for), nibble (at), play (against), rule (over), sip (at), sniff (at), tug (at), twiddle (with)*

3.58 Many of the verbs that can take an object or a prepositional phrase are verbs, e.g. *wander* and *cross*, that describe physical movement.

The preposition is one that indicates place, and so allows you to emphasize the physical position of the subject in relation to the object.

Example 3.1.92. *He wandered the halls of the Art Institute.*
He wandered through the streets of New York.
I crossed the Mississippi.
The car had crossed over the river to Long Island.
We climbed the mountain.
I climbed up the tree.

Here is a list of verbs that describe movement, and examples of the prepositions that can follow them:

Example 3.1.93. *chase (after), climb (up), cross (over), jump (over), leap (over), reach (across), roam (over/through), run (across), skirt (round), walk (through), wander (through)*

3.1.7 Changing your focus by changing the subject: *I opened the door, The door opened*

3.59 Some verbs allow you to describe an action from the point of view of the performer of the action or from the point of view of something that is affected by the action.

This means that the same verb can be used with an object, or without an object, and without the original performer being mentioned.

In the 1st example below, *the door* is the object of the verb *opened*, but in the 2nd example *the door* is the subject of *opened* and there is no mention of who opened the door.

Example 3.1.94. *I opened the door and peered into the room.*
Suddenly the door opened.
An explosion shook the rooms.
The whole room shook.

Note that the object of the transitive verb, which is the subject of the intransitive verb, usually refers to a thing, not a person.

Verbs that can have the same thing as their object, when transitive, or their subject, when intransitive, are called **ergative verbs**.

There are several hundred ergative verbs in regular use in current English.

3.60 Many ergative verbs describe events that involve a change from 1 state to another.

Example 3.1.95. *He was slowing his pace.*
She was aware that the aircraft's taxiing pace had slowed.
I shattered the glass.
Wine bottles had shattered all over the pavement.
They have closed the town's only pub.
The firm has changed its name.
Over the next few months their work pattern changed.
The driver stopped the car.
A big car stopped.

3.61 Here is a list of ergative verbs that describe events involving a change of some kind:

Example 3.1.96. *age, begin, bend, bleach, break, burn, burst, change, close, continue, crack, darken, decrease, diminish, disperse, double, drown, dry, empty, end, fade, finish, grow, improve, increase, open, quicken, rot, shatter, shrink, shut, slow, split, spread, start, stick, stop, stretch, tear, thicken, widen, worsen*

3.62 There are many other ergative verbs that relate specifically to certain areas of meaning.

E.g., some relate to food and cooking, others describe physical movement, and others involve a vehicle as the object of the transitive verb or the subject of the intransitive verb.

Example 3.1.97. *I've boiled an egg.*
The porridge is boiling.
I'm cooking spaghetti.
The rice is cooking.
The birds turned their heads sharply at the sound.
Vorster's head turned.
She rested her head on his shoulder.
Her head rested on the edge of the table.
She had crashed the car twice.
Pollock's car crashed into a clump of trees.

3.63 Here is a list of verbs relating to food, physical movement, and vehicles:

Example 3.1.98. *bake, boil, cook, defrost, fry, melt, roast, simmer, thicken*
balance, drop, move, rest, rock, shake, spin, stand, steady, swing, turn
back, crash, drive, fly, park, reverse, run, sail

3.64 Note that some verbs are used ergatively with 1 or 2 nouns only.
E.g., you can say *He fired a gun* or *The gun fired.*
You can also say *He fired a bullet*, but you would not normally say *The bullet fired.*

Example 3.1.99. *I rang the bell.*
The bell rang.
A car was sounding its horn.
A horn sounded in the night.
He had caught his sleeve on a splinter of wood.
The hat caught on a bolt and tore.

3.65 Here is a list of verbs that can be used ergatively with the noun, or type of noun, that is given:

Example 3.1.100. *catch (an article of clothing), fire (a gun, rifle, pistol), play (music), ring (a bell, the alarm), show (an emotion e.g. fear, anger), sound (a horn, the alarm)*

3.66 There are a few ergative verbs that usually have an adverb or some other phrase or clause when they are used intransitively.
This is because you choose this structure when you want to emphasize how something behaves when affected in some way, and so the person who does the action is not important.

Example 3.1.101. *I like the new Range Rover. It handles beautifully.*
Wool washes well if you treat it carefully.

Here is a list of ergative verbs that are usually followed by some extra information when they are used intransitively:

Example 3.1.102. *clean, freeze, handle, mark, polish, sell, stain, wash*

3.67 Note that ergative verbs perform a similar function to the **passive** because they allow you to avoid mentioning who or what does the action.
E.g., you could say *Jane froze a lot of peas from the garden.*
If you were not interested in who froze them but in what she froze, you could say *A lot of peas were frozen*, using the passive.
If you were interested in how they froze, you could say, *The peas from the garden froze really well*, making use of the fact that the verb is ergative.
For information about the **passive**, see **9.8**–**9.24**.

3.1.8 Verbs that involve people affecting each other with the same action: *John & Mary argued*

3.68 Some verbs can describe processes that involve 2 people or 2 groups of people doing the same thing to each other.
E.g., *John and Mary argued* means that John argued with Mary and Mary argued with John.

Example 3.1.103. *The pair of you have argued about that for years.*
He came out and we hugged.
They competed furiously.

These verbs are called **reciprocal verbs**.

3.69 1 of the structures in which you use reciprocal verbs is where the 2 groups are put together in a plural subject and the verb is then used without an object.

Example 3.1.104. *Their faces touched.*
Their children are always fighting.
They kissed.

3.70 When you want to emphasize that both participants are equally involved in the action, you put *each other* or *one another* after the verb.

Example 3.1.105. *We embraced each other.*
They kissed each other in greeting.
They fought each other desperately for it.
The 2 boys started hitting one another.

Here is a list of reciprocal verbs that are us transitively with the pronouns *each other* and *one another*:

Example 3.1.106. *consult, cuddle, embrace, engage, fight, hug, kiss, marry, match, meet, touch*

With some verbs you need to use a preposition, usually *with*, in front of *each other* or *one another*.

Example 3.1.107. *You've got to be able to communicate with each other.*
3rd World countries are competing with each other for a restricted market.
The 2 actors began to engage with one another.

Here is a list of reciprocal verbs that must be followed by *with* before the pronouns *each other* and *one another*.

Example 3.1.108. *agree, alternate, argue, balance, clash, coincide, collide, combine, communicate, conflict, consult, contend, contrast, converse, co-operate, disagree, engage, integrate, mate, merge, mix, quarrel, struggle*

Here is a list of verbs that can be used with a preposition other than *with*:

Example 3.1.109. *compete (against/with), correspond (to/with), fight (against/with), part (from), relate (to), separate (from), talk (to/with)*

Note that *consult, engage*, and *fight* can be used either with an object or with a preposition.

3.71 In the examples given above, the speaker or writer believes that both people or groups are equally involved in the event, because both are the subject.

However, the user may want to focus on 1 person more than the other.

In this case, a noun that refers to that person is put in subject position.

If the verb can be used with an object, a noun referring to the other participant is used as the object of the verb.

Example 3.1.110. *He embraced her.*
She married a young engineer.
You could meet me at a restaurant.
He is responsible for killing many people.

If the verb needs a preposition after it, the other noun is used as the object of the preposition.

Example 3.1.111. *Our return coincided with the arrival of bad weather.*
Youths clashed with police in Belfast.
The distribution of aid corresponds to need.

3.72 People sometimes make 1 person or group the subject when the event is a violent or unpleasant one, in order to make them appear aggressive or responsible for the violence.

E.g., the headline *Police clash with youths* might suggest that the police were responsible for the clash, even though the youths also clashed with the police.

Example 3.1.112. *Paul collided with a large man in a sweat-stained shirt.*
The role of worker conflicts with the role of parent.
She liked him even when she was quarreling with him.

3.1.9 Verbs that can have 2 objects: *give someone something*

3.73 Sometimes you may want to talk about an event that involves someone in addition to the people or things that are the subject and object of the clause.

This 3rd participant is someone who benefits from the action or receives something as a result.

They become the **indirect object** of the clause.

The **direct object**, as usual, is the person or thing that something is done to.

E.g., in *I gave John a book, John* is the indirect object and *the book* is the direct object.

The indirect object is put immediately after the verb, in front of the direct object.

Example 3.1.113. *Dad gave me a car.*
Can you pass me the sugar please?
She brought me a boiled egg and toast.
He had lent Tim the money.
A man promised him a job.
The distraction provided us a chance to relax. (Am)

3.74 Instead of putting the indirect object in front of the direct object, it is possible to put it in a phrase beginning with *to* or *for* that comes after the direct object.

Example 3.1.114. *He handed his room key to the receptionist.*
Ralph passed a message to Jack.
He gave it to me.

This structure is used particularly in cases where you want to focus on the indirect object.

You can use it, e.g., when the indirect object is significantly longer than the direct object.

Example 3.1.115. *He had taught English to all the youth of Ceylon and India.*
He copied the e-mail to every single 1 of his staff.

3.75 It is normal to use this prepositional structure when the direct object is a pronoun e.g. *it* or *them*.

Example 3.1.116. *I took the bottle and offered it to Oakley.*
Woodward finished the 2nd page and passed it to the editor.
It was the only pound he had and he gave it to the little boy.
God has sent you to me.

Note that in informal spoken English, some people put the indirect object in front of the direct object when both objects are pronouns.

E.g., some people say *He gave me it* rather *He gave it to me.*

Both pronouns are unstressed and both refer to information that is already known, and so it does not matter what order they come in.

If you want to put the indirect object in a phrase that begins with a preposition, you use the preposition *to* with some verbs, especially ones where the direct object is something that is transferred from 1 person to another.

Example 3.1.117. *Mr Schell wrote a letter the other day to the New York Times.*
I had lent my apartment to a friend for the weekend.
I took out the black box and handed it to her.

Here is a list of verbs that can have an indirect object introduced by *to*:

Example 3.1.118. *accord, advance, award, bring, deal, feed, forward, give, grant, hand, lease, leave, lend, loan, mail, offer, owe, pass, pay, play, post, quote, read, rent, repay, sell, send, serve, show, sing, take, teach, tell, write*

3.77 If the action you are describing involves 1 person doing something that will benefit another person, you can use the preposition *for* to introduce the indirect object.

Example 3.1.119. *He left a note for her on the table.*
He poured more champagne for the 3 of them.
She brought presents for the children.

Here is a list of verbs that can have an indirect object introduced by *for*:

Example 3.1.120. *book, bring, build, buy, cash, cook, cut, design, fetch, find, fix, get, guarantee, keep, leave, make, mix, order, paint, pick, play, pour, prepare, reserve, save, secure, set, sing, spare, take, win, write*

3.78 [i] Note that the verbs *bring, leave, play, sing, take*, and *write* are in both of the lists (**3.76–3.77**).

That is because there are a few verbs that can take either *to* or *for* in front of the indirect object, depending on the meaning you want to express.

E.g., *Karen wrote a letter to her boyfriend* means that the letter was addressed to her boyfriend and was for him to read.

Karen wrote a letter for her boyfriend means that her boyfriend wanted to send someone else a letter and Karen was the person who actually wrote it.

3.79 [i] There are some verbs that take 2 objects where the indirect object almost always comes in front of the direct object rather than being introduced by *to* or *for*.

E.g., you say *He begrudged his daughter the bread she ate* and *She allowed her son only 2 pounds a week.*

It would be very unusual to say *She allowed 2 pounds a week to her son.*

Here is a list of verbs that do not usually have their indirect object introduced by *to* or *for*:

Example 3.1.121. *allow, ask, begrudge, bet, cause, charge, cost, deny, draw, envy, forgive, grudge, promise, refuse*

Note that *wish* can be used as this sort of verb when its direct object is a word or phrase like *luck, good luck*, or *happy birthday.*

3.80 When you use a passive form of a verb with 2 objects, either the direct object or the indirect object can become the subject.

See **9.20** for full information.

3.81 [i] When the subject and the indirect object refer to the same person, you can use a **reflexive pronoun** as the indirect object.

Example 3.1.122. *I'm going to buy myself some new clothes.*
He had got himself a car.
He cooked himself an omelette.

Reflexive pronouns are explained in paragraphs **1.111–1.118**.

3.82 Most of the verbs listed above as verbs that take 2 objects can be used with the same meaning with just a direct object.

Example 3.1.123. *He left a note.*
She fetched a jug from the kitchen.

However, the following verbs always or usually have both a direct object and an indirect object:

Example 3.1.124. *accord, advance, allow, deny, give, hand, lend, loan, show, tell*

A few verbs can be used with the person who benefits from the action, or receives something, as the direct object.

Example 3.1.125. *I fed the baby when she woke.*
I forgive you.

Here is a list of these verbs:

Example 3.1.126. *ask, envy, feed, forgive, pay, teach*

3.1.10 Phrasal verbs: *I sat down, She woke me up*

3.83 There is a special group of verbs that consist of 2 or 3 words.

These are called **phrasal verbs**.

They consist of

- a verb followed by an adverb:

  Example 3.1.127. *He sat down.*
  The noise gradually died away.
  The cold weather set in.

- a verb followed by a preposition (sometimes called a **prepositional verb**):

  Example 3.1.128. *She looked after her invalid mother.*
  She sailed through her exams.
  She fell down the steps and broke her ankle.

- or a verb followed by an adverb and a preposition:

  Example 3.1.129. *You may come up against unexpected difficulties.*

  I look forward to reading it.

  Fame has crept up on her almost by accident.

By combining a verb and an adverb or preposition in this way, you can extend the usual meaning of the verb or create a new meaning, different from any that the verb has on its own.

You cannot, therefore, always guess the meaning of a phrasal verb from the usual meanings of the verb and the adverb or preposition.

E.g., if someone says *I give up* they do not give anything to anyone, nor is there any upward movement involved.

In the case of a few phrasal verbs, the 1st part is not found independently as a verb at all.

E.g., there are phrasal verbs *sum up, tamper with*, and *zero in on*, but no verbs *sum, tamper*, or *zero*.

Note that phrasal verbs are never written as a single word or with a hyphen.

3.84 Most phrasal verbs consist of 2 words.

These are explained below in paragraphs **3.85–3.110**.

3-word phrasal verbs are explained in paragraphs **3.111-3.113**.

3.85 Some phrasal verbs are used without an object.

These plural verbs are generally verb plus adverb combinations.

Example 3.1.130. *Rosamund went away for a few days.*

The boys were fooling around.

She must have dozed off.

3.86 Here is a list of phrasal verbs that consist of a verb and an adverb with no object:

Example 3.1.131. *back away/down/off, balance out, barge in, bear up, boil over, bounce back, bow down/out, branch out, break away/out, butt in, camp out, cast about, catch on, change down, check up, chip in, climb down, close in, cloud over, club together, come about/along/apart/away/back/down/forward/in/on/out/round/to/up, cool off, creep in, crop up, cry off, cuddle up, curl up, cut in, die away/down/out, dine out, double back, doze off, drag on, drop back/by/out, ease up, ebb away, end up, fade away/out, fall apart/away/back/behind/out/over/through, fight back, fizzle out, flare up, fool around, forge ahead, get about/ahead/along/by/up, give in, glaze over, go ahead/along/around/away/back/down/on/out/under/up, grow up, hang back/together, hit out, hold on, land up, lash out, let up, lie back/down, live in, look ahead/back/in, loom up, make off, meet up, melt away, mount up, move off/over, nod off, opt out, own up, pass away, pay up, pine away, play around, pop up, press ahead/on, push ahead/on, rear up, ride up, ring off, rise up, roll about/in/over, rot away, run away/out, rush in, seize up, sell up, set in, settle down/in/up, shop around, simmer down, sink in, sit around/back/down, slip up, speak up, splash out, spring up, stand back/down/in/out, start out, stay in/on/up, steam up, step aside/back/down/in, stick around, stock up, stop by/off/over, tag along, tail away/off, taper off, tick over, touch down, tune in, wade in, wait about/up, walk out, waste away, watch out, wear off, weigh in*

3.87 Other phrasal verbs used in intransitive clauses are verb plus preposition combinations.

These are sometimes called **prepositional verbs**.

Example 3.1.132. *Ski trips now account for nearly half of all school visits.*

I'm just asking for information.

... the arguments that stem from gossip.

Note that the nouns at the end of the above examples (*nearly half of all school visits, information*, and *gossip*) are objects of the prepositions and not direct objects of the verbs.

3.88 Here is a list of phrasal verbs that consist of a verb with no object and a preposition:

Example 3.1.133. *abide by, account for, allow for, answer for, ask after/for, bank on, bargain for, break into/with, brood on, bump into, burst into, call for/on, care for, come across/between/by/for/from/into/under/upon, count on, cut across, dawn on, deal with, dispose of, draw on, drink to, dwell on, eat into, embark on, enter into, expand on, fall for/into/on, feel for, flick through, frown upon, get at/into/over, go about/against/for, grow on, hang onto, head for, hit on, hold with, jump at, keep to, laugh at/into, lay into, leap at, level with, lie behind, live for/off/with, look after/into/to, make for, meet with, part with, pick at/on, pitch into, plan for/on, play at/on, pole at, pore over, provide for, puzzle over, rattle through, reason with, reckon on/with/without, rise above, romp through, run across/into/to, sail through, see to, seize on, set about, settle for/on, skate over, smile on, stand for, stem from, stick at/by, stumble across/on, take after/against, tamper with, tangle with, trifle with, tumble to, wade through, wait on, walk into, watch for, worry at*

3.89 In the case of some intransitive phrasal verbs, the 2nd word (*across, around, down*, etc) is a preposition if the 2nd thing involved needs to be mentioned, or can be an adverb if the 2nd thing involved is clear from the context.

Example 3.1.134. *I could hang around your office.*
We'll have to hang around for a while.
They all crowded around the table.
Everyone crowded around to see him jump into the water.

3.90 Here is a list of intransitive phrasal verbs whose 2nd word is a preposition if the other thing involved needs to be mentioned, or an adverb if it does not:

Example 3.1.135. *ask around, bend over, break through, bustle about, come across/after/along/by/down/in/off/on/over/through/up, cross over, crowd around, do without, fall behind/down/off, gather around, get in/off/on/round, go about/along/down/in/round/through/up/without, hang around, join in, knock about, lag behind, lean over, lie about, look round/through, lounge about, move about, pass by/over, push by/past/through, rally round, run around/down/up, scrape through, see round, shine through, show through, sit around, spill over, stand around, stop by, trip over*

3.91 Some phrasal verbs are nearly always used with an object.

Example 3.1.136. *We put our drinks down on the bar.*
I finished my meal off as quickly as I could.
She read the poem out quietly.

3.92 Here is a list of phrasal verbs that consist of a transitive verb and an adverb:

Example 3.1.137. *add on, beat up, blot out, board up, bring about/along/back/down/forward/in/off/out/round/up, buy out/up, call off/up, carry off/out, cast aside, catch out, chase up, chat up, clean out, conjure up, count out, cross off/out, cut back/down/off/up, deal out, dig up, do up, drag in/out/up, dream up, drink in, drive out, drum up, eat away/up, explain away, fight off, fill in/up, filter out, find out, fix up, follow up, frighten away, gather up, give away/back/off, hammer out, hand down/in/on/out/over/round, have on, hire out, hold down/up, hunt down, hush up, keep back, kick out, knock down/out/over, lap up/down/on/out, leave behind/out, let down/in/off/out, lift up, live down, melt down, mess up, mix up, nail down, note down, order about, pack off, pass down/over/round, patch up, pay back/out, phrase in/out, pick off/out, piece together, pin down/up, play back/down, plug in, point out, print out, pull apart/down, push about/around/over, put about/around/away/down/forward/off/on/out/through/together/up, read out, reason out, reel off, rinse out, rip off/up, rope in/off, rub in/out, rule out, rush through, scale down, screen off, seal off, see off, seek out, sell off, send up, set apart/aside/back/down, shake off/up, shoot down, shrug off, shut away/in/off/out, size up, smooth over, snap up, soak up, sort out, sound out, spell out, spin out, stamp out, step up, stick down, summon up, switch on, take apart/away/back/down/in/on/up, talk over/round, tear apart/down/up, tell apart/off, think over/through/up, thrash out, throw away/off/on/out, tidy away, tie down/up, tip off/up, tire out, tone down, top up, track down, trade in, try on/out, turn down/on, use up, warn off, wash away, weed out, weigh out/up, whip up, win back/over, wipe away/out/up*

Phrasal verbs that consist of a transitive verb and a preposition are explained in paragraphs **3.107–3.110**.

3.93 A large group of phrasal verbs can be used both with and without an object.
Often this is because a phrasal verb has more than 1 meaning.
E.g., *break in* does not have an object when it is used in the sense of *get into a place by force.*
But *break in* does take an object when it is used in the sense of *get someone used to a new situation.*

Example 3.1.138. *If the door is locked, I will try to break in.*
He believes in breaking in his staff gradually.
A plane took off.
Gretchen took off her coat.
The engine cut out.
She cut out some colored photographs from a magazine.

3.94 Here is a list of phrasal verbs that can be used both with an without an object, depending on which meaning is being used:

Example 3.1.139. *add up, bail out, black out, break in, call in, carry on, clear out, cut out, draw on/out/up, dress up, drop off/round, fight back, finish up, get down/in/out/together, give up, hang out, hold off/out, join up, keep away/down/in/off/on/out/up, kick off, knock about/off, lay off, leave off, look out/up, make out/up, mess about, miss out, pass off/on, pay off, pick up, pull in, put in, roll up, run down/off/over, set forth/off/out, show off/up, split up, stick out/up, stow away, strike out, string along, sum up, switch off, take off, tear off, throw up, tuck in, turn away/back/in/round/up, wind down/up, work out, wrap up*

3.95 There are a few phrasal verbs that have only 1 meaning, but that can be used either with or without an object.
It is possible to use them without an object because the object is either obvious or can be guessed in a particular context.

Example 3.1.140. *It won't take me a moment to clear away.*
I'll help you clear away the dishes.

3.96 Here is a list of phrasal verbs that have only 1 meaning but that can be used with or without an object:

Example 3.1.141. *answer back, breathe in/out, call back, clear away/up, cover up, drink up, help out, open up, take over, tidy away, wash up*

3.97 Just as with ordinary verbs, some phrasal verbs are **ergative verbs**; i.e., you can use the object of the transitive verb as the subject of the intransitive verb.

Example 3.1.142. *The guerrillas blew up the restaurant.*
The gasworks blew up.
I won't wake him up just yet.
He woke up in the middle of the night.

See paragraphs **3.59–3.67** for information about ergative verbs.
3.98 Here is a list of ergative phrasal verbs:

Example 3.1.143. *back up, block up, blow up, book in, break off/up, buck up, build up, burn up, check in, cheer up, close down, dry up, get off, heat up, hurry up, line up, move on, open up, peel off, pull through, rub off, shut up, sign up, slow down, spread out, start off, thaw out, wake up, warm up, wear down/out*

3.99 In the case of some ergative phrasal verbs, the 2nd word can be a preposition if the other thing involved needs to be mentioned, or can be an adverb if the other thing involved is clear from the context.

Example 3.1.144. *... leaves that had been blown off the trees.*
My hat blew off.

3.100 Here is a list of ergative phrasal verbs whose 2nd word can be a preposition or an adverb:

Example 3.1.145. *blow off, chip off, get down/through/up, move down/up, peel off, poke through, stick in/on*

3.101 When you are using a phrasal verb with an object that is a short noun phrase, you usually have a choice as to where you put the object.
It can be placed either after the 2nd word of the phrasal verb or after the 1st word and before the 2nd word.

Example 3.1.146. *He filled up his car with petrol.*
She filled my glass up.
He handed over the box.
Mrs Kaul handed the flowers over to Judy.

3.102 However, when the object consists of a long noun phrase, it is more likely to come after the 2nd word of the phrasal verb, so that the 2 parts of the phrasal verb are not separated too widely.
In this way, attention is focused on the information contained in the noun phrase, rather than on the 2nd word of the phrasal verb.

Example 3.1.147. *Police have been told to turn back all refugees who try to cross the border.*

3.103 When the object is a pronoun e.g. *me, her*, or *it*, it usually comes before the 2nd word of the phrasal verb.
This is because it is not new information, and so it is not put in a position of prominence at the end of the clause.

Example 3.1.148. *I waited until he had filled it up.*
He tied her up and bundled her into the car.

3.104 If the object of a phrasal verb is an abstract noun e.g. *hope, confidence*, or *support*, it usually comes after the 2nd world of the phrasal verb.
So, although you can say *He built his business up*, you usually say *We are trying to build up trust with the residents.*
Similarly, although you can say *He put my parents up for the night*, you normally say *The peasants are putting up a lot of resistance.*

Example 3.1.149. *The newspapers whipped up sympathy for them.*
They attempted to drum up support from the students.
He didn't hold out much hope for them.

3.105 With a small number of phrasal verbs, the object is always placed between the 1st and the 2nd words of the verb.
E.g., you can say *I can't tell your brothers apart* but not *I can't tell apart your brothers.*

Example 3.1.150. *Captain Dean was still ordering everybody about.*
I answered my father back and took my chances.

Note that most of these verbs take a human object.
Here is a list of phrasal verbs that always belong in this group when they are used with an object:

Example 3.1.151. *answer back, ask in, bash about, bind over, book in, bring round/to, brush off, call back, carry back, catch out, churn up, count in, drag down, dress down, drop round, feel out, get away, hear out, help along, invite in/out/over, jolly along, keep under, knock about, mess about, move about, much about, order about, play along/through, pull about/to, push about/around/to, run through, see through, send ahead/away/up, shut up, sit down, slap around, stand up, stare out, string along, talk round, tear apart, tell apart, tip off, trust up, turf out*

Some phrasal verbs have more than 1 transitive sense, but belong in this group when they are used with 1 particular meaning.
E.g., *take back* belongs in this group when it means *remind someone of something* but not when it means *regain something.*

Example 3.1.152. *The smell of chalk took us all back to our schooldays.*
... his ambition of taking back disputed territory.

Here is a list of phrasal verbs that belong in this group when used with a particular meaning:

Example 3.1.153. *bowl over, bring down/out, buoy up, cut off, do over, draw out, get back/out, give up, have on, hurry up, keep up, kick around, knock out/up, nail down, pass on, pin down, pull apart, push around, put down/out, see out, set up, shake up, show around/up, start off, straighten out, take back/in/off, throw about, toss about, trip up, turn on, ward off, wind up*

3.106 Remember that when a phrasal verb consists of an intransitive verb followed by a preposition, the noun phrase always comes after the preposition, even when it is a pronoun.

Example 3.1.154. *A number of reasons can account for this change.*
They had dealt with the problem intelligently.
If I went away and left you in the flat, would you look after it?

There is a list of phrasal verbs that consist of an intransitive verb and a preposition in paragraph **3.88**.
3.107 Some phrasal verbs consist of a transitive verb and a preposition.
They have 1 noun phrase after the 1st word, as the object of the verb, and a 2nd noun phrase after the 2nd word, as the object of the preposition.

Example 3.1.155. *They agreed to let him into their secret.*
The farmer threatened to set his dogs on them.
They'll hold that against you when you apply next time.

3.108 Here is a list of phrasal verbs that consist of a transitive verb and a preposition:

Example 3.1.156. *build into/on, draw into, drum into, frighten into, hold against, keep to, lay before, leave off, let into, lumber with, make of, put on/onto/through, read into, set against/back/on, talk into, thrust upon, write into*

3.109 In the case of some transitive phrasal verbs, the 2nd word is a preposition if the 3rd thing involved needs to be mentioned, but it is an adverb if the 3rd thing involved is clear from the context.

Example 3.1.157. *Rudolph showed them around the theater.*
Rudolph showed them around.

3.110 Here is a list of transitive phrasal verbs whose 2nd word can be a preposition or an adverb:

Example 3.1.158. *cross off, dab on, hawk around, hurl about, keep off, knock off, lop off, push around, scrub off, show around, shut in, sink in*

3.111 Most phrasal verbs consists of 2 words: a verb and an adverb, or a verb and a preposition.
However, some phrasal verbs consists of 3 words: a verb, an adverb, and a preposition.
This type of verb is sometimes called a **phrasal-prepositional verb**.
Most 3-word phrasal verbs are intransitive.
The preposition at the end is followed by its own object.

Example 3.1.159. *His girlfriend walked out on him.*
You're not going to get away with this!
She sometimes finds it hard to keep up with her classmates.
The local people have to put up with a lot of tourists.
Terry Holbrook caught up with me.

3.112 Here is a list of intransitive 3-word phrasal verbs:

Example 3.1.160. *be in for, be on to, bear down on, boil down to, break out of, brush up on, bump up against, burst in on, call out for, catch up with, chime in with, clamp down on, clean up after, come across as, come down on/to/with, come in for, come on to, come out in/of/with, come up against/to/with, crack down on, creep up on, crowd in on, cry out against/for, cut back on, date back to, do away with, double back on, face up to, fall back on, fall in with, get away with, get down to, get in to, get off with, get on to/with, get round to, get up to, give up to, go along with, go back on, go down with, go in for, go off with, go over to, go through with, grow out of, keep in with, keep on at, keep up with, kick out against, lead up to, live up to, look down on, look forward to, look out for, look up to, make away with, make off with, make up to, match up to, measure up to, miss out on, monkey about with, play along/around with, put up with, read up on, run away/off with, run up against, shy away from, sit in on, snap out of, stick out/up for, suck up to, take up with, talk down to, tie in with, walk away from/with, walk off with, walk out on, wriggle out of, zero in on*

3.113 A few 3-word phrasal verbs are transitive.
The direct object of the verb comes immediately after the verb.
A 2nd noun phrase is put after the preposition, as normal.

Example 3.1.161. *I'll let you in on a secret.*
Kroop tried to talk her out of it.
They put their success down to hard work.

Here is a list of transitive 3-word phrasal verbs:

Example 3.1.162. *do out of, frighten out of, let in for/on, play off against, pot down as/to, take out/up on, talk out of*

3.113 [!] In standard written English it is not possible to have indirect objects with phrasal verbs.
The only objects you can have are direct objects of the verb and objects of prepositions.
In informal spoken English, however, a few phrasal verbs do have both a direct and an indirect object.
In such cases, the indirect object is placed between the verb and the particle, and the direct object follows.

Example 3.1.163. *Would you break me off a piece of chocolate, please?*
We brought her back some special cookies from Germany.

3.115 There is 1 way in which a preposition that is part of a phrasal verb behaves differently from an ordinary preposition.
Normally, when the object of a preposition is put at the beginning of a question or a relative clause, it can be preceded by the preposition, especially in formal speech or writing.
E.g., you can say *From which student did you get the book?* and *the document on which he put his signature.*
However, if the preposition is part of a phrasal verb, it cannot be put before its object in such structures.
You have to say *What are you getting at?* not *At what are you getting?*, and *the difficulties which he ran up against* not *the difficulties against which he ran up.*

Example 3.1.164. *Who were they laughing at?*
This was 1 complication he had not bargained for.

3.116 Most phrasal verbs that contain a transitive verb can be used in the **passive**.
So can a few phrasal verbs that contain an intransitive verb and a preposition.
See paragraphs **9.17–9.23**.

3.1.11 Compound verbs: *ice-skate, baby-sit*

3.114 Some verbs, e.g. *cross-examine* and *test-drive*, consist of 2 words.
They are sometimes called **compound verbs**.

Example 3.1.165. *He would have been cross-examined on any evidence he gave.*
He asked to test-drive a top-of-the-range vehicle.
It is not wise to hitch-hike on your own.

3.118 [!] It is important to realize that you cannot always guess the meaning of a compound verb if you are not already familiar with it.
E.g., to *soft-soap* does not mean to use soap that is soft; it means to flatter someone in order to persuade them to do something for you.
3.119 Compound verbs are usually written with a hyphen.

Example 3.1.166. *No one had cross-referenced the forms before.*
Children ice-skated on the sidewalks.

However, some compound verbs may be written with a space between the words and some may be written as single words.
E.g., both *roller-skate* and *roller skate* are used, as are *baby-sit* and *babysit*.
3.120 Many compound verbs consist of a noun plus a verb.

Example 3.1.167. *It may soon become economically attractive to mass-produce hepatitis vaccines.*

Others consist of an adjective plus a verb.

Example 3.1.168. *Somebody had short-changed him.*

3.121 A few compound verbs consist of words that seem strange because they are not normally used as single words on their own, e.g. *pooh-pooh* and *shilly-shally*.
These verbs are usually used in informal conversation rather than formal writing.

Example 3.1.169. *Sally had pooh-poohed the idea of 3 good meals a day.*
Come on, don't shilly-shally. I want an answer.

Other compound verbs look strange because they have been borrowed from foreign languages, e.g. *ad-lib* and *kow-tow*.

Example 3.1.170. *They ad-libbed so much that the writers despaired of them.*
He resents having to kow-tow to anyone or anything.

3.122 Some compound verbs do not have an object.

Example 3.1.171. *Many people window-shopped in the glass of the great store.*
If you keep to the rules, you may roller-skate.
He has learned to lip-read.
I'm learning to water-ski.

Here is a list of compound verbs that do not have an object:

Example 3.1.172. *baby-sit, back-pedal, hitch-hike, ice-skate, jack-knife, kow-tow, lip-read, name-drop, play-act, roller-skate, shilly-shally, touch-type, water-ski, window-shop, wolf-whistle*

3.123 Other compound verbs typically have an object:

Example 3.1.173. *You can spin-dry it and it will still retain its shape.*
I didn't have time to blow-dry my hair.
At 1st we cold-shouldered him.
They ill-treated our ancestors.

Here is a list of compound verbs that typically have an object:

Example 3.1.174. *back-comb, blow-dry, cold-shoulder, court-martial, cross-check, cross-examine, cross-question, cross-reference, double-cross, double-glaze, dry-clean, field-test, force-feed, frog-march, ghost-write, ill-treat, pooh-pooh, proof-read, rubber-stamp, short-change, short-weight, soft-soap, spin-dry, spoon-feed, stage-manage, tape-record, toilet-train, wrong-foot*

3.124 A 3rd group fo compound verbs may be used with or without an object.

Example 3.1.175. *Kate had to double-park outside the flat.*
Murray double-parked his car and jumped out.
I tried to ad-lib a joke.
The commentator decided to ad-lib.

Here is a list of compound verbs that can be transitive or intransitive:

Example 3.1.176. *ad-lib, bottle-feed, breast-feed, bulk-buy, chain-smoke, criss-cross, deep-fry, double-check, double-park, mass-produce, short-circuit, sight-read, spring-clean, stir-fry, tie-dye*

3.125 Only the 2nd part of a compound verb inflects.
If the 2nd part is used on its own as a verb, the compound verb usually inflects in the same way as the verb on its own.
See the Reference section for an explanation of how to inflect verbs.

3.2 Linking verbs

3.126 If you want to describe someone or something, e.g. to say who or what they are or what qualities they have, you use 1 of a special set of verbs.
These verbs are called **linking verbs**.

Example 3.2.1. *Cigarette smoking is dangerous to your health.*
The station seemed a very small one.
He looked English.
I became enormously fond of her.

The most common linking verbs are *be, become, look, remain*, and *seem*.
3.127 A linking verb links a subject and an adjective or a noun phrase (called a **complement**).
The subject, as usual, comes 1st and the adjective or noun phrase comes after the verb.
The adjective or noun phrase describes or identifies the subject.

Example 3.2.2. *Her general knowledge is amazing.*
The children seemed frightened.
That's a very difficult question.
She's the head of a large primary school.
Suleiman Salle became the 1st President of Eritrea.

Linking verbs are explained in paragraphs **3.132–3.154**.
Some other intransitive verbs are sometimes used in a similar way to linking verbs.
See paragraphs **3.155–3.160**.
3.128 Some verbs, e.g. *make* and *find*, are used with an **object complement**, i.e., both an object and an adjective or a noun phrase.
The adjective or noun phrase describes the object.

Example 3.2.3. *The lights made me sleepy.*
I found the forest quite frightening.

These verbs are explained in paragraphs **3.161–3.171**.
3.129 You can often use a phrase beginning with a preposition after a linking verb.

Example 3.2.4. *The 1st-aid box is on the top shelf.*
I began to get in a panic.

For more information about phrases and clauses that can be used after ling verbs, see paragraphs **3.172–3.181**.
3.130 *Be* is often used with *it* as an impersonal subject.
This structure is used to comment on places, situations, actions, experiences, and facts.

Example 3.2.5. *It was very quiet in the hut.*
It was awkward keeping my news from Ted.
It's strange you should come today.

Some other linking verbs are occasionally used in a similar way.
The use of *it* as an impersonal subject is explained in paragraphs **9.31–9.45**.
3.131 *Be* is often used with *there* as its subject to indicate the existence of something.

Example 3.2.6. *There is another explanation.*
There is a rear bathroom with a paneled bath.

This use of *there* is explained in paragraphs **9.46–9.55**.

3.2.1 Adjectives after linking verbs: *He seems happy, I'm tired*

3.132 Many **adjectives** can be used after linking verbs.

Example 3.2.7. *I am proud of these people.*
They seemed happy.
You don't want them to become suspicious.
They have remained loyal to the Government.

They can be modified in various ways or have various structures after them.

Example 3.2.8. *We were very happy.*
Your suspicious are entirely correct.
Their hall was larger than his whole flat.
He was capable of extraordinary kindness.

Adjectives used after linking verbs, and the structures used with them, are explained in paragraphs **2.41**–**2.53**.
3.133 Here is a list of verbs that can be used as linking verbs with a following adjective:

Example 3.2.9. *be*
appear, feel, look, prove, seem, smell, sound, taste
become, come, fall, get, go, grow, keep, remain, stay, turn

Note that the verbs in 3rd group refer to changing or to saying the same.
3.134 [i] Some verbs in the 2nd group listed above have special features.
Appear, prove, and *seem* are often followed by *to be* and an adjective, instead of directly by an adjective.

Example 3.2.10. *Mary was breathing quietly and seemed to be asleep.*
Some people appeared to be immune to the virus.

See paragraph **3.192** for information on using a *to*-infinitive after these verbs.
3.135 With some verbs in the 2nd group, especially *feel, look*, and *seem*, you can use the *-ed* participle of a verb as an adjective.

Example 3.2.11. *The other child looked neglected.*
The quarrel of the night before seemed forgotten.

3.136 When you are using the 2nd group of verbs to say what qualities someone or something seems to have, you may want to mention the person whose viewpoint you are giving.
You can do this by using a phrase beginning with the preposition to.
It usually comes after the adjective.

Example 3.2.12. *They looked all right to me.*
It sounds unnatural to you, I expect.

3.137 [!] You cannot use all adjectives with all linking verbs.
Some verbs, e.g. *be* and *look*, are used with a wide range of adjectives and some are used with a restricted range.
E.g., *taste* is used only with adjectives that describe the taste of something; *go* is used mainly with adjectives that indicate color or a negative state; and *fall* is used mainly with *asleep, ill*, and *silent*.

Example 3.2.13. *Sea water tastes nasty.*
It tasted sweet like fruit juice.
Jack went red.
It all went horribly wrong.
The world has gone crazy.
He fell asleep at the table.
The courtroom fell silent.

3.2.2 Nouns after linking verbs: *She is a teacher, It remained a secret*

3.138 **Nouns** can be used after the following linking verbs:

Example 3.2.14. *be, become, remain*
feel, look, prove, seem, sound
constitute, make, represent
comprise, form

3.139 You can use descriptive nouns or noun phrases after *be, become, remain, feel, look, prove, seem, sound, constitute*, and *represent* to say what qualities someone or something has.

Example 3.2.15. *Their policy on higher education is an unmitigated disaster.*
He always seemed a controlled sort of man.
I feel a bit of a fraud.
The results of these experiments remain a secret.
Any change would represent a turnaround.

Make is only used as a linking verb with a noun that indicates whether someone is good at a particular job.

Example 3.2.16. *He'll make a good president.*

3.140 With *be, become, remain, feel, look, prove, seem*, and *sound*, you can use a noun phrase based on *one*.
The noun phrase consists of *a* or *an* followed by the adjective and *one*, if the subject is singular.
E.g., instead of saying *The school is large*, you can say *The school is a large one.*

Example 3.2.17. *The sound is a familiar one.*
The impression the region gives is still a rural one.

If the subject is plural, you can use the adjective followed by *ones*.

Example 3.2.18. *My memories of a London childhood are happy ones.*

One can also be followed by a **prepositional phrase** or a **relative clause**.

Example 3.2.19. *Their story was indeed 1 of passion.*
The problem is one that always faces a society when it finds itself threatened.

3.141 If you want to make a statement about the size, age, color, or shape of something, you can use a noun phrase based on *size, age, color*, or *shape* after the linking verbs mentioned in the previous paragraph.
The noun phrase begins with a determiner and has an adjective in front of the noun or the preposition *of* after it.

Example 3.2.20. *It's just the right shape.*
The opposing force would be about the same size.
The walls are a delicate pale cream color.
His body was the color of bronze.
It is only the size of a mouse.

3.142 You can use noun phrases beginning with *a* or *an*, or plural noun phrases without a determiner after *be, become, remain, comprise*, and *form*, to say what type of person or thing someone or something is.

Example 3.2.21. *He is a geologist.*
I'm not an unreasonable person.
He is now a teenager.
The air moved a little faster and became a light wind.
They became farmers.
Promises by MPs remained just promises.
These arches formed a barrier to the tide.

3.143 You can use names or noun phrases referring to a particular person or thing after *be, become, remain, constitute, represent, comprise*, and *form* to talk about exactly who or what someone or something is.

Example 3.2.22. *This is Desiree, my father's 2nd wife.*
He's now the Director of the Office of Management and Budget.
The winner of the competition was Ross Lambert of Forest Hill Primary School.
The downstairs television room became my room for receiving visitors.
... the 4 young men who comprised the TV crew.

3.144 [i] When you use a noun indicating a unique job or position within an organization, you do not have to put a determiner in front of the noun.

Example 3.2.23. *At 1 time you wanted to be President.*
He went on to become head of 1 of the company's largest divisions.

3.145 **Personal pronouns** are sometimes used after linking verbs to indicate identity.
Note that the object pronouns are used, except in very formal speech or writing.

Example 3.2.24. *It's me again.*

Possessive pronouns are also used after linking verbs, to indicate identity or to describe something.

Example 3.2.25. *This one is yours.*
This place is mine.

Indefinite pronouns are sometimes used to describe something, usually with a qualifying structure after them.

Example 3.2.26. *It's nothing serious.*
You're someone who does what she wants.

When pronouns are used after linking verbs, the linking verb is usually *be*.
3.146 The use of noun phrases containing **measurement nouns** after *be* and other verbs is explained in paragraphs **2.252**–**2.254**.
3.147 Some verbs function as ling verbs when they are followed by a particular preposition.
The object of the preposition describes or classifies the subject of the verb.

Example 3.2.27. *His fear turned into unreasoning panic.*
Taylor's fascination with bees developed into an obsession.
An autobiography really amounts to a whole explanation of yourself.

Here is a list of verb and preposition combinations that function as linking verbs:

Example 3.2.28. *amount to, change into/to, develop into, grow into, morph into, turn into/to*

These all have the same basic meaning as *become*, except for *amount to*, which has a similar meaning to *constitute*.
The phrasal verb *make up* also functions as a linking verb.

Example 3.2.29. *Wood made up 65% of the Congo's exports.*

3.2.3 Commenting

3.148 There are several ways in which a ***to*-infinitive** can be used to comment on someone or something in relation to an action.
3.149 If you want to say that someone shows a particular quantity when they do something, you can use the structure: subject + linking verb + adjective or noun phrase + *to*-infinitive.

Example 3.2.30. *Most people think I am brave to do this.*
I think my father was a brave man to do what he did.

3.150 You can use a similar structure to say that someone or something would do a particular task better than anyone or anything else.

Example 3.2.31. *He was absolutely the right man to go to Paris and negotiate.*
She may be an ideal person to look after the children.
He is just the man to calm everyone down.

You cannot use adjectives alone in constructions of this kind.
You use a noun phrase containing an adjective e.g. *right, ideal*, or *best*, or *just the* followed by the noun *person, man*, or *woman*.
E.g., you can say *He was the ideal person to lead the expedition*, but you cannot say *He was ideal to lead the expedition.*
Instead of a *to*-infinitive, you can sometimes use a phrase beginning with the preposition *for*.
In this structure, an adjective can be used alone.

Example 3.2.32. *He's not the right man for it.*
They are ideal for this job.

3.151 If you want to express your feeling about an event, you can use a *to*-infinitive after a noun phrase that follows a linking verb.

Example 3.2.33. *It seemed such a terrible thing to happen.*

The *to*-infinitive consists of *to* and an intransitive verb, usually *happen*.
You cannot use an adjective alone in constructions of this type.
E.g., you can say *It was a wonderful thing to happen*, but you cannot say *It was wonderful to happen*.

3.152 If you want to say that someone is willing or unwilling to do something, you can use a *to*-infinitive after an adjective that follows a linking verb.

Example 3.2.34. *They were willing to risk losing their jobs.*
I am anxious to meet Mrs Burton-Cox.
She is eager to succeed.
He is unwilling to answer questions.
I was reluctant to involve myself in this private fight.

You cannot use nouns in constructions of this type.
E.g., you can say *He was willing to come*, but you cannot say *He was a willing person to come*.

3.153 If you want to show your opinion of something by describing what the experience of doing something to it is like, you can use a *to*-infinitive after an adjective or noun phrase that follows a linking verb.

Example 3.2.35. *Silk is comfortable to wear.*
It's a nice thing to have.
Telling someone they smell is a hard thing to do.
She was easy to talk to.

Note that the *to*-infinitive must be the *to*-infinitive of a transitive verb or of an intransitive verb followed by a preposition.

3.154 If you want to show your opinion of an action, you can use a *to*-infinitive that has an object.

Example 3.2.36. *They thought this was a sensible thing to do.*
This is a very foolish attitude to take.

The *to*-infinitive is usually *to do, to make*, or *to take*.
You cannot use an adjective alone in constructions of this kind.
E.g., you can say *It was a silly thing to do*, but you cannot say *It was silly to do*.

3.2.4 Other verbs with following adjectives: *He stood still*

3.155 Some intransitive verbs can be followed by adjectives in the same way as linking verbs.

Example 3.2.37. *George stood motionless for at least a minute.*
Pugin died insane at the early age of 40.

However, it is clear that these verbs are not just linking verbs.
George stood motionless does not mean the same as *George was motionless*.
In the sentence *George stood motionless*, the verb *stand* is performing 2 functions: it is telling us that George was standing, and it is also acting as a linking verb between *George* and the adjective *motionless*.
Here is a list of verbs that can be used in this way:

Example 3.2.38. *hang, lie, sit, stand*
gaze, stare
emerge, escape, go, pass, survive
blush, flame, gleam, glow, run
be born, die, return

Ways in which these verbs can be used with following adjectives are discussed in the following paragraphs.
Adjectives are sometimes used in combination with other verbs, but are separated from the main clause by a comma.
This use is dealt with in paragraph **8.147**.

3.156 [i] You can use adjectives describing states after *hang, lie, sit*, and *stand*.

Example 3.2.39. *I used to lie awake watching the rain seep through the roof.*
A sparrow lies dead in the snow.
Francis Marroux sat ashen-faced behind the wheel.
She stood quite still, facing him.

Gaze and *stare* can be used in a similar way with a limited set of adjectives.

Example 3.2.40. *She stared at him wide-eyed.*

3.157 You can use some combinations of verbs and adjectives to say that something does not happen to someone or something, or that someone does not have something.

Go, pass, emerge, escape, and *survive* are often used in combinations like these.

The adjectives they combine with are often formed by adding *un-* to *-ed* participles.

Example 3.2.41. *Your efforts won't go unnoticed.*
The guilty went unpunished.
Somehow, his reputation emerged unblemished.
Fortunately we all escaped unscathed.
Mostly, they go unarmed.
The children always went barefoot.

3.158 Verbs e.g. *blush, flame, gleam, glow*, and *run* can be used with color adjectives after them to say what color something is or what color it becomes.

Example 3.2.42. *They blew into the charcoal until it glowed red.*
The trees flamed scarlet against the grass.

3.159 *Die, return*, and the passive verb *be born* can be followed by either adjectives or noun phrases.

Example 3.2.43. *She died young.*
He died a disappointed man.
At the end of the war, he returned a slightly different man.
He was born a slave.

3.160 Some combinations of verb and adjective are fixed phrases.

You cannot use the verb in front of any other adjective.

Example 3.2.44. *I wanted to travel light.*
The children ran wild.
The joke was wearing thin with use.

3.2.5 Describing the object of a verb

3.161 You can put an adjective after the object of some transitive verbs.

This adjectives describes the object, and is often called an **object complement**.

Example 3.2.45. *Willie's remarks made her uneasy.*
I find the British legal system extremely complicated.

Some of these verbs are used to say that someone or something is changed or that someone is given a new job.

Others are used to describe a person's opinion of someone or something.

For information on how to use these verbs in the passive, see paragraph **9.21**.

3.162 If you want to say that someone or something causes a person or thing to have a particular quality, you can use 1 of a group of intransitive verbs, followed by an adjective.

Example 3.2.46. *He said waltzes made him dizzy.*
They're driving me crazy.
Then this captor had knocked him unconscious.
She painted her eyelids deep blue.
He wiped the bottle dry.

Here is a list of verbs that can be used in this way:

Example 3.2.47. *cut, drive, get, knock, make, paint, pat, pick, plane, render, rub, send, shoot, sweep, turn, wipe*

Most of these verbs can be followed by only 1 adjective or a very small range of adjectives.

However *make* and *render* can be used with a wide range of adjectives.

3.163 You can also use *keep, hold*, and *leave* with an object followed by an adjective, to say that someone or something is caused to remain in a particular state.

Example 3.2.48. *The light through the thin curtains had kept her awake.*
Leave the door open.
Hold it straight.

3.164 If you want to say that someone is given an important job, you can use *make, appoint, crown*, or *elect* with an object followed by a noun phrase referring to the job.

Example 3.2.49. *In 1910 Asquith made him a junior minister.*

The noun used in this way does not usually have a determiner when it refers to a unique job.

Example 3.2.50. *Ramsay MacDonald appointed him Secretary of State for India.*

3.165 Some transitive verbs with the general meaning *consider* can be used with an adjective or noun phrase to say what someone's opinion of a person or thing is.

Example 3.2.51. *They consider him an embarrassment.*
Do you find his view of America interesting?

Here is a list of these verbs:

Example 3.2.52. *account, believe, consider, deem, find, hold, judge, presume, reckon, think*

Prove can also be followed by an object complement, although it means *show*, not *consider*.

Example 3.2.53. *He had proved them wrong.*

3.166 These verbs are often used in the passive.
Believe, presume, reckon, and *think* are nearly always used in the passive in these structures.

Example 3.2.54. *Her body was never found and she was presumed dead.*
30 bombers were believed shot down.

3.167 All the verbs listed in paragraph **3.165** except *account* can also be used with a *to*-infinitive clause after their object showing what someone thinks a person or thing is like or does.

Example 3.2.55. *We believed him to be innocent.*

See paragraph **3.206** for information abotu using a *to*-infinitive clause after the object of these verbs.
3.168 You can use the verbs listed in **3.165** with *it* as their object followed by an object complement and a *to*-infinitive clause to show someone's opinion of an action.
E.g., instead of saying *She found breathing difficult*, you can say *She found it difficult to breathe.*

Example 3.2.56. *Gretchen found it difficult to speak.*
He thought it right to resign.
He considered it his duty to go.

These are examples of *it* being used in an impersonal way.
For more information about the impersonal use of *it*, see paragraphs **9.31–9.45**.
3.169 If you want to say that people use a particular word, word group, or name to describe or refer to someone or something, you can use the word, word group, or name after 1 of a group of transitive verbs.

Example 3.2.57. *People who did not like him called him dull.*
They called him an idiot.
Everyone called her Molly.
He was declared innocent.
They name the place Tumbo Kutu.

Here is a list of verbs that can be used in this way.
The 1st group is followed by an adjective; the 2nd group is followed by a noun phrase; and the 3rd group is followed by a name.

Example 3.2.58. *call, certify, declare, label, pronounce, term*
brand, call, declare, designate, label, proclaim, term
call, christen, dub, name, nickname

3.170 The passive verbs *be entitled, be headed*, and *be inscribed* are followed by a title or inscription.

Example 3.2.59. *The draft document was entitle 'A way forward'.*

3.171 A few transitive verbs can be followed by an adjective to say that someone or something is in a particular state when something happens to them, or is preferred to be in that state.

Example 3.2.60. *More than 40 people were burned alive.*
... a soup that can be served cold.
They found it dead.
Do you want it white or black?

Here is a list of verbs that can be used in this way:

Example 3.2.61. *burn, eat, find, leave, like, prefer, serve, show, want*

Sometimes and *-ed* participle or an *-ing* participle describing a state is used.

Example 3.2.62. *She found herself caught in a strong tidal current.*
Maureen came in and found Kate sitting on a chair staring at the window.

3.2.6 Using a prepositional phrase after a linking verb

3.172 When you want to give information about someone or something by describing their circumstances, you can sometimes use a **prepositional phrases** after a linking verb.
3.173 You can use many kinds of prepositional phrase after *be*.

Example 3.2.63. *He was still in a state of shock.*
I walked home with Bill, who was in a very good mood.
She had an older brother who was in the army.
I'm from Dortmund originally.
... people who are under pressure.
Your comments are of great interest to me.
This book is for any woman who has a child.

3.174 Some other linking verbs can be used with a more restricted range of prepositional phrases.

Example 3.2.64. *He seemed in excellent health.*
We do ask people to keep in touch with us.
These methods have gradually fallen into disuse.
He got into trouble with the police.

Here is a list of other linking verbs that are used with prepositional phrases:

Example 3.2.65. *appear, fall, feel, get, keep, remain, seem, stay*

3.175 Some verbs that are always or often followed by an adjective can also be used with prepositional phrases relating to place.

Example 3.2.66. *She's in California.*
I'll stay here with the children.
The cat was now lying on the sofa.

Here is a list of these verbs:

Example 3.2.67. *be, keep, remain, stay*
hang, lie, sit, stand

For more information about prepositional phrases and adverbs relating to place, see paragraphs **6.73–6.92** and **6.53–6.72**.
3.176 *Be* can be used with time expressions to say when something took place or will take place.

Example 3.2.68. *That final meeting was on Nov 3.*

For more information about time expressions, see paragraphs **4.85–4.111**.
3.177 Prepositional phrases can also be used in transitive structures to say that someone or something is caused to be in a particular state.

Example 3.2.69. *They'll get me out of trouble.*
The fear of being discovered kept me on the alert.

3.2.7 Talking about what role something has or how it is perceived: the preposition *as*

3.178 Prepositional phrases beginning with *as* can be used after some verbs.

3.179 Prepositional phrases beginning with *as* are used after certain intransitive verbs to show what role or function the subject has, or what identity they pretend to have.

Example 3.2.70. *Bleach removes color and acts as an antiseptic and deodoriser.*
He served as Kennedy's ambassador to India.
The sitting room doubles as her office.

Here is a list of verbs that can be followed by *as* in this way:

Example 3.2.71. *act, come, double, function, pass, pose, serve*

Work can also be used in this way, when it has a human subject.

Example 3.2.72. *She works as a counselor with an AIDS charity.*

3.180 A number of transitive verbs can be used with *as* after their object.
With some, a noun phrase is used after *as*.
The *as* phrase describes the role of the object or what it is thought to be.

Example 3.2.73. *I wanted to use him as an agent.*
I treated business as a game.

Here is a lit of transitive verbs that can be used with *as* and a noun phrase:

Example 3.2.74. *brand, cast, categorize, certify, characterize, choose, class, condemn, consider, define, denounce, depict, describe, diagnose, elect, establish, give, hail, identify, intend, interpret, label, name, perceive, recognize, regard, scorn, see, suggest, take, treat, use, view*

With others, an adjective is used after *as*.
The adjective indicates what quality or characteristic the object is thought to have.

Example 3.2.75. *Party members and officials described him as brilliant.*
They regarded manual work as degrading.

Here is a list of transitive verbs that can be used with *as* and an adjective:

Example 3.2.76. *brand, categorize, certify, characterize, class, condemn, define, denounce, depict, describe, diagnose, establish, label, perceive, regard, scorn, see, view*

3.181 *Look upon, refer to*, and *think of* are also used with *as* in this way.
As must be followed by a noun when used with *refer to*.

Example 3.2.77. *In some households the man was referred to as the master.*

3.3 Talking about closely linked actions: using 2 main verbs together

3.182 This section describes the ways in which you use 2 main verbs together to talk about 2 actions or states that are closely linked.
These 2 actions may be performed by the same person.
See paragraphs **3.189–3.201**.

Example 3.3.1. *She stopped speaking.*
Davis likes to talk about horses.

Alternatively, the actions may be performed by different people.
If they are, the performer of the 2nd action is the object of the 1st verb.
See paragraphs **3.202–3.212**.

Example 3.3.2. *I don't want them to feel I've slighted them.*
1 of the group began pumping her chest to help her breathe.

3.183 Note that the 1st verb needs the 2nd verb after it because it does not give enough information on its own.
E.g., *I want* does not give enough information to be a useful statement, but *I want to talk to you* does.
Some of the verbs dealt with below, e.g. *want* and *like*, can also be ordinary transitive verbs, with a noun phrase after them.
Transitive verbs are explained in paragraphs **3.14**–**3.25**.

3.184 If you want to talk about 2 actions that are less closely linked, you refer to each action in a separate clause.
Ways of combining clauses are explained in Chap. 8.

3.185 The 1st verb involved in this type of structure is the main verb of the structure.
It usually inflects for tense and agrees in number with the subject; it is **finite**.

Example 3.3.3. *I wanted to come home.*
Lonnie wants to say sorry.
More and more people are coming to appreciate the contribution that these people make to our society.

3.186 The 2nd verb in the combination does not inflect for tense or change its form at all; it is **non-finite**.

Example 3.3.4. *She tried to read.*
They had been trying to read.

Information about finite and non-finite forms can be found in the Reference section.

3.187 There are 4 non-finite verb forms that are used for the 2nd verb in this type of structure:

- the *-ing* participle
- the *to*-infinitive
- the infinitive without *to*
- the *-ed* participle

Note that the infinitive without *to* and the *-ed* participle form of the verb are used in only a few combinations.
Other kinds of *-ing* form and infinitive are also sometimes used.

Example 3.3.5. *Those very close to the blast risk being burnt.*
Neither Rita nor I recalled ever having seem her.
She wanted to be reassured.
They claimed to have shot down 22 planes.

3.188 The position of *not* in negative structures of this type is explained in paragraphs **5.59**–**5.60**.

3.3.1 Talking about 2 actions done by the same person

3.189 When you are talking about 2 actions that are done by the same person, you use the 2nd verb directly after the 1st.

Example 3.3.6. *Children enjoy playing alongside each other.*
You deserve to know the truth.

3.190 Some verbs are always followed by an *-ing* participle clause in structures of this kind.

Example 3.3.7. *She admitted lying to him.*
Have you finished reading the paper?
He missed having someone to dislike.
I recall being very impressed with the official anthems.

Here is a list of verbs that are used with an *-ing* participle, but not a *to*-infinitive:

Example 3.3.8. *admit, adore, appreciate, avoid, celebrate, commence, consider, contemplate, defer, delay, deny, describe, detest, discontinue, dislike, dread, endure, enjoy, fancy, finish, go, imagine, keep, lie, loathe, mention, mind, miss, postpone, practice, recall, report, resent, resist, risk, sit, stand, stop, suggest*

These verbs are also sometimes used with a passive *-ing* form.

Example 3.3.9. *They enjoy being praised.*

Admit, celebrate, deny, mention, and *recall* are quite often used with a perfect *-ing* form.

Example 3.3.10. *Carmichael had denied having seen him.*

3.191 [i] Note that *need* can be used with an *-ing* participle after it, but the *-ing* participle then has the same meaning as a passive *to*-infinitive.

E.g., *The house needs cleaning* means the same as *The house needs to be cleaned.*

Require and *want* are also occasionally used in the same way, although some people do not like this use o *want.*

3.192 Other verbs are used with a *to*-infinitive.

Example 3.3.11. *Mrs Babcock had always longed to go to Ireland.*
She forgot to bring a suitcase.
She wishes to ask a favor of you.

Here is a list of verbs that are used with a *to*-infinitive, and rarely or over with an *-ing* participle:

Example 3.3.12. *ache, afford, agree, aim, appear, arrange, ask, attempt, care, choose, claim, consent, dare, decide, demand, deserve, desire, disdain, endeavor, expect, fail, fight, forget, grow, happen, help, hesitate, hope, intend, learn, live, long, manage, mean, need, neglect, offer, opt, pay, plan, pledge, prepare, pretend, promise, prove, reckon, refuse, resolve, scorn, seek, seem, survive, swear, tend, threaten, trouble, venture, volunteer, vote, vow, wait, want, wish*

Most of these verbs can be used with a passive infinitive.

Example 3.3.13. *She refused to be photographed.*
He deserves to be shot.

The following verbs from the above list are not usually used with a passive infinitive, because of their meanings:

Example 3.3.14. *claim, dare, forget, intend, learn, manage, mean, neglect, pretend, threaten, trouble, venture*

Appear, claim, happen, pretend, prove, seem, and *tend* are quite often used with a perfect infinitive.

Example 3.3.15. *They seemed to have disappeared.*

Note that *help* is also followed by the infinitive without *to.*

Example 3.3.16. *Coffee helped keep him alert.*

3.193 [i] Note that *afford* is always preceded by a modal, and that *care* is normally used with a negative.

Example 3.3.17. *Can we afford to ignore this source of power as other sources of energy are diminishing?*
. . . a kitchen for someone who doesn't care to cook.

3.194 The use of *have* followed by a *to*-infinitive clause is explained in paragraph **5.244**.

3.195 A few verbs can be used with either an *-ing* participle or a *to*-infinitive without changing the meaning of the verb.

Example 3.3.18. *It started raining.*
A very cold wind had started to blow.
We both love dancing.
He loves to talk about his work.

Here is a list of verbs that can be followed either by an *-ing* participle or a *to*-infinitive without greatly changing the meaning:

Example 3.3.19. *attempt, begin, bother, cease, continue, deserve, fear, hate, like, love, prefer, start*

Note that *bother* is often used with a negative or a broad negative.

Example 3.3.20. *He didn't bother complaining about it.*
We hardly even bother to clean it.

3.196 [i] With a few verbs, the meaning is altered depending on whether you use an *-ing* participle or a *to*-infinitive.

These verbs are *come, go on, remember, try*, and *regret.*

If someone *comes running, flying*, or *hurtling* somewhere, they move in that way.

If you *come to do something*, you gradually start doing it.

Example 3.3.21. *When they heard I was leaving, they both came running out.*
People came to believe that all things were possible.

If you *try to do something*, you attempt it, to see if you can do it.
If you *try doing something*, you do it in order to find out if it is effective.

Example 3.3.22. *She tried to think calmly.*
Try lying down in a dark room for a while. That usually helps.

With the other verbs, the difference in meaning relates to the timing of the action.
If you *go on doing something*, you continue to do it, but if you *go on to do something*, you subsequently start doing it.

Example 3.3.23. *They went on arguing into the night.*
She went on to talk about the political consequences.

If you *remember doing something*, you did it in the past, but if you *remember to do something*, you do it at the present time.

Example 3.3.24. *I remember promising that I would try.*
We must remember to say thank you.

Similarly, if you *regret doing something*, you have already done it, but if you *regret to do something*, you have to do it at the present time.

Example 3.3.25. *She did not regret accepting his offer.*
I regret to say rents went up.

Regret is only used with the *to*-infinitive of small number of verbs that share the meaning of giving or receiving information.
These verbs are:

Example 3.3.26. *announce, inform, learn, say, see, tell*

3.197 [!] When you have a choice between an *-ing* participle and a *to*-infinitive, you do not use the *-ing* participle if the 1st verb is in a progressive form.

Example 3.3.27. *The 3rd World is beginning to export to the West.*
The big clouds were starting to cover the sun.
Educational budgets are continuing to increase.

With verbs that cannot be followed by a *to*-infinitive, you normally use a noun phrase instead of the *-ing* participle.

Example 3.3.28. *I knew Miss Head would just be finishing her cello practice.*

3.198 Note that a few verbs, principally *need, want, have, buy*, and *choose*, are used with an object and a *to*-infinitive when talking about 2 actions performed by the same person.
The *to*-infinitive must be transitive.
It is understood as relating to the noun, rather than being closely connected with the 1st verb.

Example 3.3.29. *I need a car to drive to work.*
She chose the correct one to put in her bag.

3.199 Note that verbs that refer to a deliberate action are sometimes followed by a clause expressing purpose.
Here, *to* means *in order to*.

Example 3.3.30. *Several women moved to help her.*
The captain stopped to reload the machine-gun.

Note that the 1st verb has a complete meaning of its own; the 2nd verb is giving a reason for the 1st action, not completing the information about it.
See paragraphs **8.43–8.46** for more details on expressing purpose.
3.200 [i] When the base form of *try* is used, e.g. as an **imperative** or with a **modal**, it is sometimes used with *and* followed by the base form of the 2nd verb, rather than with a *to*-infinitive.
The 2 actions seem to be separate, because of the *and*, but are in fact very closely linked.

Example 3.3.31. *Try and get a torch or a light, it's terribly dark down here.*
I'll try and answer the question,

Some speakers consider this to be informal or incorrect.
Come and *go* are often used in a similar way with *and*, in simple forms as well as in the base form.
The verb after *and* can also inflect.

Example 3.3.32. *Come and see me whenever you feel depressed.*
I went and fetched another glass.

3.201 In informal spoken English, *get* is sometimes used with an *-ed* participle directly after it, in a structure with a passive meaning.

Example 3.3.33. *Then he got killed in a plane crash.*

[AE] When *get* is used to form passives in the past and present perfect, American English normally uses the participle *gotten*, rather than *got*.

Example 3.3.34. *Her foot had gotten caught between some rocks. (Am)*

3.3.2 Talking about 2 actions done by different people

3.202 If you want to talk about 2 closely linked actions that are performed by different people, you follow the 1st verb with an object.

This object then functions as the subject of the 2nd verb.

E.g., in *She asked Ginny to collect the book, Ginny* is the person who is asked, and she is also the person who performs the action of collecting the book.

Example 3.3.35. *I saw him looking at my name on the door.*
You can't stop me seeing him!

3.203 Note that when the 2nd verb is an *-ing* participle, a possessive determiner is sometimes used in front of it, instead of a pronoun.

This is rather formal.

Example 3.3.36. *These professional ethics prevent their discussing their clients with the public.*
She did not like my living in London.

Note that a possessive determiner is only used in this way when the 2nd verb can have a human subject.

3.202 If you want to talk about 2 closely linked actions that are performed by different people, you follow the 1st verb with an object.

This object then functions as the subject of the 2nd verb.

E.g., in *She asked Ginny to collect the book, Ginny* is the person who is asked, and she is also the person who performs the action of collecting the book.

Example 3.3.37. *I saw him looking at my name on the door.*
You can't stop me seeing him!

3.204 Some verbs are used with an object and an *-ing* participle.

Example 3.3.38. *He caught Hooper looking at him.*

Here is a list of verbs that are used with an object and an *-ing* participle:

Example 3.3.39. *catch, describe, feel, find, hear, imagine, keep, leave, like, notice, observe, picture, prevent, save, see, send, spot, stop, want, watch*

Listen to also belongs in this group.

The object after it is the object of the preposition *to*.

Example 3.3.40. *I listened to Kaspar talking.*

These verbs are sometimes used with a passive *-ing* form, but not usually with a perfect *-ing* form.

Example 3.3.41. *She felt herself being spun around.*

3.205 Some of the verbs in the above paragraph can also be used with an infinitive without *to*.

Example 3.3.42. *She felt her hair rise on the back of her neck.*
Dr Hochstadt heard her gasp.

There is a slight change of meaning depending on which form is used.

If you choose the *-ing* participle, you emphasize that the action continued happening for a period of time.

Example 3.3.43. *But I stayed there, listening to her singing.*
I looked over and saw Joe staring at me.

If you choose the infinitive without *to*, you emphasize that the action was completed.

Example 3.3.44. *We listened to Jenny finish the sonnet.*
It was the 1st time she had heard him speak of his life.

Here is a list of verbs that can be used with an *-ing* participle or an infinitive without *to*, with the change of meaning described above:

Example 3.3.45. *feel, hear, listen to, notice, observe, see, watch*

Note that these verbs can be used in the active only when they are followed by an infinitive without *to*.
See paragraph **3.208**.
3.206 Other verbs are used with an object and a *to*-infinitive clause.

Example 3.3.46. *His sister had taught him to sew.*
I encourage students to do these exercises at home.

Here is a list of verbs that are used with an object and a *to*-infinitive:

Example 3.3.47. *advise, allow, ask, beg, cause, challenge, choose, command, compel, dare, defy, enable, encourage, expect, forbid, force, get, help, induce, inspire, instruct, intend, invite, lead, leave, like, mean, move, oblige, order, pay, permit, persuade, prefer, press, programme, prompt, recruit, remind, teach, tell, train, trust, urge, use, want, warn*

Note that some of the verbs in the above list are used for reporting orders, requests, and advice.
For more information on this use, see paragraph **7.39**.
Here is a list of verbs that are always or usually used in the passive when followed by a *to*-infinitive:

Example 3.3.48. *allege, assume, believe, claim, consider, deem, discover, estimate, feel, find, know, learn, prove, reckon, report, require, rumor, say, see, think, understand*

They refer to saying, thinking, or discovering.
The *to*-infinitive that follows them is most commonly *be* or *have*, or a perfect infinitive.

Example 3.3.49. *The house was believed to be haunted.*
He was proved to be wrong.

3.207 If you do not know who the subject of the 2nd verb is, or you do not want to mention them, you can use a passive construction.

Example 3.3.50. *A gardener was immediately sacked if he was caught smoking.*
I was asked to come for a few days to help them.

The following verbs are not usually used in the passive when followed by an *-ing* participle:

Example 3.3.51. *feel, imagine, like, listen to, prevent, save, stop, want*

The following verbs are not usually used in the passive when followed by a *to*-infinitive:

Example 3.3.52. *defy, get, like, prefer, want*

3.208 [i] *Hear, observe*, and *see* are not used with a *to*-infinitive when they are active but they can be used with either an *-ing* participle or a *to*-infinitive when they are passive.
You use them with an *-ing* participle when you want to show that the action described by the 2nd verb took place over a period of time.

Example 3.3.53. *A terrorist was seen standing in the middle of the road.*
Her companions could be heard playing games.

If a *to*-infinitive is used, you are implying that the action was completed.

Example 3.3.54. *She could distinctly be seen to hesitate.*
The baby was seldom heard to cry.

See also paragraph **3.205**.

3.209 There are some verbs used with another verb with a *to*-infinitive that are followed by the preposition *for* and its object, rather than by a direct object.

The object of *for* is the performer of the 2nd action.

Example 3.3.55. *They called for action to be taken against the unions.*
I waited for him to speak.

Note that the *to*-infinitive is often a passive one.

Here is a list of verbs that can be used in this way:

Example 3.3.56. *appeal, apply, arrange, ask, call, clamor, long, opt, pay, plead, press, vote, wait, wish, yearn*

3.210 A few verbs are followed by an object and an infinitive without *to*, not an *-ing* participle or a *to*-infinitive.

They are *let, make*, and *have* in the sense of *cause to happen* or *experience*.

Example 3.3.57. *Jenny let him talk.*
My father made me go for the interview.
He lay in a darkened room and had her bring him meals on trays.

Verbs that can be used either with an infinitive without *to* or with an *-ing* participle are explained in paragraph **3.205**.

3.211 A special use of *have* when used with another verb is to say that the subject causes something to be dealt with by someone else.

In this case, *have* is followed by an object referring to the thing dealt with, and then by the *-ed* participle of a transitive verb or of an intransitive verb followed by a preposition.

Example 3.3.58. *I have my hair cut every 6 weeks.*

This structure is also used to say that something belonging to the subject of *have* is affected in some way.

Example 3.3.59. *She'd just lost her job and had some money stolen.*

If you want to mention the performer of the 2nd action, you use *by* followed by a noun.

Example 3.3.60. *He had to have his leg massaged by his trainer.*

Get can also be used with an object and an *-ed* participle to talk about causing something to be dealt with or affected in some way.

Example 3.3.61. *We must get the car repaired.*

3.212 *Want* is also used with an object and an *-ed* participle, to show that you would like something to be done.

Example 3.3.62. *I want the whole approach changed.*
I don't want you hurt.

Need is used in a similar way, usually when the object is something that belongs to the subject.

Example 3.3.63. *You need your eyes tested.*

Chapter 4

Expressing time: tenses & time adverbials

4.1 Introduction

4.1 When you are making a statement, you usually need to make it clear whether you are talking about a situation that exists now, existed in the past, or is likely to exist in the future.

There are different ways of expressing time: **tense** is one; the use of **time adverbials** is another.

A tense is a verb form that indicates a particular point in time or period of time.

The form belonging to a particular tense is obtained by the addition of **inflections** to the base form of the verb.

In English, time is also indicated by the inclusion of **auxiliaries** or **modals** in the verb phrase.

Example 4.1.1. *smile... smiled*
was smiling... has been smiling... had smiled
will smile... may smile

Some verbs have irregular forms for past tenses.

Example 4.1.2. *fight... fought*
go... went

For information about all these forms, see the Reference section.

4.2 Sometimes the point in time is clear from the tense of the verb, and no other time reference is required.

However, if you want to draw attention to the time of the action, you use a **time adverbial**.

A time adverbial may be

(i) an adverb (e.g. *afterwards, immediately*),

(ii) a prepositional phrase (e.g. *at 8 o'clock, on Monday*), or

(iii) a noun phrase (e.g. *the next day, last week*).

Example 4.1.3. *She's moving tomorrow*
He was better after undergoing surgery on Saturday.
Record profits were announced last week.

For more general information about adverbials, see the beginning of Chap, 6.

4.3 Time adverbials normally come at the end of a clause, after the verb or after its object if there is one.

You can put more focus on the time by placing the adverbial at the beginning of the clause.

Example 4.1.4. *We're getting married next year.*
Next year, the museum is expecting even more visitors.
I was playing golf yesterday.
Yesterday the atmosphere at the factory was tense.

if the time adverbial is an adverb, it can also come immediately after *be* or after the 1st auxiliary in a verb phrase.

Example 4.1.5. *She is now pretty well-known in this country.*
Cooper had originally been due to retire last week.
Public advertisements for the post will soon appear in the national press.

4.4 Some verb forms are used to say that an event takes place continuously over a period of time, or is repeated several times.

You may also want to say how long something lasts, or how often it happens.

To do this, **adverbials of duration** (e.g. *for a long time*) and **adverbials of frequency** (e.g. *often, every year*) are used.

Example 4.1.6. *America has always been highly influential.*
People are sometimes scared to say what they really think.
Hundreds of people are killed every year in fires.
They would go on talking for hours.

Adverbials of frequency are explained and listed in paragraphs **4.114–4.122**.

Adverbials of duration are explained and listed in paragraphs **4.123–4.144**.

4.5 The following paragraphs describe the ways in which you can talk about the present, the past, and the future.

After each of these, there is a section on the ways in which you use time adverbials with each tense.

There are sometime adverbials that are used mainly with the past tenses.

These are explained in paragraph **4.41**.

Time adverbials that are used with future forms can be found in paragraphs **4.60–4.62**.

4.6 This chapter deals only with the choice of tense in **main clauses**.

Sometimes, the point in time is not indicated by a time adverbial, but by a **subordinate clause**.

Subordinate clauses of time are introduced by conjunctions that refer to time, e.g. *since, until, before*, and *after*.

For information about the tense of the verb in the subordinate clause, see paragraph **8.9**.

4.2 The present

4.7 In situations where you are discussing an existing state of affairs, you use a verb that is in the present tense.

Usually, the verb tense is sufficient to show that you are referring to the present.

You normally use a time adverbial for emphasis, or to refer to something that is unrelated to the present moment.

4.2.1 The present in general: the present simple

4.8 If you want to talk about your thoughts and feelings at the present moment, or about your immediate reactions to something, you use the **present simple**.

Example 4.2.1. *I'm awfully busy.*
They both taste the same.
Gosh, he looks awful.
I want a breath of fresh air.

You can also use the present simple to talk about a physical feeling that is affecting you or someone else.

Example 4.2.2. *I feel heavy. I do. I feel drowsy.*
My stomach hurts.

Note, however, that if you are talking about physical perceptions e.g. seeing and hearing, you normally use the modal *can*, although the present simple is occasionally used.

Example 4.2.3. *I can see the fishing boats coming in.*
I can smell it. Can't you?
I see a flat stretch of ground.
I hear approaching feet.

4.9 If you want to talk about a settled state of affairs that includes the present moment but where the particular time reference is not important, you use the present simple.

Example 4.2.4. *My dad works in Saudi Arabia.*
He lives in the French Alps near the Swiss border.
He is a very good brother. We love him.
She's a doctor's daughter.
Meanwhile, Atlantic City faces another dilemma.

4.10 If you want to say that something is always or generally true, you use the present simple.

Example 4.2.5. *Near the equator, the sun evaporates greater quantities of water.*
A molecule of water has 2 atoms of hydrogen and 1 of oxygen.
A chemical reaction occurs in the fuel cell.

4.11 If you want to talk something that a particular person or thing does regularly or habitually, you use the present simple.

Example 4.2.6. *Do you smoke?*
I get up early and eat my breakfast listening to the radio.

4.12 You usually use the present simple when you are discussing what happens in a book, play, or film.

Example 4.2.7. *In the film he plays the central character of Charles Smithson.*
In those early chapters, he keeps himself very much in the background.

4.13 [i] You can use the present simple of the verb *say* when you are describing something you have read in a book.

Example 4.2.8. *The criminal justice system, the author says, has failed to keep pace with the drug problem.*
The Bible says love of money is the root of all evil.

4.14 On radio and television, commentators often use the present simple when they are describing an event e.g. a sports match or a ceremony at the time that it is happening.

Example 4.2.9. *He turns, he shoots, he scores!*

4.15 When you are reporting what someone said to you at a point in the recent past, you can use the present simple of a reporting verb e.g. *hear* or *tell*.

Example 4.2.10. *I've never been paragliding myself, but they tell me it's a really exciting sport.*
Tamsin's a good cook, I hear.
Grace says you told her to come over here.

For more detailed information about reporting verbs, see Chap. 7.

4.16 When you are commenting on what you are saying or doing, you use the present simple of a verb e.g. *admit, promise, reject*, or *enclose*.

For more information on this type of verb, see paragraphs **7.64–7.67**.

Example 4.2.11. *This, I admit, was my favorite activity.*
I enclose a small cheque which may come in handy.
I leave it for you to decide.

4.2.2 The present progressive

4.17 If you want to talk about an activity that is in progress, you use the **present progressive**.

Example 4.2.12. *We're having a meeting. Come and joint in.*
What am I doing? I'm looking out of the window.
My head is aching.
I'm already feeling tense.

4.18 If you want to emphasize the present moment or to indicate that a situation is temporary, you use the present progressive.

Example 4.2.13. *Only 1 hospital, at Angal, is functioning.*
We're trying to create a more democratic society.
She's spending the summer in Europe.
I'm working as a British Council Officer.

4.19 You also use the present progressive to talk about changes, trends, development, and progress.

Example 4.2.14. *The village is changing but it is still undisturbed.*
His handwriting is improving.
World energy demand is increasing at a rate of about 3% per year.

4.20 If you want to talk about a habitual action that takes place regularly, especially one that is new or temporary, you use the present progressive.

Example 4.2.15. *You're going out a lot these days.*
Do you know if she's still playing these days?
She's seeing a lot more of them.

4.2.3 Time adverbials with reference to the present

4.21 You do not normally need to use an additional time adverbial with present forms of verbs, but you can add them in order to emphasize the immediate present or general present, or to contrast the present with the past or future.

Example 4.2.16. *They're getting on quite well at the moment.*
We're safe now.
What's the matter with you today, Marnie?
I haven't got a grant this year.

4.22 If you are using the present simple to talk about something that is always or generally true, you can reinforce or weaken your statement by using an adverb.

Example 4.2.17. *Babies normally lose weight in the beginning.*
The attitude is usually 1 of ridicule.
Traditionally, the Japanese prefer good quality clothes.

Here is a list of common adverbs that can be used to modify your statement in this way:

Example 4.2.18. *always, generally, mainly, normally, often, traditionally, usually*

The use of the present simple to talk about general truths is explained in paragraph **4.10**.
4.23 When you use the present simple to say that an action takes place regularly, you can use an **adverbial of frequency** e.g. *often* or *sometimes* to be more specific about how often it happens.

Example 4.2.19. *Several groups meet weekly.*
I visit her about once every 6 months.
It seldom rains there.
I never drink alone.

The use of the present simple to talk about regular activities is explained in paragraph **4.11**.
More information about adverbials of frequency, including a list of the most common ones, can be found in paragraphs **4.114**–**4.122**.
4.24 The present progressive is also used with words like *always* and *forever* when you want to emphasize how often the action takes place.
This use expresses disapproval or annoyance.
The adverb is placed after the auxiliary verb.

Example 4.2.20. *You're always looking for faults.*
It's always raining.
And she's always talking to him on the telephone.
They are forever being knocked down by cars.

The use of the present progressive to talk about frequent, habitual actions is explained in paragraph **4.20**.
4.25 Note the some adverbs that refer to the present time, e.g. *now* and *today*, are also used to express past time.
However, there are a few adverbs and other time adverbials that are almost always used with present verb forms:

Example 4.2.21. *I'm not planning on having children at present.*
... the camping craze that is currently sweeping America.
Nowadays fitness is becoming a generally accepted principle of life.

The following is a list of time adverbials that are normally only used with present verb forms:

Example 4.2.22. *at present, currently, in this day and, age, nowadays, presently, these days*

Note that in this list the word *presently* means *now*.

4.3 The past

4.26 When you are talking about the past, a time adverbial is necessary to specify the particular time in the past you are referring to.
The time reference can be established in a previous clause, and the verbs in the following clauses are therefore put in the past tense.

Example 4.3.1. *It was very cold that night. Over my head was a gap in the reed matting of the roof.*
The house was damaged by fire yesterday. No-one was injured.

4.3.1 Stating a definite time in the past: the past simple

4.27 If you want to say that an event occurred or that something was the case at a particular time in the past, you use the **past simple**.

Example 4.3.2. *The Israeli Prime Minister flew into New York yesterday to start his visit to the US.*
Our regular window cleaner went off to Canada last year.
On Feb 1 1968 he introduced the Industrial Expansion Bill.
They gave me medication to help me relax.

4.28 If you want to say that a situation existed over a period of time in the past, you also use the past simple.

Example 4.3.3. *He lived in Paris during his last years.*
Throughout his life he suffered from epilepsy.

4.29 If you are talking about something that happened in the past, and you mention a situation that existed at that time, you use the past simple.
You can do this whether or not the situation still exists.

Example 4.3.4. *All the streets in this part of Watford looked alike.*
About 50 miles from the university there was 1 of India's most famous and ancient Hindu temples.

4.30 If you want to talk about an activity that took place regularly or repeatedly in the past, but that no longer occurs, you use the past simple.

Example 4.3.5. *We walked a great deal when I was a boy.*
Each week we trekked to the big house.

Would and *used to* can also be used to say that something happened regularly in the past but no longer does so.
See paragraphs **5.114–5.255** for more information.

4.3.2 Actions in progress in the past: the past progressive

4.31 If you want to focus on action in progress or repeated actions that occurred in the past, you use the **past progressive**.

Example 4.3.6. *Her tooth was aching, her burnt finger was hurting.*
He was looking ill.
Everyone was begging the captain to surrender.
I was meeting thousands of people and getting to know no one.

4.32 If you want to contrast a situation with an event that happened just after that situation existed, you use the past progressive to describe the 1st situation.
You then use the past simple to describe and draw attention to the event that occurred after it.

Example 4.3.7. *We were all sitting round the fire waiting for my brother to come home. He arrived about 6 in the evening.*
I was waiting angrily on Monday morning when I saw Mrs. Miller.

4.3.3 The past in relation to the present: the present perfect

4.33 If you want to mention something that happened in the past but you do not want to state a specific time, you use the **present perfect**.

Example 4.3.8. *They have raised £190 for a swimming pool.*
I have noticed this trait in many photographers.

4.34 [!] You cannot use time adverbials that place the action at a definite time in the past with the present perfect.
E.g., you cannot say *I have done it yesterday.*
You can, however, use an **adverbial of duration**.

Example 4.3.9. *The settlers have left the bay forever.*
I ate brown rice, which I have always hated, and vegetables from my garden.

Adverbials of duration are explained and listed in paragraphs **4.123–4.142**.
You can also use *since* and *for* with the present perfect because they are used in this way they refer to a definite time.

Example 4.3.10. *They have been back every year since then.*
She has worked for him for 10 years.

For more information on *since* see paragraph **4.137**.
Other uses of *for* are explained in paragraphs **4.125–4.128**.

4.35 If you want to talk about an activity or situation that started at some time in the past, continued, and is still happening now, you use the present perfect or the **present perfect progressive**.

Example 4.3.11. *All my adult life I have waited for the emergence of a strong center party.*
She's always felt that films should be entertaining.
National productivity has been declining.
I have been dancing since I was a child.

4.36 If you want to emphasize the duration of a recent event, you use the present perfect progressive.

Example 4.3.12. *She's been crying.*
Some people will say that what I have been describing is not a crisis of industry.
The Department of Aboriginal Affairs has recently been conducting a survey of Australian Aborigines.

4.3.4 Events before a particular time in the past: the past perfect

4.37 If you want to talk about a past event or situation that occurred before a particular time in the past, you use the **past perfect**.

Example 4.3.13. *1 day he noticed that a culture plate had become contaminated by a mould.*
Before the war, he had worked as a bank manager.
She had lost her job as a real estate agent and was working as a waitress.
I detested games and had always managed to avoid children's parties.

4.38 If you want to emphasize the recentness and the duration of a continuous activity that took place before a particular time in the past, you use the **past perfect progressive**.

Example 4.3.14. *Until now the rumors that had been circulating were exaggerated versions of truth.*
The doctor had been working alone.
He died in hospital where he had been receiving treatment for cancer.
They had been hitting our trucks regularly.

4.39 If you want to say that something was expected, wished for, or intended before a particular time in the past, you use the past perfect or the past perfect progressive.

Example 4.3.15. *She had naturally assumed that once there was a theater everybody would want to go.*
It was the remains of a 10-rupee note which she had hoped would last till the end of the week.
It was not as nice on the terrace as Clarissa had expected.
I had been expecting some miraculous obvious change.

4.3.5 Time adverbials with reference to the past

4.40 When you are using past verb forms, you normally use a time adverbial to indicate that you are talking about the past.

Example 4.3.16. *At 1 time the arts of reading and writing were classed among the great mysteries of life for the majority of people.*
I've made some poor decisions lately, but I'm feeling much better now.
It was very splendid once, but it's only a ruin now.
It's Mark who lost his wife. A year last January.
It was terribly hot yesterday.

4.41 Time adverbials can refer either to a specific time, or to a more general indefinite period of time.
The lists below give the most common indefinite time adverbials that are used mainly with past verb forms.
With the exception of *since* and *ever since*, which come at the end of a clause, you put them after the auxiliary or modal in a verb phrase that has more than 1 word; if you use them with the past simple you put them in front of the verb.
The words in the following list can be used with all past verb forms:

Example 4.3.17. *again, already, earlier, ever since, finally, 1st, in the past, just, last, previously, recently, since*

The words in the following list can be used with all past verb forms except the present perfect:

Example 4.3.18. *afterwards, at one time, eventually, formerly, immediately, next, once, originally, subsequently*

Note that *once* here means *at some time in the past.*
For its uses an adverb of frequency, see paragraph **4.115**.
For the uses of *since* as a preposition in time adverbials, see paragraph **4.137**.
Some time adverbials used with past verb forms are more specific.
They include words like *yesterday, ago, other*, and *last.*
Note that *ago* is placed after the noun phrase.

Example 4.3.19. *I saw him yesterday evening.*
We bought the house from her the day before yesterday.
3 weeks ago I was staying in San Francisco.
I saw my goddaughter the other day.
It all happened a long time ago.

4.42 [!] You say *last night*, not *yesterday night.*
4.43 There are some cases where you have to specify the time reference.
In other cases, you may simply want to make the timing of the action clear, or emphatic.
These cases are described below.
4.44 When you use the past simple to describe habitual or regular activities, you can use an **adverbial of frequency** to indicate the regularity or repetition of the activity.

Example 4.3.20. *He often agreed to work quite cheaply.*
Sometimes he read so much that he became confused.
Etta phoned Guppy every day.

The use of the past simple to describe habitual actions is explained in paragraph **4.30**.
4.45 If you are using the past progressive to talk about repeated actions, you can add an adverb of frequency e.g. *always* or *forever* after the auxiliary to emphasize the frequency of the action or to express your annoyance about it.

Example 4.3.21. *In the immense shed where we worked, something was always going wrong.*
She was always knitting - making sweaters or baby clothes.
Our builder was forever going on skiing holidays.

The use of the past progressive to describe repeated actions is explained in paragraph **4.31**.
4.46 When you use the present perfect to mention something that is still relevant to the present, you can add an adverb of frequency to show that the action was repeated.

Example 4.3.22. *I've often wondered why we didn't move years ago.*
Political tensions have frequently spilled over into violence.

The use of the present perfect to talk about situations that are still relevant is explained in paragraph **4.33**.
4.47 Note that if you are talking about a quality, attitude, or possession that still exists or is still relevant, you need to ues the present perfect with an adverbial of duration.

Example 4.3.23. *We've had it for 15 years.*
He's always liked you, you know.
I have known him for years.
My people have been at war since 1917.

4.48 If you use the present perfect and the present perfect progressive to mention a continuing activity that began in the past, you can add an adverbial of duration to show how long it has been going on.

Example 4.3.24. *For about a week he had been complaining of a bad headache.*
They have been meeting regularly for 2 years.
He has looked after me well since his mother died.

The use of the present perfect and the present perfect progressive to talk about activities that began in the past is explained in paragraph **4.35**.
4.49 When you use the past perfect to describe a repeated even that took place before a particular time in the past, you use an adverbial of frequency to show how often it was repeated.

Example 4.3.25. *Posy had always sought her out even then.*
The housekeeper mentioned that the dog had attacked its mistress more than once.

The use of the past perfect to describe events that occurred before a particular time in the past are explained in paragraph **4.37**.

4.50 If you are using the past perfect to talk about a situation that did not change in the past, you use an adverbial of duration to emphasize the length of time during which it existed.

Example 4.3.26. *They weren't really our aunt and uncle, but we had always known them.*
All through those many years he had never ever lost track of my father.
His parents had been married for 12 years when he was born.

4.51 If you are using the past perfect progressive to mention a recent, continuous activity, you can specify when it began.

Example 4.3.27. *The Home Office had until now been insisting on giving the officers only 10 days to reach a settlement.*
Since then, the mother had been living with her daughter.

Adverbials of frequency or duration can also be added for emphasis.

Example 4.3.28. *The drive increased the fatigue she had been feeling for hours.*
The rain had been pouring all night.

The use of the past perfect progressive to talk about a recent, continuous activity is explained in paragraph **4.38**.

4.4 Expressing future time

4.52 It is not possible to talk with as much certainty about the future as it is about the present or the past.
Any reference you make to future events is therefore usually an expression of what you think might happen or what you intend to happen.

4.4.1 Indicating the future using *will*

4.53 If you want to say that something is planned to happen, or that you think it is likely to happen in the future, you use the **modal** *will* in front of the base form of the verb.

Example 4.4.1. *Nancy will arrange it.*
These will be dealt with in Chap. 7.
'I will check,' said Brody.
When will I see them?
What do you think Sally will do?
You will come back, won't you?

If the subject is *I* or *we*, the modal *shall* is sometimes used instead of *will* to talk about future events.

Example 4.4.2. *I shall do everything I can to help you.*
You will stay at home and I shall go to your office.
'We shall give him some tea,' Naomi said.

[AE] This is not common in modern American English.
The modals *will* and *shall* are used in several other ways, usually with some element of future time.
For more information, see Chap. 5.

4.54 If you want to talk about general truths and to say what can be expected to happen if a particular situation arises, you use *will*.

Example 4.4.3. *When peace is available, people will go for it.*
An attack of malaria can keep a man off work for 3 days. He will earn nothing and his family will go hungry.

4.55 If you are sure that something will happen because arrangements have been made, you can use the **future progressive**.

Example 4.4.4. *I'll be seeing them when I've finished with you.*
She'll be appearing tomorrow and Sunday at the Royal Festival Hall.
I'll be waiting for you outside.
I understand you'll be moving into our area soon.
They'll spoil our picnic. I'll be wondering all the time what's happening.
Our people will be going to their country more.

Note that a time adverbial or an adverbial of frequency is normally required with the future progressive.

4.56 If you are referring to something that has not happened yet but will happen before a particular time in the future, you can use the **future perfect**.

Example 4.4.5. *By the time you get to the school, the concert will have finished.*
Maybe by the time we get there he'll already have started.
By then, maybe you'll have heard from your sister.

Note that you must indicate the specific future time referred to by using a time adverbial or another clause.

4.57 If you want to indicate the duration of an event at a specific time in the future, you can use the **future perfect progressive**.

Example 4.4.6. *By the time the seasons ends, I will have been playing for 15 months without a break.*
The register will have been running for a year in May.

Note that you need to use a time adverbial to indicate the future time and an adverbial of duration to state how long the event will last.

4.4.2 Other ways of talking about the future

4.58 If you are stating an intention that something will happen, of if you have some immediate evidence that something will happen fairly soon, you can use *be going to* followed by an **infinitive**.

Example 4.4.7. *I'm going to explore the neighborhood.*
Evans knows lots of people. He's going to help me. He's going to take me there.
You're going to have a heart attack if you're not careful.
We're going to see a change in the law next year.

4.59 You can use *be due to* and *be about to* to refer to planned future events that you expect to happen soon.
They are followed by infinitive clauses.

Example 4.4.8. *He is due to start as a courier shortly.*
The work is due to be started in the summer.
Another 385 people are about to lose their jobs.
Are we about to be taken over by the machine?

4.4.3 Time adverbials with reference to the future

4.60 The **present simple** is used to talk about timetabled or scheduled events.
The **present progressive** is used to state firm plans that you have for the future.
A time adverbial is necessary unless you are sure that the hearer or reader knows that you are talking about the future.

Example 4.4.9. *My last train leaves Euston at 11.30.*
The UN General Assembly opens in New York later this month.
Tomorrow morning we meet up to exchange contracts.
I'm leaving at the end of this week.
My mum is coming to help look after the new baby.

4.61 When you want to make a general or vague reference to future time, you use an adverbial that refers to indefinite time.

Example 4.4.10. *I'll drop by sometime.*
Sooner or later he'll ask you to join him there.
In future she'll have to take sedentary work of some sort.

Here is a list of indefinite time adverbials that are used mainly with future forms:

Example 4.4.11. *in future, in the future, 1 of these days, some day, sometime, sooner or later*

4.62 Adverbials that include the word *tomorrow* are mainly used with references to future time.

Example 4.4.12. *We'll try somewhere else tomorrow.*
Shall I come tomorrow night?
He'll be here the day after tomorrow.
This time tomorrow I'll be in New York.

4.63 Some adverbials that are mainly used with reference to future time include the word *next*.

If you are using a specific day or month e.g. *Saturday* or *October*, you can put *next* either before or after the day or month.

Otherwise, *next* is placed in front of the time reference.

Example 4.4.13. *Next week Michael Hall will be talking about music.*
Next summer your crops will be very much better.
I think we'll definitely be going next year.
Will your accommodation be available next October?
The boots will be ready by Wednesday next.
A post mortem examination will be held on Monday next.
She won't be able to do it the week after next.

[AE] In American English, *next* is always placed in front of the time reference.

4.5 Other uses of verb forms

4.64 So far in this chapter, the commonest and simplest uses of the various verb forms have been dealt with.

However, there are also some less common uses of tenses.

4.5.1 Vivid narrative

4.65 Stories are normally told using the past.

However, if you want to make a story seem vivid, as if it were happening now, you can use the **present simple** for actions and states and the **present progressive** for situations.

Example 4.5.1. *There's a loud explosion behind us. Then I hear Chris giggling. Sylvia is upset.*
The helicopter climbs over the frozen wasteland.
Chris is crying hard and others look over from the other tables.
He sits down at his desk chair, reaches for the telephone and dials a number.

4.5.2 Forward planning from a time in the past

4.66 There are several ways of talking about an event that was in the future at a particular time in the past, or that was expected to occur.

These are described in the following paragraphs.

4.67 The **past progressive** can be used to talk about events planned in the past, especially with some common verbs e.g. *come* and *go*.

Example 4.5.2. *4 of them were coming for Sunday lunch.*
Her daughter was going to a summer camp tomorrow.
My life was joining me later with the 2 children.

4.68 The **past simple** of *be* can be used in structures used to express future events, e.g. *be going to, be about to*, and *be due to*.

The implication is usually that the expected event has not happened or will not happen.

For more information on *be going to*, see paragraph **5.233**.

Example 4.5.3. *I thought for a moment that she was going to cry.*
He was about to raise his voice at me but stopped himself.
The ship was due to sail the following morning.

4.5.3 Referring to states rather than activities

4.69 Certain verbs are mainly used in the present simple or past simple rather than the present progressive or past progressive.

These are called **stative verbs**.

The most common stative verbs are listed in the Referene section.

They include verbs that refer to lasting emotions and mental states, e.g. *love, like, want* and *know*; verbs that refer to the senses, e.g. *see* and *hear*; and verbs that refer to permanent states, e.g. *keep, fit* and *belong*.

Example 4.5.4. *Do you like football?*
I want to come with you.
Where do you keep your keys?
Then I heard a noise.

Generally, these sentences cannot be expressed as, e.g., *Are you liking football?, I'm wanting to come with you, Where are you keeping your keys?* or *Then I was hearing a noise.*

However, a few of these verbs are sometimes used with present and past progressive forms, particularly in informal spoken English.

You can use the progressive form with these verbs when you want to emphasize that a state is new or temporary, or when you want to focus on the present moment.

Example 4.5.5. *Rachel is loving 1 benefit of the job - the new clothes.*
I'm liking grapes these days too.
I'm wanting the film to be deliberately old-fashioned.

Some people think this usage is incorrect, and it is usually avoided in formal texts.

Here is a list of verbs that are traditionally considered to be stative verbs, but that are sometimes used with present and past progressive forms:

Example 4.5.6. *forget, guess, imagine, lack, like, love, remember, want*

You can use the present perfect progressive or past perfect progressive with some stative verbs in both formal and informal contexts.

Example 4.5.7. *I've been wanting to speak to you about this for some time.*
John has been keeping birds for about 3 years now.
Then she heard it. The sound she had been hearing in her head for weeks.

4.6 Using time adverbials to indicate past, present, or future

4.70 In many statements, it is the time adverbial rather than the verb form that carries the time reference.

E.g., a common use is to put time adverbials that normally refer to future time with the present simple or present progressive when it is used to refer to future actions.

They can also be used with references to the future that are made in the past.

Example 4.6.1. *The company celebrates its 50th anniversary this year.*
After all, you're coming back next week.
The farmer just laughed and rode away. So the next week I tried my luck at another farm.
We arranged to meet in 3 weeks' time.

The adverbs *now, today, tonight*, and expressions involving *this* refer to a period of time that includes the present moment.

They are used fairly commonly with all verb forms.

This is because an event can be located before, during, or after the time specified by the verb form.

Example 4.6.2. *I was now in a Scottish regiment.*
Your boss will now have no alternative but to go to his superiors and explain the situation.
1 of my children wrote to me today.
I will ski no more today.
It's dark today.
'I went to the doctor this morning,' she said.
He won't be able to fight this Friday.
I'm doing my ironing this afternoon.

4.71 If you want to refer to time that follows a particular event or period of time, you use an adverb e.g. *soon* or *later*.

You can use an adverb e.g. *beforehand* or *earlier* to refer to time that preceded a particular period of time or an event.

Example 4.6.3. *Sita was delighted with the house and soon began to look on it as home.*
It'll have to be replaced soon.
He later settled in Peddle, a small town near Grahamstown.
I'll explain later.
I was very nervous beforehand.
You'll be having a bath and going to the hairdresser's beforehand.
She had seen him only 5 hours earlier.

This type of time reference is common with past and future forms.
It is sometimes used with present forms when they are used to refer to past, future, or habitual actions.

Example 4.6.4. *Sometimes I know beforehand what I'm going to talk about.*
I remember the next day at school going round asking the boys if they'd ever seen a ghost.
But afterwards, as you read on, you relate back to it.

Here is a list of adverbials that are used to refer to time in a relative way:

Example 4.6.5. *afterwards, at once, before long, eventually, finally, immediately, in a moment, instantly, later, later on, presently, shortly, soon, suddenly, within minutes, within the hour*
the next day/week/month/year, the following day/week/month/year, the day/week/month/year after
beforehand, early, earlier, earlier on, in advance, late, 1 day, on time, punctually

Note that in this list *presently* means *soon*.
You can use *early* to show that something happens before the expected or planned time, and *late* to indicate that it happens after that time.
On time and *punctually* are used to show that something happens at the planned time.
These adverbs come after the verb or at the end of the clause.

Example 4.6.6. *Tired out, he had gone to bed early.*
If you get to work early, you can get a lot done.
He had come to the political arena late, at the age of 62.
We went quite late in the afternoon.
If Atkinson phoned on time, he'd be out of the house in well under an hour.
He arrived punctually.

With *early* and *late* you can also use the comparative forms earlier and later.

Example 4.6.7. *I woke earlier than usual.*
Later, the dealer saw that it had been sold.

Note that *early, late*, and *on time* are also used after linking verbs.

Example 4.6.8. *The door bell rang. Barbara was appalled. 'They're early.'*
The Paris train was slightly late.
What time is it now? This bus is usually on time.

For more information on **linking verbs**, see paragraphs **3.126–3.181**.
4.72 You can also specify a time by relating it to an event, using a qualifying expression or a relative clause after the time adverbial.

Example 4.6.9. *I didn't sleep well the night before the prosecution.*
I called him the day I got back.

4.73 You can also use some prepositions to relate events to each other, or to particular period of time.
These prepositions are listed in paragraph **4.100**, and there is a full explanation in paragraphs **4.103–4.108**.

Example 4.6.10. *After the war, he returned to teaching.*
Joseph had been married prior to his marriage to Mary.
Wages have fallen during the last 2 months.

4.74 If you want to refer to a *necessary time*, beyond which an event will no longer be relevant, useful, or successful, you can use *in time*.

Example 4.6.11. *I had to walk fast to reach the restaurant in time.*
He leapt back, in time to dodge the train.

If something happens before the necessary time, you can use *too early*, and if it happens after the necessary time, you can use *too late*.

Example 4.6.12. *Today they grow up too early.*
It's much too early to assess the community service scheme.
They arrived too late for the information to be any good.
It's too late to change that now.

4.75 If the time you are referring to in the past or future has already been mentioned, you can use the adverb *then*.

Example 4.6.13. *We kept 3 monkeys then.*
We were all so patriotic then.
It'll be too late then.

To be more specific, you can use *that* with the name of a day, month, season, and so on, or with a general time word.

Example 4.6.14. *William didn't come in that Tuesday.*
So many people will be pursuing other activities that night.

4.6.1 Emphasizing the unexpected: continuing, stopping, or not happening

4.76 If you want to comment on the existence of the relationship between past, present, and future situations, you can use 1 of the following adverbials:

Example 4.6.15. *already, any longer, any more, as yet, no longer, so far, still, up till now, up to now, yet*

4.77 If you want to say that a situation exists up to the present time, you use *still*.
If you use *be* as a main verb or an auxiliary verb, you put *still* after *be* or the auxiliary.
If you use any simple verb except *be* you put *still* in front of the verb.
Still often suggests that the continuation of the situation is surprising or undesirable.

Example 4.6.16. *It's a marvel that I'm still alive to tell the tale.*
Male prejudice still exists in certain quarters.
Years had passed and they were still paying off their debts.

In negative statements that use the *n't* contraction, *still* is placed in front of *be* or the auxiliary.

Example 4.6.17. *We've been working on it for over 2 years now. And it still isn't finished.*
We still don't know where we're going.

4.78 You can also use *still* in front of a *to*-infinitive to say that something has not happened yet, although it is expected to, or you feel that it should.

Example 4.6.18. *The Government had still to agree on the provisions of the bill.*
The problems were still to come.
There are many other questions still to be answered.

Still is not used in negative statements in this way; see paragraph **4.79** for a similar use of *yet*.
4.79 If you want to indicate that something has not happened up to the present time, but is likely to happen in the future, you use *yet* with a negative.
Yet usually comes at the end of the clause.

Example 4.6.19. *We don't know the terms yet.*
I haven't set any work yet. I suppose I shall some day.
They haven't heard yet.

If you want to sound more emphatic, you can put *yet* before a simple verb or after the auxiliary and negative word.

Example 4.6.20. *No one yet knows exactly what it means.*
Her style had not yet matured.

Yet can also be used in questions, where it is usually put at the end of the clause.

Example 4.6.21. *Has she had the baby yet?*
Has Mr. Harris arrived yet?

In American English, when asking whether asking whether something has happened, it is more unusual to use the past simple with *yet*.

Example 4.6.22. *Did you eat yet?*
Did the kids see that movie yet?

4.80 You can also use *yet* in affirmative statements to say that something that is expected has not happened up to the present time.
In this case, *yet* is followed by a *to*-infinitive clause.

Example 4.6.23. *The true history of art in post-war America is yet to be written.*
He had yet to attempt to put principles into practice.

4.81 *Yet* is also used in affirmative statements with superlatives to show that the statement applies up to the present, but may not apply in the future.

Yet normally comes at the end of the clause.

Example 4.6.24. *This is the best museum we've visited yet.*
Mr. Fowler said that February had produced the best results yet.
This is the biggest and best version yet.

4.82 If you want to say that a situation that has existed up to the present time may change in the future, you can use *as yet, so far, up to now*, or *up till now.*

They are normally placed either at the beginning or the end of the clause.

They are also occasionally placed after an auxiliary verb.

Example 4.6.25. *As yet, no group has claimed responsibility for the attack.*
Only Mother knows as yet.
So far, the terms of the treaty have been carried out according to schedule.
You've done well so far, Mrs Rutland.
Up till now, the most extraordinary remark I remember was made by you.
... something he had up to now been reluctant to provide.
It's been quiet so far.
You haven't once up till now come into real contact with our authorities.

Note that these expressions can be used in affirmative and negative statements.

4.83 If you want to say that a past situation does not exist in the present, you can use *no longer*, or a negative with *any longer* or *any more.*

Example 4.6.26. *She was no longer content with a handful of coins.*
They didn't know any longer what was funny and what was entertaining.
They don't live together any more.

4.84 If you want to emphasize that a situation exists, rather than not yet having occurred, you use *already*,

It is usually put in front of any simple verb except *be*, or after *be* as a main verb, or following an auxiliary verb.

Example 4.6.27. *The energy already exists in the ground.*
Senegal already has a well established film industry.
He was just a year younger than Rudolph, but was already as tall and much stockier.
My watch says 9 o'clock. And it's already too hot to sleep.
Britain is already exporting a little coal.
We have already advertised your post in the papers.

In American English, when stating that something has happened, it is more usual to use the past simple with *already.*

Example 4.6.28. *We already advertised your post in the papers.*
The kids already saw that movie.

You can put *already* at the beginning or the end of the clause for emphasis.

Example 4.6.29. *Already robberies and lootings have increased.*
I was happy for her; she looked better already.

Already is not often used with the past simple, except with the verbs *be, have*, and *know.*

Note that *already* cannot normally be used in negative statements, but can be used in negative *if*-clauses, negative questions, and relative clauses.

Example 4.6.30. *Refer certain types of death to the coroner if this has not already been done.*
Those who have not already left are being advised to do so.
What does it show us that we haven't already felt?

4.7 Time adverbials & prepositional phrases

4.7.1 Specific times

4.85 Specific time adverbials are used after the verb *be* when you want to state the current time, day, or year.

Example 4.7.1. *'Well what time is it now?' - 'It's 1 o'clock'.*
It was a perfect May morning.
6 weeks isn't all that long ago, it's January.

They are also often used in prepositional phrases to say when something happened, or when it is expected to happen.

Example 4.7.2. *I got there at about 8 o'clock.*
The submarine caught fire on Friday morning.
That train gets in at 1800 hours.

4.86 Clock times are usually expressed in terms of hours and parts of an hour or minutes, e.g. *1 o'clock, 5 minutes past 1, 1:20, half past 1.*

The day is usually divided into 2 sets of 12 hours, so it is sometimes necessary to specify which set you mean by adding *a.m., p.m.*, or a prepositional phrase e.g. *in the morning* or *in the evening.*

In many official contexts, a 24 hour system is used.

If the hour is known, only the minutes are specified: *5 past, 10 to, quarter to, half past* and so on.

Midday and *noon* are occasionally used.

4.87 The most frequently used words for periods of the day are *morning, afternoon, evening*, and *night.*

There are also some words that refer to the rising and setting of the sun, e.g. *dusk* and *sunset*, and others that refer to mealtimes.

Example 4.7.3. *On a warm, cloudy evening, Colin went down to the river.*
They seem to be working from dawn to dusk.
Most of the trouble comes outside the classroom, at break-time and dinnertime.

Here is a list of words that are used to talk about periods of the day:

Example 4.7.4. *morning, afternoon, evening, night*
dawn, daybreak, 1st light, sunrise, dusk, sunset, nightfall
daytime, night-time, breakfast-time, break-time, lunchtime, teatime, dinnertime, suppertime, bedtime

4.88 The 7 days of the week are **proper nouns**:

Example 4.7.5. *Monday, Tuesday, Wednesday, Thursday, Friday, Saturday, Sunday*

Saturday and Sunday are often referred to as *the weekend*, and the other days as *weekdays.*

A few days in the year have special names, e.g.:

Example 4.7.6. *New Year's Day, Valentine's Day, Presidents' Day, Good Friday, Easter Monday, 4th of July, Labor Day, Halloween, Thanksgiving, Christmas Eve/Day, Boxing Day, New Year's Eve*

You can also name a day by giving its date using an **ordinal** number.

Example 4.7.7. *'When does your term end?' - '1st of July'.*
The Grand Prix is to be held here on the 18th July.
Her season of films continues until October the 9th.

You can omit the month if it is clear from the context which month you are referring to.

Example 4.7.8. *So Monday will be the 17th.*
St Valentine's Day is on the 14th.

There is more information about ordinals in the Reference section.

4.89 The 12 months of the year are **proper nouns**:

Example 4.7.9. *January, February, March, April, May, June, July, August, September, October, November, December*

There are 4 seasons: *spring, summer, autumn* (usually *fall* in American English) and *winter.*

Springtime, summertime, and *wintertime* are also used.

Some periods of the year have special names; e.g., *Christmas, Easter*, and *the New Year.*

4.90 Years are referred to in English by numbers.

When you are speaking, you refer to years before 2000 as *nineteen sixty-seven* (1967), or *seventeen hundred* (1700), e.g.

- ... the 11th of January, 1967.

  A 2nd conference was held in Feb 1988.

  My mother died in 1945.

When you are speaking, you refer to years between 2000 and 2009 as *two thousand* (2000) or *two thousand and eight* (2008), e.g.

Years after 2009 are said as either *two thousand and ten* (2010), *two thousand and eleven* (2011), etc. or as *twenty ten* (2010), *twenty eleven* (2011), etc.

To refer to periods longer than a year, decades (10 years) and centuries (a hundred years) are used.

Decades start with a year ending in 0 and finish with a year ending in 9: *the 1960s* (1960 to 1969), *the 1820s* (1820 to 1829).

If the century is already known, it can be omitted: *the 20s, the twenties, the Twenties.*

To be more specific, e.g. in historical dates, *AD* is added before or after the numbers for years or centuries after Jesus is believed to have been born: *1659 AD, AD 1650, AD 1650–53, 1650–53 AD.*

Some writers who prefer to avoid referring to religion use *CE*, which stands for *the Common Era: 1650 CE.*

BC (which stands for *Before Christ*) is added after the numbers for years or centuries before Jesus is believed to have been born: *1500 BC, 15–1200 BC.*

An alternative abbreviation that does not refer to religion is *BCE*, which stands fro *Before the Common Era.*

Centuries start with a year ending in 00 and finish with a year ending in 00.

Ordinals are used to refer to them.

The *1st century* was from *0 AD* to *99 AD*, the *2nd century* was *100–199 AD*, and so on, so the period *1800–1899 AD* was the *19th century* and the current century is the *twenty-first century* (2000–2099 AD).

Centuries can also be written using numbers: *the 21st century.*

4.91 If you want to say when something happens, you use *at* with clock times, periods of the year, and periods of the day except for *morning, evening, afternoon*, and *daytime.*

Example 4.7.10. *Our train went at 2.25.*

I got up at 8 o'clock.

The train should arrive at a quarter to one.

We go to church at Easter and Christmas.

I went down and fetched her back at the weekend.

On Tuesday evening, just at dusk, Brody had received an anonymous phone call.

He regarded it as his duty to come and read to me at bedtime.

At night we kept them shut up in a wire enclosure.

Let the fire burn out now. Who would see smoke at night-time anyway?

You can also use *at* with *time* and similar words e.g. *moment* and *juncture* and with units of clock time e.g. *hour* and *minute.*

Example 4.7.11. *General de Gaulle duly attended the military ceremony at the appointed time.*

It was at this juncture that his luck temporarily deserted him.

If I could have done it at that minute I would have killed him.

There were no lights at this hour, and roads, bungalows, and gardens lay quiet.

4.92 You can also use *at* when you want to relate the time of 1 event to another event e.g. a party, journey, election, and so on.

Example 4.7.12. *I had 1st met Kruger at a party at the British Embassy.*

She represented the Association at the annual meeting of the American Medical Association in Chicago.

It is to be reopened at the annual conference in 3 weeks' time.

4.93 *At* is also used with ages, stages of development, and points within a larger period of time.

Example 4.7.13. *At the age of 20, she married another Spanish dancer.*

He left school at 17.

At an early stage of the war the British Government began recruiting a team of top mathematicians and electronics experts.

We were due to return to the United Kingdom at the beginning of March.

4.94 If you want to mention the period of time in which something happens, you use *in* with centuries, years, seasons, months, and the periods of the day *morning, afternoon*, and *evening.*

You also ues *in* with *daytime* and *night-time.*

Example 4.7.14. *In the 16th century there were 3 tennis courts.*
It's true that we expected a great deal in the 60s.
Americans visiting Sweden in the early 1950s were astounded by its cleanliness.
If you were to go on holiday on the continent in wintertime what sport could you take part in?
To be in Cornwall at any time is a pleasure; to be here in summer is a bonus.
It's a lot cooler in the autumn.
She will preside over the annual meeting of the Court in December.
In September I traveled to California to see the finished film.
I'll ring the agent in the morning.
Well, she does come in to clean the rooms in the day-time.

Note that if *morning, afternoon*, and *evening* are used with a modifier or a following phrase or clause, you use *on*. See paragraph **4.96** for details.

4.95 *In* is also used when you want to specify a period of time, minutes, hours, days, and so on, using an **ordinal**.

Example 4.7.15. *Vehicle sales in the 1st 8 months of the year have plunged by 24.4 per cent.*
... in the early hours of the morning.

In is also used with some other nouns referring to events and periods of time.

Example 4.7.16. *My father was killed in the war.*
Everyone does unusual jobs in wartime.
In winter, we tend to get up later.
2 people came to check my room in my absence.

Ordinals are explained in paragraphs **2.232**–**2.239**.

4.96 If you want to mention the day when something happens, you use *on*.
You can do this with named days, with days referred to by ordinals, and with days referred to by a special term e.g. *birthday* or *anniversary*.

Example 4.7.17. *I'll send the cheque round on Monday.*
Everybody went to church on Christmas Day.
I hear you have bingo on Wednesday.
Pentonville Prison was set up on Boxing Day, 1842.
He was born on Apr 3, 1925 at 40 Grosvenor Road.
... the grey suit Elsa had bought for him on his birthday.
Many of Eisenhower's most cautious commanders were even prepared to risk attack on the 8th or 9th.
... addressing Parliament on the 36th anniversary of his country's independence.

You can use *the* with named days for emphasis or contrast, and *a* to indicate any day of that name.

Example 4.7.18. *He died on the Friday and was buried on the Sunday.*
We get a lot of calls on a Friday.

You also use *on* with *morning, afternoon, evening*, and *night* when they are modified or when they are followed by extra information in the form of a phrase or a clause.

Example 4.7.19. *... at 2.30 p.m. on a calm afternoon.*
There was another important opening on the same evening.
Tickets will be available on the morning of the performance.
It's terribly good of you to turn out on a night like this.

4.97 *On* is also used with words referring to travel e.g. *journey, trip, voyage, flight*, and *way* to say when something happened.

Example 4.7.20. *But on that journey, for the 1st time, Luce's faith in the eventual outcome was shaken.*
Eileen was accompanying her father to visit friends made on a camping trip the year before.

4.98 *On* can be used in a slightly formal way with nouns and *-ing* forms referring to actions or activities to show that 1 event occurs after another.

Example 4.7.21. *I shall bring the remaining 700 pounds on my return in 11 days.*

4.99 On the few occasions when people have to specify a time and date exactly, e.g. in legal English or formal documents, the usual order is: clock time, followed by period of day, day of week, and date.

Example 4.7.22. *... at 8 o'clock on the morning of Oct 29, 1618.*
... on the night of Thursday Jul 16.

4.7.2 Non-specific times

4.100 If you want to be less precise about when something happened, you can use a word like *around* or *about*.

Example 4.7.23. *At about 4 o'clock in the morning, we were awoken by a noise.*
The device that exploded at around midnight on Wednesday severely damaged the 4th-floor bar.
The supply of servants continued until about 1950, then abruptly dried up.
The attack began shortly before dawn.

Here is a list of words and expressions that you can use if you want to be less precise about when something happened:

Example 4.7.24. *about, almost, around, just after/before, nearly, round about, shortly after/before, soon after, thereabouts*

About, almost, around, nearly, and *round about* are usually used with clock times or years.
With *about, around*, and *round about*, the preposition *at* can often be omitted in informal English.

Example 4.7.25. *Then quite suddenly, round about midday, my mood began to change.*
About 9 o'clock he went out to the kitchen.

It is also possible to use prepositions to relate events to less specific points or periods of time, e.g. when the exact time of an event is not known, or when events happen gradually, continuously, or several times.

Example 4.7.26. *He developed central chest pain during the night.*
For, also over the summer, his book had come out.

Here is a list of prepositions that are used to relate events to a non-specific time:

Example 4.7.27. *after, before, by, during, following, over, prior to*

4.101 [!] *Almost* or *nearly* can only be used after the verb *be*.
4.102 You can also use *or thereabouts* after the time adverbial.

Example 4.7.28. *Back in 1975 or thereabouts someone lent me an article about education.*
... at 4 o'clock or thereabouts.

4.103 *During* can be used instead of *in* with periods of the day, months, seasons, years, decades, and centuries.

Example 4.7.29. *We try to keep people informed by post during September.*
She heated the place during the winter with a huge wood furnace.
During 1973 an Anti-Imperialist Alliance was formed.
During the Sixties various levies were imposed.
During the 17th century incendiary weapons were invented.
They used to spend the whole Sunday at chapel but most of them behaved shockingly during the week.

4.104 *During* is used with most event nouns to show that 1 event takes place while another is occurring.

Example 4.7.30. *During his stay in prison, he has written many essays and poems.*
... trying to boost police morale during a heated battle with rioters.
The young princes were protected from press intrusion during their education.
Some families live in the kitchen during a power cut.
During the journey I came to like and respect them.

4.105 [!] *During the week* means on weekdays, in contrast to the weekend.
4.106 *Over* can be used with *winter, summer*, and special periods of the year to show that an event occurred throughout the period or at an unspecified time during it.

Example 4.7.31. *... to keep their families going over the winter.*
My friends had a marvelous time over the New Year.

Over is also used when referring to a period of time immediately before or after the time of speaking or the time being talked about.

Example 4.7.32. *The number will increase considerably over the next decade.*
They have been doing all they can over the past 24 hours.
We packed up the things I had accumulated over the last 4 years.

Over can be used with meals and items of food or drink to show that something happens while people are eating or drinking.

Example 4.7.33. *Davis said he wanted to read it over lunch.*
Can we discuss it over a cup of coffee?

4.107 You can also be more general by stating the relationship between an event and a period of time or specific point in time.
Before, prior to, and *after* are used to relate events to a time.

Example 4.7.34. *She gets up before 6.*
If you're stuck, come back and see me before Thursday.
... the construction of warships by the major powers prior to 1914.
City Music Hall is going to close down after Easter.
He will announce his plans after the holidays.

They can also be used to relate 1 event to another.

Example 4.7.35. *I was in a bank for a while before the war.*
She gave me much helpful advice prior to my visit to Turkey.
Jack left after breakfast.
He was killed in a car accident 4 years after their marriage.
After much discussion, they had decided to take the coin to a jeweler.

Following, previous to and *subsequent to* can also be used with events.

Example 4.7.36. *He has regained consciousness following a stroke.*
He suggests that Ross was prompted previous to the parade.
The testimony and description of 1 witness would be supplied prior to the interview; those of the other 2 subsequent to it.

4.108 *Before* and *after* can also be used to show the order of events when the same person does 2 actions or 2 people do the same action.

Example 4.7.37. *I should have talked about that before anything else.*
He knew Nell would probably be home before him.
I do the floor after the washing-up.

You can also sometimes use *earlier than* or *later than*.

Example 4.7.38. *Smiling develops earlier than laughing.*

4.109 To indicate that 2 or more events happen at the same time, the adverbs *together* and *simultaneously*, or the adverbials *at the same time* and *at once* can be used:

Example 4.7.39. *Everything had happened together.*
His fear and his hate grew simultaneously.
Can you love 2 women at the same time?
I can't be everywhere at once.

4.110 You can also show what order things happen in using adverbs e.g. *1st, next*, and *finally*.
Simultaneously and *at the same time* are used in a similar way to link clauses.
This is dealt with in paragraph **10.53**.
4.111 *By* is used to emphasize that an event occurs at some time before a specific time, but not later.
By is also used to indicate that a process is completed or reaches a particular stage not later than a specific time.

Example 4.7.40. *By 11 o'clock, Brody was back in his office.*
The theory was that by Monday their tempers would have cooled.
By next week, there will be no supplies left.
Do you think we'll get to the top of this canyon by tomorrow?
By now the moon was up.
But by then he was bored with the project.

4.7.3 Extended uses of time adverbials

4.112 Time adverbials can be used after the noun phrase to specify events or periods of time.

Example 4.7.41. *I'm afraid the meeting this afternoon exhausted me.*
The sudden death of his father on Nov 17, 1960 was not a surprise.
... until I started to recall the years after the 2nd World War.
No admissions are permitted in the hour before closing time.

Clock times, periods of the day, days of the week, months, dates, seasons, special periods of the year, years, decades, and centuries can be used as modifiers before the noun phrase to specify things.

Example 4.7.42. *Every morning he would set off right after the 8 o'clock news.*
Castle was usually able to catch the 6 35 train from Euston.
He boiled the kettle for his morning tea.
He learned that he had missed the Monday flight.
I had summer clothes and winter clothes.
Ash had spent the Christmas holidays at Pelham Abbas.

Possessive forms can also be used.

Example 4.7.43. *... a discussion of the day's events.*
It was Jim Griffiths, who knew nothing of the morning's happenings.
The story will appear in tomorrow's paper.
This week's batch of government statistics added to the general confusion over the state of the economy.

4.8 Frequency & duration

4.113 Here is a list of units of time that are used when you are showing how often something happens, or how long it lasts or takes:

Example 4.8.1. *moment, second, minute, hour, day, night, week, fortnight, month, year, decade, century*

Fortnight is used only in the singular.

Moment is not used with numbers because it does not refer to a precise period of time, so you cannot say e.g. *It took 5 moments.*

[AE] *Fortnight* is not used in American English, where *2 weeks* is used instead.

Words for periods of the day, days of the week, months of the year, and seasons are also used, e.g. *morning, Friday, July*, and *winter*.

Clock times may also be used.

4.8.1 Talking about how frequently something happens

4.114 Some adverbials show approximately how many times something happens:

Example 4.8.2. *again and again, a lot, all the time, always, constantly, continually, continuously, ever, frequently, from time to time, hardly ever, infrequently, intermittently, much, never, normally, occasionally, often, over and over, periodically, rarely, regularly, repeatedly, seldom, sometimes, sporadically, usually*

Example 4.8.3. *I never did my homework on time.*
Sometimes I wish I was back in Africa.
We were always being sent home.
He laughed a lot.

Never is a negative adverb.

Example 4.8.4. *She never goes abroad.*

Ever is only used in questions, negative clauses, and *if*-clauses.

Example 4.8.5. *Have you ever been to a concert?*

Much is usually used with *not*.

Example 4.8.6. *The men didn't talk much to each other.*

Some adverbs of frequency e.g. *often* and *frequently* can also be used in the comparative and superlative.

Example 4.8.7. *Disasters can be prevented more often than in the past.*
I preached much more often than that.
They cried for their mothers less often than might have been expected.
... the mistakes that we make most frequently.

4.115 [i] To show how many times something happens, you can use a specific number, *several*, or *many* followed by *times*.

Example 4.8.8. *We had to ask 3 times.*
It's an experience I've repeated many times since.
He carefully aimed his rifle and fired several times.

If the number you are using is *one* you use *once* (not *1 time*) in this structure.
If it is *2* you can use *twice*.

Example 4.8.9. *I've been out with him once, that's all.*
The car broke down twice.

If something happens regularly, you can say how many times it happens within a period of time by adding *a* and a word referring to a period of time.

Example 4.8.10. *They group met once a week.*
You only have a meal 3 times a day.
The committee meets twice a year.

You can also use an adverb of frequency e.g. *once* with a unit of time preceded by *everyday* to say that something happens a specified number of times regularly within that unit of time.

Example 4.8.11. *The average Briton moves house once every 7 and a half years.*
We meet twice every Sunday.
3 times every day, he would come to the kiosk to check that we were all right.

If an event happens regularly during a specific period of the day, you can use the period of day instead of *times*:

Example 4.8.12. *I used to go in 3 mornings a week.*
He was going out 5 nights a week.

A regular rate or quantity can also be expressed by adding *a* and a general time word.
Per is sometimes used instead of *a*, especially in technical contexts.

Example 4.8.13. *He earns about £1000 a week.*
I was only getting 3 hours of sleep a night.
... rising upwards at the rate of 300 feet per second.
He hurtles through the air at 600 miles per hour.

4.116 If you want to be less precise about how frequently something happens, you can use 1 of the following words or expressions: *almost, about, nearly, or so, or less*, and *or more*.
You can use *almost* and *about* in front of *every*.

Example 4.8.14. *In the last month of her pregnancy, we went out almost every evening.*

You can also use almost in front of *-ly* time adverbs derived from general time words, e.g. *monthly, weekly*, and *daily*.

Example 4.8.15. *Small scale confrontations occur almost daily in many states.*

Or so, or less, and *or more* are used after frequency expressions, but not after adverbs of frequency.

Example 4.8.16. *Every hour or so, my shoulders would tighten.*
If the delay is 2 hours or more, the whole cost of the journey should be refunded.

4.117 If you want to say that something happens at regular intervals, you can use *every* followed by either a general or a specific unit of time.
Each is sometimes used instead of *every*.

Example 4.8.17. *We'll go hunting every day.*
You get a lump sum and you get a pension each week.
Some people write out a new address book every January.

Every can also be used with a number and the plural of the unit of time.

Example 4.8.18. *Every 5 minutes the phone would ring.*

The regular or average rate of quantity of something can also be expressed using *every* and *each*.

Example 4.8.19. *1 fighter jet was shot down every hour.*
... the 300,000 garments the factory produces each year.

4.118 [i] If something happens during 1 period of time but not during the next period, then happens again during the next, and so on, you can use *every other* followed by a unit of time or a specific time word.
Every second is sometimes used instead of *every other*.

Example 4.8.20. *We wrote to our parents every other day.*
Their local committees are usually held every other month.
He used to come and take them out every other Sunday.
It seemed easier to shave only every 2nd day.

Prepositional phrases with *alternate* and a plural time word can also be used.

Example 4.8.21. *On alternate Sunday nights, I tell the younger children a story.*
Just do some exercises on alternate days at 1st.

4.119 The adverbs *1st, next*, and *last* are used to show the stage at which an event takes place.
1st, the 1st time, and *for the 1st time* can indicate the 1st occurrence of an event.

Example 4.8.22. *He was, I think, in his early 60s when 1st encountered him.*
They had seen each other 1st a week before, outside this hotel.
... the tactical war games which were 1st fought in Ancient Greece.
It rained heavily twice while I was out. The 1st time I sheltered under a tree, but the 2nd time I walked through it.
For the 1st time Anne Marie felt frightened.

The repetition of an event or situation that has not happened for a long time can be indicated by using *for the 1st time* with *in* and the plural form of a general time word.

Example 4.8.23. *He was happy and relaxed for the 1st time in years.*

A future occurrence is indicated by *next time* or *the next time*.

Example 4.8.24. *Don't do it again. I might not forgive you next time.*
The next time I come here, I'm going to be better.

The use of *next* with statements referring to the future is described in paragraph **4.63**.
The most recent occurrence of an event can be indicated by using *last* as an adverb or the noun phrases *last time* or *the last time*.

Example 4.8.25. *He seemed to have grown a lot since he last wore it.*
He could not remember when he had last eaten.
When did you last see him?
You did so well last time.

The final occurrence can be indicated by *for the last time*.

Example 4.8.26. *For the last time he waved to the 3 friends who watched from above.*

The use of *last* in statements about the past is described in paragraph **4.41**.
You can also use *before, again*, and noun phrases with an ordinal and *time* to say whether an event is a 1st occurrence, or one that has happened before.
You can use *before* with a perfect form of a verb to show whether something is happening for the 1st time or whether it is a repeated occurrence.

Example 4.8.27. *I've never been in a policeman's house before.*
He's done it before.

The adverb *again* is used to talk about a second or subsequent occurrence of an event.

Ordinals can be used with *time*, in noun phrases or in more formal prepositional phrases with *for*, to specify a particular occurrence of a repeated event.

Example 4.8.28. *Someone rang the front door bell. He stood and listened and heard it ring again and then a 3rd time.*
We have no reliable information about that yet, he found himself saying for the 3rd time.

4.120 Some general time words can be changed into adverbs by adding *-ly* and used to show the frequency of an event.

Example 4.8.29. *hourly, daily, weekly, fortnightly, monthly, quarterly, yearly*

Note the spelling of *daily*.

The adverb *annually* and the adjective *annual* have the same meaning as *yearly*.

Example 4.8.30. *It was suggested that we give each child an allowance yearly or monthly to cover all he or she spends.*
She phones me up hourly.

The same words can be used as adjectives.

Example 4.8.31. *To this, we add a yearly allowance of £65.00 towards repairs.*
The media gave us hourly updates.
They had a long-standing commitment to making a weekly cash payment to mothers.

4.121 Prepositional phrases with plural forms of specific time words can also be used to indicate frequency.

E.g., *on* is used with days of the week; *during* and *at* are used with *weekends*.

Example 4.8.32. *We've had teaching practice on Tuesdays and lectures on Thursdays.*
She does not need help with the children during weekends.
We see each other at weekends.

[AE] In American English, and in informal British English, you can use the plural forms of specific time words without *on*.

Example 4.8.33. *She only works Wednesdays and Fridays.*
Thursday mornings I volunteer at the local senior center.
His radio program broadcasts Friday nights at 9.

In is used with periods of the day, except *night*.

Example 4.8.34. *I can't work full time. I only work in the afternoons, I have lectures in the mornings.*
Harry Truman loved to sit in an old rocking chair in the evenings and face the lawns behind the White House.

4.122 To show that something develops gradually, or happens at regular intervals, you can use a general time word with *by* followed by the same general time word.

Example 4.8.35. *She was getting older year by year, and lonelier, and more ridiculous.*
Millions of citizens follow, day by day, the unfolding of the drama.

Gradual development can also be indicated by the adverbs *increasingly* and *progressively*.

Example 4.8.36. *... the computers and information banks on which our world will increasingly depend.*
His conduct became increasingly eccentric.
As disposable income rises, people become progressively less concerned with price.

4.8.2 Talking about how long something lasts

4.123 The following section explains ways of showing how long something lasts or takes.

Some adverbs and adverbial expressions are used to show how long an event or state lasts.

Here is a list of adverbs that are used to show duration:

Example 4.8.37. *always, briefly, forever, indefinitely, long, overnight, permanently, temporarily*

Example 4.8.38. *She glanced briefly at Lucas Simmonds.*
You won't live forever.
The gates are kept permanently closed.

Briefly and *permanently* can be used in the comparative.

Example 4.8.39. *This new revelation had much the same outward effect, though more briefly.*
This is something I would like to do more permanently.

The form *long* is only used as an adverb in negatives and questions.

Example 4.8.40. *I haven't been in England long.*
How long does it take on the train?

In affirmative clauses, it is used in expressions e.g. *a long time* and prepositional phrases e.g. *for a long time.*
However, the comparative and superlative forms *longer* and *longest* can be used in affirmative and negative clauses.

Example 4.8.41. *Then of course you'll go with Parry. She's been your friend longer.*
I've been thinking about it a lot longer than you.
She remained the longest.

In affirmative and negative *if*-clauses, you can use *for long.*

Example 4.8.42. *If she's away for long we won't be able to wait.*

4.124 However, prepositional phrases are more commonly used.
The following prepositions are used in adverbials of duration:

Example 4.8.43. *after, before, for, from, in, since, throughout, to, until*

The prepositional object can be a noun phrase referring to a specific period of time.
This can be in the singular after the determiner *a* (or *one* for emphasis), or in the plural after a number or quantity expression.
The noun phrase can also refer to an indefinite period, e.g. expressions e.g. *a long time, a short while, a while*, or *ages*, or plural time words e.g. *hours.*
4.125 The preposition *for* indicates how long something continues to happen.

Example 4.8.44. *Is he still thinking of going away to Italy for a month?*
The initial battle continued for an hour.
This precious happy time lasted for a month or 2.
For the next week, she did not contact him.
We were married for 15 years.
I didn't speak for a long time.
She would have liked to sit for a while and think.

You use *the* instead of *a* when the period of time is already known, with seasons, periods of the day, and *weekend*, or when you modify the time word with words like *past, coming, following, next, last*, or an **ordinal**.

Example 4.8.45. *Tell Aunt Elizabeth you're off for the day.*
We've been living together for the past year.
For the 1st month or 2 I was bullied constantly.
For the next few days he had to stay in bed.
Put them in cold storage for the winter.
I said I'm off to Brighton for the weekend.

Remember that you do not use a determiner with special periods of the year.

Example 4.8.46. *At least come for Christmas.*

4.126 *For* can also be used with specific time adverbials to show the time when something is to be used, not how long it takes or lasts.

Example 4.8.47. *Everything was placed exactly where I wanted it for the morning.*

4.127 *For* can also be used in negative statements when you want to say that something need not or will not happen until a certain period of time has passed.
Yet is often added.

Example 4.8.48. *It won't be ready to sail for another 3 weeks.*
I don't have to decide for a month yet.

4.128 *For* is used with a plural noun phrase to emphasize how long something lasts.

Example 4.8.49. *Settlers have been coming here for centuries.*
I don't think he's practiced much for years.
I've been asking you about these doors for months.

4.129 [i] You can also use a general time word with *after* followed by the same general time word to emphasize that a state continues for a long time or that an action is repeated continuously for a long time.

Example 4.8.50. *I wondered what kept her in Paris decade after decade.*
They can go on making losses, year after year, without fearing that they will go bust.

4.130 *In* is used to indicate that something happens or will happen before the end of a certain period of time.
In more formal English *within* is used.

Example 4.8.51. *Can we get to the airport in an hour?*
That coat must have cost you more than I earn in a year.
The face of a city can change completely in a year.
They should get the job finished within a few days.

4.131 *In* and *within* are also used to show that something only took or takes a short time.

Example 4.8.52. *The clouds evaporated in seconds.*
What an expert can do in minutes may take you hours to accomplish.
Within a few months, the barnyard had been abandoned.

4.132 *For* and *in* can be used in negative statements to say that something does not happen during a period of time.
You can use them in this way with specific units of time, and with more general time references.

Example 4.8.53. *He hadn't had a proper night's sleep for a month.*
I haven't seen a chart for 40 years!
The team had not heard from Stabler in a month.
He hasn't slept in a month.
I haven't seen him for years.
Let's have a dinner party. We haven't had one in years.
I haven't fired a gun in years.

4.133 Note that with the verbs *last, wait*, and *stay*, which have duration as part of their meaning, the adverbial can be a noun phrase instead of a prepositional phrase with *for*.

Example 4.8.54. *The campaign lasts 4 weeks at most.*
His speech lasted for exactly 14 and a half minutes.
'Wait a minute,' the voice said.
He stayed a month, 5 weeks, 6 weeks.

The verbs *take* and *spend* can also indicate duration but the adverbial can only be a noun phrase.

Example 4.8.55. *It took me a month to lose that feeling of being a spectator.*
What once took a century now took only 10 months.
He spent 5 minutes washing and shaving.

4.134 If you want to be less precise about how long something lasts, you can use 1 of the following words or expressions: *about, almost, nearly, around, more than, less than*, and so on.

Example 4.8.56. *They've lived there for more than 30 years.*
They have not been allowed to form unions for almost a decade.
The 3 of us traveled around together for about a month that summer.
In less than a year, I learned enough Latin to pass the entrance exam.
He had been in command of HMS Churchill for nearly a year.

When you make a general statement about the duration of something, you can indicate the maximum period of time that it will last or take by using *up to*.

Example 4.8.57. *Refresher training for up to 1 month each year was the rule for all.*

You can also use expressions e.g. *or so, or more, or less*, and *or thereabouts* to make the duration less specific.

Example 4.8.58. *He has been writing about tennis and golf for 40 years or so.*
Our species probably practiced it for a million years or more.
... hopes which have prevailed so strongly for a century or more.

Almost, about, nearly, and *thereabouts* are also used when talking about when an event takes place; see paragraph **4.100** for details of this.

4.8.3 Talking about the whole of a period

4.135 If you want to emphasize that something lasts for the whole of a period of time, you can use *all* as a determiner with many general time words.

Example 4.8.59. *'I've been wanting to do this all day,' she said.*
I've been here all night.
They said you were out all afternoon.
We've not seen them all summer.

You can also use *whole* as a modifier in front of a general time word.

Example 4.8.60. *It took me the whole of my 1st year to adjust.*
... scientists who are monitoring food safety the whole time.
... people who have not worked for a whole year.

You can also use *all through, right through*, and *throughout* with *the* and many general time words, or with a specific decade, year, month, or special period.

Example 4.8.61. *Discussions and arguments continued all through the day.*
Right through the summer months they are rarely out of sight.
Throughout the 60s, man's 1st voyage to other worlds came closer.

Words referring to events are sometimes used instead of the time words to emphasize that something happened for the entire duration of the event.

Example 4.8.62. *He wore an expression of angry contempt throughout the interrogation.*
A patient reported a dream that had recurred throughout her life.
All through the cruelly long journey home, he lay utterly motionless.

4.136 If you want to emphasize that something happens all the time, you can list periods of the day or seasons of the year, or mention contrasting ones.

Example 4.8.63. *... people coming in morning, noon, and night.*
I've worn the same suit summer, winter, autumn and spring, for 5 years.
Thousands of slave laborers worked night and day to build the fortifications.
10 gardeners used to work this land, winter and summer.
Each family was filmed 24/7 for 6 weeks.

24/7 is an abbreviation of *24 hours a day, 7 days a week.*
It is used in informal English and in journalism.

4.8.4 Showing the start or end of a period

4.137 You can also show how long a situation lasts by using prepositional phrases to give the time when it begins or the time when it ends, or both.

If you want to talk about a situation that began in the past and is continuing now, or to consider a period of it from a time in the past to the present, you use the preposition *since* with a time adverbial or an event to show when the situation began.

The verb is in the present perfect.

Example 4.8.64. *I've been here since 12 o'clock.*
I haven't had a new customer in here since Sunday.
Since January, there hasn't been any more trouble.
I haven't been out since Christmas.
The situation has not changed since 2001.
There has been no word of my friend since the revolution.

Since is also used to indicate the beginning of situations that ended in the past.
The verb is in the past perfect.

Example 4.8.65. *I'd been working in London sine January at a firm called Kendalls.*
He hadn't prayed once since the morning.
I'd only had 2 sandwiches since breakfast.

Since can also be used with other prepositional phrases that indicate a point in time.

Example 4.8.66. *I haven't seen you since before the summer.*

The noun phrase after *since* can sometimes refer to a person or thing rather than a time or event, especially when used with a superlative, *1st*, or *only*, or with a negative.

Example 4.8.67. *They hadn't seen each other since Majorca.*
I have never had another dog since Jonnie.
Ever since London, I've been working towards this.

4.138 The time when a situation began can also be shown by using the preposition *from* and adding the adverb *on* or *onwards*.
The noun phrase can be a date, an event, or a period.
The verb can be in the past simple or in a perfect form.

Example 4.8.68. *... the history of British industry from the mid 60s on.*
From the 18th century on, great private palaces went up.
But from the mid-1960s onwards the rate of public welfare spending has tended to accelerate.
The family size starts to influence development from birth.
They never perceived that they themselves had forced women into this role from childhood.
... the guide who had been with us from the beginning.

4.139 You can also use the preposition *after* to give the time when a situation began.

Example 4.8.69. *They don't let anybody in after 6 o'clock.*
After 1929 I concentrated on canvas work.
He'd have a number of boys to help him through the summertime but after October he'd just have the one.

4.140 Similarly, if you want to say that a situation continues for some time and then stops, you can indicate the time when it stops by using the preposition *until* with a time adverbial or an event.

Example 4.8.70. *The school was kept open until 10 o'clock 5 nights a week.*
They danced and laughed and talked until dawn.
She walked back again and sat in her room until dinner.
I've just discovered she's only here until Sunday.
He had been willing to wait until the following summer.
Until the end of the 18th century little had been known about Persia.
Until that meeting, most of us knew very little about him.

Until can also be used in negative clauses to say that something did not or will not happen before a particular time.

Example 4.8.71. *We won't get them until September.*
My plane does not leave until tomorrow morning.

Until is also used with other prepositional phrases that indicate a point in time.

Example 4.8.72. *I decided to wait until after Easter to visit John.*

Some people use *till* instead of *until*, especially in informal English.

Example 4.8.73. *Sometimes I lie in bed till 9 o'clock.*

Up to and *up till* are also sometimes used, mainly before *now* and *then*.

Example 4.8.74. *Up to now, I have been happy with his work.*
It was something he had never even considered up till now.
I had a 3-wheel bike up to a few years ago but it got harder and harder to push it along.
Up to 1989, growth averaged 1 per cent.

4.141 You can also use the preposition *before* to indicate when a situation ends.

Example 4.8.75. *Before 1716 Cheltenham had been a small market town.*

4.142 The duration of a situation or event can be shown by saying when it begins and when it ends.
You can use *from* to show when it begins and *to, till*, or *until* to show when it ends.

Example 4.8.76. *The Blitz on London began with nightly bombings from Sep 7 to Nov 2.*
They are active in the line from about January until October.
They seem to be working from dawn till dusk.

You an also use *between* and *and* instead of *from* and *to*.

Example 4.8.77. *The car is usually in the garage between Sunday and Thursday in winter.*

[AE] In American English, *through* is often placed between the 2 times:

Example 4.8.78. *The chat show goes out midnight through 6 a.m.*

If you are using figures to refer to 2 times or years, you can separate them with a dash, instead of using *from* and *to*.

Example 4.8.79. *... open 10-5 weekdays, 10-6 Saturdays and 2-6 Sundays.*

4.8.5 Using time expressions to modify nouns

4.143 You can also use time expressions involving a **cardinal number** and a general time word to modify nouns.
Note that an apostrophe is added to the time word.

Example 4.8.80. *4 of those were sentenced to 15 days' detention.*
They want to take on staff with 2 years' experience.

This use of cardinal numbers is described in paragraph **2.231**.
4.144 Time expressions are also used as **compound adjectives** to modify countable nouns.

Example 4.8.81. *They all have to start off with a 6-month course in German.*
I arrived at the University for a 3-month stint as a visiting lecturer.

Compound adjectives are explained in paragraphs **2.94–2.102**.

Chapter 5

Varying the message: modals, negatives, & ways of forming sentences

5.1 This chapter deals with 3 different ways in which the meaning of a sentence can be varied, by altering the order of words or by adding other words to the verb phrase.

Paragraphs **5.2**–**5.48** explain how to form statements, questions, orders, and suggestions.

Paragraphs **5.49**–**5.49** explain how **negative words** are used to talk about the opposite of something or the absence of something.

Paragraphs **5.94**–**5.258** explain how **modals** are used to talk about possibility, or to show the attitude of the speaker.

5.1 Statements, questions, orders, & suggestions

5.2 Sentences are used to do many different things.

The most common use is to give information.

Example 5.1.1. *I went to Glasgow University.*
Carol was 1 of my sister's best friends.

Sometimes you use a sentence to obtain information, rather than to give it.

Example 5.1.2. *Where is my father?*
What did you say to Myra?
How long have you been out of this country?

At other times you want to express an opinion, give an order, make a suggestion, or make a promise.

Example 5.1.3. *That's an excellent idea.*
Go away, all of you.
Shall we listen to the news?
If you have any questions, I'll do my best to answer them.

When someone says or writes a sentence, they need to show what they are trying to do with it, so that it will be clear, e.g., that they are asking a question and not making a statement.

5.3 Often it is the order of words that indicates which way a sentence is being used.

E.g., if you say *He is Norwegian*, the word order makes it clear that you are making a statement.

If you say *Is he Norwegian?*, the word order indicates that you are asking a question.

Another way of showing which way a sentence is being used is to begin it with a verb, rather than with the subject.

E.g., if you say *Give this book to Michael*, it is clear that you are giving an order or instruction, rather than making a statement or asking a question.

5.4 There are 3 main ways of showing what type of sentence is being used in English.

These sentence-types are used for forming statements, questions, and ordres.

The **declarative** form is used in most main clauses.

Statements are almost always made using the declarative form.

When a clause is in the declarative, the subject is placed in front of the verb.

The declarative is sometimes called the **indicative**.

Example 5.1.4. *I want to talk to Mr Castle*
Gertrude looked at Anne.
We'll give you 15 pounds now.

The **interrogative** form is usually used in questions.
In clauses, the subject is often placed after the main verb or after an auxiliary verb.

Example 5.1.5. *Is she very upset?*
Where is my father?
Have you met Harry?
Did you give him my letter?

The **imperative** is used to try to direct someone's actions.
In clauses, the subject is usually omitted and the **base form** of the verb is used.

Example 5.1.6. *Come back this minute.*
Show me the complete manuscript.

There is a 4th form called the **subjunctive**.
This is a feature of English verbs that sometimes occurs in subordinate clauses.
The subjunctive is not used to distinguish between different uses of language, and is therefore not dealt with in this chapter.
Clauses in which the subjunctive occurs are explained in paragraphs **7.43, 8.41**, and **8.48**.
5.5 The ways in which these different structures are used are explained in the following paragraphs.
Paragraphs **5.6**–**5.9** explain how the declarative is used to make statements.
Paragraphs **5.10**–**5.36** explain how the interrogative is used to ask questions.
Paragraphs **5.37**–**5.41** explain how the imperative is used to try to direct someone's actions.
Other uses of the declarative, interrogative, and imperative are explained in paragraphs **5.42**–**5.48**.

5.1.1 Making statements: the declarative form

5.6 When you are giving information, you use the **declarative** form.

Example 5.1.7. *We ate dinner at 6.*
I like reading poetry.
Officials have refused to comment.

5.7 When you are expressing an opinion, you usually use the declarative form.

Example 5.1.8. *I think she is a brilliant writer.*
It's a good thing Father is deaf.
He ought ot have let me know he was going out.

5.8 When you make a promise, you use the declarative form.

Example 5.1.9. *I shall do everything I can to help you.*
I'll have it sent down by special delivery.

5.9 You can emphasize a statement by putting *do, does*, or *did* in front of the **base form** of the verb.

Example 5.1.10. *I do feel sorry for Roger.*
A little knowledge does seem to be a dangerous thing.
He had no time to spend time with his family, but he did bring home a regular salary.

5.1.2 Asking questions: the interrogative form

5.10 When you ask a question, you usually use the **interrogative** form.
5.11 There are 2 main types of question.
Questions that can be answered by *yes* or *no* are called *yes/no*-questions.

Example 5.1.11. *'Is he your only child?' - 'Yes.'*
'Are you planning to marry soon?' - 'No.'
'Can I help you?' - 'Yes, I'd like to book a single room, please.'
'Are you interested in racing?' - 'Yes, I love it.'
'Are you a singer as well as an actress?' - 'No, I'm not a singer at all.'
'Do you like it?' - 'Yes, I really like it.'

The actual answer to a *yes/no*-question is not always *yes* or *no*.

E.g., if you ask someone *Do you read in bed?*, they might say *Sometimes* or *Never*.

If you say to someone *Do you like jazz?*, they might say *I think it's great*.

But the questions *Do you read in bed?* and *Do you like jazz?* are still *yes/no*-questions, because *yes* and *no* are the type of answers the questioner expects.

Sometimes will be interpreted as a weak *yes* answer, *never* as a strong *no* answer, and *I think it's great* as a strong *yes* answer.

Yes/no-questions are fully explained in paragraphs **5.12**–**5.22**.

The other main type of question begins with a *wh*-word e.g. *what, where*, or *when*.

When you ask a question of this type, the answer cannot be *yes* or *no*.

Example 5.1.12. *'Who gave you my number?' - 'Your mother did.'*
'Why didn't you ask me?' - 'I was afraid to.'
'Where is he now?' - 'He's at university.'

This type of question is called a *wh*-question.

When *wh*-words are used as pronouns or adverbs at the beginning of a *wh*-question, they are called **interrogative pronouns** or **interrogative adverbs**.

Wh-questions are explained in paragraphs **5.23**–**5.36**.

5.1.3 *Yes/no*-questions

5.12 In a *yes/no*-question, if there is an auxiliary verb, the auxiliary verb comes 1st, followed by the subject, then the main verb.

Example 5.1.13. *Are you staying here, by any chance?*
Will they win again?
Will they like my garden?
Can he read yet?

If there is more than 1 auxiliary verb, the 1st auxiliary verb comes at the beginning of the clause, followed by the subject, followed by the other verbs.

Example 5.1.14. *Had he been murdered?*
Has it been thrown away, perhaps?

For information about auxiliaries, see the Reference section.

5.13 If there is no auxiliary verb, you put *do, does*, or *did* at the beginning of the clause, in front of the subject, followed by the base form of the main verb.

Example 5.1.15. *Do you understand what I'm saying?*
Does it hurt much?
Did you meet George in France?

Note that if the main verb is *do*, you still put *do, does*, or *did* at the beginning of the clause, in front of the subject.

Example 5.1.16. *Do they do the work themselves?*
Does David do this sort of thing often?

5.14 If the verb is *be*, you do not use *do*.

You simply put the verb at the beginning of the clause, followed by the subject.

Example 5.1.17. *Are you okay?*
Is she Ricky's sister?
Am I right?
Was it lonely without us?

If the verb is *have*, you usually put *do, does*, or *did* at the beginning of the clause, in front of the subject.

Example 5.1.18. *Do passengers have rights?*
Does anyone have a question?
Did you have a good flight?

However, when you use *have* in the sense of *own* or *possess*, you do not need to use *do, does*, or *did*.
You can simply put *have, has*, or *had* at the beginning of the clause.
This is a slightly formal use.

Example 5.1.19. *Have we anything else we ought to talk about 1st?*
Has he any idea what it's like?

If you use *have got* or *has got* in a *yes/no*-question, you put *have* or *has* at the beginning of the clause, followed by the subject, followed by *got*.

Example 5.1.20. *Have you got any brochures on Holland?*
Has she got a car?

Have got and *has got* are explained in paragraph **3.15**.

5.1.4 Making a question more polite

5.15 You can make a question or request softer or more polite by beginning with n expression like *Do you know...* or *Could you tell me...*
This type of question is called an **indirect question**.
Here are some expressions you can use to make questions more polite:

- Could you tell me...
- Do you know...
- Do you have any idea...
- Would you mind telling me...

When 1 of these introductory expressions is used, the word order of the rest of the sentence is the same as in an affirmative statement.

Example 5.1.21. *Could you tell me what time the train leaves?*
Do you know where he lives?
Do you have any idea what's happening?
Would you mind telling me how old you are?

When you answer a question of this type, the answer is usually *yes* or *no*, followed by the information asked for.

Example 5.1.22. *'Could you tell me what time the train leaves?' - 'Yes, it leaves at 3 o'clock.'*
'Do you know where he lives?' - 'Yes, in the farm up on the hill.'
'Do you have any idea what's happening?' - 'No, I'm afraid not!'
'Would you mind telling me how old you are?' - 'Not at all. I'm 52.'

Note that the 'positive' answer to a question beginning *Would you mind telling me...* is *No* or *Not at all*.
It means *No, I wouldn't mind* (= *Yes, that's fine*).

5.1.5 Making a statement into a question: question tags

5.16 You can ask for confirmation that something is true by making a statement in the declarative, then adding an expression e.g. *isn't it?* or *was she?*
Constructions like these are called **question tags**.
Question tags are most often used in spoken English.
5.17 Question tags are formed using an auxiliary or a form of *be* or *do*, followed by a personal pronoun referring to the subject.
If the main clause is in the affirmative, you use a negative tag.
Negative tags are always contracted, except in old-fashioned or very formal English.

Example 5.1.23. *It is quite warm, isn't it?*

If the main clause is in the negative, you use an affirmative tag.

Example 5.1.24. *You didn't know I was an artist, did you?*

If the main clause of your statement has an auxiliary in it, you use the same auxiliary in the tag.

Example 5.1.25. *You will stay in touch, won't you?*

If the main clause has the past simple or present simple form of *be* as the main verb, you use this in the tag.

Example 5.1.26. *They are, aren't they?*

If the main clause does not have an auxiliary or the verb *be*, you use *do, does*, or *did* in the tag.

Example 5.1.27. *After a couple of years the heat gets too much, doesn't it?*
He played for Ireland, didn't he?

Note that the negative tag with *I* is *aren't I*, even though *am* is the auxiliary or main verb in the main clause.

Example 5.1.28. *I'm controlling it, aren't I?*

5.18 If you have an opinion or belief about something and you want to check that it is true, or to find out if someone agrees with you, you can make a statement and add a question tag after it to make it into a question.

If you are making an affirmative statement and you want to check that it is true, you use a negative question tag.

Example 5.1.29. *You like Ralph a lot, don't you?*
They are beautiful places, aren't they?

If you are making a negative statement and want to check that it is true, you use an affirmative tag.

Example 5.1.30. *It doesn't work, does it?*
You won't tell anyone else all this, will you?

You can also use an affirmative tag if your statement contains a broad negative, a negative adverb, or a negative pronoun.

Example 5.1.31. *That hardly counts, does it?*
You've never been to Benidorm, have you?
Nothing had changed, had it?

5.19 The person you are speaking to replies to the content of your statement rather than to the tag, and confirms an affirmative statement with *yes* and a negative statement with *no*.

Example 5.1.32. *'It became stronger, didn't it?' - 'Yes it did.'*
'You didn't know that, di you?' - 'No.'

5.20 If you are making a statement about yourself and you want to check if the person you are talking to has the same opinion or feeling, you can put a tag with *you* after your statement.

Example 5.1.33. *I think this is the best thing, don't you?*
I love tea, don't you?

Question tags can also be used to show your reaction to something that someone has just said or implied, e.g. to show interest, surprise, or anger.

Note that you use an affirmative tag after an affirmative statement.

Example 5.1.34. *You fell on your back, did you?*
You've been to North America before, have you?
Oh, he wants us to make films as well, does he?

When using *let's* to suggest doing something, you can add the tag *shall we* to check that the people you are talking to agree with you.

Example 5.1.35. *Let's forget it, shall we?*

If you are suggesting that you do something and you want to check that the person you are speaking to agrees, you can add the tag *shall I?*

Example 5.1.36. *I'll call the doctor, shall I?*

If you are telling someone to do something and you want to make your order sound less forceful, you can do so by adding a question tag.

The tag is usually *will you*, but *won't you* and *can't you* are also used.

Example 5.1.37. *Come into the kitchen, will you?*
Look at that, will you?
See that she gets safely back, won't you?

When you are using a negative imperative, you can only use *will you* as a tag.

Example 5.1.38. *Don't tell Howard, will you?*

You can also add an affirmative tag e.g. *are you?* to an affirmative statement if you want to show interest in a piece of information.

Example 5.1.39. *So, you're leaving us, are you?*
He's a friend of yours, is he?

5.21 In informal spoken English, you can use a 1-word all-purpose question tag e.g. *right?* or *eh?*

Example 5.1.40. *You're American, right?*
He's a lawyer, right?
Let's talk about something else, eh?
Not good, eh?

In some varieties of English, particularly those spoken in India, Singapore and Malaysia, *isn't it?* is used as an all-purpose question tag.

Example 5.1.41. *We've seen that film already, isn't it?*
They're arriving tomorrow, isn't it?

Informal multicultural British English uses the common all-purpose question tag *innit* (a shortened form of *isn't it*), both with and without a rising question mark.

Example 5.1.42. *It makes you think though, innit?*
It's all just a bit of fun, innit?
So eventually he gave me the sack, innit.

5.1.6 *Either/or*-questions

5.22 You sometimes ask a question in which you mention 2 or more possible answers.
You link the possible answers with *or*.
E.g., you might say *Is he awake or asleep?* or *Do you like your coffee white or black?*
You expect the actual answer to your question to be 1 of the answers you have mentioned.
Words, phrases, and clauses can all be linked in this way.
Questions like these are sometimes called *either/or*-questions.

Example 5.1.43. *'Is it a boy or a girl?' - 'A beautiful boy.'*
'Was it healthy or diseased?' - 'Diseased, I'm afraid.'
'Shall we take the bus or do you want to walk?' - 'Let's walk, shall we?'

5.1.7 *Wh*-questions

5.23 When you ask someone a *wh*-question, you want them to specify a particular person, thing, place, reason, method, time, or amount.
You do not expect them to answer *yes* or *no*.
5.24 *Wh*-questions begin with a *wh*-word.
Wh-words are a set of pronouns, adverbs, and determiners which all, with the exception of *how*, began with *wh-*.
Here is a list of the main *wh*-words:

Example 5.1.44. *how, what, when, where, which, who, whom, whose, why*

5.25 When a *wh*-word is the subject of a verb, or when it forms part of the subject, the word order of the clause is the same as that of a clause in the declarative, i.e. the subject is put 1st, followed by the verb.

Example 5.1.45. *Who invited you?*
And then what happened?
Which mattress is best?

5.26 When a *wh*-word is the object of a verb or preposition, or when it forms part of the object, or when it is an adverb, the position of the subject is the usual one in the interrogative form; i.e., it comes after the 1st verb in the clause.

Example 5.1.46. *What am I going to do without you?*
Which graph are you going to use?
Why would Stephen lie to me?
When would you be coming down?

If you are using the **present simple** or the **past simple** of any verb except *be*, you put *do, does*, or *did* in front of the subject.

Example 5.1.47. *What do you really think?*
Which department do you want?
Where does she live?
How do you know what it's like?
When did you last see John Cartwright?

If you are using the present simple or the past simple of *be*, the main verb goes in front of the subject.
You do not use *do, does*, or *did*.

Example 5.1.48. *Where is the station?*
How was your meeting?
When was the last time you cleaned the garage?

5.27 In conversation, a *wh*-question sometimes consists of a *wh*-word on its own.
E.g., if you say to someone *I'm learning to type*, they might say *Why?*, meaning *Why are you learning to type?*

Example 5.1.49. *'He saw a snake.' - 'Where?'*
'I have to go to Germany.' - 'When?'
'I knew you were landing today.' - 'How?'

A *wh*-question can also consist of a noun phrase containing a *wh*-word.
E.g., if you say to someone *I gave your book to that girl*, they might say *Which girl?*, meaning *Which girl did you give my book to?*

Example 5.1.50. *'He knew my cousin.' - 'Which cousin?'*
'Who was your friend?' - 'What friend?'

5.28 The pronoun *who* is used to ask questions about a person's identity.
Who can be the subject or object of a verb.

Example 5.1.51. *Who discovered this?*
Who were here friends?
Who is Michael Howard?
Who did he marry?

In more formal English, *whom* is sometimes used instead of *who* as the object of a verb.

Example 5.1.52. *Whom shall we call?*
Whom did you see?

Who and *whom* can also be the object of a preposition.
When *who* is the object of a preposition, the preposition is put at the end of the clause.

Example 5.1.53. *Who did you dance with?*
Who do I pay this to?

When *whom* is the object of a preposition, the preposition is put at the beginning of the clause, in front of *whom*.

Example 5.1.54. *For whom was he working while in Baghdad?*
To whom is a broadcaster responsible?

In informal spoken English, *who* is sometimes used after a preposition.

Example 5.1.55. *So you report to who?*

This use is especially common when you leave out part of the question.

Example 5.1.56. *'They were saying horrible things.' - 'Really? To who?'*
'It could be difficult.' - 'For who?'

5.29 *Whose* is used as a determiner or pronoun to ask which person something belongs to or is associated with.

Example 5.1.57. *Whose children did you think they were?*
Whose coat was it?
Whose is that?

5.30 *Which* is used as a pronoun or determiner to ask someone to identify a specific person or thing out of a number of people or things.

Example 5.1.58. *Which is the best restaurant?*
Which is her room?
Which do you like best?
Which doctor do you want to see?

When *which* is a determiner, it can be part of the object of a preposition.
The preposition is actually put at the end of the question.

Example 5.1.59. *Which station did you come from?*
Which character did you like most?

5.31 *When* is used to ask questions about the time something happened, happens, or will happen.

Example 5.1.60. *When did you find her?*
When do we have supper?
Ginny, when are you coming home?

Where is used to ask questions about place, position, or direction.

Example 5.1.61. *Where does she live?*
Where are you going?
Where do you go to complain?

5.32 *Why* is used to ask a question about the reason for something.

Example 5.1.62. *Why are you here?*
Why does Amy want to go and see his grave?
Why does she treat me like that when we're such old friends?

Why is sometimes used without a subject and with the base form of a verb, usually to ask why an action is or was necessary.

Example 5.1.63. *Why wake me up?*
Why bother about me?
Why make a point of it?

Why not can be used with the base form of a verb, in order to make a suggestion or to ask why a particular action has not been taken.

Example 5.1.64. *Why not end it now?*
Why not read a book?
If you have money in the bank, why not use it?

5.33 *How* is usually used to ask about the method used for doing something, or about the way in which something can be achieved.

Example 5.1.65. *How do we open it?*
How are you going to get that?
How could he explain it to her?
How did he know when you were coming?

How is also used to ask questions about the way a person feels, about the way someone or something looks, or about the way something sounds, feels, or tastes.

Example 5.1.66. *How are you feeling today?*
'How do I look?' - 'Very nice.'
How did you feel when you stood up in front of the class?

5.34 *How* can be combined with other words at the beginning of questions.
How many and *how much* are used to ask what number of things there are or what amount of something there is.
How many is followed by a plural countable noun.

Example 5.1.67. *How many people are there?*
How many languages can you speak?
How many times have you been?

How much is followed by an uncountable noun.

Example 5.1.68. *How much money have we got in the bank?*
Just how much time have you been devoting to this?

How many and *how much* can be used without a following noun when you do not need to make it clear what sort of thing you are talking about.

Example 5.1.69. *How many did you find?*
How much did he tell you?
How much does it cost?
How much do they really understand?

How long is used to ask about the length of a period of time.

Example 5.1.70. *How long have you lived here?*
How long will it take?
How long can she live like this?
How long ago was that?

How long is also used to ask questions about the length of something.

Example 5.1.71. *How long is this road?*

How far is used in questions about distance and extent.

Example 5.1.72. *How far can we see?*
How far is it to Montreal from here?
How far have you got with your homework?

You can combine *how* with an adjective when you are asking to what extent something has a particular quality or feature.

Example 5.1.73. *How big is your flat?*
How old are your children?

How come? is an informal way of asking *why?*
It is normally used only in speech.

Example 5.1.74. *How come you know so much about Linda?*

5.35 *What* can be a pronoun or determiner, or it can be used in combination with *if* or *for*.
What is used as a pronoun to find out various kinds of specific information, e.g. details of an event, the meaning of a word or expression, or the reason for something.

Example 5.1.75. *What's wrong with his mother?*
What has happened to him?
What is obesity?
What keeps you hanging around here?

What can be used to ask someone's opinion of something.

Example 5.1.76. *What do you think about the present political situation?*

What is often used as the object of a preposition.
The preposition usually goes at the end of the question.

Example 5.1.77. *What are you interested in?*
What did he die of?
What do you want to talk about?

What is used as a determiner to find out the identity of something or to ask what kind of thing it is.

Example 5.1.78. *What books does she read?*
What church did you say you attend?

What if goes in front of a clause in the declarative.
It is used to ask what should be done if a particular difficulty occurs.

Example 5.1.79. *What if it's really bad weather?*
What if they didn't want to part with it, what would you do then?

You put *what* at the beginning of a question and *for* at the end of it when you want to know the reason for something or the purpose of something.
What are you staring for? means the same as *Why are you staring?*
What is this handle for? means *What is the purpose of this handle?*

Example 5.1.80. *What are you going for?*
What are those lights for?

In informal spoken English, you can also say *What for?* when someone says what they have done, or what they intend to do, and you want to know the reason for their actions.

Example 5.1.81. *'I've bought you a present.' - 'What for?'*

What can also be used in combination with *about* or *of*.
This use is explained in paragraph **5.47**.
5.36 If you want a question to sound more emphatic, you can use *whatever* instead of *what, wherever* instead of *where*, or *whoever* instead of *who*.

Example 5.1.82. *Whatever is the matter?*
Wherever did you get this?
Whoever heard of a bishop resigning?

5.1.8 Directing other people's actions: the imperative

5.37 When someone gives a very clear order or instruction, they usually use the **imperative**.

Example 5.1.83. *Discard any clothes you have not worn for more than a year.*
Put that gun down.
Tell your mother as soon as possible.

Written instructions are given in the imperative.

Example 5.1.84. *Boil up a little water with washing up liquid in it.*
Fry the chopped onion and pepper in the oil.

[i] When they are followed by a 2nd verb, the imperative forms of *come* and *go* are used with *and*, followed by the base form of the 2nd verb, rather than a *to*-infinitive.
The 2 actions seem to be separate, because of the *and*, but they are in fact very closely linked.

Example 5.1.85. *Come and see me whenever you need help.*

[AE] In spoken American English, the imperative forms of *come* and *go* can be followed directly by the base form of the verb.

Example 5.1.86. *Come see what the dog did to the couch. (Am)*
Go get some sleep. (Am)

An order can be made more forceful by putting *you* in front of the verb.

Example 5.1.87. *You get in the car.*
You shut up!

5.38 You can use the imperative when you are giving advice or a warning.

Example 5.1.88. *Be sensible.*
You be careful.

Often advice or a warning is expressed in a negative form.
You form a negative imperative by putting *don't* or *do not* in front of the base form of the verb.

Example 5.1.89. *Don't be afraid of them.*
Don't be discouraged.
Do not approach this man under any circumstances.

You can also form a negative imperative by putting *never* in front of the base form of a verb.

Example 5.1.90. *Never make a social phone call after 9.30 p.m.*

Another way of giving advice or a warning its to use 1 of the modals *should* or *ought to* in a declarative sentence.

Example 5.1.91. *You should get to know him better.*
You shouldn't keep eggs in the refrigerator.

This use is explained in detail in paragraph **5.215**.

5.39 You use the imperative when you are trying to get someone to do something.

Example 5.1.92. *Come quickly... Come quickly... Hurry!*

You can make an appeal more forceful by putting *do* in front of the verb.

Example 5.1.93. *Oh do stop whining!*
Do come and stay with us in Barbados for the winter.

5.40 You can use the imperative with some verbs when you are explaining something and you want the listener or reader to think about a particular thing or possibility, or to compare 2 things.

Example 5.1.94. *Take, for instance, the new proposals for student loans.*
Imagine, e.g., an assembly line worker in a factory making children's blocks.
But suppose for a moment that the automobile industry had developed at the same rate as computers.
E.g., compare a typical poor country like Indonesia with a rich one like Canada.
Consider, e.g., the contrast between the way schools today treat space and time.

Here is a list of verbs that are used in this way:

Example 5.1.95. *compare, consider, contrast, imagine, look at, note, picture, suppose, take*

5.41 *Let* is used in imperative sentences in 4 different ways:

- it is used to give an order or instruction

  Example 5.1.96. *Let Phillip have a look at it.*

- you use it followed by *us* when you are making a suggestion about what you and someone else should do.

  Let us is almost always shortened to *Let's*

  Example 5.1.97. *Let's go outside.*
  Let's creep forward on hands and knees.

- you use it followed by *me* when you are offering to do something.

  Example 5.1.98. *Let me take your coat.*

- in very formal English, it is used to express a wish.

  Example 5.1.99. *Let the joy be universal.*
  Let confusion live!
  Let the best man or woman win.

To make a negative suggestion you use *Let's not or*, in informal American English, *Let's don't.*

Example 5.1.100. *Let's not stay till the end.*
Let's don't ask about the missing books. (Am, informal)

5.1.9 Other uses of the declarative, the interrogative, & the imperative

5.42 You can confirm that something is true by asking a question using the **declarative** form.

Example 5.1.101. *So you admit something is wrong?*
Then you think we can keep it?

When you ask a question using the declarative form, you expect a *yes*-type answer, unless you use a negative construction, in which case you expect the answer *no*.

Example 5.1.102. *'You mean it's still here?' - 'Of course.'*
'You parents don't mind you being out so late?' - 'No, they don't.'

Questions expressed in the declarative form often begin with a conjunction.

Example 5.1.103. *So you're satisfied?*
And you think that's a good idea?

5.43 In informal spoken English, you can give an instruction by using a declarative sentence with *you* as the subject.

Example 5.1.104. *You put the month and the temperature on the top line.*
You take the bus up to the landing stage at 12:30.
You just put it straight in the oven.

5.44 When you are making an offer or an invitation, you usually use a *yes/no*-question beginning with a model e.g. *can* or *would*.
This use is explained in detail in paragraphs **5.173–5.178**.

Example 5.1.105. *Can I help you?*
Can I give you a lift?
Would you like me to get something for you?
Would you like some coffee?
Would you like to go to Ernie's for dinner?

You can also make an offer or invitation in a more informal way by using the **imperative** form.
Note that you can only do this when it is clear that you are not giving an order.

Example 5.1.106. *Have a cigar.*
Come to my place.
Come in, Mrs Kintner.

You add emphasis by putting *do* in front of the verb.

Example 5.1.107. *Do have a chocolate biscuit.*
Do help yourselves.

5.45 When you are making a request, you usually use a *yes/no*-question beginning with 1 of the modals *could, can*, or *would*.

Example 5.1.108. *Could I ask you a few questions?*
Can I have my hat pack, please?
Would you mind having a word with my husband?

You can also give an order or instruction using a *yes/no*-question beginning with a modal.

Example 5.1.109. *Will you tell Watson I shall be in a little late?*

These uses are explained in detail in paragraphs **5.156–5.166**.
5.46 When you use a *yes/no*-question to offer help or to make a request, you still expect the answer *yes* or *no*.
However, people sometimes say things that seem like *yes/no*-questions, although they do not expect an answer at all.
They are using the *yes/no*-question form to express a strong feeling, opinion, or impression.
E.g., instead of saying *That's an ugly building*, someone might say *Isn't that an ugly building?*
Or instead of saying *You never seem to get upset*, someone might say *Don't you ever get upset?*
Questions like these are called **rhetorical questions**.

Example 5.1.110. *Is there nothing she won't do?*
Can't you see that I'm busy?
Hasn't anyone round here got any sense?
Does nothing ever worry you?

Another kind of rhetorical question consists of a statement followed by a question tag e.g. *are you?* or *is it?*
E.g., someone might say *So you are the new assistant, are you?* or *So they're coming to tea, are they?*

Example 5.1.111. *So you want to be an actress, do you?*
So they're moving house again, are they?

Rhetorical questions can also begin with *how*.
They usually express a feeling of shock or indignation.
E.g., instead of saying *You are very cruel*, someone might say *How can you be so cruel?*

Example 5.1.112. *How can you say such things?*
How dare you speak to me like that?

Rhetorical questions are dealt with fully in paragraph **9.94**.

5.47 You can ask a question consisting of *what about* or *what of* in front of a noun phrase, without a verb.
You ask a question like this to remind someone of something, or to draw their attention to something.
With this type of question, you often expect an action, rather than a reply.

Example 5.1.113. *What about the others on the list?*
What about your breakfast?
But what of the women themselves?

5.48 There are several ways in which you can make a suggestion:

- you can use the modal *could* in a declarative sentence (see paragraph **5.183**)

  Example 5.1.114. *We could have tea.*
  You could get someone to dress up as a pirate.

- you can use a negative *wh*-question beginning with *why*

  Example 5.1.115. *Why don't we just give them what you want?*
  Why don't you write to her yourself?

- you can use a question consisting of *what about* or *how about* in front of an *-ing* form

  Example 5.1.116. *What about becoming an actor?*
  How about using makeup to dramatize your features?

- you can use the imperative.

  Example 5.1.117. *'Give them a reward each,' I suggested.*

You can also make a suggestion about what you and someone else might do by using *let's*.
This use is explained in paragraph **5.41**.

5.2 Forming negative statements

5.49 When you want to say that something is not true, is not happening, or is not the case, you normally use a **negative statement**.
Negative statements contain words like *not, never*, or *nowhere*.
These are called **negative words**.
Here is the list of negative words in English:

Example 5.2.1. *neither, never, no, nobody, none, no one, nor, not, nothing, nowhere*

Negative words indicate the opposite of something or an absence of something.

5.50 Another group of words e.g. *scarcely* and *seldom* can be used to make a statement almost negative.

These words are called **broad negatives**.

They are explained in paragraphs **5.82**–**5.89**.

5.51 If a statement about the existence of something has a negative word in it, you use *any* (not *no*) as a determiner in front of the following noun phrase.

You can also use a word beginning with *any-* e.g. *anyone* or *anywhere*.

Example 5.2.2. *We didn't have any money.*
He writes poetry and never shows it to anyone.
It is impossible to park the car anywhere.

For another use of *any* see paragraph **2.163**.

5.52 [!] In standard English, it is almost always unacceptable to use 2 negative words in the same clause.

E.g., you do not say, *I don't never go there*, or *I don't know nothing*.

5.53 The use of negatives in **reported speech** is explained in paragraph **7.13**.

The use of negatives with **modals** is explained in paragraph **5.104**.

5.54 The most commonly used negative word is *not*.

Its use with different verbs corresponds to the way these verbs are used in ***yes/no*-questions** (see paragraphs **5.12**–**5.14**).

5.55 When *not* is used with a verb phrase that contains an auxiliary verb, it comes after the 1st verb in the phrase.

Example 5.2.3. *They could not exist in their present form.*
They might not even notice.
The White House has not commented on the report.
He had not attended many meetings.
I was not smiling.
Her teachers were not impressed with her excuses.

5.56 If there is no auxiliary verb, you put *do, does*, or *did* after the subject, followed by *not* or *-n't*, followed by the base form of the main verb.

Example 5.2.4. *They do not need to talk.*
He does not speak English very well.
I didn't know that.

Be and *have* are exceptions to this; this is explained in the following paragraphs **5.57**–**5.58**.

The shortening of *not* to *-n't* is explained in paragraphs **5.61**–**5.62**.

5.57 If the verb is *be*, you do not use *do*.

You simply put *not* or *-n't* after the verb.

Example 5.2.5. *It is not difficult to see why they were unsuccessful.*
There is not much point in heading south.
This isn't my 1st choice of restaurant.

5.58 If the verb is *have*, you usually put *do, does*, or *did* after the subject, followed by *not* or *-n't*, followed by the base form *have*.

Example 5.2.6. *The organization does not have a good track record.*
He didn't have a very grand salary.

[AE] You can simply put *not* or *-n't* after the verb, but this use is less common, and almost never used in modern American English.

Example 5.2.7. *He hadn't enough money.*
I haven't any papers to say that I have been trained.

If you use *have got*, you put *not* or *-n't* after *have*, followed by *got*.

Example 5.2.8. *I haven't got the latest figures.*
He hasn't got a daughter.

Have got is explained in paragraph **3.15**.

5.59 When *not* is used with an *-ing* form or a *to*-infinitive clause, it is placed in front of the *-ing* form or *to*-infinitive.

Example 5.2.9. *We stood there, not knowing what was expected of us.*
He lost out by not taking a degree at another university.
Try not to worry.
It took a vast amount of patience not to strangle him.

5.60 When a clause contains an inflected verb and an *-ing* form or *to*-infinitive, you put *not* either with the inflected form or with the *-ing* form or *to*-infinitive, depending on the meaning you want to express.

E.g., you can say either *Mary tried not to smile* or *Mary did not try to smile*, but they express different meanings.

The 1st means that Mary tried to avoid smiling.

The 2nd means that Mary did not even try to smile.

However, with some verbs that are used with *to*-infinitives, the meaning is the same whether *not* is placed with the main verb or with the *to*-infinitive.

Example 5.2.10. *She did not appear to have done anything.*
Henry appears not to appreciate my explanation.
It didn't seem to bother them at all.
They seemed not to notice me.

Here is a list of verbs that are used with *to*-infinitives.

With all of these, the meaning of the clause is the same, whether *not* is put in front of the verb or in front of the *to*-infinitive:

Example 5.2.11. *appear, expect, happen, intend, plan, seem, tend, want, wish*

The use of 2 verbs in a clause to talk about 2 actions or states is dealt with in paragraphs **3.182**–**3.212**.

Note that with some **reporting verbs** the meaning is the same whether you put *not* in front of the reporting verb or in front of the main verb.

This is explained in paragraph **7.13**.

5.61 In spoken English and in informal written Englis, *not* is often shortened to *-n't* after *be* or *have* or after an auxiliary.

-n't is attached to the end of the verb.

Example 5.2.12. *Maria isn't really my aunt at all.*
He doesn't believe in anything.
I haven't heard from her recently.

Note that *cannot* is shortened to *can't, shall not* is shortened to *shan't*, and *will not* is shortened to *won't*.

Here is a complete list of the shortened forms you can use:

Example 5.2.13. *aren't, isn't, wasn't, weren't, didn't, doesn't, don't, hadn't, hasn't, haven't, can't, couldn't, mightn't, mustn't, oughtn't, shan't, shouldn't, won't, wouldn't*

5.62 [i] Note that if the verb is already shortened and added to its subject, you cannot shorten *not* to *-n't*.

This means, e.g., that you can shorten *she is not* to *she isn't* or *she's not*, but not to *she'sn't*.

Example 5.2.14. *It isn't easy.*
It's not easy.
I haven't had time.
I've not had time.

Note that you cannot add *-n't* to am.

You can only use *I'm not* as the shortened form.

Example 5.2.15. *I'm not excited.*

The form *aren't I* is used in questions.

In questions, *not* is usually shortened to *-n't* and added to the 1st verb in the verb phrase.

Example 5.2.16. *Didn't she win at the Olympics?*
Hasn't he put on weight?
Aren't you bored?

However, in formal English, it is also possible to put *not* after the subject.

Example 5.2.17. *Did he not have brothers?*
Was it not rather absurd?

5.63 You can also use *not* with almost any word or word group in a clause.
E.g., you can use it with nouns, adjectives, adverbs, prepositional phrases, and some quantity expressions e.g. *a lot of*.
You usually do this in order to be more forceful, careful, polite, hesitant, and so on.
The following paragraphs **5.64–5.65** describe some of these uses.

5.64 *Very* is often used after *not* to soften the negative meaning of a clause.
This sounds more polite or hesitant than using *not* without *very*.

Example 5.2.18. *His attitude is not very logical.*
It's not very strong tea; it won't stain.
He wasn't a very good actor.
She shook her head, but not very convincingly.

You can use *not* with *absolutely, altogether, entirely*, or *necessarily* in a similar way.
You do this in order to sound more polite or less critical.

Example 5.2.19. *Previous experience isn't absolutely necessary, but it helps.*
I was not altogether sure.
They are not entirely reliable.
Science is not necessarily hostile to human values.

You use *not* to show that the thing you are describing does in fact have some good qualities, although you do not want to make them sound better than they really are.
This structure is often used with words that have a negative prefix e.g. *un-* or *-less*.

Example 5.2.20. *She's not an unattractive woman.*
It's not a bad start.
It's a small point, but not an unimportant one.
America is very well developed, but not limitless.

5.65 *Not* is sometimes used to contrast 1 part of a clause with another.
Using *not* in this way emphasizes the positive part of a statement.

Example 5.2.21. *He held her arm in his hand, not hard, but firmly.*
We move steadily, not fast, not slow.
'Were they still interested?' - 'Not just interested. Overjoyed.'
I will move eventually, but not from Suffolk.
It's not a huge hotel, but it's very nice.

5.66 *Never* is used to say that something was not or will not ever be the case.
When it is used with a verb phrase that contains an auxiliary verb, *never* is put after the 1st verb in the verb phrase and in front of the main verb.

Example 5.2.22. *I would never trust my judgment again.*
... a type of glass that is rare and is never used.
The number of people who died will never be shown.
50 years ago, men were never expected to wash the dishes or help with the children.
I had never been to this big town before.
I've never done so much work in all my life.

However, you can put *never* in front of the 1st word in the verb phrase in order to emphasize the negative aspect of a statement.

Example 5.2.23. *I never would have guessed if he hadn't told me.*
There was no such person - there never had been.

5.67 If the main verb is the present simple or past simple of *be, never* usually comes after the verb.

Example 5.2.24. *She was never too proud to learn.*
I'm never very keen on keeping a car for more than a year.
There were never any people in the house.

However, you can put *never* in front of a simple form of *be* for emphasis.

Example 5.2.25. *There never was enough hot water at home.*
It never was very clear.
There never is any great change.

5.68 If the main verb is the present simple or past simple of any verb except *be, never* comes in front of the verb.

Example 5.2.26. *I never want to see you in my classes again.*
She never goes abroad.
He never went to university.
He never did any homework.

5.69 You can make a negative statement more emphatic by using *never* followed by *do, does*, or *did* in front of the base form of the verb.
E.g., instead of saying *I never met him*, you can say *I never did meet him.*

Example 5.2.27. *They never did get their money back.*
She never did find her real mother.
Some people never do adjust to life here.

5.70 *Never* can be used at the beginning of imperative structures.

Example 5.2.28. *Never change a wheel near a drain.*
Never dry clothes in front of an open fire.

Imperative structures are explained in paragraph **5.4** and in paragraphs **5.37–5.41**.
5.71 *No* is an indefinite determiner that is used in front of singular and plural nouns to say that something does not exist or is not available.

Example 5.2.29. *There was no money for an operation.*
We had no parents, nobody to look after us.
He has no ambition.
I could see no tracks.

Indefinite determiners are explained in paragraphs **1.223–1.250**.
5.72 In spoken English, *-n't* is often used with *any* instead of *no.*
E.g., instead of saying *I had no money*, you can say *I didn't have any money.*

Example 5.2.30. *They hadn't meant any harm to her.*
I can't see any hope in it.

5.73 The pronoun *none* is used to say that there is not a single thing or person, or not even a small amount of a particular thing.

Example 5.2.31. *I waited for comments but none came.*
The entire area is covered with shallow lakes, none more than a few yards in depth.
We have been seeing difficulties where none exist.

For another use of *none* see paragraph **1.155**.
5.74 *None of* is a quantity expression.

Example 5.2.32. *None of the townspeople had ever seen such weather.*
None of this has happened without our consent.

For an explanation of *none of* see paragraphs **2.179–2.185**.
5.75 There are 4 words beginning with *no-* that are used in negative statements.
Nothing, no one, and *nobody* are **indefinite pronouns**.
Nowhere is an **indefinite place adverb**.

Example 5.2.33. *There's nothing you can do.*
Nobody in her house knows any English.
There's almost nowhere left to go.

Indefinite pronouns are explained in paragraphs **1.128–1.141**.
Indefinite place adverbs are explained in paragraphs **6.61–6.71**.
5.76 *Nothing, no one, nobody*, and *nowhere* can be followed by *but* to mean *only.*
E.g., *There was nothing but cheese* means that there was only cheese.

Example 5.2.34. *I look back on this period with nothing but pleasure.*
He heard no one but his uncles.

Indefinite pronouns and adverbs that begin with *any* can be used in similar structures.
However, in these structures *but* means *except*, rather than *only*.

Example 5.2.35. *I could never speak about anything but business to Ivan.*
He never spoke to anyone but his wife.

5.77 *Neither* and *nor* are used together to say that 2 alternatives are not possible, likely, or true.
Neither goes in front of the 1st alternative and *nor* goes in front of the 2nd one.

Example 5.2.36. *Neither Margaret nor John was there.*
They had neither food nor money until the end of the week.

5.78 *Neither* can be used on its own as a reply, to refer to 2 alternatives that have already been mentioned.

Example 5.2.37. *'Does that mean yes or no?' - 'Neither'.*

5.79 If a clause contains a negative word, particularly *not*, you can use *neither* or *nor* to negate a 2nd clause.
In the 2nd clause, you put *neither* or *nor* 1st, followed by the verb, followed by the subject.

Example 5.2.38. *This isn't a dazzling achievement, but neither is it a negligible one.*
These people are not insane, nor are they fools.

If there is an auxiliary, it is placed in front of the subject in the 2nd clause.

Example 5.2.39. *The organization had broken no rules, but neither had it acted responsibly.*
I don't feel any shame. Neither do I think I should.

5.80 *Neither* can be used on its own in front of a singular noun referring to each of 2 things when you are making a negative statement about both of them.
E.g., *Neither partner benefited from the agreement* means that there were 2 partners and the negative statement applies to both of them.

Example 5.2.40. *Neither report mentioned the Americans.*
Neither film was particularly good.
Neither sex has a monopoly on thought or emotion.
Neither parent is the good one or the bad one.

Note that in this structure *neither* is used with a singular verb.
5.81 When *neither* is followed by *of*, it makes a set of 2 things negative.
Neither of is followed by a plural noun phrase.

Example 5.2.41. *Neither of us was having any luck.*
Neither of the boys screamed.
Neither of them was making any sound.

Neither of is normally used with a singular verb.

Example 5.2.42. *Neither of these extremes is desirable.*
Neither of these opinions proves anything.

However, it is also possible to use a plural verb.

Example 5.2.43. *Neither of the children were there.*

5.2.1 Broad negatives: *hardly, seldom*, etc.

5.82 Another way in which you can make a statement negative is by using a **broad negative**.
Broad negatives are adverbs like *rarely* and *seldom*, which are used to make a statement almost totally negative.

Example 5.2.44. *The estimated sales will hardly cover the cost of making the film.*
We were scarcely able to move.
Kuwait lies barely 30 miles from the Iranian coast.

Here is a list of the most common broad negatives:

Example 5.2.45. *barely, hardly, rarely, scarcely, seldom*

5.83 The position of a broad negative within a clause is similar to that of *never* (see paragraphs **5.66–5.68**).

5.84 When you use a broad negative with a verb phrase that contains an auxiliary verb, you put it after the 1st word in the verb phrase and in front of the main verb.

Example 5.2.46. *I could scarcely believe my eyes.*
Religion was rarely discussed in our house.
His eyes had hardly closed.

5.85 The verb is the present simple or past simple of *be*, the broad negative usually comes in front of the verb.

Example 5.2.47. *He seldom bathed.*
Marsha rarely felt hungry.
John hardly ever spoke to the Press.

It is also possible to put a broad negative after the verb, but this is less common.

Example 5.2.48. *Such moments happen rarely in life.*
They met so seldom.

5.86 If the verb is the present simple or past simple of any verb except *be*, the broad negative usually comes in front of the verb.

Example 5.2.49. *He seldom bathed.*
Marsha rarely felt hungry.
John hardly ever spoke to the Press.

It is also possible to put a broad negative after the verb, but this is less common.

Example 5.2.50. *Such moments happen rarely in life.*
They met so seldom.

5.87 In formal or literary English, a broad negative is sometimes placed at the beginning of a clause for emphasis.

If you are using a verb phrase with an auxiliary, the 1st word in the verb phrase is placed after the broad negative, followed by the subject and then the remainder of the verb phrase.

Example 5.2.51. *Seldom has society offered so wide a range of leisure time activities.*
Hardly he he settled into his seat when Adam charged in.

If there is no auxiliary, you put the present simple or past simple of *do* after the broad negative, followed by the subject, followed by the base form of the main verb.

Example 5.2.52. *Seldom did a week pass without a request for assessment.*
Rarely do local matches live up to expectations.

Note that *barely* and *scarcely* are not often used in this way.

5.88 [i] If yo make a **question tag** out of a statement that contains a broad negative, the tag on the end of the statement is normally in the affirmative, as it is with other negatives.

Questions tags are explained in paragraphs **5.16–5.20**.

Example 5.2.53. *She's hardly the right person for the job, is she?*
You seldom see that sort of thing these days, do you?

You can modify *rarely* and *seldom* by putting *so, very, too*, or *pretty* in front of them.

You can also modify *rarely* by using *only*.

Example 5.2.54. *It happens so rarely.*
Women were very seldom convicted.
He too seldom makes the 1st greeting.
Most people go to church only rarely.

If you want to say there is very little of something, you can use a broad negative with *any* or with a word that begins with *any-*.

Example 5.2.55. *The bonds show barely any interest.*
Hardly anybody came.
In fact, it is seldom any of these.
With scarcely any warning, the soldiers charged.
Sometimes 2 or 3 relatives are admitted, but rarely any friends.

5.89 Instead of using a broad negative, you can use *almost* followed by a negative word e.g. *no* or *never*.
E.g., *There was almost no food left* means the same as *There was hardly any food left.*

Example 5.2.56. *They've almost no money for anything.*
The cars thinned out to almost none.
They were very private people, with almost no friends.
Children almost never began conversations.

5.2.2 Emphasizing the negative aspect of a statement

5.90 You can add *at all* to a negative statement in order to make it more emphatic.
You use *at all* with any negative word, with *without*, or with a **broad negative**.

Example 5.2.57. *She had no writing ability at all.*
'There's no need,' said Jimmie. 'None at all'.
He did it without any help at all.
He hardly read anything at all.

Broad negatives are explained in paragraphs **5.82–5.88**.
5.91 You can put *whatsoever* after *none* and *nothing* in order to emphasize the negative aspect of a statement.

Example 5.2.58. *'You don't think he has any chance of winning?' - 'None whatsoever.'*
There is absolutely no enjoyment in that, none whatsoever.
You'll find yourself thinking about nothing whatsoever.

If *no* is used as a determiner in a noun phrase, you can put *whatsoever* after the noun phrase.

Example 5.2.59. *There is no need whatsoever to teach children how to behave.*
There was no debate whatsoever, not even in Parliament.

You can also use *whatsoever* in negative statements that contain *any* or a word that begins with *any-*.

Example 5.2.60. *You are not entitled to any aid whatsoever.*
He was devoid of any talent whatsoever.
I knew I wasn't learning anything whatsoever.

5.92 You can put *ever* after negative words in order to emphasize the negative aspect of a statement.

Example 5.2.61. *I can't say I ever had much interest in fishing.*
Nobody ever leaves the airport.
I never ever believed we would have such success.

5.93 There are several expressions that are used to emphasize a negative statement that contains *not*.
These include *in the least, the least bit, in the slightest*, and *a bit*.

Example 5.2.62. *I don't mind in the least, I really don't.*
Neither of the managers was the least bit repentant afterwards.
I don't really envy you in the slightest.
They're not a bit interested.

If *in the least* and *in the slightest* are used with verbs, they are placed either immediately after the verb or after the object, if there is one.

Example 5.2.63. *I wouldn't have objected in the least.*
She did not worry Billy in the least.
The weather hadn't improved in the slightest.

If *in the least* is used with an adjective, it is put in front of it.
In the slightest usually comes after an adjective.

Example 5.2.64. *I wasn't in the least surprised.*
She wasn't worried in the slightest.

The least bit and *a bit* are used only with adjectives and are placed in front of the adjective.

Example 5.2.65. *I'm not the least bit worried.*
They're not a bit interested.

5.3 Using modals

5.94 Language is not always used just ot exchange information by making simple statements and asking questions.
Sometimes we want to make requests, offers, or suggestions, or to express our wishes or intentions.
We may want to be polite or tactful, or to indicate our feelings about what we are saying.
We can do all these things by using a set of verbs called **modals**.
Modals are always used with other verbs.
They are special kind of **auxiliary verb**.
Here is a list of the modals used in English:

Example 5.3.1. *can, could, may, might, must, ought to, shall, should, will, would*

In some grammars, *dare, need*, and *used to* are also referred to as modals.
In this grammar, we call these words **semi-modals**.
They are dealt with separately in paragraphs **5.248**–**5.258**.
Ought is sometimes regarded as a modal, rather than *ought to*.
For a further note about this, see paragraph **5.101**.
Modals are sometimes called **modal verbs** or **modal auxiliaries**.
5.95 The main uses of modals are explained in paragraphs **5.96**–**5.100**.
Special features of modals are described in paragraphs **5.101**–**5.108**.
Ways of referring to time when using modals are explained in paragraphs **5.109**–**5.116**.
Ways of using modals to say whether something is possible are explained in paragraphs **5.117**–**5.153**.
Ways of using modals when interacting with other people are explained in paragraphs **5.154**–**5.222**.
Expressions that can be used instead of modals are described in paragraphs **5.223**–**5.247**.
Semi-modals are explained in paragraphs **5.248**–**5.258**.

5.3.1 The main uses of modals

5.96 Modals are mainly used when you want to show your attitude towards what you are saying, or when you are concerned about the effect of what you are saying on the person you are speaking or writing to.
5.97 When you are giving information, you sometimes use modals to show how certain you are that what you are saying is true or correct.
E.g., if you say *Mr Wilkins is the oldest person in the village*, you are giving a definite statement of fact.
If you say *Mr Wilkins must be the oldest person in the village*, the modal *must* shows that you think Mr Wilkins is the oldest person, because you cannot think of anyone in the village who is older than Mr Wilkins.
If you say *Mr Wilkins might be the oldest person in the village*, the modal *might* shows that you think it is possible that Mr Wilkins is the oldest person, because he is very old.
5.98 You can use modals to show your attitude towards the things you intend to do, or intend not to do.
E.g., if you say *I won't go without Simon*, you are expressing strong unwillingness to go without Simon.
If you say *I can't go without Simon*, you are saying that there is a special reason for not going without him.
If you say *I couldn't go without Simon*, you are saying that you are unwilling to go without Simon, because to do so would be wrong, or impossible because of the circumstances.
5.99 When you use language, you are affecting and responding to a particular person or audience.
Modals are often used to produce a particular effect, and the modal you choose depends on several factors, e.g. the relationship you have with your listener, the formality or informality of the situation, and the importance of what you are saying
E.g., it would normally be rude to say to a stranger *Open the door*, although you might say it in an emergency, or you might say it to a close friend or a child.
Normally, you would say to a stranger *Will you open the door?, Would you open the door?*, or *Could you open the door?*, depending on how polite you want to be.
5.100 Modals have special uses in 3 kinds of sentence containing more than 1 clause:

- they are used in **reported clauses**

  Example 5.3.2. *Wilson dropped a hint that he might come.*
  I felt that I would like to wake her up.

  For more information about reported clauses see Chap. 7.

- they are used in **conditional statements**

  Example 5.3.3. *If he had died when he was 50, he would have died healthy.*
  If only things had been different, she would have been far happier with George.

  For more informational about conditionals see paragraphs **8.25**–**8.42**.

- they are used in **purpose clauses**.

  Example 5.3.4. *He stole under the very noses of the store detectives in order that he might be arrested and punished.*
  He resigned so that he could spend more time with his family.

  For more information about purpose clauses see paragraphs **8.47**–**8.48**.

5.3.2 Special features of modals

5.101 Modals are followed by the **base form** of a verb.

Example 5.3.5. *I must leave fairly soon.*
I think it will be rather nice.
They ought to give you your money back.

Note that *ought* is sometimes regarded as a modal, rather than *ought to*.
Ought is then said to be followed by a *to*-infinitive.

5.102 Sometimes a modal is followed by the base form of 1 of the auxiliary verbs *have* or *be*, followed by a participle.
When a modal is followed by *be* and an *-ing* participle, this shows that you are talking about the present or the future.

Example 5.3.6. *People may be watching.*
You ought to be doing this.
The play will be starting soon.

When a modal is followed by *have* and an *-ed* participle, this shows that you are talking about the past.

Example 5.3.7. *You must have heard of him.*
She may have gone already.
I ought to have sent the money.

In passive structures, a modal is followed by *be* or *have been* and an *-ed* participle.

Example 5.3.8. *The name of the winner will be announced.*
They ought to be treated fairly.
Such charges may have been justified.

A modal is never followed by the auxiliary verb *do*, or by another modal.

5.103 Modals do not inflect.
This means there is no *-s* form in the 3rd person singular, and there are no *-ing* or *-ing* or *-ed* forms.

Example 5.3.9. *There's nothing I can do about it.*
I am sure he can do it.
I must leave fairly soon.

Could is sometimes thought to be the past tense of *can*.
This is discussed in paragraphs **5.112**–**5.113**.

5.104 Negatives are formed by putting a **negative word** e.g. *not* immediately after the modal.
Can not is usually written as 1 word, *cannot*.

Example 5.3.10. *You must not worry.*
I cannot go back.

In the case of *ought to*, you put the negative word after *ought*.

Example 5.3.11. *He ought not to have done so.*

[AE] In American English, the *to* of *ought to* is optional in negative statements.

Example 5.3.12. *News organizations ought not treat them so poorly. (American)*

After *could, might, must, ought, should*, and *would, not* is often shortened to *-n't* and is added to the modal.

Example 5.3.13. *You mustn't talk about Ron like this.*
Perhaps I oughtn't to confess this.
He oughtn't turn away from those who have supported him. (American)

Shall not, will not, and *cannot* are shortened to *shan't, won't*, and *can't*.
May not is not shortened at all.

Example 5.3.14. *I shan't get much work done tonight.*
He won't be finished for at least another half an hour.
I can't go with you.

5.105 Questions are formed by putting the modal in front of the subject.
In the case of *ought to*, you put *ought* in front of the subject and *to* after it.

Example 5.3.15. *Could you give me an example?*
Ought we to tell someone about it?
Mightn't it be better to leave things as they are?
Why could they not leave her alone?
Must we explain everything we do it such detail?

5.106 Modals are used in **question tags**.

Example 5.3.16. *They can't all be right, can they?*
You won't tell anyone, will you?

With a negative tag, the shortened form of the negative is used.

Example 5.3.17. *It would be handy, wouldn't it?*
It'll give you time to think about it, won't it?

Question tags are explained in paragraphs **5.12–5.20**.
5.107 In spoken English, when *will* and *would* are used after a pronoun, they are often shortened to *-'ll* and *-'d* and added to the pronoun.

Example 5.3.18. *I hope you'll agree.*
She'll be all right.
They'd both call each other horrible names.
If I went back on the train, it'd be better.

Will and *would* cannot be shortened like this when they are used on their own, without a following verb.
E.g., you can say *Paul said he would come, and I hope he will*, but you cannot say *Paul said he would com, and I hope he'll.*
5.108 [i] You sometimes use a modal on its own, without a following verb.
You do this when you are repeating a modal.
E.g., if someone says *I expect Margaret will come tonight*, you can say *I hope she will*, meaning *I hope she will come.*

Example 5.3.19. *'I must go.' - 'I suppose you must.'*
'You should have become an archaeologist.' - 'You're dead right, I should.'
If you can't do it, we'll find someone who can.

You also omit the verb following a modal when this verb has just been used without a modal, or with a different modal.
E.g., if someone says *George has failed his exam*, you can say *I thought he would*, meaning *I thought he would fail his exam.*

Example 5.3.20. *I love him and I always will.*
They had come to believe that it not only must go on for ever but that it should.

However you cannot omit the verb *be* after a modal when you have just used it without a modal.
E.g., if someone says *Is he a teacher?*, you cannot say *I think he might.*
You must say *I think he might be.*

Example 5.3.21. *Weather forecasts aren't very reliable and never will be.*
The Board's methods are not as stringent as they could be.
Relations between the 2 countries have not been as smooth as they might have been.

For more information on leaving out words in verb phrases see paragraphs **10.60–10.81**.

5.3.3 Referring to time

5.109 Modals do not usually show whether you are talking about the past, the present, or the future.
Usually you indicate this in other ways, e.g. by putting an auxiliary verb and a participle after the modal.
Sometimes the general context makes it clear whether you are talking about a past, present, or future event or situation.
5.110 *Shall* and *will* are exceptions to this.
Shall always indicates that you are talking about a future event or situation.

Example 5.3.22. *I shall do what you suggested.*
Eventually we shall find a solution.

Will usually shows that you are talking about a future event or situation.

Example 5.3.23. *The farmer will feel more responsible towards his workers.*
He will not return for many hours.

However, *will* is sometimes used to talk about present situations.

Example 5.3.24. *You will not feel much love for him at the moment.*

This use of *will* is described in paragraph **5.123**.
5.111 *Could* and *would* are sometimes described as past tense forms of *can* and *will*.
However, this is true in only a few minor ways.
These are explained in the following paragraphs.
5.112 *Could* can be regarded as the past tense of *can* if you are simply talking about the ability of a person or thing to do something.
E.g., if you are talking about a living person, you can say *He can speak Russian and Finnish.*
If you are talking about a dead person, you can say *He could speak Russian and Finnish.*
For a fuller explanation of these uses see paragraphs **5.118–5.120**.
5.113 *Could* and *would* are sometimes used in place of *can* and *will* when you are reporting what someone has said.
E.g., if your friend has said *I can come*, you might report this as *He said that he could come.*
Similarly, if he has said, *I will come*, you might report this as *He said that he would come.*
For a full explanation of **reported speech** see Chap. 7.
5.114 *Would* is used to talk about something that happened regularly in the past, but no longer happens.

Example 5.3.25. *The other children would tease me and call me names.*
A man with a list would come round and say you could go off duty.

When you use *would* like this, you often add a time expression.

Example 5.3.26. *She would often hear him grumblin.*
Once in a while she'd give me some lilac to take home.
Every day I'd ring up home and ask if they'd changed their minds.

You can use *used to* instead to *would*.
Used to is explained in paragraphs **5.254–5.258**.
5.115 *Would* is also used in stories to talk about the thoughts that someone is having about the future.
E.g., if a character in a story is thinking that she will see a girl called Jane the next day, the author might simply say *She would see Jane the next day.*

Example 5.3.27. *He would recognize it when he heard it again.*
They would reach the castle some time.

5.116 When *would* is used with *not* to talk about something that happened in the past, it has a special meaning.
It is used to say that someone refused to do something.

Example 5.3.28. *They just would not believe what we told them.*
After all this, I wouldn't come back to the farm.

The use of modals to express a refusal is explained in paragraphs **5.196–5.201**.

5.3.4 Talking about possibility

5.117 The following 4 sections explain the different ways in which modals are used to talk about the possibility of something happening or being done.

Paragraphs **5.118–5.121** explain how *can* and *could* are used to talk about the ability of a person or thing to do something.

Paragraphs **5.122–5.141** explain how modals are used to express degrees of certainty about past, present, and future situations and events.

Paragraphs **5.142–5.145** explain how modals are used to say that something is permissible.

Paragraphs **5.146–5.153** explain how modals are used to say that something is forbidden or unacceptable.

5.3.5 Talking about ability

5.118 *Can* is used to say that someone has a particular skill or ability.

Example 5.3.29. *You can all read and write.*
Some people can ski better than others.
He cannot dance.
. . . the girl who can't act.

Could is used to say that someone had a skill or ability in the past.

Example 5.3.30. *When I arrived, I could speak only a little English.*
I could barely walk.
He could kick goals from anywhere.

5.119 *Can* is also used to say that someone is aware of something through 1 of their senses.

Example 5.3.31. *I can see you.*
I can smell it. Can't you?

Could is used to say that someone was aware of something through 1 of their senses on a particular occasion in the past.

Example 5.3.32. *I could see a few faint stars in a clear patch or sky.*
I could feel my heart bumping.
Police said they could smell alcohol on his breath.

5.120 *Can* and *could* are also used to express facts that are generally the case, particularly when they relate to something or someone being capable of having a particular effect, or of behaving in a particular way.

Example 5.3.33. *It can be very unpleasant.*
Art can be used to communicate.
Throwing parties can be hard work.
He could be very stiff, could Haggerty.
He could really frighten me, and yet at the same time he could be the most gentle and courteous of men.

5.121 [!] You cannot use *can* or *could* to say that someone or something will have a particular ability in the future.

Instead you use *be able to* or *be possible to*.

Be able to and *be possible to* can also be used to talk about someone's ability to do something in the present or the past.

Be able to and *be possible to* are dealt with in paragraphs **5.224–5.231**.

5.3.6 Talking about likelihood

5.122 The following paragraphs explain how modals are used to express different degrees of certainty about past, present, and future situations and events.

Paragraphs **5.123–5.129** explain the main ways in which modals are used to express degrees of certainty.

Paragraphs **5.130–5.134** explain special uses of modals when talking about possible future situations.

Paragraphs **5.135–5.141** explain special uses of modals when talking about possible situations in the past.

5.123 You use *will* when are assuming that something is the case, and you do not think there is any reason to doubt it.

Example 5.3.34. *Those of you who are familiar with the game will know this.*
He will be a little out of touch, although he's a rapid learner.
She will have forgotten all about it by now.

Similarly, you use *will not* or *won't* when you are assuming that something is not the case.

Example 5.3.35. *The audience will not be aware of such exact details.*
You won't know Gordon. He's out new doctor.

After *you*, you can use *would* instead of *will*, if you want to be more polite.

Example 5.3.36. *You would agree that the United States should be involved in assisting these countries.*

5.124 You also use *would* to say that something is certain to happen in particular circumstances.

Example 5.3.37. *Even an illiterate person would understand that.*
Few people would agree with this as a general principle.
A picnic wouldn't be any fun without you.

After *I*, you can use *should* instead of *would*.

Example 5.3.38. *The very 1st thing I should do would be to teach you how to cook.*
I should be very unhappy on the continent.

[AE] This is unusual in American English, which normally uses *would* after *I*.

5.125 You use *must* to show that you believe something is the case, because of particular facts or circumstances.

Example 5.3.39. *Oh, you must be Sylvia's husband.*
Fashion must account for a small percentage of sales.
This article must have been written by a woman.

When you are indicating that something is not the case, you use *cannot*.
You do not use *must not*. (See paragraph **5.128**.)

Example 5.3.40. *The 2 conflicting messages cannot possibly both be true.*
You can't have forgotten me.
He can't have said that. He just can't.

5.126 You use *could, might*, or *may* to say that there is a possibility of something happening or being the case.
May is slightly more formal than *could* or *might*; otherwise there is very little difference in meaning between these modals.

Example 5.3.41. *Don't eat it. It could be poisonous.*
His route from the bus stop might be the same as yours.
In rare cases the jaw may be broken during extraction.

If you put *well* after *could, might*, or *may*, you are saying that it is fairly likely that something is the case.

Example 5.3.42. *It could well be that the economic situation is getting better.*
His predictions could well have come true.
You might well be right.
I think that may well have been the intention.

5.127 You use *might not* or *may not* to say that it is possible that something is not the case.

Example 5.3.43. *He might not be in England at all.*
That mightn't be true.
That may not sound very imposing.

5.128 You use *could not* or *cannot* to say that it is impossible that something is the case.

Example 5.3.44. *... knowledge which could not have been gained in any other way.*
It couldn't possibly the poison.
He cannot know everything that is going on.
You can't talk to the dead.

5.129 *Could* is sometimes used in negative constructions with the comparative form of an adjective.
You use *could* like this to say that it is not possible for someone or something to have more of a particular quality.

Example 5.3.45. *I couldn't be happier.*
You couldn't be more wrong.
The setting couldn't have been lovelier.
He could hardly have felt more ashamed of himself.

5.130 The following paragraphs explain how modals are used when you are talking about possible future situations.

The uses of *must, cannot, could, might*, and *may* are similar to their uses when you are talking about possible situations in the present.

5.131 You use *will* to say that something is certain to happen or be the case in the future.

Example 5.3.46. *They will see everything.*
The price of food will go up.
The service will have been running for a year in May.

Be going to can also be used to say that something is certain to happen in the future.
This use of *be going to* is dealt with in paragraph **5.233**.

5.132 *Shall* is also used to say that something is certain to happen.
You usually use *shall* when you are talking about events and situations over which you have some control.
E.g., you can use *shall* when you are making a resolution or a promise.

Example 5.3.47. *I shall be leaving as soon as I am ready.*
Very well, my dear. You shall have the coat.
Of course he shall have water.
'You'll make a lot of money.' - 'I shall 1 day.'

[AE] This usage is considered very formal in American English and is not often used.
You use *must* to say that something is certain to happen because of particular facts or circumstances.

Example 5.3.48. *This research must eventually lead to computer decision-making.*

You use *cannot* to say that something is certain not to happen because of particular facts or circumstances.
You do not use *must not*.

Example 5.3.49. *A team cannot hope to win consistently without a good coach.*
The bad weather can't last.

5.133 You use *should* or *ought to* to say that you expect something to happen.

Example 5.3.50. *She should be back any time now.*
This course should be quite interesting for you.
The Court of Appeal ought to be able to help you.
It ought to get better as it goes along.

Should and *ought to* are also used when you are talking about the importance of doing something.
This use is explained in paragraph **5.215**.

5.134 You use *could, might*, or *may* to say that it is possible that a particular thing will happen.

Example 5.3.51. *England's next fixture in Salzburg could be the decisive match.*
The river could easily overflow.
They might be able to remember what he said.
Clerical work may be available for 2 students who want to learn about publishing.

If you put *well* after *could, might*, or *may*, you are indicating that it is fairly likely that something will happen or be the case.

Example 5.3.52. *When it is finished it may well be the largest cathedral in the world.*
We might well get injured.

If you put *possibly* or *conceivably* after *could, might*, or *may*, you are indicating that is possible, but fairly unlikely, that something will happen or be the case.

Example 5.3.53. *These conditions could possibly be accepted.*
Rates could conceivably rise by as much as a whole percentage point.

5.135 The following paragraphs explain how you use modals when you are talking about possible situations in the past.

5.136 You use *should* or *ought to* with *have to* say that you expect something to have happened already.

Example 5.3.54. *Dear Mom, you should have heard by now that I'm O.K.*

You also use *should* or *ought to* with *have* to say that something was expected to happen, although it has not in fact happened.

Example 5.3.55. *Muskie should have won by a huge margin.*
She ought to have been home by now.

5.137 You use *would* with *have* to talk about actions and events that were possible in the past, although they did not in fact happen.

Example 5.3.56. *Denial would have been useless.*
I would have said yes, but Julie persuaded us to stay at home.
You wouldn't have pushed him, would you?

5.138 You use *could* or *might* with *have* to say that there was a possibility of something happening in the past, although it did not in fact happen.

Example 5.3.57. *It could have been awful.*
I could easily have spent the whole year on it.
You could have got a job last year.
A lot of men died who might have been saved.
You might have found it very difficult.

5.139 You also use *could, might*, or *may* with *have* to say that it is possible that something was the case, but you do not know whether it was the case or not.

Example 5.3.58. *It is just possible that such a small creature could have preyed on dinosaur eggs.*
They might have moved house by now.
I may have seemed to be overreacting.

5.140 You use *might not* or *may not* with *have* to say that it is possible that something did not happen or was not the case.

Example 5.3.59. *They might not have considered me as their friend.*
My father mightn't have been to blame.
The parents may not have been ready for this news.

5.141 You use *could* with a negative and *have* to say that it is impossible that something happened or was the case.

Example 5.3.60. *It couldn't have been wrong.*
The money was not, and never could have been, the property of the organization.

5.3.7 Talking about permission

5.142 *Can* is used to say that someone is allowed to do something.

Example 5.3.61. *You can drive a van up to 3-ton capacity using an ordinary driving license.*

If you are giving permission for something, you use *can*.

Example 5.3.62. *You can borrow that pen if you want to.*
You can go off duty now.
She can go with you.

5.143 In more formal situations, *may* is used to give permission.

Example 5.3.63. *You may speak now.*
They may do exactly as they like.

5.144 *Could* is used to say that someone was allowed to do something in the past.

Example 5.3.64. *We could go to any part of the island we wanted to.*

5.145 [!] You cannot use *can* or *could* to say that someone will be allowed to do something in the future.
Instead you use *be able to*.
Be able to is dealt with in paragraphs **5.224–5.231**.

5.3.8 Saying that something is unacceptable

5.146 Modals are often used in negative structures to say that an action is forbidden or unacceptable.

5.147 *Cannot* is used to say that something is forbidden, e.g. because of a rule or law.

Example 5.3.65. *Children cannot bathe except in the presence of 2 lifesavers.*
We're awfully sorry we can't let you stay here.

5.148 *May not* is used in a similar way to *cannot*, but is more formal.

Example 5.3.66. *You may not make amendments to your application once we have received it.*
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5.149 *Will not* is used to tell someone very firmly that they are not allowed to do a particular thing.
Usually, the speaker has the power to prevent the hearer from doing this thing.

Example 5.3.67. *'I'll just go upstairs.' - 'You will not.'*
Until we have cured you, you won't be leaving here.

5.150 *Shall not* is used to say formally that a particular thing is not allowed.
Shall not is often used in written rules, laws, and agreements.

Example 5.3.68. *Persons under 18 shall not be employed in nightwork.*
Equality of rights under the law shall not be denied or abridged by the United States or by any State.

Shan't is used in a similar way to *will not* and *won't*.

Example 5.3.69. *You shan't leave without my permission.*

5.151 You can also say that something is not allowed by using an **imperative** sentence.
Imperative sentences are explained in paragraph **5.4** and in paragraphs **5.37–5.41**.

5.152 *Should not* is used to tell someone that an action is unacceptable or undesirable.

Example 5.3.70. *You should not take her help for granted.*
You shouldn't do that.
You shouldn't be so unfriendly.

5.153 *Must not* is used to say much more firmly that something is unacceptable or undesirable.

Example 5.3.71. *You must not accept it.*
You mustn't do that.
You mustn't breathe a word of this to anyone.

5.3.9 Interacting with other people

5.154 You often say things in order to get someone to behave in a particular way.
E.g., you may wants someone to take a particular action, to accept an offer, or to give their permission for something to be done.
In these situations, modals are often used.
The modal you choose depends on several factors.
The main ones are:

- the formality or informality of the situation
- the relationship between yourself and the person you are speaking to
- the degree of politeness you want to show.

In particular situations, other factors can be important.
E.g., if you are making an offer or suggestion, the modal you choose may depend on how persuasive you want to be.

5.155 The following sections explain how to use modals in different situations.
Paragraphs **5.156–5.172** explain how to give instructions and make requests.
Paragraphs **5.173–5.181** explain how to make an offer or an invitation.
Paragraphs **5.182–5.189** explain how to make suggestions.
Paragraphs **5.190–5.195** explain how to state an intention.
Paragraphs **5.196–5.201** explain how to express unwillingness or a refusal to do something.
Paragraphs **5.202–5.210** explain how to express a wish.
Paragraphs **5.211–5.215** explain how to indicate the importance of doing something.
Paragraphs **5.216–5.222** explain various ways of introducing what you are going to say.

5.3.10 Giving instructions & making requests

5.156 When you give an instruction or make a request, you usually use a modal in an interrogative sentence.

You use *will, would, can*, or *could* with *you* to tell someone to do something, or to task someone to do something.

You use *can, could, may*, or *might* with *I* or *we* or with other personal pronouns or noun phrases to ask someone's permission to do something.

Instructions and requests are always made more polite by adding *please*.

Please and other markers of politeness are explained in paragraph **5.172**.

5.157 *Will, would*, and *could* are used with *you* in 2 ways:

- you use them to give an instruction or an order
- you use them to ask for help or assistance.

5.158 *Will* is used to give an instruction or order in a fairly direct way.

It is slightly less forceful than using the imperative.

Example 5.3.72. *Will you pick those toys up please?*
Will you pack up and leave at once, please.

Will is used to ask for help in fairly informal situations.

Example 5.3.73. *Mummy, will you help me?*

5.159 When *would* is used to give an instruction or order, it is more polite than *will*.

Example 5.3.74. *Would you tell her that Adrian phoned?*
Would you ask them to leave, please?

When *would* is used to ask for help, it is less informal and more polite than *will*.

Example 5.3.75. *Would you do me a favor?*

5.160 When *could* is used to give an instruction or order, it is more polite than *would*.

Example 5.3.76. *Could you follow me please?*
Could you just switch the projector on behind you?

When *could* is used to ask for help, it is more polite than *would*.

Example 5.3.77. *Could you show me how to do this?*

5.161 *Can* can be used with *you* to ask for help.

You usually use *can* when you are not sure whether someone will be able to help you or not.

Example 5.3.78. *Oh hello. Can you help me? I've been trying this number for 10 minutes and I can't get through.*

5.162 *Can, could, may*, and *might* are used with *I* or *we* when you are asking for something, or are asking permission to do something.

These modals can also be used with *he, she*, or *they*, or with other noun phrases, when you are asking for something on behalf of someone else.

E.g., you can say *Can she borrow your car?* or *Could my mother use your telephone?*

5.163 *Can* is used to make a request in a simple and direct way.

Example 5.3.79. *Can I ask a question?*
'Can I change this?' I asked the box office lady, offering her my ticket.

5.164 *Could* is more polite than *can*.

Example 5.3.80. *Could I have a bottle of lemonade, please?*
Could I just interrupt a minute?

5.165 You can make a request sound more persuasive by using *can't* or *couldn't* instead of *can* or *could*.

E.g., you can say *Can't I come with you?* instead of *Can I come with you?*

Example 5.3.81. *Can't we have some music?*
Couldn't we stay here?

5.166 *May* and *might* are more formal than *can* and *could*.

In the past, people were taught that, when asking for something, it was correct to say *may* rather than *can*, and *might* rather than *could*.

However *can* and *could* are now generally used.

Requests beginning with *might* are unusual, and are considered by most people to be old-fashioned.

Example 5.3.82. *May I have a cigarette?*
May we have something to eat?
May I ask what your name is?
Might I inquire if you are the owner?

5.167 *Would like* can be used with *I* or *we* in a declarative sentence to give an instruction or order.

It is followed by *you* and a *to*-infinitive clause.

Example 5.3.83. *OK, everyone, I would like you to get into a circle.*

Want can be used in a similar way to *would like*.

This use of *want* is dealt with in paragraph **5.236**.

5.168 An instruction or order can also be given using *will* in a declarative sentence.

This form is used when the speaker is angry or impatient.

Example 5.3.84. *You will go and get 1 of your parents immediately.*
You will give me those now.

5.169 *Shall* is sometimes used in a declarative sentence to give an instruction or order.

This is a very formal use.

Example 5.3.85. *There shall be no further communication between you.*

5.170 The **imperative** can also be used to give an instruction or order.

This use is explained in paragraph **5.37**.

5.171 You can use *would like* or (in British English only) *should like* in a declarative sentence to make a request.

Would like and *should like* are followed by a *to*-infinitive clause or a noun phrase.

Example 5.3.86. *I would like to ask you 1 question.*
I'd like to have a little talk with you.
I should like a list of your customers over the past year.

5.172 All the ways of giving instructions or making requests described above can be made more polite by using *please*.

Example 5.3.87. *Can I speak to Nicola, please?*
Please may I have the key?

You can also make a request more polite by adding the name of the person you are addressing at the beginning or end of your question.

Example 5.3.88. *Martin, could you make us a drink?*
Can I talk to you, Howard?

Another way of making a request more polite is to add an adverb e.g. *perhaps* or *possibly* after the subject of the verb.

Example 5.3.89. *Could I perhaps bring a friend with me?*
May I possibly have a word will you?

In spoken English, you can make a request more polite by adding *just* after the subject of the verb.

Example 5.3.90. *Could you just come into my office for a minute?*

5.3.11 Making an offer or an invitation

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